we could be free, if you wanted

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/28667883.

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Mature

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Graphic Depictions Of Violence

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Adora/Catra (She-Ra), Bow/Glimmer (She-Ra)

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Adora (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra), Glimmer (She-Ra), Bow (She-Ra), Scorpia (She-Ra), Shadow Weaver | Light Spinner (She-Ra), Perfuma (She-Ra)

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teaching au, Alternate Universe, Military, Friends to Enemies to Lovers, Angst, Fluff, Hurt/Comfort, depictions of war, Post-Traumatic Stress Disorder - PTSD, Scars, feelings and plot, Alternate Universe - Teachers, hot teachers with tragic back stories, Slow Burn, spicy themes

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by ChasingTheStars

Summary

At sixteen, Catra and Adora run away to join the military, hoping to escape their abusive foster home. At eighteen, they're recruited into the Special Forces. At twenty-one, they're sent on a suicide mission that will supposedly end a thirty-year war. Neither of them expects to survive, but they do. Their friendship doesn't.

Adora hasn't seen Catra since that fateful day five years ago. Now a teacher, (and infamous ex-war hero) at Brightmoon School, she knows the new Literature teacher a little too well. A lot has happened in five years, but Adora is set on fixing a broken promise from long ago.

However, with their troubled past, scarred present, and a new threat called 'Prime' rising to power, it seems they might also have to fight for their future.

or, you've read the college AUs, so here's the angsty, tragic-backstory teaching AU no one asked for.

Notes

See the end of the work for notes

Coffee Stains

Twenty-one years old

There's blood on the floor. On the wall. It's leaving footprints on the dusty ground, paving their way towards death.

They knew they weren't going to survive this – they weren't *supposed* to survive this. The Special Forces were heading this task and the instructions from the top came with a warning: *suicide mission.* Survivors unlikely.

The army didn't ask permission. It was do or die. Catra and Adora were some of the best soldiers in the Special Forces, and when they were briefed on a plot to bring down the Horde's Arms Factory, which could potentially end a thirty-year war, of course stupid Adora said yes straight away.

And, well, wherever Adora went, Catra followed.

An explosion rattled the wall they were shielding behind. Catra slid towards the floor, pulling Adora with her. When the dust started to fall like rain, with shards of metal and chunks of brick plummeting from the sky, Catra scanned the perimeter for a safe place.

"We need to" – Adora winced as she pulled herself up, a hand gripping her side – "get the failsafe to the transmitter."

They were so close.

The rest of their team had already taken down the building, seized the factory, and locked-down the base. Judging by the radio silence, no one had survived. They were the last two standing, which meant it was up to them to bring down the transmitter – the last thread of the mission. If the Horde lost their transmitter, they lost the war. Etheria would have them conquered within the week.

Once the communications tower was down, boom. End of the Horde. It sounded so simple.

The problem was getting to the transmitter.

“There’s no ‘we’ about it,” Catra snapped. She eyed the blonde's waist; the exit hole looked clean, but it was a miracle she hadn't passed out from blood loss by now. “You’ve been shot. You can barely walk.”

“Catra, I need to do this,” Adora insisted with a huff. Pain danced in her blue eyes, but underneath there was a glimmer of resilience Catra loved to hate; the spirit of a fighter. She watched as Adora shook herself and leaned in close, taking a few steadying breaths. Her face was pinched; clammy and covered in dirt. Her hair was matted under the visor, but she had never looked so - so, well, *Adora*. Holding onto the last moment with everything she had, fighting to the end. Stubborn and wilful and oh so *stupid*.

“And I said no," Catra argued. She grabbed Adora's wrists and held them tight. "We’ll put you somewhere safe – you can give it to me and I’ll do it.”

“I can’t give it to you." A shake of her head, another wince. "We don’t know what will happen when it activates.”

Catra let out a noise of frustration. “You and your heroics – listen, we don't have time, either I go or we go together.”

Adora was quiet. The floor rumbled but neither of them felt it. Catra couldn’t tear her eyes away from Adora’s soft, pleading stare.

Looking back, Catra would revisit this moment. All the time they spent together - almost two decades of shared memories - and *this* was what broke her heart. She knew, deep down, what was going to happen, she just didn't want to believe it.

She would never forget. She would never forgive.

“I’m sorry,” Adora croaked.

Before the brunette had a chance to react, Adora pulled her by the collar and pressed her lips against Catra’s open mouth. It was so gentle; so misplaced in their current world of blood and mayhem. Adora moved again, closer, clutching her best friend's shoulders. Swept up in the moment, Catra was slow to respond. It wasn't until she pushed back into the kiss that she heard Adora repeat;

“*I’m so, so sorry*."

And the next thing Catra knew, something hard and sharp hit against the side of her head and the world turned black.

Present day

Adora was *almost* late to the staff meeting – which meant she was less than her usual fifteen minutes early. As always, she took her place beside Bow in the staff room, who was happily tapping away on his tablet. He didn’t look up when she sat down on the edge of her seat, instead he pointed at the cup of steaming coffee on the table in front of them.

“Freshly brewed, just for you.”

“Ugh, thanks, Bow.” Adora reached for the cup and wrapped her hands around it like a hug. “Just what I needed.”

“Everything okay?”

Adora bought a few seconds by taking a long sip of coffee. She nodded, taking her time, but because of the slight hesitation, Bow looked up. His eyes tight with concern.

“Yeah, I just” – she shrugged, trying to play it cool – “didn’t sleep well.”

That was an understatement, although she wasn't in the mood to get into it. If it wasn't night terrors keeping her awake, it was residual pain encasing her body in a fiery blanket of torture. Last night she had barely been able to move because every bone in her body felt inflamed, every scar felt flayed open. When she closed her eyes, she heard explosions shaking the walls, seen flashes of colour, smelt death in the air.

How could you tell any of this to a colleague on a Monday morning over a cup of coffee?

Bow was different, however. One of Bow's dads had been in the army and Bow himself was in a regiment for a short period. This was Brightmoon College, after all; a school that encouraged teachers from varied backgrounds because their pupils were also 'troubled' in some way. Teachers could be called by their first name, and classes were taught with a mind-first attitude. The resident school councillor, Perfuma, encouraged group meditation sessions and trips to nature resorts. When Adora had first joined three years ago, she thought she'd accidentally signed up to a hippie commune.

"What do you need?" Bow immediately asked. "I can get Mermista to make you some tea, or Perfuma can guide you through meditation at lunch – oh, I could get Entrapta to fit you with another –"

"Bow, I'm fine, really," Adora insisted. She nudged his shoulder with her own. "But thank you."

They shared a soft smile. Adora was about to ask Bow about his weekend when Glimmer, Brightmoon's principal (and, more importantly, best friend to Bow and Adora) walked in, a new recruit tagging behind her. Adora, not looking at what she was doing, went to take another sip of coffee but it spilled it down the front of her white blouse. She swore under her breath and desperately looked around for a napkin – a tissue – anything –

“Morning, everyone,” Adora heard Glimmer begin. “As promised, I’d like you to meet our new Literature teacher.”

“Here,” Bow said, handing her a packet of tissues.

Adora whispered him praise and started trying to salvage the brown stain on her blouse. It was typical, really, that she spilt coffee on herself when she was wearing white, of all colours – and in front of Glimmer giving a meeting. If the ground could swallow her up, now would be a good time for it.

But then two things happened simultaneously.

Glimmer said, “This is Catra Areli.”

And Adora looked up –

As Catra caught her wide-eyed stare.

It was so vivid, the day Adora had last seen her. Five years ago. Five whole years and she always went back to that moment, reliving it in her mind. Changing what she said, doing things differently – as if there was an answer to find, a piece of peace to uncover. Not a day went by when she didn’t think of Catra; once upon a time, she had been her best friend. Her only friend. Her family.

And now all she could do was stare with her mouth open, coffee staining her white shirt. Catra blushed and looked down and, oh, what Adora would give to know what she was thinking.

Her heart was beating its way through her ribs.

Glimmer was talking but the words skated past her. Adora couldn’t take her eyes off Catra. Her hair was no longer the short pixie cut that she’d kept during their time in the army, but it wasn’t quite the length it had been during their late teens either – it sat somewhere below her shoulders, soft and bouncy, more tamed than Adora could remember. She sported no obvious new scars – at least, not as obvious as Adora's own – and from her clothes

(smart trousers and a crimson blazer) to her posture, she seemed well-put-together. There were none of the rough edges that Adora remembered so fondly.

She had no right to feel a nostalgic twist of disappointment.

They had grown up.

They had grown apart.

They had reason to call each other strangers at this point.

Heart in her throat, and mind twisted in a tight knot, Adora missed the end of the staff meeting and was shaken back to reality by a rather concerned-looking Bow.

"Adora? Are you okay?"

"Where did she go?" Adora blurted.

"Who?"

"Catra."

"Glimmer's bringing her to her classroom – hey, Adora!"

But she was gone. Leaving her bag behind and her coffee cup on the counter, Adora bolted for the door. She ran down the corridor, dodging children in her path, ignoring the sharp pain in her hip. There they were – turning into the left wing –

"Catra! Wait – Catra!"

She had no idea what she was doing.

Glimmer turned around first, eyes narrowed and lips pressed in a tight line. She gave Adora a 'what the hell is going on' look which the blonde chose to ignore. Breathing heavily, and heat rising in her cheeks, Adora watched Catra slowly turn on her heel and -

Observe her with nothing more than cold disinterest.

Fuck.

That hurt.

“Hey Adora,” she said.

But there was nothing there; no tease, no warmth, no recognition.

Only a sparkle of contempt.

“Catra, I –” what was there to say? Embarrassment washed over her like a lilting wave, and she felt so stupid for being so hopeful, so desperate, that this strange coincidence would’ve worked out differently. Nothing had changed. She was a fool for thinking otherwise. Trying to regain what dignity she had left, Adora backed off, taking a step away. “I just – I didn’t know you were the new Literature teacher. Hi, I guess.”

Adora waited a nanosecond for a reply. When it didn’t come, she added, “I need to go – uh, teach.”

“That sounds like a good idea,” Glimmer almost hissed.

Adora winced. There was no doubt she’d be getting interrogated at lunch time for this.

Unable to look back, scared at seeing an echo of hatred in her old best friend’s eyes, Adora walked back down the corridor, latching onto the pain in her hip. Each step reminded her of what she had lost that day, and the fact it was still irreplaceable five years later.

How had this happened? Catra hadn't looked surprised to see her - had she been warned she was taking up a post where her ex- everything worked? Why hadn't someone told *her*? Why was she the last to know; why was this feeling like a pill she couldn't swallow?

Adora paid a visit to the bathroom before heading to her first class. She leaned against the cubicle with her head in her hands, squeezing her eyes tight.

Shit. She didn't feel well.

Flashes of Catra played behind her eyelids. When they were seven and they first met. Twelve, during their first real argument. Fifteen, when Adora held Catra all night while she cried. Sixteen, packing their bags to run away. Nineteen, when they were chosen by the Special Forces to join their ranks.

Everything after that was blurry and confusing and *hurt*.

Realising that her breaths were coming in short gasps, Adora sat on the toilet and put her head between her legs. She needed to calm down, this wasn't good. She hadn't felt like this in over a year, and if she didn't get herself under control, she'd –

Well, panic attacks weren't fun.

Recounting Perfuma's teaching, she breathed in through her nose, held it for six seconds, and let it out of her mouth. She did this until her hands stopped shaking and her head felt floaty and light.

When she was ready, Adora let herself out of the cubicle door and caught her reflection in the mirror. Her own hair was different too, she realised; she no longer wore her hair in the ponytail Catra had hated. Now, she wore it partially down, with the top layer pulled back away from her face. Between the coffee stain on her white blouse and the dark circles under her eyes from no sleep, she looked a state. Trust her to look like this when seeing Catra for the first time in five years.

As for the scar running down the side of her left cheek, there was nothing she could ever do about that.

Five years since that day. Standing on the podium – barely able to keep weight on her legs. Catra. So full of rage, and yet when their eyes met for that last time – the hurt there was like a knife through Adora's heart.

It was something she would never forget. Something she would never forgive.

But she had wasted enough time – there was a pottery class waiting for her. So, Adora did what she always did; she put her shoulders back, tightened her jaw and went out to fight her demons.

Blush

Chapter Summary

Content warning: implied child abuse

Fifteen years old

“Catra.”

“What?”

“You’re going to get in trouble.”

“So what?”

Adora sighed, hands on her hips, and shook her head. “You shouldn’t antagonise her.”

Catra spun around, eyes flashing. She fixed her hand wrap with a harder tug than was necessary. “She has a go at me anyway, what difference does it make?”

She watched as Adora put on her other glove and made sure the velcro was tight. Of course Adora didn’t understand – Adora never understood. Adora, the perfect student who appreciated authority and didn’t see any reason in openly rebelling against any system, because the system suited her.

That was a little unfair, Catra chided herself. Adora knew how to break the rules, but she always outweighed the risk. Catra, on the other hand, didn’t care. Why should she pay respect to a world that never respected her? Consequences be damned.

“I worry about you,” Adora muttered when she thought Catra had turned away.

And her blue eyes looked up at her, so sad, so hopeful, so cautious. Catra blinked a few times to make her mind catch up. To

cover how flustered she felt, how hard her heart was beating, Catra scoffed. "That sounds like a *you* problem, not a *me* problem."

But to enforce the tease, Catra swiped playfully at the blonde's head. Adora ducked just a second too late and caught the bottom of Catra's palm. Just as she was about to swivel around and kick her in the shins, a booming voice rang out behind them.

"That's enough, children. Let's get into the proper fighting, shall we?"

Octavia was their trainer in the army cadets. Despite being only a few years older than them, Catra had almost clawed one of her eyes out during their first training session. Since then, Octavia was particularly spiteful against her. Adora saluted and said a quick, "Yes, instructor."

Catra just folded her arms.

Octavia narrowed her eyes at the smaller girl. "Alright, then. You two" – she jabbed a finger at Adora and Catra – "up first."

Pfft. Was that supposed to be some kind of punishment? Catra *loved* fighting Adora. It was one of her favourite things to do. The adrenaline of their competitiveness, the way their bodies sang as they danced, and, most of all, the feeling she got when she had Adora pinned to the mat, claiming victory over her.

Yeah, Catra told herself, it was definitely declaring victory that made her feel like that.

Catra and Adora had joined the army cadets a year ago for very different reasons. For Adora, it was all about the adventure of it; learning new exercise techniques, meeting new people, going on the occasional excursion. For Catra, it was avoiding home for a few extra hours each week and, well, the fact Adora was so lit up on it.

So far, they had learnt gymnastics and how to box. Now, they were on mixed martial arts. Octavia had said MMA was a mixture of the two; good footwork and skilful technique. Someone flexible could easily take down a better fighter with timing and precision. Catra had been good at gymnastics, whereas Adora had excelled at boxing, making the two perfectly matched at MMA.

Catra slipped into the ring first, making sure to flick the net at Adora as she ungracefully pushed through and almost landed on her face.

Catra didn't help her up. She enjoyed the slight blush on Adora's cheeks as she regained balance. She couldn't wait to see her best friend's face flush red when she had her spinning to the floor in a few minutes, forfeiting the game.

Winning always felt so good.

"Keep it clean," Octavia warned, eyeing Catra, who sniggered.

Adora took to the right corner, Catra to the left. They locked eyes across the ring. Adora; determined and sure. Catra; loose and confident.

"On a count of three."

Adora quirked an eyebrow, making Catra smirk. Suddenly, they were the only people in the entire world. No one or nothing existed outside of the ring.

"One."

Catra bounced on the balls of her feet. Her heart started to pump up.

"Two."

A strand of hair fell into Adora's eyes. Catra's first thought was to help her brush it away but, no, she had to focus. Her distraction was Adora's gain.

“Three!”

Catra leapt like spring across the ring, immediately pivoting into a middle round-kick. Adora dodged it easily, going in for a quick jab. Catra jumped, bringing her hand down and launching into an overhand attack, causing Adora to bring her arms up to protect her face. Adora lashed out a foot, attempting to trip Catra on her landing, but she missed. Catching her misplaced foot between both of her own, Catra used her legs to spin Adora around and slam her into the mat.

A perfect landing, a jab to the face later, and Adora’s lip split.

Catra was shocked by the flash of red. Blood splattered on the white mat. She flinched, despite being the one to land the blow, but Adora seized the second of pause. The blonde twisted her hips and used gravity to reverse the positions into a guard pass. She pinned Catra to the floor using her elbows and, staring down at her opponent, whispered, “Gotcha.”

But there was a stain of red on her teeth, a stain that Catra had caused. It unsettled her; it made her feel small and ashamed. In all of their tousles before, sure, they’d given each other injuries – some had even scarred. So why was this getting under Catra’s skin?

She stared up at Adora with wide eyes; there was an uncomfortable clench in her chest and a pulling sensation in her stomach. Adora’s hair had come loose, and her fringe was falling into her sweaty face. There was a blush to her cheeks, and her lips were slightly parted. Catra wanted her arms free; she wanted to wipe away the blood, she wanted to –

Octavia was timing her out, but she didn’t care.

Catra had just realised something.

She let out an angry noise, something close to a growl, and pushed herself up – pushed Adora off her. “Yeah, I get it. You win,” she snarled. Why did she say it like that? She didn’t feel full

of venom, she felt full of something else – something soft, tender, something sweet and – and – and full of Adora.

She hated it.

Catra hadn't felt something soft since she was a child. The world had toughened her around the same time she turned her back on it. Soft feelings led to being hurt, and being hurt made you vulnerable and vulnerability was weak – it meant people looked down on you, saw you as nothing, took advantage of you.

Catra was not *soft*.

But Adora *was*. Some parts of her best friend were hardened like she was, but despite what the world had done to Adora, she still had so much hope and joy beyond the defences, underneath the armour. She was a marshmallow in an iron case, while Catra was just an empty, iron case.

She couldn't even bear to look at her right now.

Octavia instructed them to hit the showers before going home, while the next pair took to the ring. They walked in silence to their lockers with Adora shooting careful glances her way. It wasn't until Catra reached for her towel that she snapped.

"What?!"

"Why did you do it?"

"Do what?"

"Let me win."

Catra gulped and looked down. She could imagine Adora's eyes right now; so blue and curious, rounded with fragility. When Catra felt the warm pull in her stomach again, she clamped down on it, refused to let it blossom.

Bravado. That's what got Catra out of most situations in her life, and it would work here too.

"If I'm too good, people will start expecting it from me." She shrugged. "I don't want anyone expecting *anything* of me."

Adora made a thoughtful sound. As it dragged on, Catra realised there was a playful edge to it.

She glanced up; Adora was staring at her with a towel draped over her shoulder, ready to walk into a cubicle. She raised an eyebrow. "I thought it was because you like me."

The blood had already dried into her lip, and it was infuriating that she was making no effort to clean it up. Snorting, Catra closed the door to her cubicle with a louder bang than what was necessary. "I do *not* like you, princess."

Present day

Catra had been expecting it, but that didn't make it any easier.

It was the first time she'd seen Adora in person for five years.

And jeez, it had been a long five years.

Had she changed? That was a difficult question. There was a part of Adora that had never changed. Was she different compared to the fifteen year old girl with the split lip Catra remembered? Physically, yes. She had scars and nervous twitches that girl didn't. Was she different compared to the last time Catra had seen her?

Also yes.

Adora was slightly thinner, like she'd lost some muscle mass. Her hair was different too; half-up, half-down, and longer. She didn't look well – in fact, she looked like shit, but Catra tried to stomp

out those cynical thoughts. She tried to stomp out the reflexive concern, too.

But it was how her ex-best friend looked at her from across the staffroom – mouth open, coffee seeping into her white shirt – that told her Adora hadn't *really* changed.

She still looked *so* hopeful, so – well, stupid.

Sparkles – or whatever her name was, everyone had weird names here – led Catra out of the staffroom to show her to her new classroom. It was still strange to think of herself as a real teacher – newly qualified with a year of training under her belt. This was her first proper job, and she *would not* screw it up. It meant too much to her.

Despite this, she could barely hear Sparkles talking over the crushing buzz squeezing her skull, which sounded a lot like:

Adora Adora Adora Adora Adora

She thought she could do this but maybe she was wrong. There was something about her ex-best friend, her well, her ex-everything, that pushed all her buttons. She would never be free of her spell, would she? Adora was woven into what was left of muscle in her chest some would call a heart. Even five years later - five years of no contact - the memories and their meanings replayed in her mind like they were yesterday.

"Catra! Wait – Catra!"

Oh fuck.

The idiot had followed her.

Fifteen years old

When they got home from cadets, Ms Weaver was waiting for them in the hallway.

Catra felt Adora tense beside her. Although her heart was beating out of her chest, Catra resolved never to show it. She acted cool, collected. She didn't care about what Weaver was about to do – she couldn't care less. There was nothing she could say, nothing she could do, that she hadn't already done before. The expected wasn't scary, it was inevitable.

They had barely reached the front door step when Weaver hissed, "I had a call from one of your teachers, Catra."

Throwing her bag at the foot of the coat stand, because she knew it annoyed the gnarly old woman, Catra said, "Yeah? And what?"

The brunette glanced Adora, who was still standing at the door, one hand on her bag and the other clutching her sleeve, as if it provided comfort. For a moment Catra focused on the split lip she had caused and then looked away.

Weaver towered over her, all threat and poise. "She told me she found cigarettes on your person."

"Oh, she did?"

"And when she confiscated them, you told her to *go fuck herself*."

Catra shrugged. "She looks like she needs to loosen up."

Weaver grabbed her by the collar of her shirt. "You think you're so smart, don't you?"

She could feel Weaver's fingers digging into the skin of her chest. There was no use pulling away; they were well-versed in this tango. Instead, Catra smirked up into Weaver's scarred face, and trying to keep the shake out of her voice, retorted, "Nah, I just think I'm surrounded by idiots."

Weaver let go all at once, throwing her towards the stairs. Catra's back slammed into the wall, but she caught herself before she fell.

Weaver advanced on her again but Adora yelped from the doorway.

"Please, Ms Weaver, the cigarettes were planted on Catra by a –"

"Do not *lie* to me, Adora," Weaver hissed, turning on her heel to look at the blonde. "I've smelled smoke on her for *weeks*."

Catra blinked. It had been a while since Adora had tried to defend her; they both knew it tended to make things worse.

This time, Weaver withdrew into the kitchen. Calling over her shoulder, she said, "Adora, wait for me upstairs."

Catra's stomach jolted when she saw her best friend's hesitation. *Move, you idiot. You're not helping.*

"*Go*," their carer barked.

Adora didn't need to be asked again. She ran upstairs, shooting Catra an apologetic glance on her way up, and leaving her alone with Weaver.

Present day

"Catra! Wait – Catra!"

Oh fuck.

The idiot had followed her.

Glimmer caught Catra's eye and raised an inquisitive brow before turning around. Catra waited a second, needing to recollect her cool.

It had been years since she lashed out. She wasn't going to show herself up now.

With her chin slightly raised she, once again, met Adora's wide-eyed stare.

How did she do that – portray every emotion on her face, like an open book?

Did she have no fear of vulnerability?

Fuck. Catra had missed that innocent openness. It was what made Adora unique, and it was so opposite of Catra. Everything Adora did, everything she thought, showed on her face and she made no attempt to hide it. It was more than honesty; it was sincerity. There wasn't a malicious bone in that woman's body, and Catra should know; once upon a time, she had tried and failed to expose the blonde's 'dark' side.

“Hey Adora,” she said, stilted by the emotions bubbling her throat. *Fondness*. That's what it was called.

Adora searched her for something – something she’d never find, and Catra hated how she looked so disappointed when she didn't find it.

No, I’m still a cold-hearted bitch, Adora. Sorry to disappoint.

I’ll never be what you need.

“Catra, I –” Adora’s voice cracked. “I just – I didn’t know you were the new Literature teacher. Hi, I guess.”

There was so much Catra *could* say. The possibilities flashed in her mind’s eye, and each scenario caused her jaw to clench a little harder.

Staring at the floor, Adora turned away. “I need to go – uh, teach.”

“That sounds like a good idea,” Sparkles snapped.

But Catra watched Adora walk (did she have a limp?) down the corridor until she disappeared in the crowd of students.

Fifteen years old

When Weaver was done with her, she asked for Adora.

Fifteen minutes after a shouting match downstairs, Adora returned to their shared room and sat on the edge of Catra's bed. Catra was under the covers, muffling her cries with a pillow.

"Catra?"

"Go away."

"Catra, please."

In a snap of rage, Catra leapt out of the bed and physically pushed Adora onto the floor. Her chest was heaving, her breaths coming in short gasps. "*I said go away*, Adora."

Adora looked up, scared and hurt. When she noticed her best friend's red-rimmed eyes, her gaze softened into concern.

Catra flumped on the bed with a sigh.

Adora got up and sat beside her.

Her hand hovered over Catra's shoulder, asking for silent permission.

With a quiet sob, Catra fell into her, hiding her face in the crook of her neck.

"I've got you," Adora whispered against her hair. "I'm not going anywhere."

And Catra believed her.

Her

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Adora was cleaning paintbrushes when Glimmer and Bow visited her at lunchtime. She was so focused on how the paint swirled with the water as it gushed down the plughole that she barely heard them at all. Her eyes were transfixed, her mind very far away, lost in the past. A blob of red paint stuck to the metal basin, and when she scraped it off, the water turned into a crimson burst. It looked so familiar, it looked like -

"Adora?"

When she glanced up, Glimmer was already standing in front of her, hands on her hips, scowling. Bow hovered by her shoulder looking concerned. Cutting off the tap, Adora dragged herself back to the present.

"I'm okay," she said reflexively.

"What was *that* about earlier?" Glimmer asked. "Do you know her – Catra?"

It was strange, hearing Glimmer say Catra's name; two separate phases of her life crashing together, blurring the lines between the two neat boxes of *the past* and *the present* in her mind.

As for the question: did she *know* Catra? That was laughable.

"I – yeah, I knew her." Swallowing, she turned away to dry the paintbrushes. "I've told you about her."

"Catra? I've never heard you mention a Catra."

When Adora turned around again, her eyes were shining. Bow, typical Bow, was the first to catch on. He gasped and slapped a

hand over his mouth.

"It's *her*, isn't it?!"

Adora gave a little nod.

Glimmer glanced between them, brows pulled together. "Wait, what? Am I missing something?"

"*Her*," Bow insisted in a loud whisper. "The one Adora told us about – the one she grew up with – the one she –"

Glimmer gave a louder gasp than Bow, almost stumbling backwards. "Oh my god! Catra's *her*?!"

"Shush!" Adora hissed, eyeing the doorway. They were far too loud for her liking. The last thing she wanted was for the whole school to know of their history.

"Oh, Adora, I didn't know." Glimmer started to pace between the desks. "I only met her today – the Governors hired her – if I'd known –"

"It's okay," she insisted, even though she felt the furthest from okay. "It's not fair on Catra – it's not like anyone knew – I don't –" she didn't what? Mind? She did. Her mind had been in the gutter all morning. She'd almost taken a panic attack for the first time in a year.

Not being able to hold it in anymore, Adora sat on one of the students' stools and leaned her elbows on her thighs. It had taken a while; countless therapy sessions, bribing and coaxing on Bow and Glimmer's part, before Adora had shared her deepest darkest past with her two best friends. She had told them everything about Catra – what she meant to her, what she symbolised, what had happened – but for some reason, she'd kept her name from them. It was a small thing, a tiny piece of control, but she revelled in it. There was power in a name - in one tiny secret nestled next to her heart.

Now it was *all* laid open.

"She seems nice," Glimmer offered. When Bow shot her a careful look, Glimmer added, "A bit stand-offish, sure, but it's her first day. I thought it was nerves, but" – her eyes widened – "what if it was because she realised *you* worked here? What have we done? She's probably feeling just as upset as you –"

"No," Adora interjected. "No, it's Catra. She's made it very clear that I don't mean anything to her anymore." Her hand flexed instinctively. "I'll just – I'll keep my distance. Keep this as amicable as possible. It'll be easy, right?" Adora stood up suddenly as the thoughts came to her. "We work on opposite sides of the school, we teach different subjects – yeah, apart from meetings and assemblies, we'll never see each other. Right, guys? It'll be easy!"

Bow was staring at her as if he was waiting for the explosion.

"It'll be fine," Adora amended. "*I'm* fine."

Quite honestly, she'd say anything to them to get them to leave her alone. She knew they meant well and that they were just looking out for her, but this was Catra.

She couldn't explain it anymore than that.

A few days went by, and Adora didn't see Catra at all.

Honestly, she wasn't sure if she felt relieved or anxious about that.

On a personal note, Adora's nightmares had gotten worse. When she didn't stay up all night, lying on her bed, paralysed, she woke up from a terror, panting and drenched in sweat. Normal amounts of caffeine and sugar didn't work on her, so she found herself drinking plain macchiatos throughout the day (with a few too many espresso shots to even be considered a macchiato anymore) and, when she wasn't catching up on marking, she was hitting the gym, *hard*. Working out was one of the few things that made

Adora feel in control of both her mind and body; when she was hitting something, she was in charge. When she was working her limbs into exhaustion, they were hurting for a different reason than residual pain.

It was during break time on Friday when Adora seen Catra again.

The staff room was buzzing – there was cake; it was Bow's birthday – and after Adora had spent a few minutes chatting to the birthday boy, she clutched her coffee and escaped outside for some fresh air. She leaned against the back door and breathed in the chilly breeze. It numbed the slight sting in her cheeks, dulled the knot in stomach. Rooms were feeling too small lately; walls too close, ceilings too high. Fresh air alleviated some of the anxiety, cleared her mind of toxic thoughts.

And then she smelled the faint scent of cigarette smoke.

Curiously, Adora peeked her head around the corner, expecting to find a student.

But, no, there was Catra with her back against the wall and a cigarette held between two fingers, openly flouting the school policy.

On the end of her first week of work.

The fact that Adora was mildly surprised was proof enough that they had spent a long time apart.

Before she could look away, Catra's eyes had landed on her. The brunette didn't react; she didn't look away either. She just stared, blowing out another puff of smoke.

Adora should say something.

This was weird.

What should she say?

Think. What did colleagues talk about? What was a normal conversation starter? The weather? No, Catra wouldn't even consider that worthy of a response. She could ask if she wanted any cake – but what if she already –?

"Hey, Adora."

Oh. The blonde stood straighter and took a step closer. A hand subconsciously brushed against the scar on her cheek. "Oh, hi there, Catra. I didn't – I was just – getting some air, you know."

Catra didn't respond. She looked down at the gravelly ground and flicked the tip of her cigarette. The embers died as they fluttered in the breeze.

"It's good to see you." *Fuck*, the words slipped out before Adora registered what she was saying. Shit. She needed to retreat. Why was she like this? Why did she mess everything up?

Why was she so fucking transparent?

Predictably, Catra didn't say anything. It was better this way, Adora told herself. A few years ago, Catra wouldn't even tolerate her silence or her presence.

That had been a scary time.

"So, what does a musclehead like you teach?" Catra asked after a few moments. "PE?"

"Ah, no." Adora self-consciously tugged at the hem of her top. She didn't quite have those muscles anymore. "I'm an Art teacher."

"Art?" Catra sounded surprised.

"Yeah." She was always so hard to read, but Adora knew what she was thinking right now. Art, in all of its variations, was a *Catra* thing, not an Adora thing. Growing up, Catra was the one with a scrapbook containing big ideas; she was the one who discussed the instruments in songs, the meaning behind the instruments.

Anything that provided meaning and escapism and Catra sank her teeth in. Adora, on the other hand, listened, agreed and never *really* understood. She had no reason to, at the time; paintings were pretty, music was catchy, the world was simpler then. Art had helped Catra cope with the darkness in life, and Adora hadn't grasped that.

"Since when have you been into art?" Catra asked with a frown.

"Since therapy," Adora admitted.

Catra took a long drag. Her eyebrows flicked up. "Ah."

Therapy. Adora had went kicking and screaming. She didn't want to talk about what happened and she didn't understand why a holiday or break from routine would help her decompress. It wasn't until she was introduced to Perfuma that she realised there was healing through activities such as art. Adora immediately took to it; it helped her reconnect with the whisper of her past through Catra, and gave her something to do with her hands. It wasn't until she met Bow and Glimmer that she realised she could also make a career out of it with the military-funded degrees. So, yeah, Catra had been an influence in her decision. Which made her wonder…

"You were always the arty one. Music, drawing, painting," she said, trying to keep the shake from her voice. "So, why – uh, why Literature?"

As a teen, Adora had been a big reader. Try as she might, Catra wasn't interested in the fantastical stories she appreciated. It was indulgent to think Catra had been influenced by Adora like Adora had been influenced by her.

"Similar to you," Catra said, still not meeting her eyes. "Therapy."

She shouldn't have expected anything different.

"Ah. Snap. So… why teaching?"

“Well, you know how it is when you leave the army.” Catra shrugged. “I looked at the options, and thought teaching was the best. Like you must’ve done.”

“Oh. Yeah.” The army didn’t offer a wide range of rehabilitation careers; the main three strands were engineering, communications or teaching.

Catra looked at her for the first time while she stubbed the cigarette against the wall. Her heterochromatic gaze flicked to the scar on Adora’s cheek and then to her blue eyes. She saw something there and scowled. Looked away. “Don’t do that.”

Adora opened her mouth. Closed it again. Her stomach swelled nervously. “Do what?” she asked.

“This is nothing." Catra dropped the cigarette and crushed it under her foot. "I’m being civil because we work together now, okay? Don’t give me the doe eyes like this means something.”

“Oh, I wasn’t –”

“I’m serious, Adora." Walking past her to the door, Catra's face twisted in a mixture of anger and pain. "After what you did – just stay out of my way, okay? Stay very fucking far away.”

This time, Adora didn’t follow her.

That was different from what she remembered.

Catra locked herself in her classroom and sat at her desk, her sharp nails trailing across her scalp until she calmed down. Fuck Adora. Bringing up memories and *feelings* she thought she’d stamped out years ago.

She was a mess inside. Completely torn up and raging, pulsing with thorned thoughts and soft aches. No, she wasn’t going back there, in that space that had almost destroyed her. She was better than that and refused to let it happen. It had taken years for her

to feel like a normal person again, and losing sight of that hadn't been the plan.

Then again, taking her frustration out on Adora wasn't part of the plan, either.

Sucking in a shallow breath, Catra got up and started writing on the whiteboard. Pushing everything else out of her mind, she focused on words and words alone: *Satire in the works of Jane Austen*.

Her class was arriving outside, but she wasn't in the mood to let them in*. Let them wait*, she thought.

Their voices drifted through the door.

"What do you have after this?"

"Art."

"Who with?"

"Miss Greyskull."

Catra rolled her eyes. She was everywhere, wasn't she? Even when she wasn't here, she was everywhere. *In more ways than one*, her mind added, betraying her.

"Is it true what they say about her?"

"What do they say about her?"

"That she's the reason the war is over."

A third, new voice added, "She's also a traitor."

Catra stopped writing.

"Huh?"

"My mum says she abandoned her post."

“Don’t they kill you for desertion?”

“Yeah, but she got away with it because everyone thinks she’s a hero.” The new voice snorted. “There’s rumours she didn’t do half of the things during the war they say she did.”

Before Catra knew what she was doing, she threw open the door with such force that she almost ripped it off its hinges. Three small girls looked up at her, a mixture of shock and fear in their eyes. Crushing the pen in her hand, Catra snarled, “Get *in* here and stop gossiping. If I hear you talk about another teacher like that again, I’ll” – she heaved a breath – “I’ll give you all detention.”

The girls looked at each other.

“*Understood*?” she hissed.

“Yes, Miss.”

“Sorry Miss.”

Probably not the best first impression to give her class, but Catra couldn’t care less. How dare they – how could they – what? Have an opinion about Adora? It wasn’t even a *lie*. She did abandon her post – she *did* leave everyone behind. So, why did it incite rage in Catra? Hell, she’d heard worse opinions about her from ex-colleagues. It wasn’t exactly a secret. Adora *was* controversial.

A wave of embarrassment sank over Catra until it felt like she was drowning. She shouldn’t care what people said about Adora. Adora was nothing to her. Just somebody she used to know, somebody who used to mean –

Catra realised with a start that her class was seated and staring at her. Clearing her throat, she picked up the worn copy of *Pride and Prejudice* on her desk and said, “Satire. Saying one thing and meaning another.”

Chapter End Notes

(please excuse the liberal creative freedom of the meaning of the word 'satire'; I needed to bend it to fit the subtext)

Apparently, it's Adora's birthday (we're almost birthday twins), so here's a chapter in her honour.

Thank you for all the comments and support so far! They're a great motivator and let me know what I'm doing right/wrong.

Stay safe.

Cx.

Granola Bars

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Bow and Glimmer were in love, that much was certain.

Sometimes Adora felt like all her friends were paired with their soulmates apart from her. She never felt left out or left behind, however; Bow and Glimmer in particular kept the public displays of affection to a minimum and included her in nearly everything they did.

But, it was a fact: Bow and Glimmer were in love, and on special occasions, like Bow's birthday dinner, she particularly noticed it.

Bow's love language was acts of service, whereas Glimmer's was gift-giving. Combined, they attacked parties – no matter how big or small – like it was a competition; every year they tried to one-up the other, and this year was no different.

After a birthday dinner with their mutual close friends (which included half of the teaching staff) on Friday night, Saturday night was saved for the Best Friend Squad.

Glimmer had transformed the entire living room into a pillow fort; there were cushions all over the floor, fairy lights trailing the walls, and a giant projector screen where the window should be. At first, Adora was taken aback by how creative yet simple her surprise had been. Last year, Glimmer had brought them on a surprise weekend getaway for Bow's birthday. Just as Adora was about to comment, however, she noticed Bow's reaction.

The birthday boy stood in the middle of the room, eyes positively shining, and wearing an expression of unadulterated joy.

"This is amazing!" he nearly yelled, making Adora jump. "A pillow fort – just like how we – when we were teens –"

"We used to hide away in your den," Glimmer finished for him, smirking. "Yep. I remembered. How good am I?"

Bow, shrieking, grabbed Glimmer by the waist and spun her in the air. "You're the best!"

Meanwhile, Adora watched with a fond smile, feeling a twist of missed nostalgia she occasionally felt with Bow and Glimmer. They had known each other since they were kids – that kind of bond was irreplaceable, and while they had adopted her into their gang of two (a bit like how a couple might adopt a golden retriever), there were some things that couldn't be replicated. This was obviously one of those things; Bow had just turned twenty-eight and was nearly crying over a pillow fort.

You had to be there.

The three friends settled into their loungewear and fought over what movie they wanted to watch first. Personally, Adora had never been a film fan; she rarely had the attention-span for anything over half an hour in length, so spent most of the time fidgeting and trying hard to pay attention. But this was Bow's birthday, and they'd already watched her favourite tv series five times over (*Buffy the Vampire Slayer*, in case you're wondering; a superhero blonde with the weight of the world on her shoulders felt oddly relatable).

Bow decided on another remake of *Robin Hood,* and then they ordered takeaway. Adora's favourite weekends were spent with Bow and Glimmer. A warmth settled in her chest whenever she was with them, talking nonsense and having raging social justice conversations. Tonight, however, she felt a little distant.

Adora's mind was elsewhere.

"Are you okay, Adora?" Bow asked between mouthfuls of noodles.

"Yeah!" she said quickly, in a voice that was a little too high. "I'm fine. Just – uh, tired."

Bow and Glimmer shared a *look*, and Adora groaned.

They were going to talk about feelings, weren't they?

"Alright, listen up," said Glimmer, and she physically took Adora's rice away. Adora tried to chase it with her chopsticks, but Glimmer slapped her hand. "We need to talk."

"What about?" she asked, swallowing hard.

"You. Catra."

Adora groaned and hid her face with her palms. "Oh no."

"Oh yes," Glimmer countered

Adora peeked through a finger. "What do you want to talk about specifically?"

"Well, you haven't seen her in five years," Bow said, putting his food down. Softly, he added, "We know what she meant to you."

Folding her knees and hugging them against her chest, Adora muttered, "I don't mean anything to her anymore. She made that clear."

"That's understandable," Glimmer said.

Adora couldn't help feeling a little betrayed, but it was fair. After what she'd done, sometimes she even struggled to stare at her own reflection. "Yeah. I get it."

"You did betray her trust," Glimmer added.

"To save her life," Adora replied.

"You left her alone in the middle of a battlefield –"

"*To save her life*," she snapped this time. "Besides, she couldn't – she didn't know the full story." Pausing, she hugged her legs closer. "She wasn't allowed to know the full story."

"Exactly," Glimmer said, snapping her fingers. "She doesn't know. Of course she's still hurt, anyone would be."

And she couldn't know. The secret had left her feeling heavy for years, almost all of her adult like. It was the reason why she wore certain types of clothing and she hated beach holidays. How would she even begin to explain it to Catra, who had been through it all with her but was kept in the dark? It would only make things worse. "It doesn't matter," Adora muttered.

"What doesn't matter?"

Sighing, she looked up at her two friends. "I think it's too late to change things. Even if she knew – it's Catra. It wouldn't change anything."

"You're not going to change things with an attitude like that," Bow pointed out.

Adora frowned. "Huh?"

"I'm not going to call what you did 'wrong'," he said. His eyes were so bright and sincere. "You saved Catra and a bunch of other people. You helped to end the war. But, you could try to put things right with her. Build a bridge, make amends."

Make amends. Adora wasn't sure she knew how to make amends. As a child, owning up to mistakes got you punished. In the army, there was no room for mistakes of any kind. But in real life, with people? Maybe it was something she could work on. "You really think I could?"

Bow offered a smile. "I think you could do anything, if you wanted."

It was Saturday night. For some people this meant parties and nightclubs and drinking and hook-ups. But Catra had moved past that part of her life.

So, her and Scorpia sat on the sofa of their apartment, eating snacks and drinking beer. You know, having girl time.

Scorpia had put on one of her favourite action movies to fill the silence. Catra wasn't exactly known for being talkative. Tonight, however, Catra had a lot on her mind and things she wanted to get off her chest. Beer loosened her lips and opened her iron-clad heart, which, to be fair, had become less metallic and more padded over the last few years since leaving the army.

"Hey, Scorpia?"

Scorpia paused the film. "Yeah, Wildcat?"

The words were out before she thought them. "Adora abandoned her post, didn't she?"

Scorpia's eyes widened, the way she always did when Catra talked about one of her sensitive subjects. "Uh, I believe she was called back to duty and refused to go."

Catra nodded. She knew that. "Then she ran away."

"Yeah, pretty much." Scorpia looked uncomfortable for a few moments. Clearing her throat, she added, "Why are you asking?"

To buy time and collect her cool, Catra took a long sip of beer. She drank until the tin was empty. Unable to avoid the question any longer, she said, "It just – I was so angry at the time that I didn't question it. But it just seems so unlike Adora, you know?"

The Adora she thought she knew would never leave anyone behind. If her superiors wanted something of her or expected something, she would go along with it, no questions asked. She was loyal to the point of it being a problem, and the idea of Adora refusing to go back to service – and going as far as fleeing the country at one point – didn't make sense.

And despite her better judgement, Catra wanted to know. What had changed?

“Yeah, she was always so loyal.” Scorpia’s tone lowered. “Then again, with what happened to the two of you at the – well, you know. Who can blame her.”

Catra wanted to skirt right past that topic. “Why wasn’t she arrested or put in prison?”

“Well, she was still a war hero. In reality, though, I don’t know. I don’t think anyone knows apart from Adora herself.”

Absent-mindedly, Catra crushed the beer tin. “Hm.”

Scorpia’s gaze flicked between Catra, the crushed can, and the tv. In a whisper, she asked, “How was it this week? Seeing her again?”

“Confusing,” Catra murmured.

“You wanted the job because you wanted to make amends.”

“No, I wanted the job because it was a good job,” Catra corrected bitingly. Then she sighed. “And I also wanted to talk to her.”

Scorpia clapped her back, almost pushing her off the sofa altogether with her strength. “You’ve came on a long way, Wildcat. It wasn’t long ago you couldn’t even mention her name without blowing up or crying or –”

Catra scowled. “I did not cry.”

Scorpia raised her big hands in a surrender. “Okay. Whatever you say.”

But Scorpia was right, wasn’t she? Annoyingly, she was usually right. For years, Catra had unhealthy coping mechanisms. She pushed everyone away and became self-destructive. There was a time that she would have a breakdown at anyone mentioned Adora or what happened on the battlefield.

Catra went to therapy and, sure, it wasn't perfect. It took time and effort and she needed to improve herself, actively, for herself. Somehow, she had made it through the other end. It didn't mean she lost grip on herself sometimes – this week had been proof of it. But she'd came a long way.

And with that thought, she felt like admitting her weaknesses was comparable to confessing sins. "I shouted at her," Catra muttered.

"During work?"

"Yeah. She's just so – I forgot how difficult it was. Being around her." *She's all-consuming*.

Scorpia nodded between mouthfuls of crisps. "Well, take it slow. If you decide you don't want to clear the air, you can always walk away." She rested her hand on the brunette's shoulder. "Do what's best for you."

"Yeah." Catra felt a pit open in her stomach. She needed to take it one step at a time, and hopefully, if she ever managed to tell Adora her side of the story, she could close out that entire section of her life. That's what she needed, wasn't it? "Thanks, Scorp."

Ten years old

It was Friday afternoon, which meant art class. Catra's favourite.

Their teacher passed around the pencils and paintbrushes, and covered their desks with old newspaper. Despite the precautions, it didn't stop accidents; Kyle managed to get PVC glue in his hair, resulting in a lot of tears and tantrums.

Their teacher was giving them prompts; she said a word and they had to draw what they felt, or what they thought the word meant. For Catra, this was no problem. Her mind regularly conjured detailed images with very little inspiration, and she had no trouble portraying it on a blank page. Over the past year especially – since things at the home had been worse – getting images out of

her head and onto a page helped Catra to calm down. When words and feelings often left her feeling muddled, images and colours and symbols made sense.

Adora, on the other hand, struggled with something that you couldn't *learn*. The first prompt was 'draw what makes you happy'. Catra had painted herself and Adora, playing outside beside their favourite tree. Adora had stared at it for far too long while her own sheet of paper remained blank.

"You drew us?" Adora asked in a small voice.

Catra's face flushed. She knew Adora probably remembered the day they'd climbed their favourite tree for the first time; it wasn't exactly a happy memory, but it held a special place in her heart. They'd climbed the tree, Adora had fallen, and Ms Weaver got mad; she sent Catra to bed without dinner. Adora had crawled into her bed that night with a stolen granola bar. But why did it matter? Well, Catra remembered how hard they laughed when they'd finally reached the highest branch, feeling on top of the world. After Adora had fallen, the blonde girl then defied Shadow Weaver twice for Catra: once when she stole the granola bar, and again when she suggested they go back to the tree, despite Weaver forbidding it.

Most of Catra's fondest memories were bittersweet. This one was just more sweet than bitter.

But Adora's intense stare left Catra feeling embarrassed. She dumped her paintbrush into the water pot and crossed her arms. "Don't make a big thing of it."

Adora didn't. She held her pencil between her finger and thumb, her forehead scrunching in a knot. Rather suddenly, she put her pencil down and pushed away the paper.

"What are you doing?" Catra snapped.

"I can't draw what makes me happy," the blonde replied. "Happiness is a *feeling*. I don't know what it looks like."

“She’s talking about memories, dummy.” Catra rolled her eyes.

“How do you know? Everyone’s drawing different things!”

Blinking, Catra looked around the class. Sure enough, Adora was right. Some people had drawn items like their bed, or their favourite football. Others had drawn food, family, their pets. Catra frowned.

As foster kids, Catra and Adora didn’t have much that they personally owned. They couldn’t call anything *theirs*. It belonged to the home, it belonged to their carers. The only thing Catra owned and took pride in was her experiences, her memories. Compared to her classmates, the loneliness of experience was overwhelming.

“Next up, I want you to draw love,” their teacher instructed, still trying to get the glue out of Kyles hair. “Draw what you think love is.”

Catra and Adora looked at each other. Love wasn’t a word they’d grown up seeing the meaning of, either. It was Catra’s turn to sigh and look disgruntled.

Love? What was love?

Catra looked to her classmates for inspiration. Most of them were drawing their family; parents hugging them, hugging each other, with little hearts around their faces. Catra felt a hot shot of anger burn through her.

If love was just for families, for doting parents, then had Catra never experienced love? She didn’t have any of those things, and yet, it didn’t feel right. Her mind instantly thought of Adora. What she felt for Adora, that feeling of wholeness, that feeling of being whatever she wanted to be in front of her without judgement – was that not love? Surely, love could be moments as well as family – surely it could be in other people, in other forms.

She stared at her previous painting. It was hardly her best work; the tree looked a little lopsided, and she definitely hadn't captured the correct blue of Adora's eyes. But that memory – that memory she associated with feeling happy – was because Adora did something for her.

Why would Adora risk stealing a granola bar for Catra? They both knew the consequences if she'd been caught.

Weaver's rage was the opposite of love.

Love was a moment, in actions, in words. It was in Adora hugging Catra through her nightmares. It was in Catra fighting anyone who dared to make fun of Adora's stupid little hair poof.

She knew exactly what to draw.

"Alright, then," their teacher said after a few more moments. "I'm going to take a walk around and see what you've drawn."

Catra glanced to the side to see Adora with her nose nearly touching the page, finishing her own image of love. Catra scoffed when the blonde girl pulled away, revealing…

A pink floaty blob.

Adora thought love was a pink floaty blob?

Jeez, she was more hopeless than Catra had thought.

When the teacher looked over their shoulders to see their art, her eyes immediately landed on Adora's pencil drawing.

"And what have you drawn, Adora?"

"What I think love is."

"And what is it, exactly?"

"A feeling. The feeling you get in your chest, and sometimes it gets so big that it feels like your chest will explode. I think this is

what love looks like – I think it's inside of us, and it makes us feel happy. Sometimes sad."

"That's very… abstract." Her smile was terse, but Adora didn't look disheartened. She looked proud, like she'd figured something out. When the teacher looked at Catra's art, her eyebrows snaked up her forehead. "And you, Catra?"

Catra's cheeks burned. It was quite obvious what her drawing was.

"It's a granola bar," she said, flatly.

The teacher nodded. "You must really love granola bars."

But Adora turned to her, eyes shining.

Chapter End Notes

Going to have to update the tags to include painful amounts of pining for this one. Thank you for reading - comments and kudos encourage me to keep going!

Stay safe.

Cx.

Familiar

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Adora wiped her hands on her overalls; for some reason they were covered in yellow paint. It was strange, she'd just taken a line drawing class, hadn't she? So, where had the paint come from?

She looked around but the classroom was empty. No one else was here. When she pulled her hands away from her apron, she noticed the yellow paint hadn't budged. She wiped them again. And again.

For a moment the yellow paint turned red, and it wasn't paint at all – it was blood, crimson blood, coating her hands, dripping to the floor, slick and hot and –

Another blink and the classroom faded in a flash.

She was standing in the middle of the Thaymor camp, and there was a battle raging around them.

"Adora, get down!"

Someone pushed their body on top of her, and they fell together onto the dusty ground.

"What the hell are you doing?"

Adora looked up at the familiar face.

Catra. Just how she remembered. So young and cocky. Her brown skin had a sheen of sweat underneath the guarded helmet.

Adora was suddenly aware of her own attire – she was wearing her teaching clothes, paint-covered apron and all. A jolt of panic

surged through her. She couldn't wear *this* in the middle of a battlefield. How hadn't Catra noticed she was unfit for service?

"I – I don't –" Adora pushed Catra away. "I don't understand what's happening."

"That's nothing new, is it, Adora?" Catra snarled. "You never see what's right in front of you. You never have. Not at the foster home, not here. Not even inside your own head."

Before she had a chance to react, two pairs of hands pulled her back to her feet. Adora couldn't stop staring at Catra – at that haunted expression she knew so well.

"Adora, snap out of it."

Glimmer was here? Bow? How did that make any sense?

"You two can't be here," Adora urged, trying to shield them with her body from the debris flying through the air. "It's too dangerous!"

"They're coming," Glimmer said. "They're coming for you, just like they said they would."

Adora frowned. "Who's coming?"

But she knew, didn't she? It was the source of her nightmares, it was –

Nightmare.

This wasn't real.

Adora woke up, gasping for air. The cropped cotton top she'd worn to bed was soaked with sweat, and her duvet had tangled around her legs. She scrambled to free herself, desperate to escape from the bed, the source of her bad dreams. Stumbling into the bathroom, she slammed her hand into the button of the shower and lost herself under the burst of water. It was cold and

made her gasp but she didn't care – anything would help, anything that could make her feel clean again, washed of regret and pain and disappointment and failure and –

It was always bad, coming up to anniversaries. After the progress she made last year, this seemed like a massive backslide. But, Perfuma had warned her about this, hadn't she? A downturn didn't mean she was down. Adora had picked herself up plenty of times, and she would keep doing it. She had to. No one else was going to do it for her.

A little voice in her subconscious reminded her that she should call someone, which started a battle of wills inside her: two different strands of argument, the weaker one being *you're not a burden* and the other, louder one believing that they just *don't need to know*.

Therapy had helped Adora through a lot, but she still didn't understand how calling someone through the middle of the night because of a post-traumatic stress disorder-influenced nightmare *wasn't* burdening someone. She could accept her friends didn't see her as something fragile, broken, or their extra baggage, but she couldn't accept that she wasn't a burden. She had extra weight to carry, and she didn't want to share it.

Instead, Adora decided to go for an early morning run. If her mind wouldn't let her rest, then at least she could still take care of her body. With some effort, she may even look human for work later.

It was Catra's first staff meeting.

And she hated it already.

Everyone here was so *nice* and *friendly*. A few years ago, Catra's cynical side would've gotten the best of her; she would've despised and resented every staff member in this stupid school.

As it was, she only felt mildly disgruntled at the fact people were talking to her with smiles on their faces before 9am.

Catra didn't need to look around to know Adora had entered the room. A shiver tickled her skin as she recognised the weight of the footsteps passing by her. Her stomach jumped, and it must've shown on her face, because Perfuma, the person who was talking at her, frowned, then look concerned.

"I'm fine," Catra said quickly.

Shit. Once upon a time ago, she had been so good at this – not letting Adora affect her. A five year absence combined with a traumatic war must've lowered her defences.

Apparently cutting Adora out of her life and then trying to stitch her back in – however temporarily – had made Catra act like a nervous teenager again.

Perfuma seemed to add it all together. She stared at Adora across the room and back at Catra.

Catra's ears blushed.

"Do you know her? Adora?"

"No," she lied, instinctively.

Perfuma's eyebrows shot up. "She's staring at you. And you tensed up when she walked past."

Stupid Adora. Catra couldn't dare look around now. Instead, she shrugged and crossed her arms, sliding low on the chair. "Whatever. I don't know her, okay?"

Perfuma hummed in response. "My door is always open if you want to chat, you know."

Catra didn't respond, she just scowled. *One therapist was enough, thanks.* It had taken her long enough to find a good one, and she

didn’t like the idea of opening up to someone on that level again. In her experience, most of them were just nosey, judgemental asshats.

Luckily, Catra didn’t have to brew in her sullen silence for long; Sparkles saved her a few minutes later by starting the staff meeting. With baby pink hair and outfits that always glittered, she didn’t look the typical image of a school principal. Catra wasn’t sure if she would’ve appreciated the act of uniformed rebellion or laughed at it when she was a teenager. Come to think of it, she wasn’t sure if she liked it or loathed it now, either.

Five minutes into the school news and reminders to practise good health and safety, Catra had to stifle a yawn. Her mind was already drifting to her first class – Chaucer with the older kids – and she was so lost in her train of thought that she almost missed the last, most important, point.

“As some of you already know, we’re having an Open Day in December for parents and perspective students. Some of our investors will also be visiting, so we need to show off the talent in Brightmoon and make each department shine. The sports teams will be on the field, the Science departments will have a display, and...” Glimmer looked at Catra and someone at the back of the room. “I would like the Literature department to work with the Drama department to put on a show for us. Then, the Art department will –”

“Show?” Catra interrupted. Ah, crap, she probably shouldn’t have done that. Too late now. “Sorry, what do you mean by *show*?”

“A performance, darling,” someone said. Catra followed the voice and judging by their appearance – black high-heels, long blonde hair and a shimmery long coat – they *had* to be a Drama teacher. Talk about a walking stereotype. “A *play*. It’s tradition for Brightmoon to end our annual Open Day with a jaw-dropping spectacle.”

“Don’t worry, though, Catra,” Glimmer added. “We’re all in this together and we all pitch in our support. You and DT won’t be responsible for all of it, I promise.”

Catra felt a twinge of anxiety but managed to push it down before it escalated. Glimmer wrapped up the staff meeting, and Catra was careful to busy herself with her book bag in case anyone tried to chat to her again.

Her efforts were futile, however, because Sparkles was over within a blink, asking in sickly sweet voice, “Catra, can I talk to you for a moment?”

Standing up straight, Catra regarded her. They were on eye-level with one another, so she didn’t feel the need to stretch her body out like she did when talking to a taller person. The way Sparkles look at her though – soft around the edges, like she already knew her, wound Catra up the wrong way.

Or, maybe it was just Catra’s ever-persistent problem with authority and Sparkles was just generally a really nice boss.

Maybe.

“I don’t see why not.”

“Great, um” – Glimmer looked around at their colleagues filtering out of the room – “Huntara, our PE teacher, has had to take a few weeks sick leave because of a broken ankle.” She paused, chewed on her lip. “And I hear you come with highly commended experience in activities like kick-boxing, martial arts and gymnastics.”

“Army certified,” she said with a mock salute.

Glimmer gave a dry laugh. “Exactly, well, I know it’s short notice, so feel free to say no, but Huntara usually takes MMA after school on a Monday. Her assistant has agreed to take over, but we need two teachers present.” Grimacing, Glimmer added, “The kids who take MMA can be a bit… feisty.”

Catra put her hand on her hip as she thought about it. Quite a few years had past since she'd practised any sort of martial arts, but it was ingrained into her as muscle memory at this point. For some sentimental reason, the idea of teaching little angry-at-the-world kids like her made her feel some things. Good things.

Despite this, she still asked, "Extra pay?"

Glimmer winked. "Time and a half for extra-curricular activities."

That was it settled, then. More money *and* it intrigued her. "Sure, I'm up for that. I'll need to go home at lunch to pick up some kit, though."

Glimmer *beamed*. Her whole face lit up like a beacon, as if Catra had made her entire week by just agreeing to do a paid favour.

Everyone in this school was *intolerable*.

"Take all the time you need!" she said, slowly backing towards the door. "It's in the gym hall at four-thirty. The cover teacher will already have it set up."

Catra waved her off and, feeling slightly uncomfortable with herself, she walked to her classroom with a slightly lighter step than before.

The Adora situation aside, Catra could get used to it here.

Catra did take all the time she needed at lunch to find appropriate gym gear. Lately, the only exercise she had committed to was cardio and basic weights. Her hand and ankle wraps were stuffed at the back of her closet, and there was no way she was going to allow some bratty teenager to accidentally break her wrist without the appropriate gear.

Part of the reason why Catra had decided to be a teacher was because she liked the idea of helping young people like the girl she had been, desperate for a relatable adult figure in her life.

Someone who wasn't stuffy, or unreliable, or *anything* like Mrs Weaver. In reality, Catra taught Literature to kids who didn't care about the subject, or were only there to get a grade. This was understandable; the education system was an utter *failure*. Sometimes she even resented her part in it.

This idea, however, of helping kids outside of the classroom sparked a new flame of interest in Catra. In her experience, students only stayed in school longer than they needed to for two reasons: they wanted to improve their grade, or they needed to escape their home.

Catra and Adora had been the latter.

And if you were taking MMA after school? You were either seriously into sport or, once again from Catra's perspective, in need of an outlet.

Brightmoon took in the strays, after all; an all-inclusive school, who looked at your character and skill rather than your history, background or current grades.

Other schools would simply call the kids 'troubled' and call it a day.

No wonder Adora ended up here, Catra thought to herself. *Her and her stupid saviour complex.*

That afternoon, to show her enthusiasm, Catra arrived at the gym hall five minutes early, already dressed in her cropped leggings and hand wraps. Just as she was about to turn into the room, she heard a very familiar yell echoing through the hall.

"Jimmy! Avra – *stop!* Break it up!"

Of *fucking* course Adora was the MMA assistant taking over from Huntara.

Of course she was.

Catra slammed her fist into the wall, then leaned her head against the cool surface.

Adora. Was. Everywhere.

And it was far too late to back out of this now.

Instead of hiding in a dark corner like she wanted, Catra stood at the threshold, propping herself up against it. She crossed her arms and looked at the small gathering of students, watching as Adora marched across the room, pointing at two of them. A girl had a skinny boy in a headlock. She wasn't letting go.

Let's see how she handles this one, Catra thought. Adora always loved telling people what to do. This was all one big ego trip for her.

Adora forcibly separated the two teens. With a hand on each of their shoulders, she asked, "Are you going to tell me what happened, or am I going to ban you from the lesson?"

A beat.

The girl, Avra, huffed. "He was being annoying."

Adora looked to the scrawny boy, Jimmy. "Were you being annoying?"

He gave dramatic gasp. "No!"

Adora shrugged. "You *are* known to be annoying, Jimmy."

Catra could help but breathe out a silent laugh. They didn't teach *this* in teaching college.

"She hit me," Jimmy argued.

There it was – the tell-tale signs of Adora losing her patience. A vein pumped in her neck, and she spared a moment to massage the space between her eyebrows. "Alright, Avra, you can

apologise to Jimmy here, or you volunteer yourself to be used for all the demonstrations today. I have to warn you, though: first up I'm teaching round-kicks, and I won't be gentle."

"Fine." Avra narrowed her eyes at her classmate. "I'm sorry that you were being so annoying that I had to hit you to shut you up, Jimmy."

Adora sighed. "Close enough. And now you can both apologise to *me* for wasting my time."

"Sorry, Miss Greyskull."

"Yeah. Sorry, miss."

"Alright, sit down. Since Huntara is off on sick leave, I'll be taking you on my own for the foreseeable future, so *please* don't –"

Catra, hating herself for it, puffed out her chest and cleared her throat.

She walked into the room and all eyes locked on her.

Adora's eyes, especially, were the size of dinner plates.

"Catra?" she squeaked. "What are you doing here?"

Catra twirled around with an arm in the air. "The principal asked me to be your glamourous assistant, and here I am. Exactly as she ordered."

There was no way she was going to let Adora think she was here of her own free will. Absolutely no way.

Adora opened her mouth. Closed it again. Her little brain was whirring so loudly that Catra swore the whole room could hear it. The students looked between the two adults, wearing a range of emotions.

Catra smirked. Oh, she *missed* flustered Adora. It was so fun to tease her, wind her up and leave her hanging.

"What's wrong?" she challenged. "You know I'm more than qualified."

Adora must've recognised the teasing lilt of her tone, because her eyes flashed, and her lips twisted into challenging smile. "No, no, I remember," she said, drawing it out. "If I remember correctly, though, in our last match, I had you pinned to the mat in less than five minutes. I wouldn't want you getting hurt."

Some of the students made dramatic 'oooooo' sounds. Catra stopped just a metre away from her ex-best friend and raised an eyebrow. "I had to let you win *one*, pr –" Catra cut herself off. Her own cheeks blushed as she realised she'd almost called her by their old pet name. "– Adora," she amended.

If the blonde caught her slip up, she didn't show it. Instead, Adora's eyes ran across Catra's face, as if drinking up every detail. This felt too… familiar. As Catra started to feel the pull of rising anxiety, a student interrupted them.

"Do you two – uh, know each other or something?"

Adora spun around so quickly that her shoes squeaked on the rubber floor. "Yeah – yes, we do. This is Miss Areli, the new Literature teacher, and we – well, we were in the army together."

Catra looked at her hands. Five years apart and suddenly that's all she was, was she? An old colleague? Never mind the growing up together, the running away together, the hostile years in the army, the special forces journey together – that's all they were now: old army mates.

Catra's stomach twisted at the thought.

But that's what you wanted, she told herself. *Just last week you told her that she meant nothing to you.*

Well, that was certainly enough introspection for one day. Any icky feelings she experienced from here on would be firmly stored in the 'save for later' box in her mind.

For now, however, she would feel a hell of a lot better wiping Adora's perfect smirk from her perfect mouth.

Did she just say *perfect*?

Save for later. Save for later. Save for later.

Adora started the lesson by demonstrating a couple of new moves, then splitting the students into pairs so they could practise taking it in turns. She asked Catra to observe for potential casualties and correct them where they went wrong.

So far, it was going well. Adora and Catra kept to their own sides of the room, never crossing paths. Catra was so focused on helping the students and giving them tips that she almost forgot she was teaching. It felt so casual, so free. The students interacted with her like she was one of them, and it made her feel… warm.

Another thing for the icky feelings box.

What she was trying to say, was that the environment Huntara and Adora had created in their after-school class was very casual and, simply, nice.

When the hour was up, Adora asked everyone to gather on the mats in front of her so she could recap on their lesson. Catra stood at the back, watching.

And then Jimmy asked, "Is there no roleplay this week, miss?"

Adora stumbled. "Um, you see – I uh –"

"Go on, miss," another prompted. "It's our favourite part!"

"What's the roleplay?" Catra asked.

“Me and Huntara would demonstrate how to use the new moves in a quick match,” Adora answered quickly, her neck and chest flushing. “Because some of the kids here are under sixteen, we’re not supposed to encourage full fighting, so we do it as their teachers instead.”

“And you don’t want to do it today because…?”

“You. I don’t want you to, you know, feel uncomfortable.”

“I’ll do it.”

“You – you will?”

“Yeah, why not? I’m a bit rusty, but I can manage.”

“Oh. Okay, then. Sure. We’ll do it.”

It had no business being this awkward. Adora led Catra over to the mats and the students gathered around them in a circle. Catra and Adora faced each other on opposite sides, just like old times.

Just like old times. Catra could remember exactly how Adora fought; she knew her weaknesses, her strengths, the force of her hits, how to make her lose balance. If Catra lost focus on the room, she felt fifteen again, doing this for the first time, finding release in the activity. Adora’s hair was even in that stupid ponytail again, and she was wearing a red and white top.

It made her feel a mixture of regret and sweet nostalgia.

Time to punch out some of those icky feelings.

“Today we learnt two new kicks; the round kick and the push kick,” Adora started. “Now, Miss Areli and I will demonstrate how to use one or both of them in a match.”

Catra was too concerned with how Adora saying her name like that made her stomach flutter that she almost missed her counting down to start.

Fuck this girl, seriously.

"One... two... three... go!"

On the word ‘go’, Catra immediately bounced across the mat to corner Adora, who had her fists up, her feet hopping. When their eyes locked, Catra saw the familiar signs of Adora holding back; her movements were too slow, her pacing careful, considered, measured.

Catra made a left jab and then right jab. Adora dodged both. In an attempt to loosen her up, Catra playfully demonstrated a round kick that she knew Adora would easily defend with a twist of a leg. It did the job, though; Adora advanced, swinging left, and finishing off with an uppercut. Catra used the momentum against her; as she ducked, she attempted a leg-trip.

When they were younger, Catra’s leg-trips rarely succeeded – Adora’s core was too strong against Catra’s lithe form. Which was why, when Adora lost balance and fell on her side, Catra was taken back.

Huh. Adora wasn’t the opponent she used to be.

As Catra descended on her, Adora defended herself by hooking her legs behind the brunette’s ankles and using an elbow jab. Breath hitching as the blow caught her in the chest, Catra started to fall back, which gave Adora a chance to flip them over.

Adora pinned her to the mat and counted to ten.

Catra made no attempt to escape. Why?

This was the closest they’d been in five years, she realised. It made her think about a few things.

Her ex-best friend felt so *light* on top of her. It didn’t feel like Adora pinning her down at all. Adora had always felt so solid, so *real*. Catra stared up at the strands of blonde hair falling into her sweaty face, reassuring herself that she was really here. Catra's

eyes made their way down to the crooked scar running from cheek to jaw, and unwanted memories flooded her mind.

What had happened to them?

The betrayal and the heartbreak aside, where had Adora gone?

Why hadn’t Catra followed?

When Adora counted ‘nine’, Catra pushed herself up out from under her. The students applauded and a loud chatter filled the room. Slightly embarrassed at the attention, Catra waved them off and told them to tone it down.

Adora was taking her time standing up. Catra tried not to notice how she clutched her left side. The brunette fought with herself for a moment – a part of her wanted to offer Adora a hand to help, but she felt physically rooted to the spot. Unmovable. Stuck.

“Alright, end of the lesson,” Adora said to the students. “See you next week.”

The students left together in smaller groups, some taking their time to grab their things. Catra stood back, gaze lingering far too long on the slight shake of Adora's legs.

Leaving her to it, Catra decided to make herself useful by tidying away the equipment. With her back turned, she listened as Adora heaved herself up and caught her breath.

Suddenly, only sounds were the mats dragging across the rubber floor and the footsteps of the last student leaving the hall.

“Thank you.”

Catra froze. Oh. It wasn't something she had expected to hear. Wiping at her forehead, she said, “I was doing Glimmer a favour.”

“Still, though… thank you. And you don’t need to put the mats away, I’ll do it.”

“I don’t mind –”

“It’s fine," Adora amended, tone sharp. "I don’t want to keep you any longer than I need to.”

Oh. Catra clenched her hands.

They had felt so close a few moments ago.

Unable to look back, because she feared what she would say, Catra slipped on her shoes and walked to the exit. Her chest felt heavy, but her mind was light, as if it had shaken a burden. Before leaving, she turned slightly and looked somewhere to Adora’s right, avoiding her.

“You shouldn’t be doing this if you still have injuries,” she said.

Still, Catra couldn't look at her.

Adora was quiet. When she eventually spoke, she sounded… annoyed? Irritated?

“I’ll see you next week, Miss Areli.”

Right. This was... new. She'd seen plenty sides of Adora, but she'd never seen her formal. Detached.

Okay, she could respect that, couldn't she? They both had boundaries, apparently.

They weren’t friends anymore.

Catra had made that clear, and she would have to live with it.

For now.

Chapter End Notes

> Hey everyone! I had a thought while writing this chapter and that was that I've been using the word 'college' in the UK/Irish sense, meaning a school primarily for people

between the ages of 15-18. I think 'college' is the equivalent to university in the US, so just thought I'd clear that up.

I hope you enjoyed the latest instalment! Kudos and comments really keep me going and are always appreciated.

Stay safe.

Cx.

Runaways

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Sixteen years old

Adora had everything packed and triple checked, but she still looked around the room anxiously, feeling like she'd forgotten something important.

"Relax, we have everything," Catra said from under the bed.

"Right, sure, yeah – *relax*." Adora huffed a fake laugh. "Relax, she says, as if we're not about to run away from our foster home to join the army. What could possibly go wrong?"

Catra poked her head up over the bed. "Did you *have* to say that?"

"Why do you leave everything to the last minute anyway?" Adora retorted.

"We have plenty of time!" Catra argued. "Weaver won't wake up for another, like, five hours. As long as we leave just before sunrise, we'll be fine." In a softer tone, she added, "We've been through this."

"I know, I'm just –" Adora put her head in her hands and fell onto the bed. "I'm just scared."

"Listen." Catra crawled from underneath the bed and placed her hands on Adora's knees. "Tomorrow is the start of our lives. Our proper lives. We'll be working, we'll be getting paid. We'll have freedom; no more stupid rules or people breathing down our necks –"

"Catra, we're joining the army," Adora pointed out. "We're getting paid *for* people telling us what to do."

Catra pulled a face. "It's still different."

Adora watched as her best friend retreated underneath the bed, searching for who knows what. They *had* planned this to perfection, but now the consequences of their actions was starting to dawn on her. Over the past few months, Adora and Catra had been attending secret army recruitment drives after school and on weekends. They'd passed the assault courses, the health checks – all of it, without the permission of Ms Weaver, the head carer at their foster home.

According to the law, this wasn't illegal. They had rights at sixteen; they could move out of the home when they wanted, as long as they gained permission. The problem was Ms Weaver herself didn't want them to go.

When their carer woke up in the morning to find their beds empty without so much as a note, it was sure to have repercussions. Adora didn't particularly care for Weaver – well, it was complicated, but she hated the thought of being responsible for someone else's distress.

As she sat on the edge of the bed, staring at their empty room, Adora asked softly, "Will you miss it? Here, I mean."

Catra snorted, sitting up straight again. Her heterochromatic eyes burned into Adora's blue. "Seriously? You really have to ask that?"

Adora looked away. "Well, no, I just – never mind."

Honestly? She didn't know. When it came to feelings, Adora felt a little lost sometimes. She couldn't distinguish certain emotions from other ones, as if they all overlapped. Flexing her fingers, she tried to push down the lump in her throat. It made her feel stupid.

The mattress shifted as Catra sat next to her. "You'll miss it, won't you?"

And Adora appreciated that her voice only held a *slight* bite to her words.

"No, I – not really." She sighed. "It's complicated, you know? I don't like it here. I don't agree with what it stands for, or how it operates, but… it's the only place I've ever been allowed to call home."

Something flashed in Catra's eyes – something unreadable. She got up and stretched. "Whatever." Her nose twitched. "You'll probably miss Weaver's favouritism. You won't get any of that in the army." Catra saw the shadow of hurt cross Adora's face. Her chest tightened, so she threw a playful nudge towards the blonde's head. "I get it. But sometimes – sometimes *home* isn't a place. Sometimes it's a feeling or a person or – you know, whatever."

Catra turned towards the window before Adora could see the faint blush that tainted her cheeks. *That idiot has now idea*, she thought, cynically, feeling the need to punch something.

"And we'll have each other," Adora pointed out, making it so much worse.

"We've signed up to a four-year tour, dummy. We're stuck together for *at least* another four years."

Adora joined her at the window. Their joint reflection clouded the glass. In a tone of disbelief, as if aging wasn't a thing they were supposed to do, Adora whispered in awe, "We'll be twenty by then."

Catra laughed despite herself. "Well done, your maths skills get better every day."

Adora pushed her over. "Shut up, you know what I mean. Even if we don't like it, we'll be stuck in it until we're twenty. Twenty," she repeated, with emphasis. "It sounds so… mature."

And even though she hated to admit it, Catra felt a wave of nostalgia. If they hadn't been paired together all those years ago… what would her life look like now? Where would she be going? In a burst of bittersweet affection, Catra draped her arm around Adora's neck. "Just four years closer to ruling the world together. That's what we dreamt of as kids, right? In this bedroom."

Adora gave her a side-eye glare. "Now look at who's being sentimental."

Catra elbowed her away just as quickly. "Shut up."

They turned back to the room together. Adora stared at their bags on the bed – in them, everything they had to show for sixteen years of living. Catra stared at the door, finally accepting this was the last time she would walk through it. She never intended to look back.

"Do you want to go?" Adora whispered.

Catra reached for her hand. "Now more than ever, princess."

Present day

Adora was tired and sore after the MMA class with Catra. As she drove home, her mind replayed their last interaction; Catra standing at the door looking something akin to concerned, and the fiery rage that ignited in Adora. She kept going over it, trying to figure out what had caused her to have such a hostile reaction.

Just last week Catra had implied she didn't want anything to do with her. Then she shows up to the afterschool class, full of her old spirit, all cheekiness and sass, just like when they were younger. When they were friends.

To top it off, she acts concerned when Adora's injury flares up.

Concern.

After everything Adora did –

After everything Catra said.

But this should be a good thing, right? Maybe this was Catra's way of building a bridge.

It didn't *feel* good. How many bridges had Adora tried to build over the last five years?

And now Catra, when she feels like it, decides to act amicable, decides to offer her advice on her injuries she knows nothing about?

It didn't feel fair. Adora couldn't switch her emotions on and off like that. At the moment, she was having problems getting a hold of her emotions in the first place, controlling them was an altogether different concern.

Adora was barely through the door when she received a text from Glimmer. Not in the mood to deal with *that* yet, she threw her phone in her bag and put her bag on the kitchen table. She had so much marking to do; she had to review the sixth years' university applications and the fifth years' exam essays, not to mention research for the O'Keeffe lesson next week.

Instead of making a start on any of it, she stood at the window and sipped on a glass of water, staring out at the darkening sky. She had to breathe lightly to avoid pulling the aching muscles in her leg and hip. Catra had fought exactly how she remembered; she had been agile, fluid, strong. It was nothing like when she demonstrated the techniques to the students with Huntara, who just went through the motions. Catra had wanted to win, and Adora…

Adora wasn't sure how much fight was left in her anymore.

Her phone buzzed again, but this time it was a phone call.

Glimmer.

Adora collected a breath before answering.

“Well?” Glimmer gushed. “How was the class with Catra?”

Adora chewed on her bottom lip. “It was fine. I’m a professional, so it was fine.”

“Yeah, and…? Did you talk to each other?”

Pausing, Adora weighed up her options. She could tell Glimmer the truth, or she could brush it off completely. Adora really hated putting her foot down when it came to her two best friends; she always felt in the wrong, as if her frustration wasn’t as valid as their hurt feelings.

This was different, however – it felt different. Adora had boundaries – solid ones when it came to Catra – and Glimmer had crossed them.

“You shouldn’t have done that, Glimmer,” Adora said, monotone. “If I wanted to speak to Catra, I would. Forcing us together isn’t going to help anything, it’ll only make it worse.”

“I was only trying to help. The two of you –”

“Don’t. Don’t try to help,” Adora rebuked, temper rising. “You don’t know Catra and you don’t know –” …what didn’t she know? Who Adora was with Catra? The full story of what happened between them? As soon as the words were out, she regretted them. Trying to recover, she went on, “I just want to do my job and get on with it, okay? I don’t want meddling, I don’t want to talk about it, I don’t even want to think about it.”

Glimmer was quiet. Adora started to wonder if she’d went too far; her mind was messy, confused. She wasn’t sure if she got the words out in the right order. When she started to feel guilt, as heavy as lead, fall to the pit of her stomach, Glimmer replied, measuredly;

"Alright. I'm sorry. I shouldn't have inserted myself in the problem. I won't do it again."

It felt like someone had lifted the weight from Adora's sagging shoulders. "Thanks, Glim. And sorry for, you know, getting angry."

"Are you okay, Adora? You sound out of breath."

Adora blinked. "No, no, I'm fine. Just tired. The class really took it out on me." *Catra really took it out of me.*

"Do you want us to come over? Do you need anything?"

"I'm fine, honestly."

After insisting she was fine a few more times, Glimmer eventually let Adora go. Alone again, Adora sat on the edge of the kitchen chair with her hands supporting her head between her knees. She had felt so on edge recently and combined with the lack of sleep, she wasn't feeling herself – whatever 'herself' was these days.

But she had to snap out of it. She had things to do, responsibilities, and people were relying on her to be present, to be here.

As long as that kept her grounded, it would keep her rooted where she needed to be.

Catra breathed in through her nose and out through her mouth.

It didn't help, though.

These two kids were testing her *patience*.

"Listen to me, Ben, because I'm not going to repeat myself –"

"My name's Curtis," said the little idiot.

Catra narrowed her eyes. "*Curtis*, I don't care if you do your homework or not – it's your future, do what you want. I do,

however, have a problem when you constantly talk over me when I'm trying to teach. Do you understand?"

"Yes, Catra."

"It's *Miss Areli*."

The other boy – what was his name? John? Jacob? Whatever, she didn't care – smirked. "Some teachers let us call them by their first name," he snarked.

Catra crossed her arms. "Yeah? I'm not one of them." Ignoring her better judgement, she asked, "What were you two whispering about anyway?"

"Noth –"

"Curtis has a crush on you," said the annoying J name.

Curtis's entire face blazed red. It took all of Catra's self-restraint to not roll her eyes. Instead, she slammed her book on the desk and pointed at the door. "Get out. Both of you. You're wasting my lunch time."

The two boy scurried out, laughing as they went. Her skin crawled as she sat at her desk, shaking her head. Ugh, teenage boys. Was there anything worse than –

"So, the kitten has claws."

Catra looked up to see the Drama teacher standing at her door. She scowled.

Yes, something worse than teenage boys? Drama teachers.

The school Catra taught in last year was less *posh* than this one, and despite being a trainee teacher, Catra had still been dragged into staff gossip. The main culprit was *always* the Drama teacher – always oversharing overdramatic stories, and wearing shades indoors to hide a pair of bruised eyes. When Catra looked at

Brightmoon's offering of a Drama teacher, she felt the same over-zealousness that begged for gossip, that fed on rumours.

"I don't think I've introduced myself." Their high heels clapped against the tiles as they sauntered over, all grace and poise. "Dani Taylor, but everyone calls me DT. I use they/them pronouns, I take black coffee, no sugar, and I'm the head of the Drama department." They held out a hand for Catra to shake. "The pleasure is all mine."

Catra reluctantly shook it before refilling the coffee machine DT hadn't subtly hinted at wanting a cup of. "Catra, Lit teacher. New, in case you didn't notice."

DT perched on the edge of her desk. "Oh, but I *have*. You were a soldier, weren't you?"

It was a school, she should've expected rumours to spread. It did in her last one. Teachers were just as bad as students for standing in corners, discussing the latest hot news. It didn't make it easier to swallow, though. Her hands grasped her thighs. "Uh, yeah."

DT's green eyes widened. "Did you ever work with Brightmoon's resident war hero?"

Catra scoffed. "Who, Adora?"

"On first name terms, I see."

Catra turned away as her cheeks darkened. "Yeah." She cleared her throat as she poured DT an extra mug. "I mean, yes, I did." When Catra turned back around, she took care to school her features into a blank mask. "She's not the only one with medals, either."

DT purred. "Catty. I like it." They took the black coffee without thanks. "I thought we could get together, discuss the Open Day play. Get the creative juices flowing."

Catra blinked. *Oh yeah, that*. "What are you thinking?"

"Tell me a little bit more about yourself first." When DT saw Catra narrow her eyes, they laughed. "I like to get to know my colleagues before working with them. I'd like to find a play that suits us both."

She thought about it, she wasn't unreasonable – anymore. DT didn't even seem all that bad. Still, this felt like a game, and Catra hated games, especially at her own expense. "I'm not really up for a heart-to-heart," she said lightly. "So, why don't you go ahead and choose something and tell me what I need to do."

DT tapped the table with a long-nailed finger. "No worries, kitten. How about you come to me when you're ready, hm?" They stood up and walked slowly to the door, taking the coffee cup with them. "You know where to find me."

As soon as she was alone again, Catra slammed a palm against her forehead and groaned. She wasn't in the mood for collaborating, or projects, or work on top of her current workload. She didn't care about a stupid play with pushy parents and cringe-worthy performances. It was the least of her worries.

She wasn't even a theatre plan; there was only a handful of plays she could name, never mind explain.

There was one, though… One that she and Adora used to sing when they were kids, one that – not so long ago – had felt so relatable.

No. There was no way she was suggesting it.

No way. She'd never live it down if Adora found out it was her idea.

Cara sighed to herself. She was going to suggest it, wasn't she? She was getting softer as she was getting older, and it was *disgusting*.

Adora sat in her classroom with the door locked.

In her hands was a letter, and she knew who it was from by the return address printed on the back. When the postman had given it to her this morning, she didn’t have time to look at it. She had shoved it in her bag and forgotten about it until a few moments ago when she’d gone looking for her lunch.

But here it was. A single brown envelope addressed to her and her alone.

There was only one reason why they would contact her.

She couldn’t bring herself to open it. Not yet.

It felt like a dead weight in her hand when she shoved it to the bottom of her bag, hoping it would somehow get lost in there. Then, she sat back and stared into oblivion.

Adora had seen the news; she knew what was happening. She knew Etheria was on the brink of another war.

And the letter was a reminder of what was required of her when the time came.

Chapter End Notes

I didn't get this up when I wanted, but better late than never! I'm almost finished my other fic, so when that's all wrapped up, I will be able to put all my concentration into this one.

Thank you so much for your comments, I love reading them. Please keep them coming, they're a great motivator! I'm excited for the next chapter.

Stay safe.

Cx.

Panic

Chapter Summary

Content warning: panic attacks.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Eighteen years old

Catra sprawled on the tattered sofa, stretching her tired legs on the foot stool. Willing her eyes not to stray across the room at the blonde girl currently butchering a game of pool (seriously, the balls were going everywhere but the table), she gave a loud, obnoxious yawn. Scorpia sat on the sofa across from her, chatting animatedly about something she missed from back home. Catra half-listened, enough so she could mumble a response when necessary, but mostly she was earwigging to the conversation across the room, scowling whenever she heard one of the girls laugh.

Adora and Catra had drifted over the last year, and Catra was adamant that it wasn't her fault. Adora had made new friends, ones Catra didn't like. Why didn't she like them? That wasn't the point. Hadn't Catra made new friends too? Yes, but only because Adora had abandoned her for other people.

Or, it felt that way, anyway.

A red pool ball flipped off the table and rolled across the floor towards her. Catra stopped it with her foot and picked it up. Adora ran over, her arm outstretched, gesturing for Catra to throw it to her. Dressed in their fatigues – tight camo tees and baggy camo trousers – the fitted t-shirt emphasised the delicate swell of Adora's bicep, and the curve of her chest. Catra, annoyed at herself for noticing, dropped the ball at Adora's feet and slumped back on the sofa.

“Your aim is as awful as your hair poof,” Catra hissed.

She watched Adora’s boots stop in front of her. “That’s all I get these days, isn’t it? Witty insults and snarky comments.”

Catra gave another exaggerated yawn, still not looking at her. “Sorry, we can’t all be one of your *adoring* fans.” She nodded to the small group of friends surrounding the pool table.

Adora breathed out a soft sigh and Catra knew why. Adora hated when someone made a pun of her name (“I get it,” she used to say. “The irony is not lost on me that my parent’s, whoever they were, gave me a name meaning ‘love’ and then abandoned me to a children’s home.”) and Catra had never – not once – used it against her. That was the problem with close friends; they had all the ammunition to use your weaknesses against you.

Somewhere, deep down, Catra felt bad for it.

Until Adora snapped, “When did you become such a brat?”

Catra looked up, then, and rose to her feet. Slowly, like she was uncoiling, she replied, “A brat? When did you become such a try-hard people pleaser?”

Adora’s mouth fell open. When she took a step closer, Catra matched her, until only a few inches separated them. Scorpia jumped up from the sofa, clenching her hands, and danced around the pair making ‘hey, hey, hey’ sounds.

Somewhere, around the edges, Adora’s face softened. “What’s wrong, Catra?”

Scoffing, Catra poked Adora in the chest. “Wrong with me? What’s wrong with you?”

Adora battered her hand away, so Catra gave her a little nudge. When Adora responded with a push, Scorpia inserted herself between the two, waving her arms in the air as a surrender.

“Hey, knock it off!” she yelled. “You two like each other, okay?” When they both scowled, Scorpia added, “At least, that’s what I was told. Unless I’ve gotten this seriously wrong. Have I? Did I misread the situation? I can do that sometimes, I’m very –”

“Greyskull! Areli!”

Ah, fuck. Catra knew that voice – *they all* knew that voice. Sometimes she heard it in her dreams, yelling at her to shine her boots or fix her hair.

Well, this was bad timing.

Everyone in the room stood to attention as their Staff Sergeant shouted from the threshold. “On me!”

This wasn’t good.

Catra caught Adora’s eye as they marched from the room, following their Staff Sergeant. In typical Adora fashion, her face had instantly drained of colour. It didn’t make any sense why they would get in trouble for a little shoving match while off-duty. They were in the army, tensions could run high. The boys, especially, enjoyed a fist fight over supper. Catra bit her tongue to stop herself from pointing this out at the risk of a worse punishment.

He led them to his private office, where there were two chairs waiting for them in front of his desk. Catra’s heart missed a few beats as she realised he’d actually prepared for this meeting.

What was this about?

What had they done wrong?

“At ease,” he said, gesturing to the chairs. “Shut the door and take a seat.”

Adora hurried to shut the door. Trying to mask her rising panic, Catra stared straight ahead, trying to gauge the expression on the Staff Sergeant’s face. He didn’t look annoyed. He looked relaxed.

“My apologies for interrupting your rec time,” he began. “But something has come to my attention, something I think you’d have interest in.” He cleared his throat as he slid forward to brown envelopes, one addressed to each of them. “The war isn’t going anywhere anytime soon, so we’re constantly looking forward. We’re constantly looking for the best of the best and – well, the results of your field training were impressive.” His eyes flicked from Adora to Catra. “The two of you were consistently the best in your platoons. Your individual strength and dedication haven’t gone unnoticed – in fact, it’s been noticed by a certain department.” He paused, laced his fingers together, before declaring triumphantly, “The Special Forces have specifically requested the two of you to try out for their ranks.”

Adora inhaled a shaky breath. Catra blinked, unsure how to react.

Shit. The Special Forces. Every private in the army *dreamed* of this happening. It was the *Special Forces*, for pity’s sake. They were the big guys with the big guns, the intelligence and suave to match.

Adora and Catra, ever since they’d been accepted into the army, both salivated over the chance of joining the SF. It wasn’t until they got here two years ago that they realised how rare it was to be selected. But Catra insisted – she *knew* they were good enough.

And she had been right.

“I had my reservations, at first,” the Staff Sergeant went on. “You’re both eighteen, which is young to join the Etherian SF. But, if your records are anything to go by, you’re both certainly capable, and you make a good team.” He gestured for them to take the letters. “This is your official correspondence, inviting you to take part in their trials.”

“What happens, then?” Adora asked.

"If you're suitable, they'll match you with a specific department, like intelligence, medics, espionage, or weaponry. After you've completed further training, you'll be promoted to Lance Corporal and then sent to the field to work on active missions." His eyes sparkled. "A privilege, girls. If for, whatever reason, you're not successful in the trials, then you remain here in my platoon. Although given both of your stats, there's a bright future for you in the army, no matter what regiment you're in."

Adora beamed. She was radiating boundless enthusiasm, and it stuck in Catra's throat. "Thank you, sir."

He laughed as he clapped his hands on the table. "Thank yourselves." His eyes caught on Catra slowly reaching for her letter. "Do you have anything to add, Areli? You're not usually this quiet."

Startled, Catra looked up. She tried not to blush. "No, I – no, sir. Thanks."

He looked uncertain. "You can come to me privately if you change your mind. Alright, dismissed."

He didn't need to tell her twice. Gripping the envelope as if it was her only lifeline, Catra gave a quick salute before walk-running from the Staff Sergeant's office. Her mind and heart were having a race, and with the amount of emotion coursing through her – relief, victory, pride – she was struggling to come up for air.

It wasn't until she heard her name that she slowed down.

"Catra? Catra!"

In her haste, she had forgotten about Adora. With a slight shake to her voice, she said, "Yeah?"

Adora ran down the corridor to catch up, waving her envelope in the air. "Well? What do you think?"

Catra huffed a breath through her nose. She shook her head. "I think this is fucking crazy."

Adora matched her amazement, blue eyes shining. Leaning against the wall, she held the envelope to her chest. "You always said we'd make it," she muttered.

Catra's heart squeezed. She stood beside the blonde so that their shoulders were almost touching. "This is on you for doubting me."

They stayed there, thinking in silence, listening to each other's breath. After a year mostly apart, this felt so… intimate. Catra closed her eyes for a moment, trying to capture this memory in her mind's eye. All their hard work, their resilience had finally paid off. They were going to get something they wanted, they were going to –

Adora's voice rang out. "Catra?"

Catra sighed. "Are you going to keep ruining it by talking?"

She nudged her arm. "What's happened to us?"

Us. Them. They were a team, they always had been. Even the Staff Sergeant said it. *You make a good team*. It almost made Catra feel guilty for her part in their separation. For a long time she didn't think she missed *Adora*, she just thought she missed someone familiar, someone to hold close. But Adora was irreplaceable, and any attempt at mirroring what they had hadn't worked out. Everything they shared, everything they'd been through, was unique to them.

Catra would never admit it, however – it just wasn't who she was. So, instead, she muttered, "I dunno. We've drifted, I guess. It happens."

Adora paused. Catra could almost hear that big brain of hers whirring.

"You've been distant," she accused.

"You've been annoying," Catra hissed. At the flicker of hurt that crossed those big blue eyes, Catra huffed another sigh. "I just – it's stupid. You've made friends so easily. I felt a little…" when she felt herself blush, she added hastily, "never mind."

Adora elbowed her. "They could be your friends too."

"I don't like Lonnie," Catra snapped.

"I didn't mention Lonnie," Adora said, obviously confused.

For someone so smart, she was so *oblivious*. Catra chewed on her bottom lip, musing over how best to phrase it. She'd heard the rumours – she knew the gossip. It wasn't anything special. You put a few teenagers together without supervision on their day off, add some alcohol and worse things have happened. So, why did it bother Catra so much?

"Yeah, well, don't," she snapped. A pause, then, "Is it true you kissed her?"

Catra looked around just in time to see Adora's cheeks blaze red. "No!" she shouted. Groaning, Adora hid her eyes with her hands. "I mean, she kissed me. It wasn't – I don't like her like that."

Something sour twisted a knife in Catra's stomach. She pictured it sometimes, when she wasn't thinking; Lonnie making a move on Adora. It made her feel – well, nothing good. Suddenly her tongue felt too big her for mouth as she snarked, "Sure."

"I don't!" Adora repeated with more conviction. "She's not my type." It took her a moment, and then as if anticipating Catra's next question, she added, "I'm not sure I have a type."

The knife twisted again. On paper, Lonnie and Catra weren't that different. They both had dark hair, similar height, similar skin tone. Lonnie had the added bonus of being more muscular – something Catra *knew* Adora liked. If Lonnie wasn't Adora's 'type' then Catra definitely wasn't.

Not like it mattered. She wasn't concerned about it at all. Adora had never been good with feelings or understanding her own. It was infuriating. Catra brushed her off with a loud, "Pfft."

She slid down the wall so that she sat on the floor. Her head tilted up towards the ceiling.

"What?" Adora asked, sliding down beside her.

Catra turned her head to look at her. "How come you don't know these things?"

Adora pulled a face. She looked down at her hands, started tearing at the skin around her fingernails. "I just don't… think about them that much, I guess. Not compared to everyone else, anyway."

They'd had this conversation before when they were much younger. When everyone in school started to talk about boys or girls they liked, Adora had been reserved about the whole topic. Nothing had really changed, apparently, and it wasn't something Catra couldn't blame her for. While their peers were obsessed with first kisses, Adora had been obsessed with being the best, being *first*. She was still the same.

Aware of how uncomfortable this conversation made her, Catra changed the subject. "How was it?"

Adora blinked. "What?"

"The kiss," Catra asked, nudging her. "Is she a good kisser?"

Adora smirked. She had two moods: hopelessly bashful or sinfully smug. When her face lit up in a wide, cocky smile, Catra knew she shouldn't have teased her. Wiggling her eyebrows, Adora teased, "You were better."

It was Catra's turn to turn red. She put her full weight into pushing Adora over. "Shut up!"

Adora laughed, making Catra's heart swell. When she sat up again, she shrugged. "It was alright," she said. "It was a kiss."

Catra felt the knife in her stomach untwist. It really did sound like it meant nothing to Adora. Maybe a kiss could just be a kiss. If that was the case, Catra could get over it.

She felt Adora's keen stare. Rolling her eyes, Catra asked, "Why are you looking at me like that?"

Adora's shit-eating grin dazzled. "Are you jealous?"

"What – no!" Catra yelled, a tad too loud. "I don't care if you sleep with the whole platoon. You do you. Whatever." She settled back down, arms wrapped around her knees. "I have had plenty of – you know. Interest."

Adora's grin slowly faded. "I don't doubt it," she said sadly. "Then why?"

"Why what?"

"Why aren't you with someone?"

Catra stiffened. "I don't need anyone."

"You don't want anyone?" she quizzed, head tilting.

Yeah, she did. There was someone, there had always been someone. For as long as she could remember, Catra had wanted *someone*. The dummy was sitting right beside her, impossibly hard to get rid of, and decidedly *not* interested in her. Catra had accepted that years ago, and there was no point going over past tragedies. Adora in her life in some capacity was better than her not in her life at all.

"I didn't say that," Catra retorted, willing away the heat radiating from her body. "I'm *not* having this conversation with you."

“Why not?” Adora asked, all wide eyes and innocence. “We used to talk about this stuff.”

Catra scoffed. “We also used to pretend we had a rainbow-coloured flying unicorn, Adora, times change.” When the blonde looked like she might do something awful like cry at that reminder, Catra changed the subject again by waving the brown envelope. “We’re going to get this. And then we’ll keep going. I know it.”

Adora nodded, but with less enthusiasm than before. “Is that what you want?”

“Isn’t it what you want?” Catra asked, her arm falling to the side.

There was a pause.

“Yeah,” she said with a tight smile. “Sure. Just checking.”

Present day

It was the last Friday of the month, which meant an assembly with the senior school.

All the kids were on chairs in the middle of the sports hall while the teachers were lined up at the sides beside the benches. Sparkles and a few other staff members were waiting on the stage, preparing to start. Catra much preferred this set up over the one in her last school. There, they separated boys and girls – boys on the left, girls on the right – which was needless and, dare she say it, not very progressive. Brightmoon, with its inclusive ethos, just let everyone sit where they wanted as long as you remained in your year group.

Catra’s eyes wandered across the hall to where a certain blonde stood with her form group. Adora with a form group? Kids reporting to her, going to her with their problems or their detentions, suspensions, anything really, felt odd. The Adora Catra knew was a fine leader, but was she responsible? That wasn’t something she’d thought about before. She had been protective,

loyal, even occasionally accountable. Being responsible implied she knew how to make good decisions, and that definitely wasn't an Adora trait.

Principal Sparkles tapped the mic, pulling Catra back to the present. The feedback whined in a high-pitched echo and some of the students covered their ears dramatically. After welcoming everyone to the assembly, Glimmer listed end of semester exam dates and reminded everyone of the half-term holidays coming up at the end of the month. When she was done, she handed the mic to Perfuma, the school councillor-slash-ethos champion (what the fuck was that anyway?), who stumbled to grasp the power cord, sending the mic crashing to the floor.

The speakers amplified the crash amplifying a loud *bang!* akin to a gunshot across the hall. As it rolled, the feedback squealed, high-pitched and frightening. For a moment, Catra's flight or fight response took control; she fought against the instinct to duck or run, as such was her military training. *It was just the mic*, she told herself, taking a deep breath to calm her heartbeat. *No need to freak out.*

Scrambling for the microphone, Perfuma picked it up with a quick apology and an awkward grimace. Catra rolled her eyes and looked across the hall to see –

Adora, who looked like she was shaking, walking swiftly towards the exit.

Oh.

Huh.

Catra shouldn't have felt so surprised. Of course Adora would have PTSD, she wasn't invincible, as much as other people tried to tell her she was. She was human, just like the rest of them, and guess what? Traumatic experiences fuck you up.

As calmly as she could, and trying not to draw attention to herself (because Adora would hate that), Catra excused herself to the

teacher on her right and exited the hall.

She found Adora in an empty classroom. She was sitting on a chair with her blonde head between her legs. Her chest shook with every breath. Catra waited at the door, cautious about startling her. When she walked in, she ensured her footsteps were loud enough to hear but not loud enough to alarm.

Adora flinched anyway; she looked up with wide, crying eyes. Her cheeks were red and there was a slight tremor to her movements.

Catra kneeled in front of her. "Hey. I'd ask if you're okay, but it would be a stupid question."

Adora struggled to form a response, so dropped her head back between her knees. Catra reached out a hand to reassure her before deciding against it. Instead, she said, "Stupid triggers, eh?"

Adora's blonde head bobbed.

"Do you want some water? Anything else you need?"

She was silent.

Catra made to move.

"Stay," Adora croaked, glancing up. Her shaky hands squeezed her own knees, as if they were the only thing keeping her grounded. "Please."

Catra licked her lips and settled down. There was a chill to the room; it made her shiver. "Okay," she murmured. "Do you want me to keep talking?"

Another bob. *Yes*.

Alright, she should've figured that out sooner. Whenever Catra experienced a panic attack, she liked to be alone and in a safe space with no one nearby. She needed silence to counter the roaring in her head. But Adora had never been one for alone-time

or personal space. Right now, she wanted someone to ground her, and Catra would provide it.

Even *if* this was the most they'd talked in five years.

"Right, talking. Talking. We used to be good at this." *Ouch, backtrack. That wasn't helpful.* "I thought I was dying during my first panic attack. I was in my car and hailstones started lashing down. It was the sound of how they hit against the roof that got me. Sounded like shrapnel hitting our truck that time we drove over a land mine." *Once again, probably not a good idea to remind her of that, Catra. Get a grip*. "So, I went to a therapist – I've been through many, by the way – and he asked me to describe what triggered me and what I felt. Then all he said was 'a lot of people feel like that'. That's all I got: *a lot of people go through this*. How does that help, you know? I want a solution. *You're* supposed to help *me*." Catra scoffed. "Then my second therapist just didn't want to know. She got me to describe my panic attacks, yawning throughout, and then casually said 'you probably have PTSD' and sent me off with a list of medication." Catra paused. "The third one made throw a chair through his window, so I won't get into *that one*."

Adora looked up then, smiling. Her breaths were still ragged, but they were longer and more paced. She sat up slightly and closed her eyes. Her lip wobbled. Catra wanted to draw her back, make her think about anything else.

"I always thought you were invincible," she started. "There's nothing weak about this, that isn't what I mean, especially after surviving the trauma we went through, but… I always thought you'd spring back. Nothing could touch you. You were the strong one, you know? I was the one who… struggled."

Adora's eyes flitted to the side and she opened her mouth as if to say something, when there was a loud –

"Adora!"

From the door.

Both women looked around to see Glimmer run into the room, immediately enveloping Adora into a hug. Catra stiffened, and said, "I wouldn't smother her yet –"

"I know what I'm doing," Glimmer retorted, ignoring Catra completely.

Catra bristled. "Usually when someone is suffering from a PTSD attack, they need boundaries. I know from personal experience."

"And I know from guiding Adora through multiple PTSD attacks what she needs," Glimmer muttered. "Talking grounds her. Touch soothes her. She loses all ability to speak and sometimes to stand. Hot flashes and shakes remain until the trigger is removed or the flashback stops." As she wiped away the tears trailing Adora's cheeks, Glimmer cast a look at Catra. "She's not good on her own."

A deep-set hot knife of jealousy twisted through Catra's stomach. It wasn't easy looking in the eyes of your replacement. Better yet, it wasn't easy listening to the new best friend dismiss the old best friend as old news. Catra no longer knew Adora, yes, did the universe have to keep rubbing it in her face? Catra watched as Adora gently removed Glimmer's hands and held them to the side. In a breathy voice, the blonde whispered, "I'm coming down, Glim. Don't worry."

"As soon as I heard the microphone I knew," Glimmer went on. "But it's been a year, Adora. A year with no, you know. Attacks." She paused. "What's wrong?"

Catra did a bit of mental maths. Then it clicked. "The anniversary, right?"

Adora studied her for a moment. Her blue eyes roamed her face as if searching for something. Eventually, she said, "Right."

Glimmer frowned. "What anniversary?"

"A war thing," Adora muttered.

Interesting. Either Adora hadn't told Sparkles here or she didn't want to discuss it in front of Catra.

Catra assumed it wasn't the latter. So, Adora *did* still keep secrets. Good to know.

"It would be better if you took the rest of the day off," Glimmer said. When Adora went to argue, she added, "I'm not suggesting. I'm demanding."

"I can't drive right now," Adora argued, holding up her shaky hands.

"I can drive you," offered Catra. "That is, if you don't mind." She added to Glimmer – despite the hostility, she was still her boss.

"Perfect. That's it settled then."

Adora tried to argue, but no one was listening. It seemed Glimmer was attuned to ignoring the protests of Adora, something that only came with time and patience. Huh. They must be close friends. Catra tried to keep a neutral outlook, yet there was a creeping doubt niggling her, something akin to…

Nah. Never mind. It wasn't worth it.

They gave Adora another moment to collect herself before Catra walked her to the car. Catra wasn't exactly materialistic, so she didn't want to drive a fancy car to show off. Still, it was hard not to be embarrassed by her silver tin bucket with wheels. There was a dent in one side and a skid mark on the bonnet, both of which weren't there when she'd bought it. She could buy a new one, but for some reason buying a new car when the current one worked felt excessive.

That was the one good thing about growing up with little money, Catra had come to realise: you never wasted it. Sure, sometimes you indulged, and you bought something you'd always wanted.

But the rest of time, you were careful with the pennies, cautious with the expenses. You appreciated what you had and, with the leftover money you had per month, you saved it because you didn't want to go back to having nothing at all.

Adora understood it. If she was judging Catra's car, she didn't show it. Either that, or she was still too zoned out from the panic attack to notice the state of the vehicle she was in.

"Where to?" Catra asked as she clicked her seatbelt.

"Oh, um, west side. Just past the forest."

"Near Thaymor?"

"Yeah, that's the one."

For the first time since working at Brightmoon and seeing Adora again, Catra wondered if Adora lived with anyone – or rather, if she was with anyone. This would be an awful way to find out.

"Catra? Can I ask you something?"

Oh no. Catra didn't like that tone. She knew that tone – that was Adora's thinking tone. As she reversed out of the staff carpark, Catra kept her gaze strictly limited to the road. "Sure."

Adora's voice was very quiet. "Why are you being so… nice to me?"

Oh. Well. That was the internal conflict she was having with herself, wasn't it? One minute she was telling Adora to leave her alone, that nothing had changed, and the next she was helping out with after-school activities and giving her rides home.

Almost like she cared again.

Old Catra, past Catra with the insecurities and pent-up anger, would've reversed the tables. She would've made a joke, put the

blame on Adora for asking a stupid question. Not anymore. She wasn't the same person, just like Adora had changed too.

"I'm being civil. I – I don't want to fight with you, Adora. Not anymore. I'm sorry about what I said before. I'm trying to be a better person – I'm trying to be more patient and well, kind. Sometimes my old self creeps back in."

"Your new self – has she changed much?"

"Not as much as I'd like." Catra bit back a laugh. When she didn't hear Adora match her reaction, her eyes flicked to her. "What about you?"

Adora's brows raised, and she looked like she'd never considered it before. "Since we last" – she cut herself off, shaking her head – "since you saw me last? Sometimes I feel like an entirely different person. Other times, I feel like I'm still the same sixteen-year-old that ran away with you."

"Huh." A lump swelled in Catra's throat. "I think I know what you mean."

They were invaded by silence, but it wasn't the negative kind. Catra was desperately trying to swallow away the lump in her throat. The idea that they were still *themselves*, whole and untouched, as they were at sixteen, innocently running away from one institution to another, hoping this time it would be different… it touched something soft and delicate inside her. Catra hadn't been than naïve in a long time, but she still felt like she could be fooled into thinking she was.

"I'm sorry," Adora said suddenly.

Catra's heart skipped a beat. "For what?"

Pausing, Adora took her time, as if trying to figure it out. "For this," she said eventually. "Being a nuisance."

Oh. For a moment Catra had thought she was apologising for something else entirely. To cover up the confusion, she teased, "It's good to know *that* hasn't changed."

"It's good to know you're still a smart ass," shot back Adora with a cheeky smile.

Catra shook her head at that. When Adora pointed out that they were close to her street, Catra absolutely denied the feeling of regret pooling her stomach. What should she do – offer that they chat over a coffee? Ask if Adora would want to see her outside of school? Leave it all alone and spend the rest of the day chiding herself for not allowing herself this, this moment to heal things between them?

Catra wanted to talk but she wasn't good at talking. She didn't know how to instigate this – all she knew was that she needed to do this for herself. She couldn't move on until she did.

Instead, all she said when she pulled into Adora's street was, "Is this you?"

"Yeah. The one with the red door."

Time was ticking away from them. Trying to stall her inevitable departure, Catra asked, "Are you going to be alright?"

Adora's smile was tight, and she did her best to hide the tremor in her hands. "I'll be fine."

"I'm sure you have somebody in there waiting to fuss over you, anyway." After she said it, Catra had no idea *why* she said it. She really was just pushing her luck at this point, being nosy. Doing anything to avoid the topic she was really interested in.

"Oh, no," Adora replied, a bit surprised. "I live alone, actually."

Catra stalled. "You? Living alone?"

"For a year or two now. I used to live with Glimmer and Bow, but then they became a couple and wanted to spread their wings, so I got my own place." She looked out of the window, towards the house. "It's nice. My kooky old neighbour bakes me a pie every other weekend."

It sounded like she was holding back, but Catra had pried enough already. "You're not selling it to me, for some reason."

"Shut up." Adora laughed and shrugged it off. "It could be worse."

Well, here she was, staring a natural moment for departure in the face and doing her best to keep conversation going. What could she say? Where could she go from here? *Just ask her, idiot,* the little logical voice in her head said. Instead, Catra blurted, "I live with Scorpia."

For some reason, this factoid made Adora frown. She tugged the end of her sleeve and glanced down. "Oh. I didn't know."

Ah – what? Had she said something? Why did Adora react like that? Suddenly she felt awkward. "Yeah."

"Is she still serving?"

"She was, until last year. Once she heard about this new threat coming up – Prime, or whatever – she decided to get out while she could." Catra paused, still unable to read Adora's expression. "I don't think any of our old crew would stick around for another war."

Once again, Adora blanched. "No. I don't think" – her voice cut off and she swallowed to recollect herself – "I don't think they would. Well, I'm… I'm happy for you."

Catra wasn't sure why she was saying that. "…Thanks."

"I should – thanks, Catra. For the lift."

"Yeah – I, uh, yeah. See you tomorrow."

It wasn’t until Catra drove away that it hit her – she’d borught up Scorpia, randomly, after Adora had mentioned living alone because her friends were together. The idiot probably thought that was Catra telling her that she was with Scorpia. Ah, fuck. What a disaster. Stupid fucking –

But still, Catra couldn’t help but laugh. After all this time and everything that had happened, they were both so… useless.

Chapter End Notes

Thank you so much for reading and sorry for the gap between updates, life kinda happened.

I will start replying to comments again next time, but I appreciate every single one of you. Reading comments and getting kudos really brightens my (very boring) day.

This fic is only going to get more angsty before it gets better, so hold on tight, folks!

Until next time (which will be sooner!) stay safe.

Cx.

Mara

Chapter Summary

Content warning: secondary character death (in line with canon)

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Adora spent the rest of the day floating around the house, trying to clear her head. She put the radio on in the kitchen and the television on in the living room despite not entertaining herself with either of them. Silence was deadly; when she was left with her own thoughts, she obsessed over what an idiot she'd been – losing it in an assembly, over something as simple as a fallen microphone.

Then, there was Catra.

Adora can honestly say that never once in her entire life had she ever complained about Catra being nice.

She had been kind and helpful. She had gone out of her way to get Adora home, made sure she was safe.

Yet, all Adora could do was obsess over the fact Catra was with Scorpia. Living together, in fact. Which had to be a big commitment, right?

Adora had been slow on the uptake for her feelings for Catra. She didn't realise until she was twenty-one, facing death, that how she felt for her best friend was more than – well, a best friend. Later, as their separation grew, Adora came to the conclusion that as a touch-starved love-depraved child, she had a pretty messed up concept of what *love* was. In Weaver's home, Adora only received praise when she did something she was manipulated into doing. Catra had never required anything from Adora – had never

needed anything from her apart from herself. Catra needed Adora, not what she could give or what she could do or what she was worth. That had always made Adora feel something, but it also made her feel guilty for those feelings.

And just as she realised what those feelings were, they were separated.

Until now.

Adora was twenty-six, she'd had relationships. Or, rather, she'd experimented with relationships. She had chased a feeling and found it irreplicable. When it came to sexual identity, Adora liked women. She was a lesbian. That had always been something she knew. When it came to sexual… *feelings*, Adora found it much harder to understand.

Intimacy was something Adora had learnt that she needed in order to want sex, and, well, intimacy was something she struggled with. Out of the handful of women she'd attempted relationships with, only one of them had almost been successful. Yes, this was another thing she was self-conscious of. It was just another thing that made her feel screwed up in some way. Sex in society was something everyone wanted, something everyone actively sought out. Society was obsessed with it; every song she heard talked about it, her friends loved to chat about it, advertisements boasted about it to sell products to consumers. Adora had never been… that into it. Sex – physical intimacy – was scary. It required a closeness and vulnerability Adora wasn't sure she was comfortable with. Until Perfuma, and to a greater extent Bow and Glimmer, told her there was no 'normal' way to feel, and what she felt (or didn't feel) was valid, Adora had spent many nights fretting over it.

And then there was Catra.

As teenagers, they had talked about stuff. Adora felt like she was the only person she could talk to about her real feelings. Catra, herself, never made a big deal about anything, and as far as she

knew – other than a few rumours – Catra had never had any significant relationships in the army, either.

But the rumours. Of Catra and Scorpia. And now they were living together…

It hurt Adora's heart.

She was happy that Catra was obviously happy – who would she be if she wished anything different? But there was a teeny tiny part of Adora that always held out hope that Catra would come back into her life one day like nothing had happened between them and they could, maybe, finally, give it a shot.

A stupid fantasy. She should've known better.

Exhausted by all the thinking and deliberating, Adora fell asleep around noon. It was fitful; the microphone incident had conjured images of IEDs and bullets rattling iron fences. Memories she would give anything to clean from her brain. When she woke up again, it was after seven o'clock in the evening, and Bow was calling her.

"Adora? Are you alright?"

"Yeah," she croaked, voice raspy from lack of use. "I was just – I fell asleep. I'm okay."

"Good because – well, we're outside. Could you let us in? Glimmer was worried, she hadn't heard from you all day."

"Outside, as in, outside my house?"

"Yeah, is that okay?"

Adora debated telling them she wasn't in the mood for company, but she knew that probably wouldn't make them leave anyway. Once Glimmer had her mind set on something then there was no point in arguing. Instead of answering, Adora pulled on a jumper

and hobbled down the stairs to the front door, taking a moment to breathe before pulling it open.

Glimmer vaulted in, looking over Adora as if she had a physical injury. "We were worried sick!"

Adora shuffled back uncomfortably. "I slept it off, Glim. You know that's the only thing that works."

"Did you eat?"

"No –"

"We'll order something –"

"I'm not hungry –"

"You just said you didn't eat, of course you're hungry –"

"I'm *fine*, Glimmer –"

Bow stood between them, the voice of reason. "Why don't we take a moment, sit down, and talk this out, okay?"

Adora wrapped her arms around her waist. "I'm okay, really. I'm sorry I didn't call. Catra dropped me home and then I fell asleep. There's nothing to discuss."

Glimmer's eyes popped. "There's *so* much to discuss!"

Huffing, Bow took matters into his own hands by physically dragging Adora and Glimmer into the kitchen. He sat them on opposite sides of the table before putting the kettle on to make them tea. Glimmer watched Adora as if she were a piece in an exhibition, and with every ticking second, Adora felt a little less patient.

She didn't want to talk about *this*.

She didn't like where this was going.

"You haven't been okay," Glimmer accused.

Bow dropped a teaspoon on the floor, groaning.

Adora felt her skin prickle. "I've been fine. I'm coping with some stuff."

"Stuff?"

"Yeah, you know." Adora chewed on her bottom lip. This was the problem with having friends she told everything to, shared everything with – suddenly asking for privacy sounded suspicious. "Stuff."

"Stuff that you don't want to talk about."

Adora hesitated.

Glimmer jumped in. "Which usually means you're afraid you're being stupid, or you're afraid of being a burden."

Looking away, Adora fumbled with her hands. When she was anxious, she felt so restless. She had to keep moving otherwise the anxiety would catch up. Right now, her flight or fight response was maddening.

"Catra mentioned an anniversary," Glimmer said softly.

Adora still said nothing.

"You've never mentioned it before."

"It's – complicated," Adora muttered. "An army thing."

Bow put a mug down in front of each of them and took a seat beside Adora. "Is this what's been causing the anxiety? The panic attack today?"

Adora clenched the mug between her hands. "Kind of." *And that brown envelope from the Etherian Army waiting, unopened, on her bedside table.*

“You don’t need to tell us, Adora, we’re just concerned,” Bow said. “We want to do something to help you.”

“I appreciate that, I do. But I think, right now, I need –”

What did she need?

Space?

Time?

There was no escaping what was coming, and the anniversary reminded her of that – of the likely outcome. There was only one reason why the Etherian army would contact her.

There would be no escaping it this time.

She needed to be brave. Bow and Glimmer couldn’t give her that. She needed to find it herself.

“I’ll be fine,” she said instead. “I promise if I need help then I’ll tell you both.” In a smaller voice, she added, “But can we leave it there for now?”

It didn’t help that Bow and Glimmer looked as unsure as she felt. Adora sat in their shared silence, sipping on the mug of tea despite it being too hot.

Nineteen years old – Mission First Ones

Adora and Catra had made it.

After their initial trials, they had successfully been accepted into the ranks of the Special Forces. A year of intense training later, and they were assigned their departments and given their first missions.

Adora was placed in weapons, while Catra was put in logistics. Despite belonging to different departments within the SF, they

were allocated the same missions and saw each other daily in the shared accommodation.

They were thriving.

But for some unknown reason, Adora felt nervous about their next mission.

As part of the logistics team, it was Catra's responsibility to assist in the planning and preparation of their missions. They were the coordinators, the big-thinkers, and ensured everything ran smoothly on the field. Adora's team, weaponry, were the muscle. They cleared, conquered and identified their targets to bring them down.

The mission today was the Horde's prison camp, where a number of high-ranking Etherian politicians had been captured. The plan was complicated; the brief had been a number of pages long, and every meeting was longer than the last. By this point, Adora had been on a few missions with her team, and she knew she could trust them. But this mission felt… different.

It prickled Adora's skin.

"How are we feeling, Greyskull?"

It was Lieutenant Despondos, Or, as Adora knew her, Mara.

Mara.

Would Adora have gotten this far without her?

Sometime over the last year, Mara had taken Adora under her wing and opened her up to her full potential as a soldier. She had pushed Adora to reach her greatest limits, and also offered an ear to listen to her problems. Adora saw her as something akin to a big sister.

It was also Mara who told Adora to get out of the army.

“Don’t let it be your life,” she had said one Sunday afternoon. “You’re so much more than what you can give to *them*. Be the best you can be, prove this to yourself, and then move on.”

Adora wouldn’t understand what she meant until years later.

“Good, yeah. Fine,” Adora replied, attempting her best poker face. When Mara raised an eyebrow, Adora conceded. “I’m nervous. I’m not usually nervous.”

“This is a big mission,” she pointed out. “There’s a lot at stake here. But we can do it. I have faith in us. Just keep your chin up, okay?”

Mara patted Adora on the back before going to check on the rest of their squadron. Adora watched her go, feeling doubt swirl her stomach.

Still, Mara had yet to let her down. Adora would follow her into any war if she asked.

Present day

Adora slept through the night, only waking to take the occasional sip of water.

Survival instincts kicked in after a day of not eating. With the cupboard and fridge empty, she decided to take a quick trip to the supermarket to stock up on some essentials. Knowing her friends, they would probably call on her again later, and if last night was anything to go by, they wouldn’t leave her alone without proof that she was functioning.

Adora was functioning. Her gears were slow, and she felt rusty enough to break in places, but she had enough energy to keep going. Barely.

It was when she was debating the ripeness of some avocados that she bumped into someone she absolutely did not want to see so

soon.

“Are you going to keep fondling that avocado, or are you going to buy it?”

Adora jumped, almost letting the fruit slip between her fingers. “Catra,” she breathed.

And she looked good; ripped jeans, boots, and a hoodie layered under a leather jacket. Very different to her in-office clothes at school, and more familiar to what Adora remembered. She made Adora feel underdressed in her baggy checked shirt and leggings.

“Congratulations in getting out of bed,” Catra said lightly. “Usually after an attack I’m under the sheets for a few days.”

Adora smiled bitterly. “It’s a small victory. Hey, uh – listen. About yesterday –”

“Don’t,” Catra chastised, already lifting her hand to protest.

“No, really, I appreciated – well, what I mean is” – Adora heaved a breath – “if I could make it up to you sometime, then, you know, I –”

“Yeah,” Catra said immediately. “Okay.”

Adora blinked. “Uh, sorry, what?”

“Yeah, you can make it up to me,” she clarified without clarifying anything at all.

“Oh.” Adora licked her lips. She hadn’t been expecting that. “How would – how would I do that?”

It was Catra’s turn to shuffle from foot to foot. A slight blush clouded her cheeks as she replied, “I want to talk. With you. About things I’ve wanted to address for so long. Too long.”

Adora’s throat was very dry. “Oh. Right.”

"You can say no," Catra added quickly. "But I was – shit, this is embarrassing. I was talking to my therapist about the progress I've made, and I realised that there's one thing holding me back. One piece of trauma I have yet to address. So, I need to do this. For me. So I can, you know." She swallowed. "Properly move on."

It felt like a knife tearing through Adora's ribs.

Catra wanted to move on. From her.

She had caused Catra trauma. Trauma that she needed to work through.

The self-loathing was pungent and almost too much to bear. Adora dropped the avocado into her basket and did her best to shut down all unnecessary emotion. She would get through this conversation like a functioning human and then go back to bed and hide away for the rest of the day.

"We can talk," she said, throat painfully dry. "Anytime you want."

Catra searched her face for something. "Thanks. Good. Uh – when?"

Adora couldn't think. Knowing she was going to regret it, she suggested, "Tomorrow?"

"Tomorrow's good. Around lunch? I can pick you up?"

"Good, yeah. That sounds good." Adora's brain was chanting a mantra of: *get out. Go home. Escape*. Desperate to end the conversation there, she gestured to her shopping basket. "I'm going to go pay for these, and I'll – I'll see you tomorrow."

Catra put her hand out to stop her. She looked concerned. "Hey, all you've got in your basket is an avocado."

Adora blanked. She didn't need to glance down to realise Catra was right. Her heartbeat picked up pace. "Right. Yeah, that's right. I only needed an avocado."

"You picked up a basket for an avocado?" Without waiting for an answer, Catra stood on her toes and got a good look at Adora's face. She immediately winced. "Shit, you're sweating. Fuck, I shouldn't have" – Catra shook her head – "I should've realised you were still… you know. Here, I'll take you home."

Adora felt some of her restraint slip away. "Catra, don't. I'm fine."

"You don't look fine. You look like you're about to –"

Adora, roughly, shoved Catra's outstretched arm out of the way. "I *said* I'm fine. I'd be *much* better if everyone stopped" – her chest was tight. She dropped the shopping basket – "*fussing* and let me be."

Feeling embarrassed and emotional, Adora turned on her heel and left the shop. All she wanted was to make a sandwich without hassle. Was that too much to ask? Everything felt heavy, spinning, like the universe was using her as its centre of gravity. Bow, Glimmer and now, confusingly, even Catra kept treating her like she was so breakable – so precious – she hated it. She resented it.

Once upon a time she hadn't been like this – riddled with anxiety, on the verge of a deep, bottomless pit every time she tread on difficult territory.

And she'd been doing so well over the last year…

As she stumbled out of the shop and down the street, her breathing tightened and her sight turned blotchy. She didn't feel herself hit the pavement. She didn't feel someone help her up.

When Adora came around, she was sitting on a public bench with her head between her knees, gasping for air.

Catra was sitting beside her, rubbing circles on her back.

Well, shit.

Nineteen years old – Mission First Ones

In retrospect, Adora always saw it coming.

At the time, there was just noise; bloated sounds, rupturing her eardrums. Guns unloading, bullets hitting walls, screams, yelling, explosions, and an insistent mutter in her headset.

"Greyskull, on me!" yelled Lieutenant Despondos through the earpiece.

Adora shouldered her gun and followed Mara as she took off for the west exit, which was –

The opposite direction of the rest of their team.

As they ducked behind a solid metal door, Adora questioned, "Ma'am?"

Mara spared her a glance. "This mission isn't just about freeing political prisoners, Greyskull. But it's a good distraction for something else that we're here for."

Adora could feel her heartbeat in her neck and head. It was beating louder than the distant gunfire.

Mara went on, putting a hand on her shoulder. "I trust you, Adora. I need to you keep watch for me, understood?"

Adora had questions, but now wasn't the time or place. She was a soldier, after all. She did, she didn't ask. So, she gave a firm nod and a grim smile. "Yes, ma'am."

When Mara patted her on the back, Adora crawled on her stomach and carefully pointed her weapon at the exit. Behind her, she heard Mara blast open the metal door. Her heavy footprints faded into the background.

Right.

Adora was suddenly on her own.

She could do this. She was keeping watch. The rest of the prison would be focussed on the rescue mission led by Catra's team, somewhere in the east of the building. Still, Adora would have to be careful. It was unusual – very unusual – for a company of two to oversee a part of the mission unless it was highly classified. All that stood between Mara and the enemy was Adora.

She swallowed and tried to refocus.

What was behind that door?

Adora did her best to conjure up a mental image of the prison architecture plans. They'd each been given a copy with their briefing package for routes and lookout posts. From what she could remember, the only thing of note in the west of the prison was the technology hub. The Horde were known for being world leaders of technological advancements. Most of their main outposts – i.e. the central targets for the Etherian army, were technological strongholds. Despite the Etherian army never figuring out how to attack their computer-based systems, there was a long-standing theory that if you were able to bring down the Horde's systems, then you could bring down the whole of the Horde.

…Was that Mara's independent mission?

Was it something to do with the Horde's systems?

Adora felt the pit in her stomach widen.

Suddenly the radio crackled, "Greyskull, I need backup. I repeat, Greyskull, back-up needed."

Adora was already on the move when she replied, "Roger that, Lieutenant."

Adora cleared every room between her and Mara, but they were already empty. Almost as if they'd been abandoned?

This felt wrong.

Mara was in the third room. It was long, like a corridor, with an exit on either side. Wires and electronic devices were in glass cases and running the length of the room. In the centre, there was a large mast, cackling with electricity. Mara stood in front of it, logging keys onto an old computer.

“Lieutenant Despondos?” Adora asked, her voice a higher pitch than normal.

Mara didn’t look up from her work. “When I do this, the system is going to go haywire. If it works, I have no idea what will happen. No one does.” She paused to take a breath. “If it’s unsuccessful, I need you to grab this chip” – she gestured to a pink glowing orb attached to the computer – “and find the rest of the team. Okay?”

Adora understood the instructions. She just didn’t understand anything else. “Ma’am? Can I ask –”

“No,” she said firmly. Mara looked up, then, and her eyes were shining. “Adora, you’re a good kid. You’re intelligent and kind. You look out for the rest of your team. Your determined. I respect that.” Her breath hitched. “The army doesn’t. They only care about winning the war. Promise me you’ll look after yourself, please. Promise me you won’t make the same mistakes I did.”

“Mara, what’s going on?” Adora whispered, taking a few steps forward.

Mara held out her hand. “No, don’t come any closer. It’s not safe.”

Adora felt her hands start to tremble. “Please –”

“You have your instructions, Lance Corporal,” Mara said, tone firm again. “And I’m sorry.”

Present day

“I’m sorry,” Adora whispered. “I don’t keep meaning to – you know. I don’t want you to see me like this.”

She didn’t have the strength to look at Catra for a reaction. Adora was tired; it was rooted in her bones. The light breeze sent an unnerving chill over her skin, turning her sweat cold. It stung her pores, made her feel unclean. She felt uncomfortable in her own body, as if it wasn’t hers anymore.

“Is it the anniversary or…?”

Adora nodded stiffly. “Yeah.” But she was a terrible liar. “Mostly.”

Catra was quiet for a few long seconds. “Have you visited her?” she said eventually. “Mara.”

Adora gulped. She looked down at her hands, at the slight tremor of her fingers. “No, I – I haven’t been able to.” She sniffed loudly to avoid tears. “I don’t think I could face it on my own.”

“We could both go.”

Adora turned to her then, all colour fading from her pinched face. “What?”

Catra shrugged. She looked awkward, as if every word was taking a lot for her to say. “I mean, she was part of my team too. I think about her a lot. How it could’ve been one of us. It nearly was, back – well, you know.”

Well, of course Catra thought about Mara too. Adora hadn’t remained friends with anyone from the army, but this was something she shared with Catra. It made something flutter in her chest. “You’d really do that?” she asked. “Visit her with me?”

It was clear Catra was trying to smile but it came out as more of a grimace. “Yeah. Sure. We could go tomorrow. It’s not far.” She looked away then, out into the road ahead of then. “Heal both of our trauma in one day. Ha.”

The lump in Adora's throat was too big to ignore. She pushed it down until it hurt. Catra hated looking back, dealing with old memories. But she was willing to do this for *her*. After everything that had happened between them.

Adora squeezed her eyes to stop herself from crying.

Catra was polite enough to pretend not to notice.

Nineteen years old – Mission First Ones

Mara typed something into the computer.

The mast in the centre of the room lit up blue, radiated heat. The energy cackling from it intensified. Adora almost lost her footing at the brightness of it reflecting off the glass cabinets.

There was a rumble from beneath the floor.

Adora and Mara's eyes locked across the room.

And then, clutching her chest, Mara jumped into the light.

Several occurrences happened at once.

Mara's body crackled with electricity.

A mighty scream tore from her throat.

Adora, too shocked to react, was slow to realise that the room was suddenly invaded by metal-clad men. They came out of the walls with weapons for arms, ready to attack, to protect the central mast –

Adora opened fire on them before they could shoot at her. The first bullet ripped one of them in half, and it gave her a grim realisation –

These weren't men at all.

They were robots.

What the *hell* was going on here?

Adora took them all out one by one. When the last fell to a heap on the ground, she spun around, searching for Mara –

But she was also on the ground.

The light from the electronic mast zapped off, plunging the room into darkness. Mara fell forward before Adora could reach her –

But it was no use.

It was clear from this angle that her chest was still. That her lungs held no air, that her heart had stopped beating. Her skin was pale and scorched and her limbs lay limp at her sides.

Mara was dead.

Fuck.

Mara was –

Adora didn't know what to do.

She wanted to scream. She wanted to yell, to cry, to lash out.

She was alone.

And Mara was dead.

Keep moving, the autopilot in her brain said. *You have instructions. Get the chip and get out*.

Mara warned you.

"Lieutenant Despondos down," Adora croaked into the radio. "I repeat, Lieutenant Despondos is down." Her voice shook and she didn't care. "Over."

Adora, ever the good soldier, did as she was instructed.

She grabbed the pink computer chip and slipped it into the secure padding of her bulletproof vest. With bleary eyes and feeling cold – so cold – Adora shouldered Mara onto her back and ran from the room, back to the rest of her team.

She was *not* going to leave her behind.

Later, on the transport home, Catra wordlessly flopped down on the seat beside her. The mission was a success, according to their superiors. One fatality and all prisoners rescued.

Mara’s chip was handed over to the Captain and that was it.

Adora sat with her back against the truck. No matter how she tried to stop thinking about it, her mind kept replaying Mara screaming, lit up with blue light. She could still feel the weight of her body slumped over Adora's shoulder. These things were unshakeable. They replayed and replayed until Adora let them take her over. It was the first time she’d noticed her hands shake uncontrollably. She stuck them between her thighs to stop the tremble.

Inside, her mind was numb.

She felt so hollow. She didn’t feel there at all.

Nothing existed outside of these memories. Nothing would ever be the same again.

Dragging her back into reality, Catra placed a hand on the nape of her neck and wordlessly pulled her closer.

Adora fell into her arms and buried her face into her shoulder.

They stayed like that for a while, just breathing.

“What happened?”

Adora shook her head. She thought of the mast, of the robots, of the chip Mara had given her life for. “I don’t know,” she mumbled.

This was an expensive war, and she was just a soldier.

She didn't know.

Present day

“You wanna, um – get lunch?” Catra asked, sitting up from the bench. She checked her watch – a military style one. Some habits were hard to shake. “Breakfast? Brunch, or whatever the middle-aged ladies call it.”

Adora quickly wiped her eyes with the back of her hands. “Oh. Sure.” *Was Catra really asking to spend time with her?* “Are you sure?” she blurted.

Catra rolled her eyes, but there was a familiar fondness in how she playfully nudged her. “I wouldn’t have asked, dummy.”

Adora thought about it. Seriously thought about it.

They hadn’t been in each other’s lives for five years. It was her fault, they both knew that. And yet here they were, helping each other – what, cope? Almost as if nothing had happened.

Almost.

There was still a distance in Catra’s eyes that Adora hated to see.

“Okay,” she said, standing on shaky legs. “That would be nice.”

So I can, you know, properly move on, Catra had said in the shop.

So what? Catra wanted to move on. Of course Catra wanted to move on.

Adora was a mess. She had nearly ruined Catra’s life.

But a long time ago, Adora had made a promise to always be there for her.

If Catra needed to move on, to live the life she deserved, then Adora would help her.

No matter how much it broke her heart.

Chapter End Notes

Hey all! So, this chapter was based on a few things Noelle said about Adora as a character, namely that Adora was late to understanding her love for Catra because she just didn't focus on those types of feelings until she had to (paraphrasing here), but that didn't take away from how much she loved Catra.

I personally like exploring how characters can approach 'love' differently, so this definitely piqued my interest in the discussion, and here's my contribution to the characterisation.

Next chapter we have the big confrontation! Oooooohh! They're going to talk about what happened on *that* day five years ago. stay tuned.

Kudos and comments brighten up my miserable life.

Stay safe,

Cx.

Moving On

Chapter Summary

> I recommend going back to read the first half of chapter one before reading this chapter.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Catra picked her up at eleven o'clock.

Adora had spent all morning trying to decide what to wear. It wasn't because she was particularly vain, or on the other hand, particularly self-conscious. It was because she wanted to look good. She wanted to look like she wasn't falling apart on the inside.

Adora had a complicated relationship with body image.

From the ages of sixteen to twenty-one (her formative years), she had predominately worn army clothes, whether that be her uniform or casuals. She felt comfortable in these clothes because she liked that they represented her role; she was a soldier. She dressed how a soldier was supposed to dress.

When she left the army and she realised that she could wear other clothes, she realised she had a bit of a body image problem.

Adora had always been on the muscular side of slim, and she liked this about herself. She also had curves, and she liked those too. Finding a way to express both of these things she liked? That was much more difficult.

For the first year or so, she stuck to shirts and trousers and didn't experiment with anything else. At the gym, she wore a tank top and shorts, which she also liked. When she met Glimmer and Bow, she experienced something of a culture shock.

Their clothes were so loud and in a weird way, they were extensions of their personality.

And they were so keen in helping Adora find clothes that she liked.

When Glimmer was desperate to get Adora into a dress, she had actively rebelled against it.

Adora? In a dress?

Adora had never worn a dress in her life.

Dresses were for other people – they certainly weren't for ex-soldiers with battle scars and rock-hard abs. They weren't for people like her.

Oh, she was so wrong.

Something inside Adora lit up when she put on a dress for the first time. She felt… nice. She liked how it accentuated her curves, but at the same time, she liked how it showed off her toned arms and the plane of her back.

She felt *pretty*.

And she cried about it in Glimmer's bathroom.

Adora had never been a *pretty* girl. Sure, people had commented on her looks before but that didn't mean she believed them, or that she felt pretty. She looked at herself in the bathroom mirror and saw a blonde princess staring back at her – someone she *wanted* to look like but also someone who *wasn't* her.

"You can be anything you want to be, and you can show it any way you want, Adora," Glimmer whispered, tilting her chin up. "The most important thing is that you express yourself. You be who you are."

"This isn't me," Adora had mumbled.

“Okay, if it doesn’t feel right, then –”

“No, it’s not that.”

“So, it does feel right?”

“But I don’t know how it can,” Adora insisted.

“Listen.” Glimmer had sat beside her on the kitchen floor. “You can be Adora wearing a tank top and gym shorts. You can be Adora in your old army uniform. But you can also be Adora in a pretty dress. One day you want to go to the shop in your sweatpants and an oversized jumper? That’s fine. The next you want to go out wearing a formal gown and heels? That’s also fine. There is no wrong way in approaching yourself.”

Adora had nodded, wiping away her tears. “I know gym Adora and soldier Adora, though.” She locked eyes with herself in the mirror. “I don’t know her.”

“Do you want to get to know her?”

Adora sniffled and looked away. “Yes.”

Glimmer held out her hand. “Come on, then. Let’s see how this Adora feels about her hair.”

Adora had went out that night in a dress but had drawn the line at changing her signature ponytail. Since then, she had experimented with adding more items to her limited wardrobe; skirts and blazers, blouses and a *few* dresses. She still wore what she was most used to, but now and again, on special occasions, Adora would indulge in her more feminine side.

Lately, Adora hadn’t been caring much for her appearance. She probably needed to visit the hairdressers and most days she wore work clothes without paying much attention to what she was actually wearing.

But she wanted to make an effort for Mara.

She wanted to prove that she was still living.

So, Adora mustered all the bravery she could stomach, and she put on a casual black ditsy-print dress and left without looking in the mirror.

When she got into Catra's car, she noticed the brunette staring. Feeling a little self-conscious, Adora tugged at the hem of her dress, offering a plateaued smile.

"I've never seen you in a dress before," Catra burst out, as if it spouted from her, unwanted.

She immediately looked away, her cheeks burning.

Adora scanned what Catra was wearing and noticed she, too, had smartened up for the occasion with a red collared shirt and dark fitted trousers. She looked good, but there was no change there.

"I know," Adora said with a forced laugh. "It's weird."

"It's not weird," Catra rebuked. Her hands tightened onto the steering wheel. "It suits you, it's – different."

Adora didn't know what to do. She sat there, trying to think of a good response, until she realised too much time had passed and now, they were just sitting awkwardly. Catra saved them by turning on the radio and starting up the engine.

"Thanks for lunch yesterday," Adora said after a few minutes. "It helped."

"Yeah, well, Sparkles said you weren't good on your own after a panic attack. It would've been heartless for me to just leave you there."

"You do know her name is Glimmer?"

"Whatever."

“And she is technically your boss.”

“Again, whatever. You two seem, uh, close.”

“She’s a good friend. So is Bow. They can be a bit much sometimes, but they taught me how to – you know. Take care of myself.”

“Ah, something I could never do.”

“I think I needed to learn it the hard way.”

Catra drove in silence. Adora stared out of the window and spared her a glance every so often. She didn’t ask if Catra remembered how to get where they were going, she trusted that she did.

Up ahead, Adora spotted The Milkshake Yard and it immediately brought to mind a fond memory. When she looked back at Catra, she noticed the other girl was also sparing it a look.

“Do you remember?” Adora asked softly, nodding towards the shop.

Catra scoffed. “Of course I remember.”

Upon receiving their first military paycheque, Catra and Adora had done what typical sixteen years old did when having freedom and money for the first time; they spent it on sweet cravings and things they’d always wanted but could never afford. But, no, not cars or phones or accessories – the first thing they bought with their first ever paycheque was one of the luxury milkshakes from The Milkshake Yard.

Sitting with Catra on the edge of the road, rewarded with the fruits of their labour – nothing had ever tasted so sweet.

Catra signalled right and turned into the drive-through. “For old time’s sake?” she muttered.

Adora bit her lip. “Do you remember my order?”

Catra raised a brow at the challenge. “Triple chocolate brownie with fudge sauce and mini marshmallows, duh.”

Something glowed in the centre of Adora’s chest. “I don’t drink dairy milk anymore. Make mine an oat-base, please.”

“Oh, well now you’ve ruined the nostalgia,” Catra said sarcastically.

Adora was pleased to hear that Catra’s order hadn’t changed (strawberry and white chocolate, extra whipped cream) when she pulled up to the order window. When it came for paying for their drinks, Adora took out her card and Catra pushed her hand away.

“I’ll get them, it’s fine.”

Adora frowned. “No. You bought us lunch yesterday. I can get them.”

Catra rolled her eyes and took out her own card. When the employee at the window reached out to take it, Adora leaned over Catra and snapped the card away. “I’m paying,” she told the man.

Huffing, Catra elbowed Adora in the ribs. “Get away, idiot. I said I’d get it.”

“You don’t want her card,” Adora told the clerk. “Her funds are dodgy. Illegal investments, fraud –”

Catra’s gasp was loud enough to make the employee flinch. “You’re an absolute bast –”

“Take mine, please,” Adora said, climbing over Catra again to give the man her card. “I’m a teacher, take my money instead.”

The poor man looked traumatised but accepted Adora’s card all the same. The blonde sat back in the passenger’s seat with a smug look on her face, as if she’d won the greatest prize in all the world.

Catra scowled at her and it kept going. Just as Adora wondered if she had gone too far and actually offended her, Catra burst into high-pitch giggles.

"Wow, you're still an overly competitive princess, aren't you?"

Adora shrugged. "Insult me all you like. I won. That's all that matters."

"You prove my point," Catra said, still laughing.

Adora's heart soared at the sound. She accepted her milkshake and took a hearty sip.

And then immediately gagged. "Oh wow," she said between coughs. "I forgot how sweet these are."

Catra took a sip and also pulled a face. "Guess we don't have the tolerance of our sixteen year old selves." She paused to take another drink and then said, "Remember that time we got one of these each – the limited edition flavour one – and we had a competition to see who could chug it the quickest?"

"If I remember correctly, you ended up throwing it up on the drive home behind a corner shop," Adora shot back, smirking.

"If I remember correctly, I won," Catra bit.

"If I remember correctly, you only did it to impress that girl – what did you call her – with the hair always covering her eyes?"

Catra glared at Adora over her takeaway cup. "You *know* her name was Fara."

Adora shrugged innocently. "Fara had a crush on you."

It was true – Adora knew of many people who had their eye on Catra, especially during their teenage years in the army. Once they got too close, most were put off by her spiky personality, but not Fara. Even though Adora hadn't heard of Catra having any

relationships or flings while serving (apart from the Scorpia rumour) she'd always expected that if something had happened, it would've been with Fara.

Adora had never liked her, and it didn't occur to her until a few years later that it was because she was *jealous*.

"Fara had a crush on everyone," Catra said, strangely neutral.

It made Adora chew on her straw.

For a few moments, it felt like both of them forgot about why they were here, driving out of town together. It could be so easily for Adora to slip back into an old routine of driving around with Catra, making up silly games and competing over nothing. And then she remembered the dress and the fear and the uncertainty of the future and *Mara*.

They were here for Mara and to resolve tension so that Catra could move on.

So that they could both move on, if Adora wanted.

Feeling the fist of nerves clench her stomach, Adora put down her milkshake and stared out of the window.

Catra clicked on the radio again.

"Thank you," Adora said suddenly.

Catra kept her eyes forward. "What for?"

"I don't feel like I've deserved the kindness you'd shown me over these past few days."

There was a pause and Adora regretted admitting it out loud. Then Catra muttered, "Everyone deserves kindness."

Catra parked the car a few streets away, and then they made their way towards the graveyard on foot.

They walked in silence until they found her.

Mara was in the soldier plot with other fallen comrades of the Etherian army. Adora recognised a few other names as they walked by.

“Here she is,” Catra said, slightly ahead of her.

Adora nodded. They stopped in front of the gravestone.

It was simple – uniformed, like everything else in the army. Even in death.

Kneeling at the stone, Adora placed a bouquet of wild daisies on the grave. In the absence of knowing Mara’s favourite flower, Adora had spent too long in the flower shop trying to decide what type of flower’s Mara would’ve liked. Adora had chosen wild daisies because not only for their beauty, but because Mara was always excited by the simple things in life.

There was a lump in Adora’s throat, and as much as she tried to push it down, it didn’t release until the first tear fell.

Catra put a hand on her shoulder. “What are you thinking?”

“I don’t know what I would’ve done without Mara as my mentor,” Adora admitted, stubbornly wiping away her tears. “The SF almost swallowed me whole.”

“Nah, you did alright. We both did.”

Adora shook her head, not sure what she was disagreeing with. “It could’ve been us,” she said quietly.

Catra hummed. “It nearly was.”

Absent-mindedly, Adora rubbed the scar on her chest. She took one more look at Mara and stood up. When she caught Catra's eye, she did her best to remain strong. "Is that what you want to talk about? That day." Her throat was dry. "The Heart of Etheria Project."

Catra flinched at the mention of the mission's name. "Yeah." She took a deep breath and gestured to a bench on the outskirts of the graveyard. "I'll – I'll give you a minute."

Adora's tears had finally dried by the time she sat beside Catra on the bench. Despite the location, the setting was quite picturesque, and Adora had to admire how Catra's eyes sparkled in the midday sun. She clenched her hands and fixed the hem of her dress, sucking in a deep breath. "So," she started.

Catra looked from her and back out to the graveyard. "So."

And the day was about to get much harder. "What did you want to…" Adora trailed, unsure of what she was going to say or where this was going to go. "Discuss?"

Catra wiped her hands on her trousers. "Well, um. Shit. This is hard." She took a steadying breath, still avoiding Adora's stare. "It's been five years since… since it happened. I've changed. A lot. Leaving the army was one of the best decisions I ever made."

Adora nodded to herself. "I heard you finished your tour."

Their army contracts, or 'tours', lasted four years. Once you signed up for another tour, you couldn't get out of it. Their first tour ended when they were twenty, and they immediately signed up for another four years. Adora knew Catra had finished her tour and then quit. She would've been twenty-four.

"I heard you didn't," Catra retorted.

Yeah. It was a well-known fact that Adora had ‘abandoned her post’.

If she hadn’t, however, she wouldn’t have been sitting on the park bench today with Catra – she would’ve been with Mara in the ground.

“A conversation for another time,” Adora murmured.

If there was another time. She had no idea how this conversation was going to go.

Catra was quiet for a few moments. Remembering how she didn’t like to be crowded, Adora stared at the ground, facing slightly away from her.

Eventually, Catra said, “After what happened, I was a mess. I had breakdowns. Severe PTSD. I think the fact that we weren’t supposed to survive it, but we did, completely screwed me up. Suddenly I had a future, extra time, that I never expected to have. And everything was different. Everything had changed in an instant. It took me years to readjust and come to terms with everything. Once I found the right therapist and I started to make progress, I started to properly live. All my life – both of our lives, I suppose – had been so controlled. First in the children’s home, then in the army. But to be free, I needed to learn what freedom was. I needed to free myself. And I did.”

While she spoke, Adora’s heart clenched. Catra was different – not just in how she talked and processed her thoughts, but it also showed in her movements. She wasn’t a tightly coiled ball of anger and anxiety anymore. She was collected, mature, and outwardly thoughtful. “I’m proud of you,” Adora admitted. “You’re a lot happier.”

Catra scrunched her nose. “Well, that’s the thing.” She sighed. “I kept coming back to one moment. One moment was holding me back.” When she met Adora’s gaze, she was holding something

back. “And it was you. What you did in the Arms factory. Then, later, how it ended between us.”

Adora shifted uncomfortably on the bench. She had spent so long hoping they would one day have this conversation, but now that it was here, Adora found herself wishing to be anywhere else. “So, you want to talk about it?” she hedged. “You want to… move on?”

“Yeah. I need to. I know it’s selfish of me, especially if you’re not ready to talk about what happened –”

“No, it’s okay. Whatever you need, Catra. I owe you this.”

In fact, she owed her much more. So much more. Adora didn’t have enough apologies, enough regret in the world to give her. She had never intended to hurt Catra, or make her feel uncomfortable, or whatever else had happened between them five years ago. So, she waited patiently for Catra to process whatever it was she wanted to say, and she would do her best to explain herself succinctly and honestly.

If this was the beginning of the end, she had to make sure she did it properly.

Catra looked out past the graveyard. Her hair fluttered in the light breeze, strands of it dancing across her brown skin. Very carefully, as if she was keeping a lid on her emotions, she asked, “Why did you do it?”

“Do what?”

“Leave me behind.”

Adora’s heart stuttered. Her mind brought her back to that moment; she was injured, bleeding, in a collapsing building. Catra was beside her, taking care of her, asking for the failsafe. Adora couldn’t give it to her, and she knew Catra wouldn’t take no for an answer.

So, she kissed her. She apologised. And then she knocked her out.

“I thought I was doing what was best,” Adora said, her voice barely above a whisper. “I thought I was saving you.”

Catra looked like she wanted to scoff, but she bit her lip and turned her head away. When she spoke next, her words shook with anger. “You took away my agency. My choice.”

“I know.”

Adora was sorry for that, of course she was. She wasn’t sorry that it worked – she wasn’t sorry that she did save her.

Catra turned to fully face her, eyes brimming with furious tears. “Why didn’t you just give it to me? The failsafe. You were injured. I was okay. I could’ve done it – we could’ve gone together.”

It sounded like she was still pleading, as if they could go back in time and change it.

Adora’s skin crawled.

That was the thing, wasn’t it? Adora couldn’t have given Catra the failsafe even if she wanted to.

And Catra could never know that.

“I… I did what I thought was right,” she answered carefully. “I wanted to protect you, I wanted you to live.”

“And the kiss?” Catra shot back, tone rising. “Did you have any idea –“ she shook her head and spluttered a sigh “– did you use my feelings against me? To manipulate me?”

Catra stared, unblinking, her chest heaving.

Everything in Adora’s mind moved very slowly. “I – what?” She looked to the trees and back to Catra. The cogs spinning her mind couldn’t click the pieces together. “Your feelings?”

This time, Catra did scoff. “You kissed me to distract me, so you could knock me out. You knew how I felt about you and you weaponised it. I think” – as a tear leaked down her cheek, Catra swiped it away – “no, it *was* what hurt the most. It made me hate you. I hated you so much, Adora. Nothing could ever make me feel so – what?”

Adora had her hands in the air in some sort of peace symbol. With every second, her heartbeat quickened, and her breaths came in short spurts. “Hold on, back up, your feelings? What feelings?”

“Don’t act dumb,” Catra chided, although an inkling of doubt creeped into her voice. “Everyone knew I was in love with you. I thought you were just being you, in other words, oblivious, in never seeing it. Until the kiss. Until you used my feelings against me.”

Adora almost choked on thin air. “In love with me?!”

The cogs whirred and whirred until Adora felt her head spin with them. All this time Catra believed Adora had kissed her because she was using her feelings against her – emotionally blackmailing her into leaving her behind. All this time Catra thought she was some sort of monster – some sort of gaslighting, manipulative –

“Wait, Adora – stop.” The hands on her shoulders pushed her down, kept her rooted. “Calm down.”

She didn’t realise she was hyperventilating until she heard the ragged sound of her own breathing. Remembering her training, Adora put her head in between her legs and did her best to focus. The blood rush caused stars to float in front of her eyes.

Catra’s hand was still on the small of her back, holding her there.

After a few more gulps of air, Adora sat up, saying, “I – I didn’t. Catra, I swear, I never – I didn’t know.”

Catra looked like she wanted nothing more in the world than to believe it. “You… didn’t?”

"No, why would I – I can't believe you'd think I'd do that. Do you really think so little of me?" She winced. This wasn't about her, this was about Catra wanting to move on. Correcting herself, Adora placed a shaky hand on Catra's knee. "I would never do that to you."

There was a brief pause, in which both girls realised their own mistakes.

Frowning, Catra asked, "Then why did you?"

"I didn't –"

"No, I mean – why did you kiss me?"

Adora's cheeks instantly blushed. She became fascinated by the peeling wood of the park bench. "I – Well, I – I thought – I thought I was going to my death, Catra." Her voice became smaller. "I thought it was my last chance."

When she looked up, Catra was watching her as if seeing her for the first time. "So, let me get this straight. You kissed me because you – what? You wanted to?"

"Um." Adora fiddled with the sleeve of her dress. "Yeah."

And she'd wanted to do it for so long.

Catra dropped her head to her hands. "Fuck." She rubbed her eyes, almost clawing them out. "Well, fuck. This didn't go how I thought it would."

"Yeah." Adora wanted the ground to swallow her whole. "Me neither."

The silence was thick between them. Adora didn't know what to do with her limbs and she didn't know where to look. This was as close to a love confession as she'd *ever* gotten. It would be the perfect chance to do it, to explain herself properly (like how she'd practised in the mirror countless times). *I am – was in love with*

you, Catra. I somehow knew it all along and also didn't know it until what I thought were our last moments. I didn't know the feelings I felt for you were love – romantic love – because I felt them all my life and never questioned it. I kissed you because I realised I couldn't lose you, and this was my last chance to express myself. I was repressed for so long and you helped me see properly. I'm sorry that kissing you made you feel uncomfortable, or you thought I was using you –

But no, Adora's inside voice was much more eloquent than her outside voice. Her outside voice died in her throat and lengthened the silence for an unholy amount of time.

And god only knew what was going on inside Catra's head.

Catra, who had just admitted she also had feelings for Adora. At that thought, Adora's cheeks reddened again. If they had communicated properly, where would they be now?

But despite Catra claiming she had feelings, Adora held a flame of doubt inside her chest. There was no way Catra felt the same about her as she felt for Catra – no way. She suddenly felt the overwhelming urge to interrogate Catra this instant about what she really meant by the word 'love'. Maybe it was platonic? Maybe she was confused and meant to say 'kinda maybe liked'? Even that didn't sound plausible.

Catra cleared her throat before piercing the silence. "So, when I stopped talking to you, you thought…?"

Adora didn't dare look at her. instead, she spoke to the bench, and there was a slight shake to her voice. "I thought it was a mixture of you feeling betrayed and that you – that my *advances* weren't appreciated."

A pause, and then a dry laugh. "We really messed this up, huh?"

Nodding, Adora bit her lip and struggled with what to say. In the end, her ineloquent outside voice got the better of her, and she

blurted, “Sorry, can we go back to the bit where you said you were i*n love with me*?”

“Oh. Um.” Catra looked like a rabbit caught in the headlights. She exaggeratedly looked at her watch-free wrist. “Wow, look at the time. I have an important appointment I completely forgot about –”

Adora put her hand out. They both flinched when she came into contact with the other’s arm. “Catra, stop. We need to talk about this. Trust me, I don’t want to, either.”

Catra deflated. “Okay. Yeah, fine. I had feelings for you.” She crossed her arms over her stomach, and spat, “Icky, soft, gross feelings, alright?”

But Adora needed more than that, just to be sure. She needed a textbook definition – at least. She needed a reference in a dictionary or in popular media – anything to clarify the confusion in her head that Catra could possibly have icky, soft, gross feelings akin to Adora’s own icky, soft, gross feelings.

“Can I ask more or –”

“Absolutely not.” Eyes narrowed, Catra leaned over to shove Adora’s arm. “Hey, wipe that stupid grin off your face. *You* were the one who kissed *me*.”

Adora stupidly touched her own mouth, shocked to find that she *was* smiling. “Yeah.” She scoffed. “To be honest, I nearly died afterwards.”

Catra rolled her eyes. “Of embarrassment, I’m sure.”

“One hundred percent.”

Adora could feel Catra’s gaze burning through her, and as she felt another sweep of shame, she could guess the next question that was going to be fired at her. She braced herself, holding onto the

edge of the bench, just as Catra asked, "Did you… have feelings for me?"

There it was.

Adora had never been so conflicted. How could she explain herself? "I – uh, I mean – um, so the thing – the thing is – I sorta, really – um…" *fuck, fuck, fuck, fuck, fuck.* "I, uh –"

"Jeez, relax." Catra deflected, looking away and brushing it off casually. "It doesn't matter, don't give yourself a hernia over it."

Adora bit her lip. Oh boy, she hated herself right now. Cautiously, she started, "Do you still…?"

"It's been *five* years, Adora," Catra *almost* hissed at her.

"Right, yeah," she replied hurriedly. "Sorry, you're right. Of course."

Yeah, of course, who would still have feelings for their ex-best friend after five years of no contact? How silly.

Ahem…

The self-loathing presented itself as a lump in her throat. The whole point of this conversation was so Catra could move on. Any chance Adora had of making Catra happy had died in the Horde Factory half a decade ago.

So, instead of pining any harder, she asked, "Where do we go from here?"

Would they still be friends? At the very least, amicable colleagues?

Did Catra want to go back to hating her?

When Adora looked towards her again, she noticed Catra had a glassy look in her eyes. Quietly, she said, "I – it's a lot easier knowing that you were just being a heroic idiot back in the Horde

Factory, rather than a manipulative jackass. I say we can call a truce, if you want."

"I do," Adora replied quickly. She winced. "Want. A truce."

Catra gave a stiff nod. She caught Adora's gaze, and her mismatched eyes scanned her for something. "Just before we move on from this shit show, can I ask you something else?"

Adora prayed for this torture to end. "Sure," she said, smiling.

"Are you sorry? For leaving me behind?"

Oh.

Maybe Catra shouldn't have called a truce so soon.

"I'm not sorry for doing what I thought would save you. I'd choose that time and time again." Adora paused to push down the lump in her throat. As of late, she'd cried too many times in front of Catra. "Now, though – now that I'm older, I realise that it was wrong of me to act on your behalf. I'm sorry for taking away your agency and make you feel worthless. But I'm not sorry for doing what I thought was the right thing."

Catra continued to study her like she was an artwork she couldn't decipher. When she shrugged, Adora felt a bit of the tension unfurl. "I shouldn't expect anything else from you, I suppose." Catra then added, "Can I ask you one more?"

Adora's heart dropped. "Okay."

"What happened at the transmitter? What happened when the failsafe activated?"

It was the worst possible question to ask.

The one secret that remained between them.

Panic bubbled in Adora's chest, and she stuttered, "I – it – there was –"

Catra put a hand on her shoulder. "No, sorry, I shouldn't have asked."

Adora nodded, grateful for it. "One day," she muttered. "I promise."

Twenty years old

They called for Adora late in the night.

At first, she thought she'd done something wrong. She was escorted by a Lieutenant and a second Lieutenant to a private meeting room in the SF barracks. Neither of them entered the room with her, but they stood outside like a couple of guards.

Adora's heart was slamming against her chest when she went inside. Captain Lonsfield and Colonel Hope were standing in front of a round table. Adora saluted from the door and waited for further instruction.

"Lance Corporal Greyskull," greeted Captain Lonsfield. "Please, take a seat."

Adora took the only chair available to her; the lonely plush chair in front of their desk. She crossed her hands on her lap, patiently waiting.

"We understand that Lieutenant Despondos was something of a mentor to you," said Colonel Hope. "She trusted you with the final steps of her mission during the First Ones operation."

Adora's throat was dry. "Yes, ma'am."

"Lieutenant Despondos had been selected because of her skill and ambition. She was consistently the best performer of her peers." Captain Lonsfield eyed her carefully. "What was more, she

believed in the Etherian cause. She mentored you because you share those traits, Lance Corporal Greyskull."

"Thank you, sir."

"Due to Lieutenant Despondos's untimely death, we have an opening with a classified project. A project that we hope – no, we *know* will bring an end to the war. Lieutenant Despondos confirmed as much upon the completion of her part of the mission. We can end the war, Greyskull. We can save countless lives."

He looked towards Colonel Hope, who said, "But we need someone to take over from Lieutenant Despondos." A pause, and a perfectly placed smile. "We want *you* to take her place, Lance Corporal Greyskull."

Adora's head was spinning. "Sorry, um – permission to speak, ma'am?"

"Permission granted."

"What is the project?" Adora asked. "What would I have to do?"

Hope's pokerface never wavered. Adora had yet to see her blink. She continued to observe her with cold interest, detached from any emotion. "Due to the classified nature, we can't tell you unless you accept the position. The Special Forces deals with the hardest, most elite military challenges. This project is *the* most elite taskforce we've ever created."

"Don't underestimate what an honour it is to be selected for this, Lance Corporal Greyskull," Lonsfield warned.

Adora startled. She hadn't expected this, and it felt oddly – cynically – forceful. Of course she would do anything in her power to help end the war – to help end the suffering of innocent people caught in a game of extreme politics and misplacement. It had been one of her primary reasons for joining the army in the first place.

But Mara…

“No, I mean – of course,” Adora said, still completely confused at what was being asked of her. “If Mara – if Lieutenant Despondos thought it was important, then I also understand that.” She tried to arrange her features to show an expression of gratitude. “It would be a privilege to take her place.”

Captain Lonsfield and Colonel Hope exchanged an unreadable *look*. Hope extended an arm across the desk, offering Adora her hand to shake. “Well, then, Lance Corporal Greyskull. Welcome to the Heart of Etheria project.”

Adora felt a chill trickle down her spine.

Chapter End Notes

I don't know about you, but I can't wait to see what Catra's internal monologue is like after this conversation.

So, there we have it! Catra wanted to move on by letting go of Adora's betrayal, only to find out it wasn't the type of betrayal she had thought it was. Adora's heard Catra used to have feelings for her, doesn't believe it, and is still keeping *something* from her and not telling the complete truth... hmm.

One of my favourite themes to explore is the power in femininity; so many times, no matter the gender that's being presented, power and strength is characterised by masculine traits, and part of what I loved about the character of She-Ra (especially Adora's true form of her) is that she has bulging arm muscles and is still feminine. I know everyone's take on Adora and Catra's gender identity is different, but the first few paragraphs in this chapter is my take on how Adora views herself (at least in this story).

I hope you enjoyed the chapter. I'm aiming to get the next one out within the week. If you liked it, please let me know

by leaving kudos or comments - I could do with the morale boost.

Stay safe.

Cx.

Bridges

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

When Catra got home after her conversation with Adora, she did something she hadn't done in quite a while.

She went for a run.

As soon as she was in through the door, she peeled off her clothes, put on a pair of leggings and a baggy top, and nearly leapt through the front door again. She didn't stretch, she didn't take a minute, she didn't even stop for water; as soon as her feet hit the pavement, she ran with as much power as her legs would grant her.

She hadn't been this confused, or felt so overwhelmed by conflicting emotions, in quite some time.

For the past five years, she'd held onto a grudge so tightly that it had physically burnt her. It had caused her pain, suffering and so many years of heartache.

Only to find out it had been somewhat of a lie.

Adora hadn't manipulated her. Adora was completely oblivious to Catra's feelings. Adora's crime was that she had done what she had always done; sacrificed herself to protect other people.

Adora wasn't a big manipulative monster, the villain of this story. Adora was just being Adora.

And wasn't that what Catra loved (and equally hated) about her?

Catra turned right to run through the park, aware of a growing stitch in her side. She thought of the last five years and all that

she'd been through – as well as all that she'd accomplished. She thought about Adora now, about Adora then, and her heart hurt.

All that wasted time. Five years' worth of wasted time. They would never get that back.

Adora had kissed me because she wanted to. Adora wanted to kiss me, Catra's mind repeated, unwarranted.

Catra had never – not once – expected Adora to return any of her feelings. So, knowing this; that for a moment Adora had willingly kissed her in an act of goodbye, felt… Well, it made her feel guilty. So much regret. Irritation that they couldn't have discussed this before – before a war, before their separation, before any of this.

Lost in a haze of hurt, Catra stopped running and bent over, breathing heavily. A dagger of rage stabbed her stomach, and she lashed out by kicking a traffic cone on the edge of the park. She kicked it and kicked it until the plastic bent and cracked.

Adora struggled to identify some of her feelings.

Kick.

Adora had never implied she had feelings for Catra.

Kick.

Adora had never implied that she *knew* about Catra's feelings for her.

Kick.

Catra, back then, always assumed the worst about people.

Kick.

Catra was too full of rage and contempt for the world to ever think she could be loved.

Kick. *Kick. Kick.*

She only stopped when her ankle gave a loud click and she felt a rush of heat fall from her knee to her foot. When she looked up, she saw a group of teenage boys staring at her across the grass. Some had even paused in eating their sandwiches. In response to their gawping, Catra gave the traffic cone one last kick, firing it in their direction, and stalked off, limping, back home.

As her rage simmered, it began to twist into more sick guilt. All this time she'd been so focused on how Adora had hurt her, that it never occurred to her that she also hurt Adora.

Adora thought Catra pushed her away because her advances weren't wanted. That *she* wasn't wanted. Catra had pushed her away, made her feel worthless, hated her for so long that it had settled in her bones.

And the thought – the *what if*. What if Adora had communicated this to her before, what if Catra had told her about her soft, icky, gross feelings? What if they'd communicated properly, without all the repression and depression? Where would they be now? What could they have been?

She was definitely not going to get any sleep tonight.

It was all over, at least. Catra had told Adora she wanted to move on. Adora thought she was in a relationship with Scorpia.

Then there was how Adora asked, so gently, if Catra still had those feelings for her.

That was the question, wasn't it? Back when Catra swore never to forgive Adora for her apparent betrayal, she told herself that she was done with everything to do with her. But that had never been the case, had it? Catra tried to destroy their relationship because it was something she could never have. It was safer to hate her than love her and lose her.

In short, no. Catra had never stopped loving Adora. Her feelings had changed, somewhat; they had matured, they were more

nuanced. She was either in love with Adora, in love with the idea of her, or in love with hating her. There was no in between.

As for Adora? It was clear that she never had true feelings for Catra. She had even struggled to answer the question when Catra had asked her. And that was okay; Catra could live with knowing that for a split second, at the end of their universe, Adora had chosen to kiss her. Had chosen *her*.

At the same time, it was *absolutely not okay, and she desperately needed to find something else to kick.*

When Catra returned home, Scorpia was in the kitchen unpacking shopping bags. At the sound of the door, Scorpia started babbling, as she usually did, detailing every tiny little thing that happened in the supermarket.

Catra stood at the kitchen counter, staring into space.

" – and the woman at the till told me to 'have a nice day', but I could tell she genuinely meant it. You know how someone's face lights up when they say something? She had the prettiest dimple on her – hey, are you okay?"

Catra shook herself, crash landing in the present. "No," she said flatly.

Scorpia dropped the carton of cashew milk. "Oh – um, was it – was it…" She lowered her voice to whisper. "*Adora*?"

Catra silently nodded.

Scorpia put her hands on her hips. "You know, I never did like her –"

"She didn't know," Catra interrupted. "About my feelings. She didn't manipulate me. She kissed me because – because she *wanted to.*"

The realisation of what this meant showed on Scorpia's face in stages. Confusion. Surprise. Understanding. Sympathy. "Oh, I'm sorry, Wild Cat. This sounds like a tricky situation."

"I don't know what to do," Catra admitted. She was swimming in the smoke of bridges she'd burned.

"You wanted to talk to her about what happened so you could move on. You wanted to close the door on that part of your life." Scorpia paused. "Is that what you still want?"

Catra wanted to move on because the only thing holding her back from being free of her past was Adora's betrayal. She couldn't understand how someone she grew up with, someone she knew in and out, someone she loved, could ever hurt her in that way. It completely destroyed her. Since then, she'd dealt with her childhood trauma and came to terms with her bad experiences in the army, but no matter how much she tried, she couldn't let go of Adora's betrayal.

She needed to move on from Adora, clear the air between them, understand her side of the story to be free.

Now? The narrative had changed. Catra could resent Adora's actions, but she resented them because they resembled the Adora she knew.

So, did she still want to move on?

What was the alternative?

Catra had prepared so long for an Adora-free life.

But what would her life look like with Adora in it?

Twenty years old

The Heart of Etheria project.

The mission that would end the thirty-year war.

Adora had been transferred to a separate facility for three weeks to prepare for it. She didn't come into contact with any other person on the team; all of her instructions came directly from Captain Lonsfield or Colonel Hope.

During those three weeks, they briefed her on the scale of the project. They told Adora what was expected of her, what training it would involve and when she would be needed.

Essentially, Adora's role would come into play at the very end of the mission. The details were limited, and Adora often found herself confused at what exactly was happening.

But she was a soldier. She wasn't there to question anything. She was merely a puppet for the puppet master.

It was only when she was asked to sign a lengthy document that she started to see red flags.

"Excuse me, Colonel," Adora said as she flicked through the file. "This says 'pre-surgery agreement'."

Hope gave a single nod. "Yes."

Adora narrowed her eyes slightly, looking back down at the writing and the cross where she was supposed to sign. "I'm sorry, I don't understand."

"We told you about a minor surgical procedure to complete your part of the mission, Lance Corporal Greyskull. This is merely the non-disclosure agreement before it's arranged."

Adora couldn't remember any mention of a 'minor surgical procedure' – it was definitely something she would remember. Bile rose in her throat. She had no idea what to do. As she paused, Colonel Hope pushed the document closer.

“I’m needed in an urgent meeting, Greyskull. Please sign so we can move on.”

The familiar pull of panic addled her stomach. Adora’s hand began to shake. Why couldn’t she remember anything about surgery? What was the surgery for? Hadn’t she been listening properly? Surely, they wouldn’t keep this from her, surely, they would need her permission before agreeing to something like this. It was her right to know, after all.

And why would Colonel Hope lie to her?

No, Adora must’ve forgotten what the surgery was, or not been listening properly. It was the only explanation.

Colonel Hope wouldn’t lie to her.

So, Adora quickly signed the document and made a mental note to ask Captain Lonsfield about it at some point.

Things after that moved very quickly.

Captain Lonsfield told her a chip would be inserted into her body, akin to the one Mara had. The chip was called a failsafe and it was a wider part of the She-Ra programme; something there would be plenty of time in the future to explain in full. What was important now, apparently, was inserting the failsafe into a host.

Adora was assured it was a painless procedure, and that she’d be out and about later that day.

Two more lies that she could add to her belt.

Adora woke up alone in hospital. She was draped in a light white blanket and wired up to a heart monitor.

And she *hurt*.

As the cloudy-full feeling in her head began to lift, she stretched her arms and legs before pushing herself up on her elbows.

The blanket fell down to her stomach.

Her chest was encircled with bandages.

And the centre of her chest was *glowing*.

Something of a squeak fell from her lips. She sat up as straight as she could manage and ghosted her hand over the bandage. The pink-purple light blinked but remained where it was.

Despite still feeling addled from the anaesthetic, Adora felt her anxiety levels rise. The heart monitor beside her bed went haywire.

The nurse found her half off the bed with a hand clutching her bandaged chest. Before he could say anything, Adora croaked, "Get Captain Lonsfield."

It must've been how she said it, the deep tension of anger in her voice, because the nurse did as she said, no questions asked.

Captain Lonsfield took his time. When he entered the hospital room, he had his hands crossed behind his back and a resolute smile on his face. With crinkled eyes, he nodded towards Adora.

Before he had a chance to speak, she asked, "What have you done to me?"

The purple glow underneath her bandages flared in time with her beating heart. His eyes darted from her face to her chest and back up again. He cleared his throat.

"It's called She-Ra. The glow over your heart is coming from the failsafe we inserted." In response to his sharp inhale, he added, "All will be explained in due course, Lance Corporal Greyskull."

Adora was finding it hard to form thoughts. She felt things, too many things, and for the first time in her life she wanted to *break* from the pressure of it all. "I – I don't –"

Catra wouldn't have let this happen.

Adora bit down on her tongue. She was bound to secrecy because of the contract. She had never felt so separated from Catra in her life, and at the same, had never needed her more.

Catra was the strong one. Catra wouldn't tolerate this. She would've known what to believe, what to question, what lies were obtuse.

She needed Catra.

"Remember Adora," Lonsfield said, drawing her back to the present. "You took an oath to do what was best for the greater good. This is what your country needs." His smile changed, becoming toothy and twisted. "You'll be a hero. That's what we all want, isn't it?" He rocked on his toes. "A legacy to live longer than us."

Adora stared at the ceiling, realising things that she'd never realised before.

Duty.

Legacy.

Ever since she was a child, Adora was told these were the only values that mattered.

So, why did they leave her feeling so cold?

Present day

The Heart of Etheria Project.

Adora's greatest mistake.

They had coerced a nineteen-year-old, grieving girl to become an experiment – the host of their latest technological advancements

to fight the Horde.

Once she had accepted, she forfeited her future. Her destiny belonged to Colonel Hope, and there was no get-out clause. She was bound to the agreement, sworn to secrecy, and practically came with an expiry date printed on her shiny new pay packet.

But what was the Heart of Etheria Project?

Adora was shown a brief presentation. The Etherian army had developed a chip that contained a string of code that could dismantle any Horde weapon, software or piece of tech. They had found a weakness they could hack that was found in all Horde systems, and since the Horde's might was only as strong as their technology, then this weakness would win Etheria the war.

Mara's role in Mission First Ones was experimental. She was the first to test it out. They called the chip She-Ra (Software hack Etheria – Regiment Army) and it was implanted into the host.

Yes. It was physically put inside a living host.

That was the trick of the transfer – the reason why the Horde never expected their weakness to be exposed.

The hack relied on a living host.

Mara's experiment had been partially successful. The chip had brought down the Horde's prison system, damaging it beyond repair, but the consequences had been severe; for a start, Mara had died doing it. Secondly, the second chip, the one she had told Adora to take, had failed to download the information that the Etherian army were trying to process.

So, they adapted She-Ra and fitted the chip with a failsafe.

The failsafe meant that even if the host died, the information procured would still be obtainable.

If Adora died, the army didn't lose anything of value.

Most of this information was given to Adora after she had agreed to become a host of She-Ra. The presentation she was shown during her induction simply told her about a chip that contained software able to hack a weakness in the Horde's systems that destroyed them and gave the Etherian army important inside knowledge. When applied to the right system, She-Ra would end the war.

She-Ra, and the host of She-Ra, would save them all.

There was no mention of a living host, no reference to failsafe, and no indication that the host, for all intents and purposes, would probably die completing their task.

Adora would find that out later.

They sent her to a medical vicinity for a compatibility check, and when everything was in order, they asked her to sign forms before undergoing an operation.

When Adora woke up in the military hospital, the bandages around her chest were glowing with a pink-purple light.

And then she understood what She-Ra was and what they'd done to her.

Now, at twenty-six, Adora stood in front of her bedroom mirror and stared at the scar in the valley of her breasts.

It was heart-shaped and pink, slightly square in its appearance. It was smooth to the touch and very visible. It had stopped glowing some time ago.

She wondered if it would ever fade entirely.

As Adora ran her fingertips across the bumpy skin of the scar, she wondered what life she would've had without She-Ra and the failsafe.

For a start, it was the only thing she'd ever kept from Catra. Not that she wanted to keep it from her. This was a military-bound secret.

Reconnecting with her this weekend, and realising that their five-year absence in each other's lives had been a simple communication problem, had given Adora a lot to unpack. She had been honest when she said she hadn't known about Catra's feelings. She *had* wanted to save her.

But she couldn't have given Catra the failsafe, even if she'd wanted to. You couldn't share something that was physically implanted inside you.

Adora couldn't help but feel like she was still being dishonest.

She sat on the edge of her bed and thought about her situation.

Catra had wanted to move on, and Adora had done her part in helping her do that. Catra could let go of her past, let go of Adora, and have a future without their baggage weighing her down. She would continue teaching probably, at Brightmoon or elsewhere. She'd settle down with Scorpia, they might have a kid or two, and Catra might have a promotion through time. They'd buy a house together and do normal civilian things like go on cheap holidays and have dates down at the local pub on Friday afternoons.

Adora hoped she would be happy.

And then she thought about herself.

What did Adora's future look like?

There was no use in putting it off any longer. It was time to read the letter.

She opened her the drawer of her bedside table and looked at the brown envelope as if it were deadly. There was a slight tremor to her hands as she picked it up and ripped it open using one of her nails.

The coat of arms of the Etherian Army was printed in the top right corner. The entire letter was written in small capitals.

Memorandum for personal record

Subject: the continuation of the Heart of Etheria project

Dear Corporal Greyskull,

As per previous correspondence, we are now calling upon you to honour the legal-bound agreement that was made re: the continuation of the Heart of Etheria project on behalf of the Etherian Special Forces (weaponry division).

We remind you that failing to honour said agreement is breeching the contract, resulting in further legal action.

You can expect further correspondence from us on how and where to re-enlist in the coming weeks.

We look forward to working again with you soon.

Sincerely,

Brigadier Hope, BA, MSc, EME, SFC

This was it.

They were calling on her agreement.

Adora's future was already written somewhere on a legal document that she was forced to sign five years ago.

She would re-enlist into the Special Forces and take up her old post. She would see through another Heart of Etheria project, and this time, well…

How many people survived a suicide mission twice?

They told her wounds would heal, but it felt like she was just a vessel for scars. Some wounds had stayed open, and she felt

cracked. Never whole.

She would do this thing that was required of her. She would see it through to the end; partly out of duty, but mostly because she had little choice.

Come Monday morning, Catra felt much more level-headed.

As she got ready for work, a thrill of excitement fluttered in her stomach, and she would never admit it was because she was looking forward to seeing Adora again.

Adora, untainted by an unforgiveable betrayal.

She had slept in (but if anyone asked, she had 'car issues' on the way into work), so she missed the Monday staff meeting. It was no matter, however; Catra would see Adora after school for their MMA lesson.

Due to being distracted for most of the day, Catra was focusing on lighter lesson plans. She read a few chapters of *Of Mice and Men* with her fifth years and discussed translation issues with *The Stranger* in her final year class. For the younger kids, she scared them with the narrative of betrayal in *Macbeth* (and even got a few of them to read sections of the prose – their little faces were the perfect picture of petrified). When the last bell rang for the day, Catra was straight out her door to get changed for the MMA class.

This time, she wore her nicest pair of leggings and a fitted slashed-neck t-shirt. Adora was already in the gym hall, setting up the equipment. Catra eyed the blonde carefully, trying to get a sense of her mood. She was chatting to a student – a boy with a shaved head; Simon, if Catra remembered correctly – as they laid out the mats together.

"Need any help?" Catra asked as she walked in.

Adora flinched and dropped the mat she was holding, causing it to fall on top of Simon.

"Oh – I'm sorry, Si!" Adora shrieked.

Red in the face as his friends cackled, Simon shrugged it off as she flung down the mat. "M fine. 'S fine."

Just as Catra was about to open her mouth to say a flirty witticism, another voice boomed across the hall, rough and intimidating.

"Careful there, Blondie. You're supposed to help the kids, not kill them."

Catra spun around to see a very large woman limp into the hall. Over six-feet high, white hair pulled back into a ponytail, and made of pure muscle, Catra felt a glimmer of her old competitive streak relight in her diaphragm.

Why?

Because, even though Adora didn't think she had a type, Catra knew *this* was her type.

Strong women, that was all. The stronger the better. And Adora had the gall to call *her* the shallow one.

Before Catra knew that she was a certified lesbian, she grew up wondering if she wanted to be like pretty women or fuck the pretty women. At around thirteen – after she realised what her feelings for Adora really were – she realised it was the latter. Partly, Adora's problem was that she had problems understanding her own sexual desires, so she had never answered that question. Yes, Adora wanted to be like the muscly women. And yes, she was also attracted to muscly women.

Her little brain was stuck on muscles.

Catra's good mood dropped like a led weight.

“Huntara,” Adora greeted, coming to stand beside Catra with her hands on her hips. “Welcome back.”

Oh, so this was the PE teacher. Without thinking, Catra asked with a sharp tongue, “Aren’t you supposed to be on sick leave?”

She felt Adora stiffen beside her as Huntara studied her. Catra glared right back, looking her up and down. Her left ankle was wrapped in bandages and a brace. Catra also noticed a familiar tattoo on the woman’s bicep – a military tattoo. In particular, the naval force.

Oh, the stereotype. Catra refused to roll her eyes.

“Who’s this one?” Huntara grunted.

“This is Catra, the new lit teacher,” Adora supplied. “She was helping me cover your classes while you were away.”

Huntara’s cheek twitched. “Supervising?”

Catra bristled. She crossed her arms and bit back, “Demonstrating.”

“Catra served with me in the SF, Huntara,” Adora added. Catra cast a glance her way; she was standing between them, eyes darting as she fumbled with her fingers.

“Surprising,” Huntara said to her. “I can usually sniff out ex-army, but I didn’t get that from you.”

Catra gave a loose shrug. “Maybe you should check yourself, then.”

“Maybe.” Huntara matched her shrug with a cheeky grin. “Alright, Kitty –”

“It’s Catra.”

Huntara ignored her. “If you want to stay and help then more the merrier. I’m still out of commission for a while anyway.” She gestured to her cast, then turned to Catra, pointing to her chest. “But I’m in charge here, okay? Blondie understands that too. Can’t be too many chefs in the kitchen.”

Catra tossed up her options; what she wanted to do was challenge Huntara, play with the power dynamics and make Adora all flustered in the process. The more mature side of her (also the newest side) decided to back down – she was a teacher after all – as long as it was on her own terms. She stood back, almost purring, “That’s okay. Adora likes to give up control every so often, and I can see the appeal.” When she winked at the blonde, her old friend was glaring daggers at her. Catra put her hands up in a surrender. “What? I’ll be good, I promise.”

Huntara hummed, although there was a mischievous sparkle in her eye.

While they waited for the rest of the students to arrive, Catra stood beside Adora and tried to catch her eye. Adora was staring ahead, into space, and letting the silence stretch on. After a few more tense moments of waiting, Catra broke the silence first.

“So… Blondie. That’s a cute nickname.”

Adora startled, as if only realising Catra was beside her this entire time. She was obviously distracted about something. “Huntara’s a bit like you. I’m not sure she’s capable of using people’s *actual* names.”

Catra’s nose wrinkled in distaste. When Adora noticed, she gave a soft chuckle. She brushed past Catra to the front of the class, muttering, “Not so funny when the tables turn, is it, *kitten*?”

A blush dusted Catra’s cheeks, and a fire lit inside her. *Oh, it’s on*.

Some of the kids were *very* happy to see Huntara back, whilst others were much more well-behaved compared to previous sessions without her. She started the lesson by recapping on what

Adora had taught them in her absence, followed by what they were moving onto: trips.

Despite her obvious injury, Huntara demonstrated a trip on Adora; she grabbed the blonde by the upper body, took control of her grounded foot and flipped her over her arm so that she landed on the mat on her back. The demonstration lacked the impact of a real fight, so Adora landed quite softly. Catra couldn't help but feel a slight protective surge at the motion, however; she knew Adora had a problem with her hip or leg, judging by how she limped.

"This is quite an advanced move," Huntara told the class. "That means no one is allowed to do try it without one of us" – she gestured at herself, Adora and Catra – "supervising. Understood?"

The class split into three, so each teacher looked after one group. Most of the students were over-excited and none of them succeeded in completing the manoeuvre. A girl in Catra's team, Avra, kicked her partner's ankle so hard that he face-planted the mat. Catra, ever the professional, laughed about it for only a few seconds before helping the poor boy to his feet.

When Huntara called an end to the lesson, Catra hung back, watching with narrowed eyes as the PE teacher interacted with Adora. They were very handsy with each other. Little touches here and there, teasing jabs. She knew a part of her was being irrational; it was impossible to teach MMA without touching someone. Catra scowled as the logical side of her brain fought with her over this.

"No roleplay this week since my ankle is –"

"Catra and I can roleplay," Adora put in quickly. "We did it last time."

Huntara's eyebrows rose on her forehead. "Alright." She looked to Catra. "Let's see if Kitty can fight."

Catra stalked forward, making sure to sway her hips to draw in Adora's attention. "Maybe *Kitty* can take you on when your ankle

is better, eh, Huntara?"

Huntara chuckled. "I like a challenge."

Adora glared at her. "What are you doing?" she whispered as they took their places on the mat.

Catra shrugged innocently, aware of the students watching them. "Making friends."

Reminding you strength doesn't always mean muscle.

It must've been the thrill of competition, because as soon as Huntara counted them down (with some students joining in too), Adora's demeanour completely changed. She widened her stance, flames dancing in her eyes. A small grin played on her lips as she watched Catra slowly lower her stance, ready to pounce.

"Three… two… one… fight!"

Catra, always so light on her feet, bounded forward, swiping Adora's left side. Adora ducked, attempting a jab which was easily deflected. They found their rhythm; back and forth, to and fro, swiping, deflecting, jabbing, defending.

Until Adora kicked Catra's right foot from under her, flipping her body backwards over her shoulder.

Ouch. Catra heaved a breath as she landed on her back, slightly winded.

And fire burned in her veins. *This* was the Adora she remembered.

She waited for Adora to straddle her hips, and when she was pinned to the mat, Catra slipped her leg out from under her and flipped Adora into a triangle choke. Upon hearing Adora huff and felt her lose her balance, Catra switched their positions and held her down with her elbows. Now face to face, she noticed Adora's cheeks were red, and despite the slight sheen of sweat on her skin, the blonde started to laugh. Catra kept still, slightly

mesmerised at the mischief lighting up Adora's smile as she bucked her hips, teasing Catra's hold on her. Shaking herself mentally, Catra leered over Adora, keeping her grip firm, and whispered, "Do you submit, princess?"

With one last buck of her hips, Adora winced and let her body relax under Catra. She raised her eyebrows. "I tapped out a while ago, *kitten*. Now you're just gloating."

Catra leaned closer, another tease on the tip of her tongue, but Huntara interrupted, making them both flinch.

"And time!" Huntara clapped along with the rest of the class. "Congrats, Kit. You showed good technique."

Scowling as she helped Adora up, Catra looked down to hide the redness of her cheeks. Huntara dismissed the students, telling them to pack up or hit the showers. Catra made herself useful by piling the training mats in the corner while Adora and Huntara talked. When she heard Huntara bark a loud laugh, she dropped the last mat with particular gusto, annoyed at herself for being so sensitive.

"Alright, that's me away," Huntara called on her way out. "See you next week!"

Forcing a smile, Catra turned around to wave.

Now it was just her and Adora in the gym.

After Adora put away the gloves, she took a moment to stretch, clenching her hand around her hip. Catra didn't say anything as she watched. There was an internal battle going on inside her mind; should she wait? Should she talk to her now? What was she waiting for?

When Adora caught her eye and smiled, Catra seized the opportunity. "Hey Adora, I was wondering if you – you know, wanted to maybe…" *spit it out, idiot*. "Hang out some time. Like we used to."

Adora paused in the middle of her lunge. “Oh.” Her eyebrows pulled together. “You want to be – friends again?”

Did she have to do all the work around here? Would it be better if she drew a map or strategy plan for Adora to understand what she meant. “Yeah.” Realising it sounded too eager, she amended, “Maybe. I had a lot of fun this weekend, aside from all the other stuff.” Adora’s face darkened. She looked troubled as she pulled her lip between her teeth and stood up straight. As Catra analysed her, she realised what that look was: guilt. A flare of hot, fast embarrassment washed over her. “Listen, it’s fine,” she hissed. “Forget it.”

Adora put her arms out to stop her. “No, Catra, I do. But, I just…”

There was something going on in that blonde head of hers, and Catra had no idea what it could be. “What is it?”

Shifting from foot to foot, Adora wrapped her arms around herself. “I don’t want to hurt you again.”

Catra blinked a few times. Unsurprisingly, she wasn’t the only idiot in the room. Adora hadn’t done anything, why would she be afraid of hurting her?

“Why would you hurt me again?” Catra asked as she walked over. “We’re free of the army, Adora. It’s just us now.” Offering a tight smile, she nudged her friend with her elbow. “I don’t think we’ll find ourselves in a situation like before, do you?”

Adora’s eyes widened slightly before she glanced at the ground. “No. Not both of us, anyway,” she muttered. When she looked up again, she returned Catra’s smile, even going as far as resting a hand on her shoulder. “Of course I want to be friends again. That’s all I’ve ever wanted.”

Chapter End Notes

> This chapter was ready last week, but I wasn't particularly happy with it. I'm still not, but I couldn't get it right, you

know? Anyway, I hope you enjoyed it all the same.

Next time: there's a fluffy revelation in the present, and an alternative view of the past...

Thank you so much for reading, and before you go, please leave a comment on your way out. They really do mean the world to writers. (Also, I'll be updating the playlist at some point, and you can follow me on tumblr, even though I don't use it much: sunsetaurora).

Stay safe!

Cx.

Fragile Promises

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

There was a note waiting for Catra on her desk on Tuesday morning. In tall, loopy writing it said: *Open Day play production meeting @ lunch time, theatre room*. Signed by DT.

Catra managed to hold in a groan, but only because a wandering student made their way over to her desk to ask about homework. Maybe at lunch, Catra would head over to the principal's office to ask permission to be removed from the project. It wasn't like she knew how to contribute. Just because she was a Lit teacher didn't mean she knew anything about *plays*.

But the new, more reasonable voice in her head said: *refusing to cooperate doesn't give a good impression, and the professional nature of your job requires you to care about good impressions now.*

Ugh. It was so tiring being sensible. Thank goodness she was a late bloomer to the concept.

So, Catra made her way to the theatre room at lunch time, only a few minutes late. The entire space was painted black, aside from the stage area. It took her eyes a moment to adjust.

"Welcome!"

Ah. There was DT, as loud as last time.

"Hi," she said, dully, not bothering to hide her disinterest. "What's happening?"

Why couldn't this be an email? She wanted to ask. Everything was better as an email.

DT was once again dressed in an all black silhouette. They curled one leg around the other as they sat on one of the chairs beside the stage, placing their chin on the back of their hand. “I thought we could sit down and talk about what play we’d produce.” Their tone became biting. “You know, that thing the principal wanted us to do. We’re running out of time and I’m nothing if not a perfectionist.”

Catra crossed her arms, and dug her fingernails into her skin to stop her from saying something she'd potentially regret. “I told you I’d go along with whatever you wanted. Just let me know what I need to do and when.”

DT gave a tight smile. “I can tell you’re not one for collaboration. No matter, kitten. I’ll choose the play, but you have to give me *something*.” They patted one of two empty chairs beside them. “Tell me what you like.”

Jeez, they were testing her patience. Catra debated ignoring the request and leaving, possibly to the staffroom, to enjoy her lunch hour somewhere else. She knew, though, that DT wouldn’t leave it alone until she gave *something*. With a huff, she said, “Fine,” and took a seat.

DT lit up and took out a small notepad and pen. “Okay. A few questions.” They eyed Catra carefully. “Plays or musicals?”

She thought about it half-heartedly. “Uh, I don’t care,” she replied. “I know one musical and I only studied prose for my degree.”

“Ooh, interesting. I got poetry vibes from you.” DT looked her up and down with the pen hooked between their fingers like a cigarette. “It must be in the moody, broody persona.”

“I don’t have a –”

“What musical?”

Still ruffled, Catra huffed, “Huh?”

“What musical do you know?”

Catra felt her cheeks darken. Discussing this was unleashing a host of memories she had purposefully tried to forget. “Wicked,” she muttered.

“Oh, darling.” DT placed a hand on her arm. “Fabulous. A musical about friendship, identity, and standing up for what you believe in. A terribly misunderstood main character, wrongly cast as the villain, who finds a connection with the antithesis of herself.” In a lower tone, DT added, “With debatable homoerotic vibes.”

Yeah, that pretty much summed it up. She wasn't going to admit it. Instead, Catra scoffed. “You sound like the brochure.”

“So, indulge me,” DT purred, jotting something down on their notepad. “What was it about Wicked that made you take a chance on it?”

Catra avoided all eye contact. “I don’t know. It, well – it sorta got me into singing.” Her heart sank when she realised this was *exactly* what DT was trying to pull from her. She paused and looked up, feeling a flare of anger at their smug expression. “No – no. Don’t do that. I don’t sing anymore. I haven’t for a long time.”

DT sat back on their chair with their eyes narrowed. “We’ll see about *that* when it comes to our Christmas staff karaoke night.” They winked. “Well, I don’t know about you, but I think Wicked is *wicked* idea.”

Catra was about to object because no, actually, Wicked felt like a terrible idea – it felt like the kind of thing that would uncover repressed memories and, even worse, repressed *feelings* of long-forgotten dreams and passions left to die with the passing of childhood. But, just as she was preparing herself for a spiel of negative denials, a certain complication in the shape of a familiar blonde stopped her in her tracks.

“Oh, Adora,” DT welcomed, adding in a murmur, “Better late than never.”

Oh, great.

The one person - the *only* person - in the world who knew how and why she hated singing, and musicals, and Wicked, and everything about this topic had just walked in.

This was fucking fantastic.

Catra rubbed the bridge of her nose. “What are you doing here?”

DT raised a curious eyebrow. “As part of the art department, Adora helps us create our set designs.”

Of course. Ugh. This was going to be embarrassing.

Adora, who had frozen in the middle of the threshold, shot Catra a cautious side-eye. “Is that okay?”

“Why wouldn’t it be okay?” Catra *sort of* snapped.

Adora gestured between them, voicing the thing everyone in the room was currently feeling. “I thought it might be, you know, awkward.”

“It’s not awkward unless you make it awkward,” Catra replied.

Which made it more awkward.

Let the ground swallow me whole, she thought.

“And it definitely isn’t already awkward,” DT said sarcastically. They patted the other empty chair beside them. “So, Adora dear, we’ve decided on a play.”

Adora shuffled over, still shooting Catra little glances. When she sat with her legs under her on the chair, she asked, “Do I know it?” And then to Catra, “I swear, DT has introduced me to so many musicals.”

“Her favourite so far is *Cats*." In a lower tone, "And I don’t know what that says about her other preferences.” DT laughed, and

Catra tried to hide a chuckle at how Adora took a moment to work out what DT was implying. When they saw her reluctant laughter, DT said to Adora, "Catra suggested we do Wicked the musical."

Adora opened her mouth and closed it again.

Cata took a moment to stare at the floor, cheeks blazing.

"Oh," Adora said after a moment. "Wicked."

Catra did her best to shrug it off. "Yeah."

She *knew* Adora was thinking the same thing as her. When they were thirteen and studying musicals during Drama class. Their teacher, Mrs Cole, had shown them a greatest hits compilation of musical performances. She made them sing *Defying Gravity* together as a group, and then she picked out the best singers for their own school production.

She had chosen *Catra*.

It was the first time Catra had been recognised for something other than her bad behaviour.

It was the first time Catra had been recognised for something on her own, without the attachment of Adora.

Mrs Cole paid attentive care to Catra and helped her recognise the talent she had. Catra and Adora stole a copy of the musical from their local library and watched the recording non-stop together for months. Adora was so proud; she helped Catra practise her parts, and she gloated to their other friends that Catra was going to be a star.

Catra started to have delusions of singing as a career.

Then came the day of the auditions for the school play.

Catra was awarded the part of Elphaba.

The main character.

And it didn't end there – Mrs Cole had tickets for her star pupils to see a live production of Wicked on stage. Catra could never have dreamed of seeing a live musical otherwise – the tickets were extortionately expensive.

There was only one hurdle: she had to get permission from Weaver. Getting permission from Weaver meant telling her all about the musical, her part in it and her newfound talent.

Predictably, it didn't go well. Weaver was appalled Catra had wasted her time on silly daydreams. In the end, she pulled Catra out of Mrs Cole's drama class and forbid her to take part in the school production.

Adora had found Catra in the park that night, crying as she burnt the stolen recording of Wicked. When there was nothing left but ashes, Catra swore that she was never going to *dream* like that again.

Dreams were for other people, people with bright futures. She and Adora were gutter rats, trying to find a way out.

"Do you know Wicked, Adora?" DT asked, pulling Catra back to the present.

Adora blinked a few times. She wiped her hands on her trousers, an indicator that she was nervous. "Yeah. Uh, yeah." Turning to Catra, she said quietly, "That was –"

"Yeah," Catra interrupted, agreeing. "It was."

DT looked as if they were watching the climax of a series finale. "Fascinating." They paused. "Alright, so I'll start thinking about auditions and song choices. Catra, you can put together something of a script, and Adora, you can think about designs for costumes and when we have it ready, set designs." They clicked their tongue. "Are we all good?"

Catra's heart was doing a weird *thump-de-thump*, and she wanted nothing more than to hide herself away in her classroom and pretend none of these memories were raising their ugly little heads. She tried to smile, but it came out as more of a grimace. "Yeah. We're good."

Twenty-one years old

Six weeks before the Heart of Etheria Project

"Do you understand?"

Adora kept her shoulders back and her spine straight. Staring straight ahead, she said, "Yes, sir."

Captain Lonsfield leaned to the side in his chair. "Repeat it back to me."

Adora felt her skin prickle at how he, once again, talked to her in such a condescending tone. Doing her best to stay patient, she recounted, "Once the building is clear, my partner and I find the transmitter. My partner activates the transmitter while I activate the failsafe. I then insert myself into the transmitter, which will fuse the failsafe to the system. Once the communication is discombobulated, She-Ra will bring down the entire network, rendering all Horde weapons and systems useless." She inhaled. Exhaled. Before finishing on, "Once the process is complete, my partner disengages the failsafe and ensures it is brought to safety."

Lonsfield had a twinkle in his eye. Satisfaction. "And how do they do that, Lance Corporal?"

Adora swallowed. "By taking…" Could she say it? It was cruel that he was making her say it out loud – after all, this part of the plan wasn't up to her. She would only pass this information on when the time was right. By this point, Adora would be dead. "…me or taking it out of me."

By taking what is left of me sounded too much of a challenge to her captain. It was best she played it safe, as a mark of respect.

Lonsfield nodded slowly. "You are the only one who can do this, Greyskull. Once the Horde's network is down, our troops will move into secure the territory. Hordak will be seized and brought to justice. We'll win the war. It'll be over." He even smiled. "You'll be a hero."

"Thank you, sir," Adora said. Her throat was too dry. "It's an honour."

She had a flash of her younger self standing in front of Weaver in the children's home. *You're made for great things, Adora. Don't let others distract you.*

Is this what she meant? Had she foreseen this… sacrifice?

"We've put out a notice to all SF operatives to volunteer for the mission," Lonsfield informed her. "It is likely there will be no survivors, depending on the unknown factors we haven't accounted for." He shuffled some papers on his desk, as if he were discussing the weather report. "If you know of anyone who would be suitable, let me know and I'll give them a personal invitation."

Adora's stomach tied itself in a knot. She could think of nothing worse than dragging someone else into this mission. "Yes, sir," she said, keeping her thoughts to herself. She was a good soldier. She was loyal and committed - even if she did resent some things.

He didn't even look at her. "Dismissed, Lance Corporal Greyskull."

Once outside his office, Adora waited until she was a safe distance away to hide in a bathroom cubicle and assess her situation.

A year ago, they had implanted her with She-Ra and the failsafe, and now they actually had a time, a date and a strategy for when the failsafe would be activated, and She-Ra would be implemented.

In a few weeks, Adora would be taking her last breaths.

This was her future, nothing more and nothing less.

Over the last year, she had managed to put off thinking about it too much. She was part of the Heart of Etheria project, and she was the most essential, central member in their plans, but there was no indication of when or where she would be needed. Those decisions were above her. They sent her on other missions, and she completed weekly chores and training like the other members of her team.

But now – now that there was a definitive *end*, Adora could barely see the future at all. It was as if she had written her personal history on a whiteboard, only for someone to come along and erase everything past the immediacy of the present.

When she was a child, where did she want to be at twenty-one? What did she want to achieve? Had she wanted a family of her own - kids? An easy life, a nice beneficial career? A house? A pet? Friends and holidays and a partner?

What did past-Adora want?

What was she going to miss out on?

Not like it mattered, she was just being sentimental. Adora would never have those things; she was never *supposed* to have those things. She was built for a purpose, and anything she'd enjoyed in between was a taste of the civilian world. A world that wasn't her own, a world she was making sure was safe for other people.

In the children's home, Weaver had always told her she was made for great things. Catra had insisted it was some weird grooming technique, and that Weaver had always been creepily obsessed over Adora, as if she was trying to keep her around for a reason. That might have been true; Adora hadn't thought about it too deeply. But standing in front of Lonsfield just now, and how he used the same manipulation techniques…

The thought made Adora's skin crawl. Adora was doing this because of a cause; someone needed to be She-Ra, someone needed to be the host of the failsafe. Someone needed to be sacrificed so the war could end. She was happy to do it – she couldn't bear the thought of someone else doing it. Especially someone in her team – someone she considered a friend. So, no, she was doing this because she needed to, not because Lonsfield claimed she was going to be a *hero*. They had tricked her into She-Ra and the failsafe, but she had stayed because she thought it was the right thing to do. But then a small, tickling thought squirmed its way into her mind: how many times had she been coerced and manipulated in her life? How many things had she done or decided to do because they were her own, unique thoughts and choices?

Adora splashed her face with cold water at the sink and left the bathroom, stomping out the intrusive thoughts with each slap of her boot against the tiled floor.

Thinking wasn't good sometimes. Thinking made things worse.

When she reached her private quarters, there was a shadow on her bed.

"Where have you been?"

Catra.

Ah. Fuck. What did she do about Catra?

It was the only part of this whole plan that felt… unwanted. She wanted to do this, but she didn't want to lose –

No. She couldn't think like that. It wasn't healthy.

What did she do about Catra?

How did she tell her that these were there last -

Adora sat on the edge of her bed, not bothering to turn on the light. She could see the bright glint of Catra's eyes watching her. "Captain Lonsfield wanted to see me."

Catra gave a disapproving grunt. "That man is creepy. Always gives me bad vibes." She sat closer, studying Adora's face, and whispered, "Hey, are you okay?"

Adora brushed it off with a half-hearted shrug. "Yeah, I'm just – you know, thinking."

"That always has been difficult for you."

Adora huffed an amused laugh, elbowing her best friend in the ribs. "Shut up."

Catra nudged her harder. "Make me."

Never one to back down from a challenge, Adora felt her old sense of competition sneak its way through her muddled thoughts. She grabbed Catra by the shoulders and pinned her to the bed. Giving a high-pitched squeal of delight, Catra used an old MMA move on her and flipped them over. Their breathless laughs lit up the shadows as they tussled for a few moments, just how they used to as kids.

They lay side by side on Adora's small camp bed, staring at the cracked ceiling of the barracks.

"So, did you get that notice?"

Adora tilted her head. "Hm?"

"The notice about the new project – the Heart of Etheria or whatever?" Catra said it so causally that Adora had to bite her tongue to stop a reaction. "They obviously didn't think about the acronym. Who's supposed to take a project with the initials HOE seriously?"

“Oh.” Adora didn’t know what to do. She kept herself rigid as they flight or fight responses kicked in. “Yeah.”

A pause.

“Makes you think though, doesn’t it?”

“What?”

Catra’s tone was unusually pensive. “Well, they called it a *suicide* mission. It’s the first time we’ve ever been actively, you know, encouraged to give our lives for their… cause.” Another pause. “I wonder what idiots will put themselves forward for it.”

They had both lost people – colleagues, teammates – in missions. That was expected. But Catra was right; this was the first time they had been warned that a mission was high-profile enough to warrant a voluntary death notice.

And once again, Adora didn’t know what to do about Catra.

Was *now* the right time to tell her?

It felt wrong. She didn’t know why.

On the other hand, when was the right time to tell your best friend that this was it? That this was… happening. Actually happening.

Adora’s resolve felt its first crack.

“I have,” she blurted, like it was forced from her.

There was a moment of silence in which Adora thought Catra hadn’t heard her.

Then Catra clicked the light on Adora’s bedside table.

Squinting, Adora sat up to look at her as her eyes adjusted to the change of tone. Catra’s eyes pierced through her, cutting her to shreds. “What?” she hissed.

Adora wet her lips. “I’m part of the Heart of Etheria project.”

Catra leapt from the bed. “Adora – wait, what?! Since when?” She wiped a hand across her face. “Is that what you were talking to Captain Creep about?”

Adora nodded.

“When were you planning on telling me, exactly?” Catra yelled. It was loud enough for carry through the thin walls of Adora’s quarters. “When they sent your dead body back for burial?”

“Now,” Adora amended. “I was going to tell you tonight.” And while that wasn’t strictly true, Adora couldn’t have told her before tonight. She wasn’t allowed to speak about her involvement in the project until it was made available to the other members of their team. Even then, there were things she could never tell her, things she had sworn never to tell. It was clear, though, at how the brunette seethed, at how her face flooded with hurt, that she didn’t buy it either. Adora pleaded, “Catra, I – it was never meant to be a secret between us. I couldn’t talk about it until… now.”

It was true. All those lonely days where Adora felt like the worst person in the world for keeping such a large secret to herself – she wanted nothing more than to tell her best friend. She wanted nothing more than to hear Catra’s thoughts, to have her guidance. Out of the two of them, Catra was always the sensible one who could see the truth and lies.

She would never have allowed you to get into this mess.

Catra’s hands covered her face. When she peeled them away, her lips were twisted into a broke scowl. “I thought you were my best friend.”

Adora felt her chest cleave in two. “Has that changed in the last five minutes?”

She gave a bitter cackle, viscous in its intensity. “It’s hard to see how you feel the same way when you didn’t tell me you were

planning to sacrifice your life for the army."

"It's for the *war*, Catra," Adora retorted, annoyed that she had to emphasise it in the first place. "It's to stop the war, so no one else has to go through this. So people can stop dying. Like Mara. Like all those civilians." She shook her head. "This is bigger than me."

Catra flinched, as if Adora had made a personal attack. She slammed her palm against her chest. "And you didn't – it didn't *once* cross your mind to ask *me* first?"

Adora looked around, hoping to find an answer. She didn't understand. "Do I have to ask your permission?"

Catra snorted. "When you're making stupid fucking mistakes like this then maybe you should!" she shouted.

"Catra, don't," Adora warned. This wasn't what she wanted; she never wanted it to create another rift between them. Adora, herself, had little control over the situation. How could she make her see without telling her the truth? "This wasn't about you. This was about – other things."

Catra studied her for a moment. She looked ready to explode. "More important things, obviously."

"I said don't," Adora snapped.

She was already so close to losing it. Right now, she wanted Catra to tell her that she understood, that she was doing the right thing. That everything was going to be okay with her gone, that she would be happy. That it was worthwhile. That Adora couldn't give it all up for something more worthwhile.

"Or what? It's true," Catra retorted. "I can't believe you'd do this. I can't believe you'd throw your life away." She raised her hands, as if shouting at more than her best friend. As if she were shouting at the world. "I can't believe you're going to risk everything for strangers when I –"

The words stopped short, and Catra turned to the side, angrily wiping at her face.

"You don't think I'm doing this for you too?" Adora asked softly. "So you'll get a chance to live in the real world, away from the army?"

Catra spun around, as vibrant as before. "If you really wanted to do something for me, you would've told me about it in the first place."

"You know what? Maybe." Adora stood up too as her tone began to rise. "Maybe that's what I should have done, but it's too late now. In a few weeks' time, I'll be in the Horde's Arms Factory doing my part to end this war. I probably won't survive. This is my decision and no matter what you say, or what you do, it's not going to change *this*." She was towering of Catra now, glaring down at her. "If you don't like it, I'm sorry. But it needs to be done, and I happen to be the one to do it."

Catra met her blue stare and the ferocity of her gaze burnt through her. It looked as if there were a million things she wanted to say, each one worse than the last. Suddenly, she backed away and walked towards the door, hissing, "Whatever."

Adora faltered. She reached out. "Catra, please. I don't want to –"

"As you just said," Catra muttered without looking back. "It doesn't matter what you want."

The door slammed behind her, leaving Adora broken in the half-light.

Present day

It was lunch time, and Catra had ventured into the staffroom. She sat in the corner by herself, picking through a salad Scorpia had left her in the fridge. Her flatmate was trying a new plant-based diet which was apparently excellent for weight-lifting. Catra,

herself, couldn't, and didn't want to, distinguish between the different leaves in front of her, and had little appetite to try them. Instead, she resolved to find every little bit of tofu and stab it with her fork. She was hungry, but at least she was somewhat entertained.

"Hey. Fancy seeing you here."

Inside, Catra's heart fluttered at seeing Adora settle in the seat opposite her. On the outside, she scowled. "It's not like I work here or anything."

Adora ignored her and put a handful of nuts in her mouth, chewing loudly. "I still find it weird that you do work here, to be honest. I thought you were living in the Forestfall Zone."

That was interesting. Adora had known where she used to live. "I was," she admitted, stabbing another piece of tofu. "It's nicknamed the Fright Zone for a reason. The percentage of burglaries in my area was higher than my final grades in teaching."

"And you obviously passed teaching."

"Exactly." Catra paused, idly watching Adora fish out more almonds. A thought occurred to her, one she had been musing over for the last few nights. Now was the perfect opportunity to ask if she wanted. She put down her fork and fidgeted with herself. "So, uh – I'm not sure if you remember or not, but my birthday is coming up."

Adora smiled; it lit up her face and made her blue eyes shine. "You hate your birthday." She gulped down the last of the almonds and added, almost as if offended, "And of course I remember."

For some reason, this didn't make Catra any less nervous about broaching the topic. She opted for light humour to cover it up. "Yeah, well, the closer I get to thirty, the more I feel like celebrating the remaining years of my youth."

Adora replied, far too seriously, “I don’t know about you, but I’ve mentally stalled at twenty-two.”

“Come on, Adora,” she teased. “You’re being generous. You still act like a teenager.”

“Alright. Just because you’ve always been mentally eighty-three.”

“Why eighty-three? That’s a very specific number.”

“I’ve had a lot of time to think it over.” Adora’s eyes narrowed, still glittering with laughter. “But you’re stalling and you don’t usually stall.”

“Right. Yeah. Birthday.” Catra sighed. *God, she sounded so pathetic*. “I’m having a small get together and I was wondering if you, you know, want to come or whatever.” In response to Adora’s impossibly wide stare, she added, “You can bring your stupid friends.”

Just please don’t reject this offer.

After the initial moment of confusion was over, Adora looked hopelessly smug as she asked, “My stupid friends that happen to be teachers at this school?”

Catra rolled her eyes. “Even the short glittery one.”

“I have to warn you, once I tell Glimmer and Bow everyone else will invite themselves.” In a lower tone, she added, “People here can sniff out a party within a fifty-mile radius.”

This was not what Catra had expected. She just wanted to extend an olive branch; show that she meant it when she said she wanted to spend more time with Adora. In all honesty, Catra had nothing planned for her birthday. This was just an excuse to spend time together. “Ugh, okay. Whatever.” She thought for a quick cover up. “It’s just at a bar anyway, I can’t stop them from being there.”

“Where is it?” Adora asked.

Catra said the first one that popped in her head. “The Crooked Rainbow.”

Raising an eyebrow, Adora hummed. “The gay bar?”

Catra shrugged again, squinting across the table, not holding back her judgemental stare. “Will your friends be weird about that?”

“As if,” Adora laughed. “Bow and Glimmer are bi. Glimmer had quite a few conquests from the Crooked Rainbow before she realised her undying love for Bow.”

“Never say ‘conquest’ again,” Catra winced. “Honestly, sometimes you act like a straight dude bro and it makes me sick.”

Adora looked equally as horrified. “That’s the worst thing you’ve ever said to me.”

“You’ll recover.”

Adora seemed unsure. “Who else are you inviting?”

“Some friends that you don’t know.” Catra purposefully looked away. Her friend group was small. Very small, and she felt embarrassed about that. When she noticed Adora looking intrigued, she sighed. “To be honest, it’ll probably just be Scorpia.”

Adora’s bottom lip jutted out. She fiddled with the hem of her shirt. “Oh.”

Oh yeah. She still thinks –

“Hey, Adora, about Scorpia. We aren’t –“

Lo and behold, in the perfect example of bad timing, the sparkly pink friend and the abs of steel boy plopped themselves on each arm of Adora’s armchair. Sparkles asked in a sing-song voice, “What are the cool kids gossiping about?”

“Catra’s birthday.” Adora smirked. “You’re invited.”

Boq squeaked. Actually *squeaked*. “As in, all of us? A staff celebration?” He almost shouted, “A whole hootenanny?”

All three women stared at him.

Sparkles groaned. “Can I fire you for that?”

Bow’s smile didn’t falter. “Only if you rehire me straight afterwards.”

“Okay, you’re fired.”

“Boo you.”

“And you’re hired again.” Glimmer leaned over to squeeze his arm. “We need those biceps.”

As Adora laughed, looking down at her own arms much to Catra’s amusement, Bow did a fake gasp. “Are you sexualising me in the workplace?”

“Maybe.” Glimmer shrugged and squeezed herself in the chair beside Adora. “Since you’ve been here, the computer science department has had a lot of interest, especially among the girls.”

“I would complain about that, but I like doing my part for bridging the gender gap.”

Glimmer patted his leg. “That’s my boy.”

Unsure if she was disturbed by their interaction, or secretly impressed at their oddity, Catra asked Adora, “Are they always like this?”

Adora grimaced. “Non-stop.”

Catra had a feeling she’d made a grave mistake suggesting birthday celebrations in the first place. Very seriously she amended, directing it to Glimmer, “Well, you can tell everyone

they can come if they want. But it's still going to be lowkey, okay?"

Glimmer struggled with herself before saying, "I respect that."

"We'll see," Adora muttered, matching the glint in Glimmer's eye.

Twenty-one years old

Three weeks before the Heart of Etheria Project

Adora was alone in the meeting room.

Colonel Hope had asked her to report to meeting room 22C along with the rest of the Heart of Etheria volunteers for a briefing.

And she was scared.

How could she look these people in the eye, people who were sacrificing themselves alongside her for She-Ra and the failsafe?

Adora stood by the window overlooking the courtyard. A few cadets were playfighting; their loose fists flying at one another, narrowly missing secure hits. Adora's stomach churned.

What if she failed?

What if Adora failed, and one day in the future one of those cadets would be where she is now, sacrificing themselves to fix her mistake?

She pressed the palm of her hand into her eye. *Stop thinking about it. Stop thinking. Stop. Stop. Stop.*

There was a knock on the door and a creak as it opened.

Adora turned around to see –

"Catra?" she squeaked. "What are you doing here?"

Catra looked around the room. She was in her casual uniform, but a lock of hair was loose behind her ear. "This is the briefing for the Heart of Etheria project, isn't it?" she asked carefully.

Adora's world split in two.

It felt like Catra had ripped her heart out of her chest and stomped it into the floorboards.

No, this couldn't be happening. Catra couldn't – she *wouldn't* –

Not Catra.

"Tell me you didn't," Adora pleaded in a broken whisper.

Catra stopped a few feet away. Her hands were clasped behind her back and her posture was rigid; her face unreadable. "I did," she said. "I volunteered."

Adora shook her head. "Catra, no. You can't."

Please don't do this. I didn't want this.

"You keep saying that and yet here we are," Catra snapped as she turned away.

Adora leapt forward, reaching out and grabbing her arm. Her hand held onto the other girl's wrist. "Please. Don't. Reverse it. Drop out. *Please*."

Catra looked down at their joined hands. When she met Adora's blue stare, her own gaze was distant. "How does it feel, hm? Being left out of important decisions?"

But the hit didn't land. Adora would take anything over this; she deserved all of Catra's rage, all of her disdain. She wanted it to pour down on her until she bled. If Catra was angry, she should've lashed out like she used to; all sharp words and hard punches. Something physical, something that would heal with time. Not like this - not with a decision neither of them could take back.

“Catra,” she muttered, somewhere between a warning and a surrender.

Something flickered in Catra’s expression. She removed Adora’s clutch on her wrist and held the blonde's hand, fingers interlaced instead. “Hey, someone has to keep you from doing something stupid. I like our chances better when we’re, you know. Together.” She paused. Her voice cracked. “You could’ve asked me. If you had told me that this is what you wanted to do, that this is how you want to –" she struggled to find the right word. " - help. I would’ve either talked you out of it or offered to go with you.”

Adora felt sick at the thought. “I would never –”

“I know.” Catra winced, and her nose scrunched up, giving away her irritation. “But it would’ve been better. Than this.”

Not only had Adora unwillingly dragged a team into this mission – *her* mission – but she’d dragged down the one person she would’ve done anything to protect.

Catra didn’t belong here, Catra deserved to live.

She deserved a future.

One of them, at least, deserved that.

But Adora had ruined that too.

Adora always dragged Catra into trouble.

This was one step too far.

No.

Not anymore.

Catra might have done this – she may have signed up to this mission to help Adora, but Adora was not going to allow this mission to hurt Catra.

She would do everything and anything in her power to ensure Catra made it out alive.

This was her new mission.

Catra would live. No matter what else happened.

“What’s going on underneath that hair poof?” Catra murmured, squeezing her hand.

Adora took a moment to recollect herself. She inhaled, exhaled. Felt resolve strengthen her nerve. And then said, “I’m annoyed. I’m upset." She held on with everything she had left. "I didn’t want you to get caught up in all this. I wanted you to live.”

Catra scoffed, but it was stiffer than her usual mirthless teasing. “Well, I guess we’ll have to do everything we can to survive this thing." Her bottom lip wobbled for a few seconds. "But, Adora, if we do survive, promise me something.”

Adora blinked. *Anything*. “What?”

Catra’s eyes were full of cold fire. “Never do this to me again. No secrets, okay?” She paused. “I need *something* to believe in.”

Adora glanced down to their hands. There were so many things she wanted to say, and she had no idea how to express them. For a start, Catra still had hope that they would survive, that there was a possibility they would both make it to the other side of this mission. She believed that this was just another challenge for the ragtag team of misfits to overcome and, once the hurdle was done, there would be a learning curve; Adora would be more transparent. Adora wouldn't hurt Catra again by keeping her shut out of important decisions.

Some of that was true. Adora wouldn't hurt Catra again. Adora wouldn't have any secrets left to keep.

Adora didn't have a future to give to her.

“Okay,” she lied. “I promise.”

Chapter End Notes

Once again, themes in this chapter were inspired by Noelle's commentary, in particular when she discussed Adora's martyrdom in terms of self-identity. The whole thing about Wicked in this chapter (and in a fluffy future scene) was inspired by Noelle's drawing of Elphie and Glinda. Stay tuned for intolerable fluff.

Next time we see the Heart of Etheria mission from Adora's POV, and Catra faces the trials and tribulations of getting older. (Did someone say drunk Adora?)

Feedback hold me together and I appreciate every single one of you!

Stay safe.

Cx.

The Heart

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Twenty-one years old

The Heart of Etheria Project

Adora had no idea how they'd made it this far.

Just as how they were briefed, their team had split into smaller groups to target different areas of the Arms Factory. Essentially, the other groups were meant to clear the way for Catra and Adora to reach the transmitter.

Of course, when given the choice, Adora had chosen Catra to be her partner. In the eyes of Colonel Hope and Captain Lonsfield, Catra was the key to Adora's lock: the only person with a chance to survive, and only because she was supposed to bring back the failsafe of She-Ra.

But no, Adora had other plans. If she had her way, Catra wouldn't set a foot anywhere near the transmitter. She was going to keep Catra *safe*.

If the army wanted the failsafe back, they would have to search the rubble for it.

This was the end of Adora, but it wouldn't be the end of Catra.

Their teammates had cleared the auxiliary, the mainframe and the personal station unit. Judging by the radio silence, they had been successful.

They were also, presumably, dead.

Taking down the mainframe and exploded half of the building, and it was the half they still had to trek through to get to the transmitter. They encountered rogue Horde soldiers and bots, who had managed to escape the attack so far. While some of them surrendered, others were still willing to put up a fight.

You couldn't reason with bots.

A fizzling electric wire above their heads rained down sparks as Catra cleared another corner. Adora leapt across a chunk of wall, blind-sided by the sparks, and found herself face-to-face with a spider-like weaponry bot.

"Get down!" she screamed, lunging for cover.

The bot fired, missing Adora by inches. She rolled on her stomach, filling a nip in her side, and aimed a round of shots at its week spot: the eye.

Catra hurdled the wall and did the same, aiming for its circuit panel. The metal shielding of the bot groaned, and it capsized, bringing part of the ceiling with it. Adora covered her head as debris plummeted on top of them. The clouds of dust burnt her nose, clogged her throat, and made it hard to breathe. She blinked as it settled, and her stinging eyes ran with tears.

"Catra?" she called.

She took a second too long to reply, and Adora felt her world spin.

"I'm here, I'm okay!"

Heart racing like never before, Adora pulled herself up, wincing at the slight stretch in her side. She must've pulled a muscle on her way down.

But that wasn't the only thing that she noticed.

Catra.

Specifically, how she *felt* about Catra.

Adora had friends, and she would do anything for them. She would take away all their pain and put it onto herself if she could.

And yet, it didn't feel like this.

Up until now, Adora had never realised that her centre of gravity, the person keeping her rooted and focused on her hopes, her dreams, and her future, was Catra. This was what she was fighting for, wasn't it? She wanted to do the right thing. She didn't want anyone else to suffer. She wanted their country to heal, for civilians to be free and safe, away from the clutches of the Horde.

But she also wanted Catra – she wanted Catra to be safe. Catra to be free. Catra to be away from the clutches of the Horde.

She wanted them equally as bad as each other.

"Hey – Adora." Catra gracefully climbed through the debris towards her, and all Adora could do was stare. Catra's helmet was cracked at the back, and her face was dusty, with a shallow cut at the base of her neck. Her mismatched eyes were bright, focused. She looked Adora up and down. "Adora, you – *shit*."

Adora's heart was melting. She watched Catra as if she was seeing her for the first time.

Catra was the one thing she cared about losing when she knew her world was going to end. She had felt it for so long, and it had been such a constant in her life, that she'd never understood it before.

She was *in love* with Catra.

Adora smiled despite feeling hot and sticky – no, that wasn't right. Adora's *hand* was hot and sticky. She looked down, curiously, just as Catra said;

“Fuck. You’ve been shot.” The brunette grabbed at her arms, pulling her down to the ground. “Adora? Are you okay?”

The blood soaking Adora’s hand didn’t feel like her own. She was having a weird disconnect from it, and even as she inspected the source of the bleeding, her mind felt fuzzy and she refused to believe that this was her body, her blood. She felt like an onlooker at her own funeral.

“Yeah, I’m – it’s fine,” she said. “I can barely feel it.”

It wasn’t until she tried to stand again that she realised that wasn’t true. Pain started to roll from her side in waves. She did her best to hide a grimace, but Catra’s eyes were piercing into her, carefully watching her every reaction.

“We need to” – Adora tried to pull herself up by holding down the wound – “get the failsafe to the transmitter.”

“There’s no ‘we’ about it,” Catra snapped. “You’ve been shot. You can barely walk.”

Adora didn’t have the strength, or the time, to argue. She met the brunette’s stubborn gaze. “Catra, I need to do this.”

I need to save you. I need to save everyone.

“And I said no," Catra argued. She grabbed Adora's wrists and held them tight. "We’ll put you somewhere safe – you can give it to me, and I’ll do it.”

That was the problem, wasn’t it? There were still secrets between them.

“I can’t give it to you." Adora shook her head. Catra would keep pushing it, and she needed a way out. "We don’t know what will happen when it activates,” she partly lied.

Catra groaned in irritation. “You and your heroics – listen, we don't have time, either I go, or we go together.”

We go together.

For the first time in her life, that was the last thing Adora wanted. Catra needed to stay as far away from the danger zone as possible.

Adora needed to do this next part alone.

An idea trickled its way to the front of her mind and she hated it. She hated the fact that she'd even thought of it in the first place.

Catra would live, but she would never forgive her for this.

Any memory she had of her would forever be tarnished.

"I'm sorry," Adora croaked, to Catra and herself.

But there was one last thing Adora wanted – one thing she had held herself back from doing since the first time she had done it.

Adora pulled Catra by the collar and pressed her lips against her open mouth. Catra's lips were soft, and she felt a tingle against her skin from where they touched. She moved closer, hanging onto Catra, pretending that this wasn't the last time, the last chance, she had to do this.

If she had to go, she wanted one last thing to hold onto.

But it was time to go.

When Catra kissed her back with feverish intent, Adora reached behind them. Her hand found a hard piece of debris and she wrapped her fingers around it.

Adora brokenly whispered, "*I'm so, so sorry*."

And then she hit Catra across the temple with it, hard enough to knock her out.

Present day

It had been quite a few years since Catra had celebrated her birthday. It was the one day of the year she always dreaded – not because she feared getting older; hell, she'd struggled to make it alive *this* long. No, it was because she hated the fuss and the attention. Since she was a teenager, Catra had an intolerance for those who had weeklong birthday celebrations and made cynical judgements about them, reserving them a place on her list of People I Will Never Like. On the other hand, however, Catra had also hated her birthdays in recent years, which she'd spent alone drinking in her bedroom, pretending not to exist. It was depressing feeling like the only person in the world who cared about not caring about it.

It was complicated.

So, when Catra asked Scorpia if she wanted to go out for a few drinks at the weekend in the Crooked Rainbow Bar, Scorpia immediately looked like she was going to burst into tears when she asked, "For your birthday?"

"Yes," Catra admitted reluctantly.

Scorpia's tone rose in pitch with every word. "Birthday drinks for your birthday? Catra wants to celebrate her birthday by having birthday drinks on her birthday? To celebrate? Her birthday?"

"Hey, ease up on the whole *celebration* thing." Catra folded her arms. "I just want to spend a few hours in a dingy, sticky bar with you and some weirdos from work. Alright? No big deal." She pointed at her flatmate. "And if you make it a big deal, I'm going to back out."

Scorpia placed a hand over her heart. "Oh no – I promise. You won't get any fuss from me." She paused, and then asked quickly, "Does this mean I can buy you a birthday present?"

Catra yelled a firm 'no' as she escaped into the sanctuary of her bedroom.

Come Saturday night, Catra felt dread creeping in as she got dressed. It had been a while since she'd went out to a bar on a weekend. She cringed every time she thought about the partying streak she went through post-army.

Those were dark times.

Catra's wardrobe consisted of two looks: grungy casual or relaxed suits. She preferred dark colours and tight-fitted clothes, and she absolutely could not tolerate dresses or skirts or pastels in any shape or form.

She had worn a dress one time in her life, and she'd never felt so uncomfortable in her own skin. It made her chest look shapeless and her legs bandy and thin; not to mention, it just felt wrong, like suddenly she was hyper-aware of her own body. Catra happened to like her body; she liked how her chest looked in shirts, and she like the curve of her hips in tight trousers. Knowing that her work colleagues (and everyone else in the Crooked Rainbow) would probably wear bright colours with sparkly bits, Catra decided on wearing dark red ripped leather trousers, and a cropped black off-the-shoulder top. She added winged eyeliner and a ponytail and felt *very* happy when checking herself out in the mirror.

Scorpia and Catra arrived half an hour late on purpose. The Crooked Rainbow was loud – she had forgotten just how hard it was to hear people over the booming bass. As they weaved their way through people, searching for familiar faces, Catra felt a little anxious at the sights, sounds and smells.

Mainly, flashing strobe lights and stale beer.

"There she is!" came a squealing shout from the corner. "The birthday girl!"

Catra already wanted to leave.

Glimmer beckoned them over, dressed in a purple dress and already looking a little tipsy. For a moment, Catra wondered what

would happen if they spotted an older student. Just behind Glimmer, the principal, was Bow, her boyfriend and computer science teacher, wearing a crop top and glitter on his cheeks.

How did Adora fit in with these people?

A chorus of 'happy birthday' greeted her as she approached their table, and Catra reluctantly nodded at each of them; she could see Mermista drinking a pint beside the smoking area, Spinerella and Netossa ordering cocktails, and Entrapta, the head of Engineering, sipping on a juice and staring into space.

"This is Scorpia," Catra told them. "My friend."

The two of them sat facing Bow and Glimmer. When Perfuma, the councillor, arrived a few minutes later with a round of drinks for the table, Catra noticed Scorpia's pupils dilate. Her mouth opened and blabbered like a fish. Catra held in a chuckle.

"Try not to drool, will you?" she teased.

Scorpia promptly shook herself out of it. "Oh, gosh – you're so pretty. I mean – who – what – I, uh –"

"I'm Perfuma," she said, squeezing her way in between them. "Nice to meet you."

Blanking out the rest of *that* interaction, Catra felt her skin prickle with disappointment. She accepted a rum and coke from Perfuma with a small word of thanks and took to stirring the ice, trying to crush it with her straw.

"Hey," Glimmer said, nudging her. "Adora's in the bathroom, she'll be out in a sec."

Catra immediately perked up. "Oh?"

"She came, don't worry," Bow supplied with a helpful smile.

Catra's cheeks reddened, and to avoid their scrutiny, she took a long sip.

"So," Glimmer said, and there was a dangerous glint in her eye. "Are we hitting the club afterwards?"

On a Friday and Saturday, the upper levels of the Crooked Rainbow transformed into a nightclub. Friday night was a celebration of rock, while Saturday was a rave. Catra, doing her best not to be rude, pretended to mull over the question as if she had genuine interest in saying yes.

"Aren't you worried about – you know." Catra gestured around them. "Bumping into a student in here?"

"Oh, we bump into students all the time," Bow brushed off, as if it were normal.

Catra raised a questioning eyebrow.

"Trust me, they're more embarrassed to see us than we are to see them," Glimmer added. "Besides, this isn't the coolest place in town. Most of them prefer The Spotlight, down near the coast."

"Glimmer's mum is on the Board," Bow said. He took a drink of his pink gin and elderflower tonic. "She trusts us."

"Oh, hey Catra."

Adora.

Catra looked around, following the voice, and almost did a double take.

Adora had always been pretty, and Catra had always found her attractive.

But not like this.

Once again, Adora was in a dress, and this time, she allowed herself to properly look.

It was red and strapless, and after her initial stare, Catra was certain it was going to be etched onto the back of her eyelids. Adora's hair was down, flowing freely around her shoulders, and she wore red lipstick and winged eyeliner. The scar on her face was still visible, but didn't draw the eye like it usually did.

She was glowing.

And it made Catra feel very warm.

"Hey Adora," she said, flashing a wicked grin.

Adora glanced her up and down, looked away, and looked back, fumbling over her words. "You look – uh, hah, great. Really great."

Try as she might, Catra couldn't tear her eyes away. "So do you."

"Adora!" Scorpia belted, making them both jump. She stood up to clap the blonde on the back. "It's good to see you!"

"Hi Scorpia," Adora said, bracing herself against the friendly claps. "Nice seeing you again."

"Well, this is weird, huh?" she went on. "I haven't seen you in, what – five or six years?"

Catra was starting to pick up on Adora's new anxious ticks. This time, she clenched her right hand into a fist, as if trying to hold onto something. "Yeah, it must be," she said without enthusiasm.

Everything was quiet for a moment. Scorpia looked between Catra and Adora with a hint of wonder, as if trying to work something out. Perfuma, probably sensing the rising tension, distracted Scorpia again by asking about her time in the army. Meanwhile, Glimmer and Bow looked on, as if watching an exhibit at a zoo.

Catra and Adora stared at each other.

“So, twenty-seven,” Adora said, giving her a small nudge. “How does it feel being so old?”

Catra rolled her eyes. “Your birthday is in less than three months, dummy. It’s creeping up on you too.”

Adora didn’t say anything. Instead, she took a long drink of a cocktail Perfuma had passed to her, and silently looked across at the school councillor talking animatedly to Scorpia.

Catra shuffled in her chair.

“Adora got you a present,” Bow interrupted, and for some unknown reason, his eyes were watering.

“Oh, it’s nothing,” Adora placated. “It’s tacky and cheap.”

“We call that *sentimental*,” Glimmer said sarcastically.

Catra glared at the blonde. “You know I hate presents.”

“And you know I love annoying you,” she retorted, shooting her an uncharacteristic wink.

Catra recovered her blush by downing her rum and coke.

“Hey.”

The table looked around to see Mermista, wearing a curvy blue dress, and holding a tray of flaming shots in one hand. She elbowed Bow and Adora out of the way to place them on the table.

“I know we don’t really know each other,” Mermista drawled to Catra. “And this could totally be awkward and everything, but you know what makes every social situation better? Shots.” She did a dull flourish with her hands. “Happy birthday, I guess.”

Huh. Catra didn’t know what to say. Mermista gave her exactly five seconds to reply. Before Catra had the right words, Mermista

lifted a shot glass from the tray and knocked it back in one.

“Drink up, bitches.”

Catra let out an involuntary laugh.

Twenty-one years old

The Heart of Etheria project

Adora watched Catra slump to the side, wincing as a trickle of blood ran from her temple. She looked around at the debris and dust, and never in her life had she felt as lonely.

Just beyond their nook was a broken wall leading to the outside. If they were where she thought they were, this side of the building had a courtyard. Adora could safely roll Catra over the wall and send up a flare, localising her position.

Captain Lonsfield was expecting Adora to give the flare to Catra before she activated She-Ra, so the back-up team could safely locate them if something went wrong. No one knew, after all, how the new failsafe would react. It could blow a crater in the ground.

Adora pulled herself to her feet, glad of the pain. Her entire left side was hot and sticky with blood. If she didn’t act quickly, blood loss would claim her before her mission was complete.

Her vision wavered in an out of focus as she carried her best friend across the room. If Catra had a weight, Adora didn’t feel her. The guilt was too busy dragging her down, practically becoming unbearable. Heaving Catra over the wall, she stared at her slack face, pressing a soft kiss to her forehead.

“I hope you can forgive me, one day,” she murmured. “I love you. I think I always have.”

Adora dropped Catra over the wall as safely as she could and shot the flare into the sky.

Catra is safe.

She'll be okay.

You have a job to do.

Present day

After a full two hours of drinking and conversations, Catra realised Adora was drunken and disorderly when she came back from the bathroom and almost barrelled into her.

"Catra!" she huffed, thumping her on the arm. "Catra! Catra!"

The birthday girl swayed with each hit. She fumbled with Adora's hands, holding them still, and trying to focus herself. As it was, Catra was also feeling the buzz of alcohol to her brain. "Woah, stop. What's wrong?"

Adora looked flustered. "It's Scorpia – I saw Scorpia."

Catra hesitated. "Okay, and?"

"And Perfuma." She pointed to the enclosed garden attached to the back of the bar. "I saw them!"

"I don't understand, what did you see?"

Adora shouted, absolutely scandalised, "They're kissing!"

Catra thought about it for a few moments. Sure, Scorpia and Perfuma had hit it off when they were introduced a couple of hours ago but wow, she'd never seen Scorpia move that quickly. She was quite impressed.

Adora, on the other hand, continued to act like it the worst news in the world. "I'm so sorry. I'm so sorry to tell you, Cat. Do you want me to go beat her up? I'll beat her up for you, promise."

As she made to move, Catra stopped her. "Why would I –?" Then it hit her: Adora still thought they were together. Oh. Huh. This was going to be awkward.

"How could she do that to you?" Adora went on. She sighed and pushed the hair out of her eyes. "I would never do that if you were my girlfriend. If you were my girlfriend, I'd – I would –"

Adora hiccupped, but now Catra was preoccupied. "You'd what, Adora?"

It came out much lower and much silkier than she intended.

Adora's cheeks tinted with a soft pink blush. "I'd not do *that*. I'd treat you right."

And oh boy, the rum was *really* working on Catra now. She subconsciously licked her lips and took a tiny step towards the blonde. Tilting her chin up, so that their faces were angled towards one another, Catra hummed, "Mhm?"

Her heart thudded against her chest and she felt so incredibly *warm*.

Adora's eyes darted down to Catra's lips and back up to her eyes. "You'd be my world," she murmured.

Catra's breath caught in her throat. How many years had she dreamt of hearing those words out of Adora's mouth? She allowed herself to believe them, for a moment, so she could sample how the fantasy tasted. This girl had caused her so much pain. There was enough history between them to fill an archive, and not all of it was good. Up until quite recently – too recently – Catra had still been stuck in the *not good* section.

Unwillingly, the image of Adora's dust-stained face during battle at the Heart of Etheria project flashed in her mind. Catra swallowed and took a step back, crashing landing into reality again.

"I've been meaning to tell you," she said, feeling slightly more sober than before. "But Scorpia and I aren't together. We never have been. So, yeah." She shrugged. "I'm happy she's having *whatever* with Perfuma tonight."

Adora stared, open-mouthed, as if none of this information made sense. "You're single?" she squeaked.

Just as she asked, Mermista appeared again and silently handed them a tequila shot each. A man with a moustache followed her, giving them a wedge of lime. Catra and Adora stared at one another, a shot in one hand and a lime in the other, perplexed at the interaction.

"Well, now that's off my chest," Catra said, tipping the shot glass and clinking it against Adora's. "Here's to being honest."

Adora, slow on the uptake, disregarded the lime and knocked back the shot, grimacing by sticking her tongue out. Lights and sounds were muddling together in a soft glow, which told Catra she was creeping into drunk territory. Instinctively, she grabbed Adora's hand and pulled them back to the table.

Glimmer and Bow were making out in the same chair, but they pulled apart when they spotted them approach. Glimmer's eyes were sparkling with mischief. "Is it time for the club yet?"

"You can go if you want," Catra offered, non-committedly. Adora was strangely quiet on her other side. When she looked around, Adora was gone. Catra almost slipped off her own chair. "What the – where did she go?"

"Uh oh," Bow drawled, patting Glimmer's arm. "Drunk Adora alert. We better go get her."

Catra was still confused. She took a moment to scan the crowd, searching for a pop of blonde hair. "Huh?" she said, leaning over the table. "I know Adora, she can hold her liquor. You don't need to worry."

In the army, Adora drank the bulkiest of the guys under the table. Rather than being drunk, per se, she was just an exaggerated version of herself. Catra had never known her to wander or be a hazard to herself.

The couple took a moment to reply, and Catra looked around curiously, half-expecting them to have disappeared too. Instead, she saw Glimmer with a hand propping up her chin, and her lips set in a firm line. "You know *an*Adora," she corrected.

Catra felt her heckles rise. "Excuse me?"

"You know a version of Adora," Glimmer went on. Beside her, Bow tensed. "You haven't known Adora over the last five years. A lot can happen in five years, and sometimes nothing happens at all. I suspect a lot has happened to the two of you. So, no." Glimmer sipped on her straw, and Catra had a sudden urge to swipe it from her. She continued, "You know the Adora you grew up with and you're applying the same to rules to Adora now."

Sober Catra probably would've, at the very least, got up and walked away before baiting the conversation, or saying something she might regret.

However, Sober Catra had left the conversation a while ago.

Glimmer's words were swirling around her brain, stinging and biting and attacking her from the inside out. As calmly as she could, Catra bit out, "Is that right?"

"I know about Adora's past; she told me all about it," Glimmer added. "And I've grown to know present Adora over the last five years. Who, as witnessed, *can't* hold her liquor, by the way."

But they both knew this was more than the topic of alcohol; Glimmer was pointing out that Catra had missed a chunk of Adora's life – an important part, and that had led to certain communication problems between them.

That was probably true, but Catra didn't care. She couldn't care less, to be honest. To her, right now, it felt like Glimmer was flaunting her privilege, marking Catra with a stamp that said 'old news'. Glimmer was Adora's new best friend.

Catra had to keep up with them.

It was petty and childish, and it yet it burned in Catra's bones like she was eighteen again and she'd just heard about Lonnie kissing Adora.

Bow was obviously sensing Catra's unease. He nudged his girlfriend, saying, "I don't –"

But Glimmer still kept talking. "It's the same with her," she said, as if this was her way of placating the conversation. "She doesn't know what you've been through over the last five years. I think that's why you keep… missing her."

Missing her.

Either Adora *hadn't* told Glimmer about their recent conversations, or she had, and she'd confessed something more, something secret, to Glimmer. Something Catra didn't know.

"I didn't ask for your advice, Sparkles, and I don't want it, either. Who do you think you are, my therapist?" Catra's throat was dry, and the latter half came out as a rasp. "I know Adora better than *anyone*. What we've been through – I can't –"

Catra's throat closed up completely, swallowing her words.

"I just don't want to see my best friend get hurt," Glimmer retorted.

Taking a deep breath, Catra stood up, almost knocking over her chair. Towering over the smaller girl, she asked, "Are you my boss right now?"

"Of course not, it's after working hours."

Grabbing her bag, Catra flung it over her shoulder and hissed, "Good, because fuck you."

And, unlike Glimmer, she didn't look for a reaction.

Twenty-one years old

The Heart of Etheria project

Adora didn't know how she made it, but she had finally reached the transmitter.

Dragging her left leg, she leaned against the workstation and took two grounding breaths.

This was it, exactly how she pictured it.

In theory, Adora's task was simple: she had to activate the transmitter and then hook herself up to the machine. She-Ra would activate and decimate the systems from the inside, and then the failsafe would ensure the job is complete; recording information as it worked. Once the communications were down, and the Horde's interface was scrambled, another team would find the failsafe – inside Adora – and use it to take down the Horde's weapons.

After that, the Horde was finished.

Etheria would win.

In reality, however, this was a job for two people – hence why Mara has asked Adora to assist her. Not to mention, Adora felt moments away from blacking out from blood loss. It was incredible that she'd made it here at all.

But for everything she'd sacrificed, for everything she had yet to save, the job needed done.

Adora used the controls as she did with Mara, working purely with her energy reserves. The transmitter – once again, a pale blue beam in the centre of the room – lit up a vibrant white as it hummed with electricity.

The heart scar of the failsafe on Adora's chest glowed pink through her uniform.

This was really it.

With a hand over her heart, Adora creeped towards the transmitter. The white light was so bright that it caused sunspots to dance in her vision. A trickling through her veins, as if someone was brushing against her with feathers, told her that the failsafe had activated automatically. It had prepared itself, even if Adora hadn't been able to do it.

Standing in front of her demise, Adora thought of Mara. Mara, who had done this with such strength and integrity, and who had tried warning Adora off from making the same sacrifice. Had Mara been told she would be a hero? Her grave was indistinguishable from all the other fallen soldiers – all the other people sacrificed in the name of the Etherian government.

Then she thought of Catra. Catra, who would survive. Who would live and love and go on, paving her own way and being who she was meant to be.

But nostalgia was no use to her now. In a few moments, Adora would be dead, leaving nothing but her body behind.

She could do this.

She could save everyone.

She wanted that more than anything.

With her mind strangely blank, Adora breathed out, and stepped into the middle of transmitter.

It took a second and then –

The room exploded in an eruption of colour. Pinks, blues, yellows – they all poured from the centre of Adora's chest, overwhelming the console of the transmitter. Metal creaked and groaned, throwing shards of glass and debris into the air.

And Adora, she strained against the pressure rising inside her, burning her from the inside. She was jelly, being tossed around, and as the pressure intensified, it started to hurt. She cried out, lost in the haze of colour, ears screeching a violent tune over the high-pitched squeal of the Horde systems failing.

The glass tube holding the transmitter upright *snapped* with a loud *crack*. Sharp pieces of glass ricocheted off her, and a particularly large fragment hit her in the face.

Adora fell.

Her knees bounced against the metal podium.

She was spent.

She-Ra was done. Curling in on herself on the floor, Adora blinked away tears as she watched the last spindles of colour pour out of her chest. She couldn't feel anything other than the sharp, bright pain radiating across her body. The world around her was nothing but a pinprick; there was nothing but pain and heat, and the hardness of the floor.

A dreaded thought whispered to her through the haze: *what if you've failed?*

And as darkness claimed her, Adora's last conscious thought was just that.

I think I failed.

Present day

Catra, in a stumbling blaze of fury, left the bar and lit a cigarette outside. She puffed on it twice before turning around, looking for somewhere to lean against. It had been raining; the walls were damp. The bouncer at the back entrance eyed her curiously. She turned on her heel to pace down the street –

And bumped into Adora.

Adora had little regard for the rain. Her hair was soaked, and she sat on the curb, staring out into the road.

Catra sighed.

Begrudgingly, she recognised Glimmer was right about one thing: this Adora *was* different. Catra wasn't used to seeing Adora vulnerable. She'd always been able to take care of herself. It was unsettling, the difference. It made Catra feel… protective.

She'd never been protective of anyone in her life. She'd never needed to be.

Catra patted her shoulder. "Hey, Adora."

It took a moment for the blonde to recognise her. Then, she gave a soft smile. "Catra. Sorry. I needed air."

"It's raining," Catra pointed out.

Adora struggled to stand. Taking another drag of cigarette, Catra put her hand out to steady her. Adora's nose wrinkled in distaste at the smell.

"You should go home," Catra said, refusing to let go. "I'm pretty sure the party's over."

"Home," Adora mumbled, looking down at her dress.

"You're not too far gone to not remember where you live, are you?"

Adora fumbled around in her bag. She pulled out her purse, a pair of glasses, lipstick, pens, a *pocketknife*, even tampons and a hairbrush, but still looked confused. As she put everything back, she winced and said, "I think I've lost my keys."

"You've lost your –" Catra didn't know whether to laugh or cry. She flicked her cigarette onto the pavement and stamped it with the heel of her boot. "Alright. Okay. You're coming home with me." When Adora opened her mouth to protest, Catra put her hand up. "No, dummy, I don't care what you have to say. You're drunk and I'm drunk, and I think it's safer if we both got out of here."

Adora deflated like a balloon. "Okay."

"Okay." Catra rolled her eyes and took out her phone to text a taxi. "How the hell did you function without me for five years?"

She said it lightly, but when she looked up, she spotted a sullen Adora, pouting as she stared into the distance. Catra let her mull it over, whatever it was causing the stress lines on her forehead, all the while hoping – really hoping – that Scorpia went home with Perfuma to avoid any awkward morning encounters.

"Wait, Catra." Adora put out her hand, grabbing Catra's wrist. Catra glanced up, watching Adora's blue eyes start to water. She held her breath as the blonde went on, "I need to tell you something. I feel so – *wrong*. Keeping it to myself. Like I'm being disingenuous."

"That's a long word for a drunk person," Catra teased. When Adora didn't crack a smile, she sighed and shook her head. "Don't. Not now. If it's that important, tell me when you're sober. Otherwise, knowing you, it's probably something really small and petty, and you're overthinking it as you typically do."

Adora's frown deepened, but this time Catra could tell it was from annoyance. "So, you don't want to hear how good your butt looks in those leathers?"

Catra gave a devilish smile. “Princess, I *know* how good I look in leather.”

As Adora blushed and tried to babble a comeback, Catra tilted her head back and laughed.

Sure, Glimmer had gotten under her skin, and she felt awkward being around such a large group, but all in all, as she watched Adora’s flushing face, she realised it wasn’t the *worst* birthday.

Chapter End Notes

These chapters just keep getting longer...

Next time: it's the aftermath and the morning after. Hopefully by now you can recognise how the past and present have parallel themes, and contain consequences for the future. I'm going to shut up now.

Thank you so much for reading. For anyone following the playlist, I've added a few more songs if you want to check them out. I'm going to (eventually) go back and add song recs for each chapter.

As always, dropping a comment or interacting in someway keeps me writing and always makes my day.

Stay safe.

Cx.

No More

Chapter Summary

Warning for people with Marie as their middle name.

That's also me, and I'm sorry.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Present day

The first thing Adora noticed was that she was lying on top of something that smelled like home.

Underneath the notes of sandalwood and smoke was the scent of another person. A familiar person. Slightly sweet, and more earthy than fragrant.

Catra, the voice in her head told her.

At that thought, Adora jumped up with a yelp, looking around the room, searching for a clue.

Where was she?

Rubbing at her eyes and cursing the black mascara flaking from her lashes, Adora grabbed her bag on the foot of the bed and felt around for her phone.

She had ten missed calls.

Over twenty messages.

This wasn’t going to be pretty. It started with:

Glimmer missed call 02:43

Bow missed call 03:01

And so they continued, right up until an hour ago. Adora scanned her messages.

Glimmer 09:22

If you don't call me in the next hour I'm phoning the police

And the most recent from Bow…

Bow 09:25

Adora pls, it's getting harder to control her

With a sigh, Adora typed a quick response.

I'm alive. Don't worry.

She'd barely had the chance to lock her phone before Glimmer replied.

Glimmer 10:07

Where are you?!

Adora 10:07

I maybe kinda don't know

Glimmer 10:08

What do you mean you don't know?!

Did you go home with somebody?

Are you safe?

Adora 10:08

I know I'm not in my own house

Glimmer 10:08

You can't remember, can you

Adora 10:09

Maybe

Maybe not

Glimmer 10:09

Leave right now and I'll pick you up

Adora 10:09

I don't know where I am!

Glimmer 10:10

I'LL FIND YOU

"Well, you don't wake up looking like a princess, that's for sure."

Adora flinched and dropped her phone. Catra stood at the threshold with two bottles of water. She was in a vest top and a pair of pyjama bottoms. Her hair was wet.

It was *very* distracting.

"Catra?" Adora croaked, wincing at her dry throat.

Catra threw her a bottle. She caught it with a nod of thanks.

"I figured you weren't going to remember." Catra chuckled. "I saved your ass." She sat on the edge of the bed with a twinkle in

her eyes. “You were drunk, and I was trying to get you home. But, the idiot that you are, lost your keys.”

Adora’s cheeks blazed. Not because of what Catra said, no. But because Adora had seen her keys stored in the zip compartment of her bag when she was searching for her phone.

Drunk Adora, the traitor, had obviously lied so she could go home with Catra.

Who, had completely misinterpreted her blushing. “I’m sure you’ll find another way to thank me,” she teased.

Adora avoided all eye contact as if her life depended on it. To distract herself, she cracked open the bottle and took a long gulp of water. When she was finished, she muttered, “I can’t remember anything. Sorry.”

Catra sat next to her on the bed. “Does that happen a lot now?” she heard her ask. “When you drink.”

“Uh, yeah. Sometimes.” Adora scratched the back of her neck. “Sometimes my anxiety meds can make me extra fuzzy.”

“Oh, yeah. Of course.” Catra cleared her throat. “Well, you didn’t miss much.”

Adora looked up at that, her eyebrows pulled together. Catra was sitting with her legs crossed with her thick brown hair over one shoulder. It dripped down her tan skin and stained the edge of her tank top. Scared that she’d been staring too long, Adora met Catra’s shining eyes and asked, “Did you have a good night?”

There was a twist to Catra’s smile. “Kind of.”

“That’s not reassuring.”

“I told Sparkles to fuck off.”

“You what?!” Adora almost fell off the bed altogether.

Catra shrugged. “I still stand by it.”

“She’s your boss!” Adora spluttered.

“Not last night, she wasn’t.” Catra narrowed her eyes. “Aren’t you at least going to ask why?”

As long as she’d known her, Catra had always been anti-authority. She thought, perhaps, that her best friend might have outgrown it during the course of adulthood. “Go on, then,” she said. “Why did you tell Glimmer to fuck off?”

A shadow flickered over Catra’s features. Her nose wrinkled, as if she was sensing something distasteful. “She was right about something and I was annoyed. She was drunk too, though, so hopefully she doesn’t remember.”

It was Adora’s turn to smirk. “Glimmer remembers everything when she’s drunk.”

“Fucking fantastic.” Catra groaned, but it trailed off into a small laugh. She looked from the blonde’s hands and back up to her face. “You don’t remember anything?”

Adora’s heart dropped. “No, why? Did I say something?”

“You said you wanted to tell me something. It doesn’t matter. I just woke up curious.”

Oh no. Drunk Adora wasn’t going to tell her about the army thing, was she? Was she?! Taking another few gulps of water, Adora was certain she felt her cheek blaze again. When she had recovered somewhat, she said, “Oh. I was probably just blabbering.”

Catra hummed with a frown. Putting her own water bottle on the bedside table, she stretched as she stood up again, wandering towards the door. “Do you want anything? Breakfast?”

Feeling awkward, Adora, ideally, wanted to take up as little of Catra’s time as possible. She’d already inconvenienced her last

night. The polite thing to do would be to leave now and consider it all a cringey mishap.

Instead, however, Adora heard herself say, "Um, sure. If you don't mind."

Catra laughed. "I don't mind, dummy. Come on."

Oh. That sounded so – genuine? Adora hesitated, looking down at the stained red dress she was still wearing from last night. Her hair felt a bit messy and had a slight natural wave which told her that at some point, her hair had gotten wet. Catra noticed her hesitation.

She mouthed the words before saying them. "Do you want to – I mean, do you need to borrow some clothes?"

Adora, for some reason, felt like this was a trick question. "Uh – I, well I – um."

There were a few seconds of awkward silence, and then Catra turned to one of her drawers. "Wonderful input, thanks Adora. Here."

She threw her a hoodie and a pair of shorts, which Adora caught with one hand, her cheeks burning a dark red. "I'll go start breakfast," Catra said, avoiding all eye contact. "Join me when you're ready."

Alone again, Adora took a moment to appreciate her surroundings. And calm the fuck down.

She was in Catra's bedroom.

And there was no way she could tell it was her ex-best friend's bedroom. There were no photos, no keepsakes. The walls were white and the furniture black, and everything was very minimal. The full-length mirror on the wardrobe caught her eye, mostly because it reminded her of how awful she looked. But it seemed

as if Catra had made conscious decisions to keep it as blank as possible – with as little attachments as possible.

Suddenly, Adora was struck by a brainwave.

She shimmied out of her red dress and shoved it in a ball to the bottom of her bag. Then, she took out the birthday card and little foil pouch that constituted as Catra's birthday present. After pulling on the hoodie and shorts, Adora left the card and present on Catra's pillow for her to find later in the day.

Minimal fuss, just how Catra liked it.

Twenty-one years old

The aftermath

When Catra regained consciousness, the first thing she noticed was how sore her head was. Her thoughts felt sluggish, and her head felt big and heavy, as if it had somehow inflated. The pain travelled down the back of her neck, and as she followed its path, she noticed her ribs were sore and her right ankle was held down, probably by some sort of brace.

The *how* and *why* came back to her in a flash of colour and sounds.

And the lingering taste of Adora on her lips.

Fuck.

Catra opened her eyes, and at the same time, her stomach coiled with a mixture of worry and anger. She coughed and leaned over to the side just in case she was sick; but, of course, it had been a while since she'd ate anything, so the dry heaves were fruitless.

The Arms factory.

Adora.

Kissing her.

A well-aimed hit to the head, and then nothing.

Catra was in a hospital bed in a simple private room, this she knew. It didn't matter. Everything fell away; the bed, the chairs, the walls. Catra blanked it all out, too overwhelmed to focus on anything other than the deep shattering of her heart.

Adora had betrayed her.

Adora had betrayed her.

She had lied. She had kissed Catra – used her feelings against her – so that she could distract her and knock her out.

And the worst part? In the middle of the bloodshed and terror, Adora had made Catra *feel something*.

When Adora pressed her lips against her own, Catra for the first time in her life, believed in a hopeful future – the very thing that her best friend was trying to fight for. She could see them together, years from now, doing nothing but *exist* in the same place, happily. For a moment she believed her deeply-harvested feelings were reciprocated.

No more.

Catra had no idea how much time had passed. There were voices somewhere in the corridor and she had little interest in them.

It didn't matter if fifteen minutes had past of fifteen hours.

Adora was most certainly dead.

And Catra couldn't handle it. There was so much going on inside her; ultimately, the haunting feeling of betrayal, but deeper than that was a growing despair that she couldn't place. Was there anything worse than someone you thought you knew, that meant

the world to you, suddenly showing a side of themselves you'd never seen before? Adora had never been manipulative, and yet…

Catra's heart gave a painful squeeze. The reality of the situation started to sink in.

And she'd never felt so alone. The person who had known her best in the whole universe – the only person to ever truly understand her – her person, her first love, her first friend, her first everything –

Adora was gone.

As betrayed as she was, the regret was just as powerful. Never again would she hear her best friend laugh, or hold her hand, or tell her petty details about her day, or listen to her sleepy breathing, or brush against her softness, her light and joy and sincerity –

Catra wanted to cry, but no tears came.

She was stuck in a swirling pit of endless thoughts and feelings, with absolutely no release.

As she thought the world was about to throw her off its axis, she stared at the ceiling and held her breath.

"Catra?"

Her eyes darted to the door.

Scorpia stood at the threshold, fumbling with her hands.

Judging by her red eyes, it looked as if she had been crying.

Catra couldn't find her voice, and the pain in her head wouldn't allow her to nod. She met Scorpia's gaze and raised her eyebrows slightly. Taking that as an invitation, Scorpia creeped into the room.

“How are you feeling, wildcat?”

Catra swallowed. She gave a one-sided shrug.

Scorpia nodded, as if she understood. “You scared me. The doc said you have a pretty bad concussion. Bruised ribs. A broken ankle.” Stopping at the side of the bed, Scorpia looked down at her friend. “Still, though. We weren’t expecting you back at all.” Her eyes grew teary. “I’m so – it’s just the best news ever.”

Was it? Catra thought about the members of her team. Surviving wasn’t a victory right now. It felt more like a punishment.

“But I’m sure you’re wondering what happened,” Scorpia went on, wiping at her face. “The Captain saw the flare in the sky and thought it was the signal for the end of the mission. They found you, though, without Adora. They assumed you were injured en route to the transmitter and Adora tried to get you to safety. Just as they found you, Adora activated the transmitter.” Scorpia’s tone shifted. She fumbled with her hands again. “I saw the footage on the news. Oh gosh, the place was *decimated*. Nothing was left apart from a huge crater in the ground.”

Catra bit her tongue and looked away.

Decimated.

The word clung to her skin.

Scorpia continued, “The effect was immediate. After the communications system was down, we managed to bring down their weapons. Any hour now, Etheria is going to announce the end of the war. The end of the Horde.” Full of pride, Scorpia gushed, “You’re a hero, wildcat. You both are.”

A sharp pain travelled across Catra’s chest. “We both… are?” she croaked.

“Yeah!” Scorpia beamed. “It’s a miracle. Adora’s in the room next door –”

Catra jumped up. Stars danced in front of her eyes, but she blinked them away, irritated. She asked loudly, "Adora's alive?"

"Woah, take it easy." Scorpia tried to push her down again. Her face was solemn. "You have a serious concussion. We can't be having you –"

"Scorpia," Catra hissed. "Is Adora alive?"

Scorpia shuffled from foot to foot. "Yeah, she's alive. She's just out of surgery. She was in a bad way, wildcat. But she's stable, and if she survives the night, the doctor's say – hey!"

Catra wasn't listening.

Adora was alive.

She had to see it to believe it.

As soon as she was up, the world started to spin. Catra felt herself tilting towards the floor as it rose up to meet her – and then a pair of strong arms were holding her up.

"Did you hear what I said? There's a swelling in your brain –"

"Scorpia," Catra bit through clenched teeth. "Take me to Adora *now*." When her friend hesitated, she yelled, with tears in her throat, "*Now*!"

Scorpia didn't hesitate again. She half carried Catra out to the hall. Catra, decidedly, did not feel good. Her vision pulsed in time with her heartbeat, and it was taking all her concentration not to black out again. She heaved in breaths, tried to focus through the pain and uneasy pressure.

Adora had really done a number on her, huh.

Sensing her discomfort, Scorpia lifted her friend off the ground and carried her bridal style into Adora's room.

There was a doctor beside the bed and a few nurses running around. The doctor began complaining – probably about Catra being out of bed, or about bringing visitors into Adora – but it barely registered in her head. She stared intently at the hospital bed and the trail of blonde hair in it.

Adora was alive.

Behind the oxygen mask, and according to the heart monitor, Adora was both breathing and had a pulse.

Catra's thick thoughts stalled to process it.

In a matter of moments, Catra had shifted from feeling bleak betrayal and the stinging pain of loss, to the sharp, clear pangs of hope.

Adora was not dead.

Their future didn't need to end here.

But… hadn't it already?

It was too much for Catra to handle. She wanted to laugh in relief, and cry with a broken heart. She was angry – *so*angry – and bitter and resentful and hurt and in pain and confused and it was all too much as it swirled around inside, in jumbled thoughts and broken feelings. She wanted – she needed –

"I don't think she's going to budge, doc," Scorpia said in the background.

"We'll get her a chair. She needs to stay off her feet." The doctor came into Catra's view, and she couldn't do anything but blink at him. "If Lance Corporal Greyskull survives the night, she'll still be in a bad way. You understand that, don't you?"

Catra couldn't think past the next five minutes, never mind hours or days from now. "I thought she was dead," was all she croaked.

The doctor gave her a look, oh so sympathetic, and it *burned* underneath her skin.

Scorpia held onto her until a nurse wheeled in a reclining chair. Catra lay down on it, staring to the side, unable to tear her eyes away from the miracle of a woman beside her. Scorpia hovered at the door.

"I'm going to be out here if you need anything," she said. "They need extra security, and I want to feel useful."

Catra frowned. "Why do they need extra security?"

"The war's not over just yet, wildcat. Colonel Hope is afraid one of the Horde might conduct a revenge attack."

If she were in the mood, Catra might question this more. Why would the army suddenly care about protecting two people who weren't supposed to survive the mission? She dismissed it as public image and left it alone.

Catra was too busy mourning a person who hadn't died.

Scorpia closed the door behind her, and Catra heaved a dry sob.

As she stared at Adora, her best friend, the person who had been with her since she was too young to remember how they first met, she replayed the events at the Heart in her mind's eye.

It didn't make sense.

Catra had never known Adora to be cruel, and yet, what other explanation was there for that kiss? Adora must've known about Catra's feelings for her, and when she needed to, used them against her.

And why? What for?

Hadn't they promised to do this together?

Why did Adora want all the glory for herself? Why couldn't she accept Catra's help? Why didn't she want to share the failsafe?

Worst of all, Adora wasn't supposed to be alive. She was happy to go out and leave Catra scarred and betrayed, as long as it didn't interfere with the stupid fucking mission.

The anger she felt surged hotter and brighter.

Catra watched the soft swelling of Adora's chest underneath the thin hospital blanket. The blonde didn't look well, and Catra was having trouble looking at her face. Her skin was pale and covered with a sheen of sweat. The black circles under her eyes and the large gash running down her cheek told part of the story that Catra hadn't witnessed.

But Catra was too busy making a decision to be properly distracted by it.

If Adora survived the night, Catra would never see her again. That was a promise. She would wait to see if Adora was okay, and if she was, Catra would leave and never come back.

If Adora didn't survive the night… well, Catra was going to mourn her best friend, anyway. She would pay her respects and pretend that the events in the Heart never happened. Adora's memory would go untainted.

Either way, Catra and Adora were finished.

And either way, Catra was breaking from the inside out.

Present day

When Adora joined Catra in the kitchen, she found the brunette busy at the stove making pancakes. Feeling like a creep, Adora stood at the counter and watched her because – and she couldn't quite believe it – Catra looked *happy*.

Not the ‘oh my god, this is the best day ever’ kind of happiness. No, this was simpler. As if, right now, at this moment, she was content with where she was and what she had.

Adora had never seen it in Catra before.

It made her feel oddly emotional.

Catra did a double take when she noticed Adora standing behind her. She grinned. “What are you looking at?” Then she looked at the stove. “Is it the pancakes?”

“My favourite,” Adora said lightly.

Catra quickly looked away. “I guess I thought –”

They were interrupted by the loud ringing of Aodra’s phone. With shaky hands, the blonde looked at the screen to see Glimmer was calling her.

“Shit, okay – you mind if I…?”

Catra shrugged. “Go head.”

Adora took a deep breath, swiped to the answer button, and began, “Hi Glim –”

“ADORA MARIE GREYSKULL –”

“Alright, Glim, calm down –”

“WHERE THE HELL –”

Catra turned around with the frying pan in her hand. “Your middle name isn’t Marie.”

There was silence on the other side of the line.

Adora stayed stock still, as if Glimmer could see her.

Then, she heard, “Is that Catra?”

"She doesn't have a middle name," Catra said loudly, so that Glimmer would hear. "It's a side effect of being dumped as a child with a dodgy birth certificate."

Adora sat back, a little affronted. "Alright, *Elizabeth*."

Catra pointed the spatula at her. "We *never* mention that name." A pause, and then, "Who has the surname *Greyskull* anyway? Have you ever met another Greyskull?"

Adora rolled her eyes. "No, otherwise I'd probably think they're, you know, family." She shook her head as Catra smirked. "Glimmer uses Marie as a placeholder. She says shouting two names doesn't have the same impact as shouting three."

"It's as 'basic white girl' as you can get," Glimmer supplied.

Adora wasn't going to repeat *that*. She didn't need them both ganging up against the basic white girl. Instead, she said, "I'm fine, Glim. I'm with Catra."

A beat.

And then, Glimmer whispered, "Did you go home with her?"

"Yeah." Adora frowned. She didn't understand why that was an issue.

"No, I mean, did you – *you know*."

"I don't know what –"

"She lost her keys, so I let her stay over, Sparkles," Catra said as she plated up the pancakes. She slipped a massive jar of syrup towards Adora. "Nothing else happened, promise."

"You lost your *keys* –"

"I found them! This morning, in my bag," Adora quickly supplied, turning slightly away so she could hide her embarrassment. "I

must've not looked properly last night. So, I'm all good, okay? I told you there was no need to worry."

"Adora, your arm could be hanging off and you'd still say you're fine." Glimmer sighed. "But okay, I'll yield." On a lower note, she said, "Can you tell Catra – actually, never mind. It can wait."

After saying quick goodbyes, Adora put her phone away and fully faced Catra again with an easy smile. The brunette offered her a plate of pancakes, and her brows were pulled together as if deep in thought. This was never a good sign. She had to do something to recover the situation.

"Glimmer's very protective," she offered, accepting the food with thanks.

Catra inclined her to the syrup jar. "I noticed." A pause. "I guess I don't understand why Adora Greyskull, saviour of Etheria and commemorated war hero, needs a small sparkly teacher to look out for her."

There was a *hint* of resentment in her voice that didn't go unnoticed. Adora thought back to how she met Bow and Glimmer, and how much of a hopeless mess she'd been then. Catra had never seen that side of her – not until recently, at least. Despite everything she had processed over the years, she couldn't help but feel a surge of disappointment in herself for not being as strong as what was expected of her.

"Glimmer's been a good friend," Adora said instead. "And Bow. I'd probably be – well, in a different situation if not for them."

A muscle in Catra's cheek twitched as she looked down. Adora did the same, pretending to take extra time to cut a large slice of pancake. It was good – really good. But it didn't feel like the right time to point it out.

"I feel like –" Catra stopped and took a deep breath. "Sorry, this is still a little hard for me to say."

Adora shook her head. “You don’t need to say anything you don’t want to.”

“No, I need to. I’ve been holding onto it for a while, and my guilt tends to turn to anger. Which, apparently, isn’t healthy. Who would’ve thought it, eh?” Catra smiled tentatively. When she met Adora’s eyes, her gaze was unwavering. “I regret not being there for you. After, you know, the Heart of Etheria project.”

Adora gently dropped her fork.

Catra went on, “I know you tried to reach out to me – *so* many times. Knowing what I know now that we’ve talked it out, I think it would’ve been best for us to be together. And work through it. Together.”

Adora felt a lot of things. Hurt. Her insides squirmed with it. Regret and guilt, just like Catra. They pulled on the back of her throat and made it impossible to speak. But there was also release – all those nights of hoping and waiting and praying to every god in existence that Catra still cared, and she’d finally heard what she wanted to hear five years ago; that Catra was there, and Catra could forgive her.

Wordlessly, Adora walked around the kitchen island and flung her arms around Catra’s neck, squeezing her into a hug. Maybe she had been expecting it, because the next thing Catra did was let out a light laugh.

"You smell like musty beer,” she said, wrapping her arms loosely around Adora’s waist.

Adora didn’t let go. “Honestly, Catra? I think anything we’d do would be better together.”

“You’re so cheesy, you know that? It’s gross.”

“Hey, we grew up to be two emotionally repressed adults, I think we deserve it.”

And it was nice, the hug.

Nice enough never to let go.

Twenty-one years old

The aftermath

Adora made it through the next twelve hours.

Catra didn't leave her side.

Different doctors arrived through the night to monitor them both. One of them – a junior doctor on the final hour of her shift – informed Catra that the war was over, the Horde had fallen.

Then she thanked her for her service.

Catra couldn't find the words to reply.

It was early morning now, and Catra was feeling another wave of nausea ripple through her. As it turned out, Scorpia was right – she *had* a very bad concussion, but the catnaps had helped. Any time she closed her eyes for too long, she woke in a panic, thinking that Adora had stopped breathing because of her negligence. The longer it went on, and the sparks of clarity that came from sleep, made Catra more and more *resentful*.

She resented the army and what it had done to them. She resented Weaver and the children's home for giving them no other choice than to run away at sixteen to find a new life for themselves. She resented their long-forgotten families that abandoned them and dumped them in a children's home. She resented it all; everything that had led them to this moment.

Begrudgingly, and perhaps most of all, Catra resented herself for falling for Adora in the first place.

No more.

Never again, she swore. Never again would she allow someone to get under her skin like Adora had – never again would she *love* someone in this way.

It was safer to hate her. It was safer to hate the world than despair at its hope.

There was a knock on their door, pulling her out of her thoughts.

Catra slowly turned her head to the side to see –

Captain Lonsfield.

He entered the room with his head bowed and his cap in his hands.

"Lance Corporal Areli. You're looking better."

In normal situations, Catra was expected to stand and salute. She didn't. She didn't even grace him with a response. Her nails dug into the arms of the chair.

"I'm not sure if you've heard, but the Horde is eliminated. All thanks to you and your team, of course."

Catra bit her tongue.

He took a few steps closer to the hospital bed, and went on, "You'll all be fully commemorated, of course. I suspect yourself and Lance Corporal Greyskull will be considered heroes."

"Is that supposed to mean something?" Catra hissed, unable to contain herself any longer.

Lonsfield paused, bending over Adora to check the bandages on her chest. When he pulled away and looked up again, he was most serious. "This is a chance for you to monopolise on the event, Areli. You'll be offered a promotion, and if you so choose, a choice to spend the rest of your tour off the battlefield. There's a bright future ahead of you in the army."

“And I wasn’t expecting to see another sunrise, Captain,” Catra bit back. “Forgive me if I can’t see the rosy future you’re describing.”

Lonsfield came to stand before her. “A lot of people sacrificed themselves so we could live to see this future. You should be grateful you’ll live to reap the rewards.”

“Grateful?” Catra hissed. If she was able, she would’ve stood up to confront him. As it was, her head was already spinning as her anger rose in intensity. “I’m supposed to be grateful that I somehow survived a suicide mission?”

“You volunteered to –”

“I volunteered because I had little choice,” argued Catra. “Not all of us have the privilege of hiding behind our title.”

Lonsfield raised his eyebrows and rocked on his heels. “I’ll put your tone down to traumatic stress, Areli. In the future you’ll do well to remember how to speak to your superiors.” He paced back to the door and glanced over his shoulder. “Let me know when she wakes up, won’t you?”

And he left.

Fuck off, she whispered as his shadow passed the hall.

As it happened, Catra felt like punching something. She could see Scorpia silhouette still guarding the door and, for a moment, she considered calling her in to have someone to rant at. There was so much going on inside of her – and with each passing second, all the feelings were merging, creating a fireball of pure fury. Any moment she felt like she’d explode.

She’d almost lost her best friend, but her best friend had betrayed her.

She couldn’t have prepared for that if she had even tried.

And to top it off, her love for Adora felt stronger than ever. Catra had almost lost her. The sight of Adora, bloodied and shot, stung her eyelids every time she blinked. She even found it difficult to look at her now, bandaged and bruised in the hospital bed.

And the feeling of Adora's lips against her own –

The *pain*, and the *confusion*, and the *hatred* –

Catra couldn't take it any longer. She had to get out.

She hobbled out of the recliner and almost fell back from the immediate headrush. The room spun, and Catra coughed a few dry heaves. But still, she continued her trek to the door, determined to find somewhere dark and quiet and – most of all – *alone*.

She was broken – and heartbroken – beyond repair.

"Hey, wildcat, take it easy."

Catra felt Scorpia's strong arms around her before she seen them. She tried to pull away, to *get away*. "I need to go –"

"Don't you want to see if Adora –"

"*I need to go*," Catra hissed, holding onto the door to keep herself upright.

And at that moment, she thought the feeling was mutual;

She was done with the world.

And the world was done with her.

Present day

Once Adora had left a few hours later, Catra retreated to her bedroom to tidy it.

As she approached the bed, she noticed the little foil pouch on her pillow and a birthday card addressed to her.

Adora, you sap, she thought. *You know I hate presents.*

Still, curiosity won her over. She opened the birthday card first, and of course it had a stupid pun; it was a birthday cake with a caption 'you want a piece of me'? Alright, maybe that was funny. She would allow her that one.

Inside, Adora had written:

Sorry for all the missed birthdays. I hope you can remember the meaning behind this gift, or this is going to be very awkward. I still have mine, but I know you lost yours. Love, Adora.

If it was a nostalgic gift, Catra hoped she remembered too. Otherwise yes, Adora was right, this *would* be very awkward.

Catra opened the foil pouch and let the small silvery item drop into her hand.

And she gasped.

Back when they eight or nine – Catra couldn't remember the specifics – Adora had won a story competition and had been awarded a small amount of money. Instead of giving it to Weaver, like she was asked to do, Adora had gone to an accessory shop and bought friendship bracelets for Catra's birthday. Two cheap silver bracelets, one with a moon charm and the other with a star charm. It was the first time Catra had been given anything for her birthday, and she'd almost cried.

Catra kept the moon and gave Adora the star. They never took them off. However, a few years later, Weaver found the charm in the pocket of Catra's shirt pocket and assumed she'd stolen it. She took it from her, and refused to give it back.

Adora stopped wearing her bracelet after that. She didn't want Weaver finding hers too. Catra assumed it was because she didn't

want to get in trouble for having it, but looking back now, she thought it was probably because it meant too much for her to lose it.

And here, in her palm, Catra stared at a moon bracelet, identical to the one from before.

Catra held it in her fist as she sat on the edge of her bed.

She angrily wiped at her eyes and sniffed.

They weren't even thirty, and so much had been taken from them. *So many missed birthdays*, as Adora had put it.

No more.

Chapter End Notes

Is this slow burn enough for you?

I'm aware that up until now we've seen Grown Up Catra in this fic, who has moved past most of her trauma. Both MCs, but specifically Catra, will be represented how she was in the show mid-breakdown. So, in other words, she'll not be very nice and she'll say a lot of mean things in the flashback scenes. (I've kind of been looking forward to it.)

Next time: in the present, the girls go out. In the past, Adora wakes up and Catra is just having the worst time.

If you enjoyed this or if you have anything to say, please drop a comment! They really brighten up my day, and I try to respond whenever I can.

Stay safe (I got my first vaccine yesterday, yay!),

Cx.

Separation

Chapter Summary

Warning for creepy men being creepy.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Present day

For the next few weeks, Catra and Adora had lunch together every day. Sometimes Catra visited Adora in the Art department and did the bare minimum helping her out with the scenery decorations for the Open Day musical production of *Wicked*. Other times, Adora visited her in the English department with no other purpose than to criticise the personal bookshelf Catra kept behind her desk. This new arrangement meant they spent little time in the staff room, and although it was unspoken between them, it was known by both parties that it was because Catra was still avoiding Glimmer.

Catra stubbornly didn't want to apologise because she meant what she said. Glimmer, on the other hand, didn't want to apologise because she didn't feel like she said anything out of turn. Adora, caught in the middle, had little interest in keeping the peace between them. Selfishly, she quite liked having them as separate friends, at least for the time being. It meant she could get Glimmer and Bow's advice without them directly interfering.

She loved them to death, but she *knew* how much they liked to meddle.

"This isn't bad," Catra said, gesturing to the prop Adora was painting. "It definitely looks like a cauldron."

"But does it say 'wicked witch brewing revenge' or does it say 'mildly irritated witch stirring pea soup'?" Adora pondered,

dangling the paintbrush from her mouth.

Catra hummed and stood back to admire it. “I’d say ‘wicked witch stirring pea soup’.”

Adora shrugged. “Eh, close enough. I can deal with that.”

“I didn’t expect you to be this good at art, you know.”

“I had to work on it.” She put rested the paintbrush on the floor while she took a bite out of her sandwich. “My personal style is abstract, though. I also dabbled in expressionism. Helped me get out all of my… guilt.”

Adora briefly thought back to the final piece she submitted for her degree course. That was a difficult process, and not one she would ever want to repeat.

“You’ll have to show me some time,” Catra said between mouthfuls of noodles.

Adora quirked an eyebrow. “My guilt?”

Catra rolled her eyes. “No, your art, dummy.”

“Oh.” Adora felt herself instantly deflate. She didn’t keep much of her artwork – the personal pieces, anyway. After she completed a piece that meant something to her (usually influenced by a therapy session) she could ever look at it again.

“What’s that face for?”

Adora shook her head and frowned at Catra’s keen stare. “I don’t know, it’s just – I don’t really show anyone my art. It feels too – uh, internal. Does that make sense?” She sighed. It probably sounded stupid, or like she was making up excuses. “It would feel like someone looking straight through me.”

“Yeah. I get it.” Catra gestured with her fork. “Scorpia said something similar about her stuffed animal collection.”

They both laughed before trailing into silence. Adora, munching on her sandwich, watching Catra smile into her lunch bowl. This was so easy, wasn't it? It felt like when they were teenagers catching up over dinner after school. Adora felt her heart glow with warm affection.

But there was something she wanted to ask, now that they were on the topic. "Speaking of Scorpia –"

"Yes, she's still talking nonstop about Perfuma and I'm still pissed off about it." Catra's nose wrinkled in distaste. "She's practically living over there now. I never get to see her anymore."

"Aw." Adora playfully nudged her. "I don't know what's sweeter – how secretly upset you are or how quickly those lesbians have moved in together."

Catra nudged her back. "I'm not upset! It just gets lonely sometimes, you know?"

"I do know. My best friends fell in love and started a life without me too."

"That's the story of our lives, isn't it?" Catra scoffed. "Being abandoned."

Adora grimaced. That hit a bit *too* close to home. "Ouch."

"Big ouch," Catra agreed, putting down her noodles to pick up a paintbrush. As she started adding to the black of cauldron, Adora urged herself to say something. Anything.

It was the perfect opportunity.

"Hey," she started, voice shaking, "since you're lonely, and since I'm lonely –"

Catra turned to glare at her. "I did *not* say the *l* word."

Adora went on, undeterred. “Since *I’m* lonely, what do you say we go for a few drinks on Saturday night? Or go to the cinema and you know, eat something or whatever.”

A pause.

Catra twirled the paintbrush through her fingers, staring.

And then her face broke into a wicked grin. “Sounds like a date.”

Adora’s mind went blank. “Not a date – not a, you know, a – I wouldn’t do that to you. Sorry.” She didn’t know what to do; she didn’t want to offend Catra, or put her in an awkward position, or force her to do something she didn’t want to do. Damn it, she should’ve just left it. Trying to fix the situation, she added, “If it was a bad idea just forget I said –”

But to her surprise, Catra cackled a high-pitched laugh. “Adora, idiot, I didn’t say no.” She smiled, genuinely. “Drinks sound good. Maybe we could see a movie before or after. If you wanted.”

“Okay.” Adora’s throat was as dry as a desert. “Cool.”

Catra stuck out her tongue slightly. “It’s a date.” At Adora’s loud intake of breath, she laughed again. “I’m joking! Jeez, if you were wound any tighter, you’d be bouncing off the walls.”

Twenty-one years old

The aftermath

Adora was dreaming, but something wasn’t quite right.

Usually her dreams were vivid; memories replayed with slight changes, interactions with friends, things she could’ve done differently if she could do them again. This time, however, she was dreaming of colours.

Flashes of red. Brown. Silver.

And fear.

Terror, in fact. Her heart kept stuttering, and she felt the overwhelming urge to *get away*. She didn't know what from, she didn't know where to. It was a flight response to an immediate threat, and she didn't know how to wake up.

She also felt completely and utterly alone.

Wake up.

You need to wake up.

As the instinct came to her, Adora was confused.

She didn't know waking up was an option.

Waking up *shouldn't* be an option.

But why…?

The façade crashed as she slammed a fist into the emergency exit.

She wasn't dead – was she?

She *should* be.

Adora became aware of other things; first, the weight of her limbs. They felt impossible to move, almost as if they were being held down by something. Then, came the sensation of heat. Adora was burning from the inside. Everything felt torn and twisted and – the more she focused on it – she realised it was pain. It wasn't focused on one area, rather it was all over, and it made it impossible to think straight. She knew she wanted to open her eyes, but she dreaded the moment she did.

She had no idea what was waiting for her.

And she could remember – she could remember everything. The transmitter, the battle, Catra. At the thought of her best friend's

name, Adora's heart ached, and she opened her eyes.

Unsurprisingly, she was in a hospital bed.

Adora, still struggling with the concept of being alive, felt like she was living a dream. The room, with the machines and the white light and the gentle smell of cleaning alcohol, had a blurry softness to it. It took a while for her eyes to adjust, and even then, she wasn't sure any of it was real.

The beeping monitor told her she had a heart, despite how it felt like there was a hole in her chest. The oxygen mask and the tube down her throat told her that she still had lungs, even though she was struggling to breathe. She had little interest in what else had happened to her body – her mind didn't have the capacity to worry about it. Overall, she only had two thoughts.

One: had she saved everyone?

And two: had she saved Catra?

These thoughts circled her drug-addled brain, and they wouldn't stop until she had an answer.

Time passed; Adora wasn't sure how long she struggled against the weight of her eyelids. Sleep would soon pull her under again, and it was sheer stubbornness for answers that had made her last this long. When a shy nurse holding new bandages entered the room, Adora's heart monitor picked up speed.

"Can you hear me?" the nurse whispered.

Adora, unable to move or speak, blinked in response.

"I'll get a doctor," she said, smiling. Then, she hesitated. "I just want to thank you. It's incredibly brave what you did. You're a hero."

Adora had never hated that word more in her life. All at once, the inability to communicate made her panic. *What about Catra?* She

wanted to ask. *Is Catra safe?*

She needed to know.

As the nurse turned to leave, Adora tried to move her hand to stop her. The woman looked around, titled her head. Adora didn't know how to express herself without her voice. Sweat gathered at the back of her neck as she strained herself to move.

"Are you in pain?" the nurse asked. She stood at the foot of the bed. "Can you blink twice for me if you're in pain?"

She was, but that wasn't what she was trying to say. Adora stayed still and twitched her hand again.

The nurse scanned the room, trying to think of what else she was trying to say. When her eyes moved over the empty chair beside Adora's bed, she exclaimed, "Oh! Is it about your colleague? Lance Corporal Areli?"

Adora blinked twice. *Yes! Please. Tell me. Is she okay?*

"She was in here, earlier," the nurse explained with a sad smile. "She didn't leave your side all night. But you'll be glad to know that she's alive and she'll make a full recovery."

If Adora was able to, she would've cried.

All the tension drained from her body. Her eyelids fluttered and she let her hand drop back to the bed. *Thank you*, she wanted to say. *Thank you for telling me*.

I did it.

I saved her.

I saved everyone.

As it happened, Adora hadn't failed. She'd very much succeeded, and she managed to do the impossible – survive. It was

unimaginable. It was against all the odds. However – and it was a big risk admitting it – something was holding her back from feeling *happy*.

Adora had achieved what she wanted to achieve. Catra was safe and the war was over.

But she hadn't expected to live to see it.

And Catra wasn't *here*.

She felt the nurse pat her hand before leaving. Unable to keep her eyes open any longer, Adora let herself rest.

Present day

It was Saturday night and Catra and Adora were out on the town again.

They went to see a movie (an artsy foreign language film, Catra's pick) and then headed to the cocktail bar across the road afterwards. Evidently, Catra knew quite a lot of the drinks on offer, judging by how she knew what to order. Meanwhile, Adora was finding it hard to pronounce 'Cointreau'.

"What's coin-true?" she asked while squinting at the sticky menu.

Catra's lips quirked up. "Cointreau. It's like an orange liqueur."

Adora's eyebrows gathered in concentration. "Con-true. Cwen – no, quee – wait, I can get this. Cuntro." She scowled as Catra's smile grew. "Help me out here."

"Nah, I like seeing you struggle with something," Catra teased. Then, to the bar tender, she said, "She'll have a Mai Tai, thanks."

"*Kwan-tro*," Adora almost yelled, slapping her hand onto the counter.

"Got there in the end, princess." Catra scooched closer, so that her arm ghosted next to Adora's. "So, what did you think of the movie?"

Right. The movie. Adora found herself leaning into Catra's warmth, so she repositioned her arms on her lap – just in case she did something stupid. "Well, it was a movie," she said, wincing. "Very… movie-ish."

In all honesty, Adora didn't understand the imagery and symbolism, but she knew Catra liked that kind of thing. Adora was more of a character person than a plot person.

Catra huffed and elbowed her in the ribs. "I *know* you can try harder than that."

Adora smiled in spite of herself. "Challenge accepted." She looked past the brunette's shoulder, concentrating hard on trying to think of something intelligent and insightful to say. "I liked the theme of accountability and acceptance. Overall, though, I thought the main character got off lightly. It felt a bit… flat."

Catra pulled an expression that clearly said she disagreed – all flared nostrils and small pout. "You don't think she deserved forgiveness?"

"Well, no," Adora quickly amended. "I think most people deserve forgiveness –"

"Just not her."

"I don't think she did the right thing."

Resting an elbow on the bar, Catra observed Adora quietly for a moment. Then, she said with a slight bite to her tone, "Sometimes it's not about doing the right thing. Sometimes it's about doing something for yourself, or realising it's not your responsibility."

Adora frowned. She thought it through, but it didn't feel right. "I think that's an irresponsible message," she countered. "If more

people in our society were accountable, and chose to do things because they were the right thing to do –"

"But what exactly *is* the right thing to do?" Catra asked.

Blinking, Adora thought it was a trick question. Surely it was obvious, wasn't it? "Being kind," she said. "Keeping people safe. Equality and fairness."

They paused the conversation as the bartender placed their drinks in front of them. Adora accepted the cloudy orange Mai Tai with a small word of thanks. She sipped on it and watched Catra, who seemed to be weighing up her words.

After sipping her own drink, Catra said, "That's a nice utopia you're living in, but in case you haven't noticed, the war we fought is a perfect example of how kindness, equality and fairness is in short supply in most people."

"But just because our society's means and methods don't value them, doesn't mean they don't matter, or they're not *right*," Adora argued. And yes, she was aware that this was probably starting an argument that she didn't want to have – least of all with Catra, but she felt defensive and impassioned by the strand of conversation.

"Alright, okay." Catra put her hands up in surrender. "I can accept that." She gestured to Adora with the drink in her hand. "You have high self-esteem and low self-esteem at the same time. You think you're morally better than everyone else, but you also don't think you're worth anything. Hence your martyr-complex."

Adora nearly snorted into her cocktail. When she saw Catra grin, clearly amused, she narrowed her eyes. "First of all: it's a hero-complex. Second of all: why don't you shut the hell up."

Catra let out a loud cackle, and Adora felt very satisfied. Her cheeks burned and she tried to cover her blushing by looking at the menu. It was wonderful, making Catra laugh after so many years of making her miserable. It was better than winning a prize.

A waiter holding a tray approached them. She put a short glass in front of Adora, along with a napkin with a number written on it.

"A tequila shot," she told Adora, smiling. "From the woman on table four."

Adora's eyes were the size of plates. *This* didn't happen often. She looked from the waiter to the shot glass, and back up again, as if searching for a clue as to what to do. She didn't dare look in the direction of table four, or the woman who had sent her the drink. "Oh, uh – I – I don't –"

Catra reached across and picked up the tequila shot. "Thanks!" she called over Adora's shoulder, raising the glass at table four, and knocking back the drink in one swift motion. Without reacting to the burning liquid, Catra said loudly, "Can't she see you're with me? That's so rude."

Adora wanted to turn invisible. She wanted the earth to swallow her whole. "You uh –" she swallowed. "You didn't need to do that."

"Are you kidding me?" Catra hissed. She stared at the number on the napkin as if it had personally offended her. "Who sends a drink to someone who looks like they're on a date?"

"Wow, okay." Adora didn't know whether to laugh or continue blushing until her entire body was just a red blob. "A lot to unpack there. First, you're establishing dominance –"

"Establishing – what?" Catra squeaked, now turning equally as red.

Adora tilted her head. "C'mon, you do it a lot." When Catra opened her mouth to argue, Adora put a finger over her lips. "Hey, if you can read me then I can read you." Catra closed her mouth. Satisfied, Adora continued, "You still do that thing where you sweep a room before sitting down. Always ready for a challenge."

"I don't do that!"

"Second of all, she *probably* thinks you're straight."

Catra let her head fall into her hands. "You keep making it worse!"

"I'm being honest!" Adora said, nodding. "You're very straight-passing."

"And you're not, Miss Basic White Girl?" Catra retorted, poking the blonde in the forehead for emphasis.

"No, obviously not. A man hasn't hit on me since I was, like, eighteen. I bet guys hit on you all the time."

Adora knew she landed a killer blow when Catra had trouble forming words.

"I – well – shut up."

"And anyway," Adora went on, "the woman from table four probably thinks I'm out of your league and that we're just friends. So, she wasn't snubbing you."

Catra, in the middle of taking a sip of her cocktail, nearly smashed the glass as she put it back down. "Okay, wait. There's *a lot* to unpack there."

Adora folded her arms. "Go ahead."

"How *the hell* am I out of your league?" she nearly shouted.

"You always have been." Adora shrugged; it was true. She wasn't mad about it, or jealous, or insecure – she was just stating a fact. Catra was prettier, stronger, and altogether a better catch than Adora was – or ever could be.

Catra gaped. She stared at her as if she had suddenly grown a third head. "That's not an answer and it's also *untrue*."

"Well, you would think that. You're in a league looking down, and I'm in a different league looking up." Adora tapped her chest, proud of her observation skills. "I see the difference more than you do."

Catra shook her head, and for a moment, Adora thought she was *angry*, especially as she sniped, "You're an idiot."

Adora wiggled her eyebrows. "I know."

Twenty-one years old

One month after the Heart of Etheria Project

Catra wasn't expecting it to be easy.

But nothing could've prepared her for how hard it was.

She heard from Scorpia that Adora was asking for her. Catra, of course, had heard the rumours: Adora was in a bad shape. She could barely walk, she was permanently scarred, and kept asking, or demanding, to talk to Catra.

Catra, who hadn't seen her since the hospital.

It was difficult to stay away, but it was even more difficult to talk about Adora while remaining calm. It didn't take much to set her off; she'd permanently turned off the TV, just in case someone started to talk about the war. She had removed all traces of Adora from her bunk room, and pointedly asked her friends to never mention *that name* again.

Catra was glad that *she* was alive, but for all intents and purposes, Adora was dead to her.

Mental and emotional well-being aside, Catra's body had healed. Her ankle was still in a brace, but that was all she had to complain about. As far as duty was concerned, she attended a state funeral for her colleagues that had perished in the mission, and then was

asked to review her position in the Special Forces. Catra still had three years left of her tour, but she was offered desk and camp duty to keep her off the field. Now that the war was over, active duty wasn't going to be a common problem, so this wasn't exactly a grand gesture. She had been hoping to be let off her contract early, but as it happened, that wasn't an option.

That being said, Catra was done with active duty and accepted cadet training in the camp instead. Looking to the future, she was also done with the army. When the next three years of her service were over, she would tear her uniform to shreds and never look back.

In the meantime, Catra was doing anything she could just to *forget*.

After a tragic experience – such as unexpectedly surviving a suicide mission – soldiers were given a few months of voluntary leave to rest and recuperate.

And Catra was struggling with it.

She spent most mornings locked away in her bedroom off-camp, doing nothing but staring at the ceilings. Sometimes she would have no recollection of what she was thinking about, or what she was staring at. It was like she was in a permanent daze, or some weird conscious dream. She had no desire to move or to help herself in any way. There were just her thoughts, the silence, and the ceiling.

In the afternoon, she would crawl out of bed and attempt to eat something. When that didn't scratch the itch, she would mindlessly switch on the radio and pretend to listen to the voices of normal being talking about normal things in their normal lives.

She went to bed early and slept in late.

Sleep was the only saviour.

Sleep was numb and emotionless.

Sometimes Scorpia came over to check on her. On those days, Catra tried to make herself seem presentable, but she wasn't sure how well she pulled it off. Scorpia made her tea and soup and all the warm comforting things. One day, while Scorpia was discussing a new member of the espionage team, Catra had a thought:

Scorpia's being a friend to me.

And it filled her with rage and hatred.

Catra didn't need friends.

Friends only hurt you.

Catra couldn't tolerate any more hurt. Sometimes her chest rattled with the broken pieces of herself, too broken to ever be put back together. She couldn't handle it – no, she didn't want it. She wanted to be alone.

She wanted out – out of *this*, her body, her mind, *herself* –

"Hey, wildcat, are you okay? Why are you crying?"

"Out," Catra snapped. When Scorpia hesitated, she pointed at the door. "*Get out*!"

Scorpia left.

Later that night, when it was just Catra and the ceiling, she assumed that was it – another friendship over. Another person out of her life for good.

She was wrong.

Scorpia came over the next day, and the day after that. She never stopped coming around, and she never stopped *trying*.

It was just a shame there was nothing left of Catra for her to save.

Present day

Once she was finished her drink, Catra excused herself to have a cigarette break.

The cocktail bar had a smoking garden, but Catra preferred the street. She paced up and down the pavement with her arms wrapped around her waist. With every drag of her cigarette, she thought about Adora and her stupid face.

In what planet did Adora think she was out of Catra's league?

Wasn't Adora the perfect example of modern Westernised beauty standards? Blonde, lean, blue eyes, white? Even that aside, Adora had *character*. Her eyes were always so wide and sincere, and her lips were the perfect colour of pink. When she smiled, it could dazzle suns. When she was frustrated, she looked like she could take down armies. She was beautiful, and most of all, true to herself.

So, the question was, did Adora have bad body image of herself, or did she just have a glorified image of Catra?

The idea that Adora had such high standards of her made Catra's intestines squirm.

Ah, fuck. She felt like a teenager with a crush all over again.

But that's what this was, wasn't it? Catra had it bad. She'd never stopped loving Adora; even when she hated her, it was fuelled by heartbreak. These last few weeks – being friends again – was good. Better than good, it was great. But here Catra was, having uncomfortable, blushing feelings for Adora again like this was her first crush.

She felt so pathetic.

With her heart already hammering in her throat, Catra turned the corner and threw her cigarette down the drain. As she took a few

deep breaths, she tried to pull herself together. She could be friends with Adora – that was the easy part. Trying not to fall in love with her again? That was more difficult.

Just as she was about to go back into the cocktail bar, she turned on her heel to find a drunken man, his arms the size of tree trunks, leering at her from the corner.

"Alright, love?" he said. "You have a light?"

She sighed. "Ah, no."

When she tried to pass him, he stood in front of her. "Say, do you have a boyfriend?"

Catra crossed her arms. She *really* wasn't in the mood for this. "Listen, I don't have time for this. Get out of my way. Now."

Twenty-one years old

Two months after the Heart of Etheria project

Adora barely heard the knock on her door.

"Come in," she muttered.

It was Lonnie, dressed in her fatigues. She smiled softly as she closed the door behind her and then hovered at the end of the bed. "How are you feeling?"

Adora gave a side glance at the wheelchair. Between not being able to sleep because of nightmares, and the constant thumping pain radiating her body, Adora had been better. She was lonely, bored, and miserable. Her body was betraying her, and her thoughts felt like they belonged to someone else. The impact of the failsafe had caused scarring to her face and back, and the bullet that had pierced her side had caused permanent stiffness in the muscles around her hip bone, which was only worsened by an infection in the wound. On the surface, she supposed she looked

better than when she was in hospital. But the progress was slow, and she was impatient.

"I'm okay, thanks," Adora said instead. "Healing."

"Any idea when you'll be back on your feet again?"

"The spinal fracture should be another month, plus physical therapy." Adora licked her lips, keen to move onto a different topic. Carefully, she asked, "Has there been anything from – you know. From Catra."

It hurt even saying her name.

When Adora came around again in hospital, she cried with relief that Catra was safe and well. She had asked to see her, but all her requests were denied. At first Adora thought it was the military officials keeping them apart – until she spoke to Scorpia.

Catra didn't want anything more to do with her.

And just like that, she had lost her best friend.

When Adora had hit Catra over the head to get her to safety, she hadn't expected to survive – to see the consequences. She understood why Catra felt betrayed, or hurt, or whatever it was she was feeling. If she hated Adora, she understood that too. Adora deserved it. She had betrayed Catra's trust to save her life.

And yet, what she wanted more than anything was for Catra to shout at her, yell, scream, kick, punch it all out – *take it all* out on her.

Anything but this silence.

And, selfishly, Adora felt a bit hurt too.

It seemed as if Catra didn't care what happened to her. Adora understood why, that wasn't issue. Although, she would be lying if she said it didn't hurt like hell. Adora was in pain, and upset, and

hated herself, and she could've really used a hug from her best friend.

Did she deserve it? No. But it didn't stop her wanting it.

Lonnie grimaced. "Sorry, no. She's still unreachable."

"But we know she's well?" Adora asked, as always.

"Scorpia keeps in contact with her." Lonnie sat on the edge of the bed. "I'm actually here because Colonel Hope asked me to come get you."

Adora pursed her lips and looked at the wheelchair. "I can do it myself."

"Come on, now, Adora. You survived the impossible, but you're not invincible." Smiling, Lonnie got up and offered her hands. "Let me help."

Adora, eventually, gave in, but only because she was aware that Colonel Hope was waiting for her. Lonnie wheeled her to the Colonel's office, making idle conversation about their old colleagues along the way. Any time a soldier passed they saluted – something Adora still wasn't used to. Between the internal gossip about what had happened at the transmitter, and the constant conversation in the press about the people behind the Heart of Etheria project, Adora was starting to resent the idea of heroism. She was glad that they succeeded, and that the war was over, but it was naïve to think that this was going to be the end of the conflict. Once the war was over, the politicians needed to step in, making the situation just as volatile.

In other words, Adora was having a change of perspective. She had done what was expected of her, and she had unexpectedly survived to see the future she had fought for – a future that wasn't as rosy as she initially thought.

Lonnie rapped the door and let herself in, saying, "Lance Corproal Greyskull for you, ma'am."

At once, Adora felt underdressed. Colonel Hope was in her full uniform, and her medals adorned her chest like a centre piece at a dinner party. Lonnie squeezed Adora's shoulder as she left to wait outside. The room felt very empty without her.

Adora jerked her hand in an attempted salute. "Ma'am," she said.

"At ease, Greyskull," Hope replied. "I'm sorry for meeting like this, I know you're on sick leave, but we have matters to discuss."

Adora had only encountered Captain Lonsfield and Colonel Hope once since the end of the project. They had congratulated her on a successful mission and promised to meet with her once she was well again about future roles in the army.

Without waiting for a reply, Hope went on, "First of all, I think we need to discuss what you want to do after your rest and recuperation."

"I thought I would take voluntary leave for a few months," Adora answered, unable to hide her confusion. Everyone in the army was entitled to compassionate voluntary leave after a serious mission. Catra was on voluntary leave now – she'd heard that through Scorpia.

Hope glanced down to her notes. "Yes, of course, you can take as much time as you want to heal. But beyond that, we're keen to continue the She-Ra experiments, since they have been – beyond our wildest dreams – very successful."

Adora opened her mouth and closed it again. Once more, she didn't understand. The army usually offered desk or camp jobs to soldiers who have went above and beyond their duty. Of what Adora had considered of her future in the military, she had thought about taking up a job in the barracks until her contract ended.

Why wasn't this being offered to her?

Hadn't she gone above and beyond her duty?

Hadn’t she done the one thing they wanted – save everyone?

This didn’t make sense.

“Are you asking me or are you telling me?” Adora asked, a hitch in her voice.

Hope smiled. “Forgive me, I thought you remembered what was written in your contract.” She shuffled the paper on her desk. “In the event that the host of She-Ra survived, and the failsafe recorded the relevant information, then the host of She-Ra would immediately return to active duty. She-Ra is too important for Etheria to lose, Lance Corporal Greyskull. Now that we know the scale of success it can offer, we need to continue investing in it.”

She-Ra.

Not Adora.

“I thought – I, uh –” Adora shook her head to clear it. She clutched the hand rest of her wheelchair. “I didn’t, uh, know that. But what if – what if I didn’t want to continue the She-Ra experiment?”

Hope’s eyebrows shot up and her lips turned down. “You’re the host of She-Ra, Lance Corporal. Military-owned equipment lives *inside* you. We own it.” A shadow of something crossed her face. “Your place in the experiment will be reviewed at the end of your tour, when your contract ends in three years. Failing to meet the requirements of your duties – as stated in your contract – is illegal, as you know, and considered an abandonment of your post.”

The Etherian military had strong rules against ‘abandoning your post’ i.e. forcibly ending your contract early. It was a measure they brought in during the war to ensure they had enough soldiers.

The consequence of which was life in prison.

Adora's world started to spin. All she could do was nod.

The message was loud and clear: she had no choice. She-Ra belonged to them, meaning Adora belonged to them too.

Adora, and She-Ra, would return to active duty.

"In other news," Hope said, changing conversation as if they were having an idle catch-up. "We have arranged for yourself and Lance Corporal Areli to have a public honours ceremony. You'll be commended for your bravery on behalf of your team, and promoted to Corporal status."

Adora barely heard her. A few years ago, she would've cried with joy at such a promotion. At twenty-one, it was practically unheard of to be promoted so quickly. But right now? She could barely fake a smile.

"Thank you, Colonel," she said, hoping her voice didn't shake too much.

"Yes, well," Hope sighed, "maybe it will decrease the media attention you have been attracting."

Media attraction, right. Everyone was interested in the faces behind the tragedy, behind the bravery, behind the sacrifice. Of course they had to respond in some way, probably to stop the outrageous rumours. This wasn't for them – it was for the media.

"If that's all, Colonel Hope, I would like to retire to my quarters," Adora said. Why did she feel so impossibly stiff? Her lips were struggling to form the words.

Colonel Hope dismissed her and called Lonnie back in. On the way, Adora didn't have the strength to tell Lonnie what happened. She was too stuck in her own head. As the corridor narrowed into the door of her room, Adora felt herself detach from her consciousness, as if she was looking at someone else's life from the outside. Her breathing was short and sharp, and the world started to spin again.

She couldn’t go back to active duty.

She didn’t have any strength left in her to fight again.

Not without Catra. Not after everything that had happened.

But what could she do?

There was no way out.

When Lonnie left, and Adora was on her own again, something new happened.

Adora experienced her first ever panic attack.

Present day

Adora was overthinking it.

It was, perhaps, one tease too far, and she found it too coincidental that Catra immediately needed to excuse herself – outside – for a smoking break.

She had probably scared her away. Maybe Catra had done a runner and wasn’t coming back. The thought of it, screwing up their friendship yet again, made her skin crawl. Why was she like this? Why did her mouth always run away with her?

There was only one thing for it. Adora wasn’t going to lose her again.

She downed her drink and headed outside after Catra.

It was a dry November night, and the breeze left a soft kiss against her skin. She took a moment to breathe it in, calm her nerves. There was a hint of cigarette smoke in the air, which she assumed was Catra. Walking down the left side of the street first, she tried to follow it. A rowdy group of men were across the street at the opposite pub, and Adora purposefully avoided looking

in their direction. Just as she was about to turn back, she stopped to smell where the cigarette smoke was coming from again.

And that's when she heard it.

"I'm giving you one last chance to fuck off, big guy, or you're going to regret it."

"What am I doing wrong? I'm just being friendly."

Adora didn't know that voice, and she doubted Catra did either. She skipped a few broken paving stones and hurled towards the corner of the building.

Catra was leaning against the brick wall of the cocktail bar, hands in her pockets and angled away from the brute of a man, who was standing uncomfortably close to her. Both swivelled around when they saw Adora skid into the alley, slightly out of breath. The man raised his eyebrows but didn't step back.

"Everything okay?" Adora asked.

"Would be better if this shithead left me alone," Catra retorted.

He laughed. "Someone's touchy. Is it a crime to talk to someone now?"

"No, but it's a bit creepy to get in someone's personal space when they're clearly not interested," Adora said, reaching out to grab Catra's arm. "Come on," she said to her. "Let's go."

They'd barely walked a few paces when they heard, "What are you, a couple of dykes?"

"Keep walking," Catra hissed.

But Adora had already slowed down.

She sensed it was going to happen before it did.

The brute man lunged after them, and Adora eyed what was presumably a group of his friends across the street. She spun around as he lunged, her fist flying out, smacking him across the face. Adora and the man both cried out; Adora's hand crunched, and a pain shot up her arm as she spotted blood flying from the man's nose.

There was a two second pause, and Catra stared, unmoving, as the man shouted, "You little bitch –"

And threw himself at Adora.

A few years ago, Adora would've been able to take him. Now, however, one side of her body was weak, and her muscles weren't as strong as the used to be. She toppled over as soon as he collided with her, and her whole body slapped against the pavement. Her mind was blank, and she didn't know what to do. The man was grabbing her by the front of her top and trying to shake her. Just as his arm swung up into the air, the weight of him left Adora's body.

Catra had him in a headlock.

She used her knee to kick him in the stomach, and when he doubled over, she kicked him again, sending him to the ground beside Adora.

His friends from across the street started to yell, and a few of them ran over. For a moment, Adora thought the worst, but they went straight for the man. They picked him up, separated him from Catra, and removed him from the scene.

"Sorry about him," one of them said. "He's an angry drunk."

"He's a fucking lunatic," Catra snarled, leaning down over Adora. "Get him the fuck away from us."

Adora wasn't sure if she was more shaken or embarrassed. Catra helped her up, cautious of her sore hip, and held onto her arms for support. Somewhere in the distance, the

brute man was arguing with his friends and shouting at the cocktail bar's bouncer. Once she was back on her feet, Adora tried to collect her breathing. She leaned against the wall and absent-mindedly held Catra's hand, avoiding all eye contact.

"What the fuck, Adora," Catra reprimanded, breathing heavily. "What are you doing picking a fight with a guy double your size?"

"He was intimidating you," Adora wheezed.

She looked up, then, to gauge Catra's reaction. The brunette looked frazzled; her hair was coming out of its ponytail and her jacket was askew. Her eyes were wide and she looked both angry and exasperated.

"Sorry," Adora added. "And thanks. For, you know, whatever that was."

"Saving you," Catra said, wearing the smallest, most irritated smirk. "Again."

Adora was trying to smile but she couldn't. Her hand was killing her. She tried to flex her fingers, but the white-hot flashes of pain it sent to her wrist made her wince. Both women looked down at it the same time, and then Catra groaned.

"Your hand – are you alright?"

Adora lifted it so they could both see. Her knuckles were bruised and grazed with blood. Catra held onto her arm and squeezed it tight.

"I think it's just bruised," Adora said, looking quickly away. She couldn't stomach injuries like she used to.

"That looks like a boxer's fracture to me," Catra said quietly. "Look at your pinky finger."

Adora was trying not to. It looked like it was in a weird angle. "I can't go to the hospital," she whined. "Don't make me go to the

hospital.”

A shadow of recognition crossed Catra’s face. Still holding on, she said, “They still freak you out too, huh?”

Adora bit her lip and nodded.

“There’s an all-night clinic across town,” Catra pointed out. “They’re supposed to help drunk people, but I’m sure they’d be able to fix you up.”

Adora struggled with herself, but it was no use. Catra was already pulling on her good hand and getting out her phone to call a taxi. Allowing herself to be led, Adora felt a bone-deep warmth spread over her. A part of her that she thought she'd lost forever - a little section of her heart that was permanently scarred - was starting to heal. She felt full; whole, for the first time in years.

It was because of Catra. It had always been Catra.

And it always would be.

Chapter End Notes

> This wrote this chapter in no time because I received a lovely flow of comments all week and it just made me really excited to get to the good plot stuff. Thank you to everyone who commented, it gave me something to look forward to.
>
> Next time: in the present, it's Christmas and Brightmoon's Open Day. In the past, Catra and Adora are reunited at the honours ceremony... In other words, it's sinfully cheesy and terribly heartbreaking all in equal measures. (And there's a kiss, tell no one.)
>
> Hopefully I can update at the same time next week, thanks for reading!
>
> Stay safe,

Cx.

For Good

Chapter Summary

Warning for super cheesy fluff.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Present day

After many stressful weeks and countless hours of overtime, it was finally the Open Day for Brightmoon School. *Wicked the musical* by BM Theatre Group was the star of the show and happening at three o'clock, if everything went according to plan. After it was all wrapped up, the staff were going to their Christmas drinks and karaoke event, and Catra wasn't sure what she was more excited for – finally having this stupid play over with, or seeing the staff humiliate themselves in front of a mic.

One of the most surprisingly things, however, was that DT had somewhat grown on her. The Drama teacher was surprisingly funny in a sinister way, and never failed to be witty and observant about other staff members.

"Where's our Elphaba?" they screeched, clapping their hands at the students running around backstage. "She's needed in make-up in" – they checked their watch – "five minutes ago." To Catra, they muttered, "There's a reason why they tell you never to work with animals or children."

"Most of us are sixteen or seventeen," pointed out Simon, who Catra also knew from MMA class. He was acting Angry Civilian 2. "And what are you? Like, forty-something?"

DT's gasp was so dramatic that everyone turned around. With a hand on their chest, they said, "Forty-something? Dear god, the audacity!"

Catra was trying to hide a snigger behind her hand. She recovered herself by pointedly scratching her face and deflecting. "Alright, Simon, before you send DT into an early mid-life crisis, can you tell us where Elphaba – I mean, Gabby is?"

Simon looked away, catching the eye of his friend, Parker. With a huge smile on his face, Parker said, "Gabby is making out with Kenzo in the prop storage."

"Kenzo?" DT blinked, smirking at this revelation. "Kenzo playing the Wizard? Dearie me, this *is* good gossip."

"I thought Kenzo had a crush on Glinda – I mean Alex?" Catra whispered, occupying herself with setting up the last light stand.

DT shook their head. "No – Glinda came out last week as bi, and has apparently been spotted on Instagram with Lauren."

Catra raised an eyebrow. "Lauren who's in my poetry class?"

DT crossed their arms. "*Mhm*. They've been having an on-and-off thing for a few years. It's your classic 'will they or won't they' situation – but you'd know all about that, wouldn't you, Adora?"

Catra nearly jumped out of her skin when she spotted Adora walking towards them, holding a box of donuts. Looking like she'd been caught doing something she shouldn't, she gaped and stayed perfectly still. "Uh – sorry, what do I know about?"

"Lauren and Alex," DT said.

Adora blinked a few times. "Oh! Oh yeah. They're both in my form group. But, what about them?"

"Ugh, it doesn't matter. You've never been into the student gossip. Catra knows what I mean." DT waved their hand, dismissing it altogether. Catra glared at them, knowing full well what they were trying to imply. DT asked instead, "What – or who – brings you here?"

“I brought donuts for sustenance,” Adora said, gesturing to the large box.

“How is it out there?” Catra asked, taking the box from her. She nodded to the world beyond the stage.

“The Open Day?” Adora sighed. “It’s the same as it always it – pushy parents, annoying prospective students, and a whole lot of small talk. Which, you know, I’m not good at. Glimmer always puts me in the background somewhere to blend in and stay out of trouble.” She shrugged. “Besides, most people visit the Art department to look at the art, not the teachers.”

“Another reason why the principal keeps you under wraps,” DT replied, wigging their eyebrows. “It’s hard not to look at the gorgeous ex-war hero we have hidden away behind the canvases.”

Adora bit her lip and looked away. Catra, smiling fondly, squeezed her arm. “Hey, Adora’s a lot more than something to look at. She can also do things like…” Catra pretended to struggle to think of something. “Punch things.”

Adora held up her right hand, which was still in a cast from the bad punch outside the cocktail bar. She had broken a few knuckles and her pinky finger, and Catra had done nothing but tease her about it ever since.

“You’re both still coming to Christmas Karaoke Night, right?” DT said, pointing at them. “Or do I have to bully some more people?”

“Yeah, yeah, we’re going,” Adora answered, brushing them off.

Before she went away, Catra held out her arm to stop her. “You’ll be able to see the show later, won’t you?”

Adora smiled. Squeezing Catra’s wrist, she said, “Of course. I know how much it means to you. I’ll be there.”

Catra watched as she walked away, unaware that she was still holding the large light stand. She put it back and turned to see DT

grinning like a maniac.

"I've never seen something so pathetic," they said.

Catra glared. "Shut up."

"The pining – the little touches – the visible *longing* –"

Another reason why Catra kept DT close?

They could see right through her.

Twenty-one years old

The Honours Ceremony

It was five months since the Heart of Etheria project.

Adora's back had healed, and she was finally out of the wheelchair. With crutches, she could walk around a hundred metres before her lungs started to ache and she had to stop to breathe. There were times she was so frustrated at how weak she felt that all she could do was cry. On good days, the frustration led to success, but they were rarer and annoyingly short-lived.

The red slash that adorned her left cheek had faded to a dark pink, matching the colour of the scars on her back. The left side of her body was slower and more painful than the right – on some days, her hip completely froze up and refused to cooperate. The scar from the surgery to remove the bullet was ugly, and she hated it.

Out of everything, however, Adora hated the scar of the failsafe on her chest the most of all.

It was still a dark red – branded onto her skin like a sign over ownership. It no longer glowed pale pink or blue, and it hadn't since she had inserted herself into the transmitter. Every morning, Adora would wake up and see it peeking over the top of her tank

top. She would stare at it, unable to look away. She would think about life before the failsafe and the She-Ra experiment, and she would think of where she would be without it in her life.

And then she would take a hot, burning shower, doing anything she could to feel clean again.

Adora sighed as she did the top button of her blouse. It was the day of the public honours ceremony celebrating the achievement of the HOE team. Adora was required to wear the ceremonial uniform of the Etherian Army – a blue blouse and tie, paired with bottle green blazer and trousers for the Special Forces division. Her hair was tied back in its signature ponytail, and she had a cap with a feather waiting for her in the lounge.

When she had joined the army, Adora dreamed of a day like this – a public celebration of her achievement, her place in the ending of the war. Some soldiers never had the honour of wearing the ceremonial uniform. It was a big deal, and she couldn't be *less* excited about it.

All she could do was stare at her reflection in the mirror and grip the edges of the sink to stop her hands from shaking.

Today was the first time in five months that she would see Catra.

She hadn't seen Catra *at all* since the Arms factory.

And there was so much she needed to say.

Adora had a feeling in her gut – a bad feeling that made her dry heave in the toilet. It was the sense that it was now or never. If she didn't say what she needed to now, she never would. Catra would be out of her life forever.

That couldn't happen. Adora would do anything in her power to apologise. To put this *right*.

Tap. Tap. Tap.

“Corporal, they’re ready for you in the lounge.”

Adora cringed. She gave one last look in the mirror to make sure her hair was still neat, and then reached for her crutches.

It wasn’t a long walk from her hotel room to the lounge. The room was set up with two sofas and a table full of snacks. Two ceremonial peaked caps waited on the coffee table; one for Adora and one for Catra.

Adora couldn’t sit because of the nerves. She leaned her crutches against the wall and propped herself up against the coffee table. Her fingers stroked the long blue feather on the cap, and her stomach squeezed with something soft and frightful.

Where was Catra?

What if she didn’t show up?

As it happened, Adora didn’t particularly want this either. She felt like a fraud accepting honours on behalf of a team that had died for the mission when she was *also* not meant to survive. Not to mention the thought of cameras watching them made her skin crawl. *Catra would hate this*, she thought to herself. If they were still on speaking terms, Catra would’ve ranted and moaned about the excess and attention – glorifying sacrifice in the name of war.

Just as she picked up one of the caps and clenched it between her fingers, the lounge door opened.

Catra.

Adora couldn’t tear her eyes away. Catra looked the perfect silhouette in her uniform, all sharp edges and slim build. Her hair was short and flicked to one side and her skin was radiant. She looked great – almost untouched by the recent events.

Apart from her eyes.

Dark shadows lingered underneath Catra's eyes, and as they swept the room, they focused on everything except from Adora. Her lips then pulled into a grimace as she spotted the feathered caps.

That was not a happy face, and Adora hadn't expected it to be any different. A twinge of guilt and self-loathing clawed at her stomach; she knew how Catra was to people she didn't like, and she knew what to expect. It didn't make it any easier that it was now directed at Adora. *I just hope I can get through to her. I hope she hasn't blocked me out completely.*

Catra approached to pick up her cap, and Adora felt her whole body recoil. It was as if Adora wasn't there, the way her old friend walked past her without so much as a blink in her direction. It hurt. Worse than that, it burned. With her voice cracking and her heart leaping out of her chest, Adora blurted, "Catra, I'm sorry."

The brunette stopped. She met Adora's eyes for a nanosecond, and then she looked away again. Her nose gave the smallest of twitches.

"I'm so, so sorry," Adora went on. The flood gates had opened and there was no going back. Everything she had wanted to say, everything that she had been holding onto, gushed out of her mouth. "I'm sorry. I didn't mean to hurt you. I never wanted to hurt you." Adora paused, searching for a trace of Catra's reaction. When a muscle in her jaw clenched, Adora continued, "I can understand why you hate me, I can understand if you feel betrayed, but I just wanted to do the right thing." When Catra reached for the cap without so much as a side-glance, Adora tried to extend a hand towards her, saying, "I'll do anything for you to forgive me – I'll do anything to make you see –"

"Get off me." Catra flinched away so dramatically that Adora stopped talking altogether. Catra looked her up and down, wearing a look of pure disgust. All Adora could do was stare, her mouth slightly open.

“Corporal Greyskull, Corporal Areli? They’re ready for you.”

Without acknowledging her in the slightest, Catra placed the peaked cap on her head and stalked off to the exit.

Adora’s throat was dry. With her hands shaking and her lip wobbling, she placed the cap on her head and supported herself on her crutches. She followed Catra towards the tunnel that led to the stage, with heart sinking further to ground with every dragged footstep. The look on Catra’s face – utter *contempt* and pure *hatred*. It scorched its way through Adora’s skin and made her feel warm and flustered. The band holding Adora together contracted, almost snapping.

Maybe this *was* unfixable.

Maybe this really was the end of them.

Present day

The show was a resounding success.

A large crowd had gathered for the performance, and as she watched the play, and the audience reactions to it, Adora felt very proud.

Catra and DT had done a fabulous job putting it all together. And despite minor mistakes (music starting too early, and some wrong lines by side-characters) it all went according to plan.

The crowd gave a standing ovation at the end, and after the actors had their fair share of the glory, Catra and DT stood on the stage hand-in-hand, giving exaggerated bows. Adora whooped the loudest, much to Catra’s dismay. In retaliation, DT called Adora onto the stage to congratulate her on behalf of the Art department for creating such fantastic set pieces.

Glimmer dragged Adora onto the stage and a few people laughed at her obvious embarrassment. In the middle of the final

applause, Catra looked at her with shining eyes and a mischievous smile on her lips.

And then Adora had a terrible thought.

I'll miss this.

With the army start date growing ever closer, she was trying to seize any opportunity to be happy that she could. After she re-enlisted, it felt like her life would be over. Happy memories would be all she would have left.

And with her arm around Catra, laughing and smiling, Adora realised she would *definitely* miss this.

Twenty-one years old

The Honours Ceremony

Catra couldn't keep still.

She was sitting in the front row with her superiors on the left side and Adora on her immediate right. On stage, Colonel Hope spoke to the audience and the cameras about bravery and sacrifice, and the cost the army had suffered over the last thirty years in defeating the threat to Etheria.

It was all bullshit. Every single word.

Catra didn't want to be here. This was the last place she wanted to be. How did all this pomp make up for the death of colleagues, her sleepless nights, or her broken heart? It didn't. It was insulting. It was offensive.

And then there was the issue of Adora.

The worst part of all this was Adora.

Over the last five months, Catra's bitter resentment – her *hatred* – had done nothing but grow.

Adora was the source of her sleepless nights. Adora was the cause of her night terrors. Adora was the reason why that when she cried, she sobbed so hard that she had to gasp through the tears.

She couldn't give a shit what her ex-best friend had to say. Hatred, bright and beautiful and destructive, coloured most of Catra's vision. The sooner she forgot about Adora – the sooner she closed the door on that part of her life forever, the sooner she would be free.

Sitting there, listening to meaningless words beside someone who made her *burn* with resentment, Catra was doing everything in her power to not lash out. All those years she had wasted being a friend to Adora – all those memories that she once held so close to her heart – all those soft feelings Adora had caused her to feel – they pierced her skin like needles and injected her with venom.

"And now, I would like to call up Corporal Adora Greyskull and Corporal Catra Areli to the stage to receive their honours."

A camera trailed low from the ceiling to follow them, and it was – predictably – only following Adora. All the media attention focused entirely on Adora. Catra was barely mentioned because, technically, she had never finished the mission. She was knocked unconscious thanks to her supposed best friend. No, the pundits and the journalists only had an appetite for the hero of the hour – the person who had risked it all for glory.

And that was all Adora cared about, wasn't it?

Glory.

Being a hero.

She was probably having *the best* time right now.

Speaking of which, Adora was having trouble getting out of her chair. Catra went on without her to take her place centre-left on the stage. As she straightened up and looked ahead, she saw Adora, stubbornly and stupidly, leaving her crutches behind. She staggered up to the stage, waving off anyone who tried to help her.

Clutching her side, and out of breath, Adora took her place beside Catra, and a round of applause exploded in the room.

Catra *seethed*.

Colonel Hope attached a large gold-plated star on the lapel of Catra's blazer. With her palms sweaty and her legs shaking with nerves, all Catra could do was nod in response. Curiosity got the best of her, and she looked to the side as Hope attached the same medal to Adora.

Adora, who was staring right back at her.

Catra met her gaze, and a for a moment, the entire room fell away.

Adora didn't look herself. She looked sick; her skin was tinged grey, and the large scar running down the side of her left cheek obscured her sense of familiarity. But her eyes, so blue and so hopeful and so sad, pierced through Catra's stone heart.

A small voice in her head whispered: *you should've been there.*

Catra cleared her throat and looked away. Her hand turned into a fist at her side.

As the cameras followed the military marching procession to salute the two honoured soldiers, Adora leaned over to whisper, "Catra, *please*. We need to talk."

"Adora, *don't*," she muttered, her words shooting like bullets.

Colonel Hope stood in between them as they watched the march. Catra was poised; she was rocking on her toes, ready to take off when the time was right. She couldn't stand here much longer, looking at Adora's fragility and basking in celebration of other people's sacrifice.

The ceremony ended with fireworks and another applause from the audience. Colonel Hope led them off the stage but stopped short of the green room to talk to reporters. Catra side-stepped all of them, eager to disappear – desperate to get away.

And then she heard Adora's voice calling her;

"Catra – Catra – please, *just listen* –"

They were halfway into the lounge. Adora hobbling without her crutches, reached for Catra's arm.

Catra jumped away as if her touched burned.

Adora stumbled, and held onto the threshold for support. Her wide eyes pleaded silently, and all Catra could do was hold her breath to stop the fury from erupting from her lips.

"No," she snapped. She took off her cap and threw it across the room. "I don't want to hear what you have to say. I don't give a *shit* what you have to say."

Just as she turned to leave, Adora said so gently, "I miss you."

Catra stood very still. She turned back again; her head titled. She couldn't look away from Adora's blue eyes. "Yeah?" she said, breathless, as she felt the spark inside her turn to a flame. "That's funny. How about you listen for once? We're done." Catra stopped in front of her, unable to control the wildfire in her heart. "We're finished. I did some thinking while you've been out of my life, and you know what I realised? *You've* been what's wrong with me. I am so much better off without you. I don't need you. I've never needed you. And I *never will*. You've always been there, doing nothing but drag me down my entire fucking life." She smiled in

spite of herself because this was it – every resenting thought, every bitter feeling was pouring out, and with every tremor of Adora's lips she felt oddly satisfied.

This was it done. There was no turning back. Catra was setting fire to anything that was salvageable between them. She went on, twisting the knife, "You know what, Adora? You're not worth it. I will never fucking forgive you for what you did. *Never*. I want nothing to do with you for as long as I live." As she let out the breath she was holding, Catra heard her own voice shake. "Now, leave me the fuck alone."

That face Adora was wearing – with the wide teary eyes, the painful grimace, the eyebrows pulled together in concentration, would forever be ingrained in Catra's mind. She stepped past Adora, desperate to flee back home, already feeling claws of guilt gripping her.

"Catra," Adora squeaked, fully crying now. "I'm sorry."

She couldn't look back. She didn't have the strength.

She was *so* tired.

"Fuck you, Adora," Catra muttered, and continued her way into a new chapter of her life.

Completely Adora-free.

Present day

Once the Open Day was wrapped up, the teaching staff of Brightmoon School had a small dinner before heading to their Christmas party.

Glimmer had hired a karaoke bar in the middle of Salineas, which they apparently did every year, to have a singing competition and a few drinks. Catra was reluctant to call this a good idea; usually Christmas parties ended with someone crying or someone

fighting, no in between. Adding a competition in the mix seemed like asking for trouble.

Adora was wearing a stupid Santa hat and had decorated her hand cast with red tinsel. Catra couldn't stop staring. She hadn't seen Adora this relaxed in a while – it was as if she had finally made peace with something. It was nice.

It also made Catra's heart squeeze with *want*.

How nice would it be to have Adora? To have her around, in her space, taking up a permanent place in her heart? Ugh, she felt *pathetic* just thinking about it.

Adora, however, had never wanted her in the same way. Whatever they were when they were teenagers, and whatever they were now, meant something different to Adora. Catra had accepted that a long time ago. If Adora felt any differently, she had plenty of opportunities to come clean.

But that would never happen.

So, in an attempt to stop her pathetic pining, as DT had called it, Catra downed another rum and coke and sat back to watch the terrible karaoke performances she was being subjected to.

While Bow and Glimmer argued over whether they wanted solo performances or a duet (Bow wanted to sing *Breaking Free* from High School the Musical with his girlfriend, while Glimmer wanted to sing a solo of *Look What You Made Me Do* by Taylor Swift), Mermista and Sea Hawk were performing on the small stage *Killing in the Name*by Rage Against the Machine.

Sea Hawk, somehow, was trying to turn it into a sea shanty as Mermista headbanged against the amp during the guitar solo.

"This is weird," Catra muttered, looking from Glimmer and Bow arguing to Mermista and Sea Hawk yelling into their mics.

"I think you mean fun," Adora corrected, looking far too smug. "I've gotten a pretty good collection of blackmail material from Glimmer's performances through the years."

"Blackmail?" Catra nodded, considering it. "I'm impressed."

"Every year it's a different Taylor Swift song," Adora explained, sounding unamused. Leaning against the back of the chair, she asked, "So, what are you going to sing?"

"Oh no." Catra adamantly shook her head. "You know I don't sing anymore."

"*Catra*," Adora whined.

Raising her eyebrows in a silent challenge, Catra said, "Go on then, princess, what have you performed in the past?"

Adora quickly looked away. After taking a drink, she shrugged. "I don't. You know I'm not the best singer."

"But it's a competiton! I thought you were unable to resist –"

Catra was drowned out by loud cheering, signalling the end of Mermista and Sea Hawk's performance. DT took away their mics, looking a little distressed. They clapped with the base of their hands and did a little flourish on the stage. "An interesting duet. I'm just glad we're all teachers and not police officers. Next on the agenda, we have another duet." A chorus of 'ooohs' sounded around the room. "So, Adora and Catra, if you want to make your way to the front."

"What?!" they both yelled at the same time.

DT smiled through their teeth. "I thought we could do a rendition from Wicked to celebrate all the hard work we put into the play," they said, leaving no room for arguments. When Catra opened her mouth to argue, DT held up a finger. "Ah, ah. I don't want to hear it. I've heard Catra is an *excellent* singer and I've been looking forward to this for *months*."

Catra refused to move. She couldn't sing in front of everyone! She'd only been teaching at Brightmoon for four months – she barely knew anyone other than Adora and DT. It was embarrassing. Actually, scratch that, this was systematic *bullying* –

"Cat, come on," Adora said, tugging at her wrist. "It's okay. We'll do it together."

Catra glared at DT. She was going to kill them. But a few of the teachers were staring, and Perfuma was doing a stupid little air fist pump to encourage her, and in the end, Catra sighed.

"Fine," she said, allowing herself to be led.

Everyone started to clap, and Glimmer even wooed them from the side of the stage. Once in the spotlight, Catra caught sight of how red Adora's cheeks were as she anxiously pulled on the hem of her Christmas jumper. DT handed them a mic each, and as they winked at her, Catra made a decision.

If this was a competiton, she was going to ensure that they win.

DT sat in front of the sound system and said, "I think you both know the lyrics to this one."

"Is it *Defying Gravity*?" Adora asked, swaying from foot to foot. "It's not really a big duet, so I won't have much to –"

"No, oh no," DT said, looking like the cat that had got the cream. "We've had enough loud, angsty songs so far. It's time to take it down a notch with a ballad." There was a glint to their eyes. "Adora, you're Glinda. Catra, you're Elphaba. And off we go."

And without further ado, the piano instrumental to *For Good* started to play.

Catra glared at the floor and, without exaggerating, wished for a merciful death.

For Good was Catra's favourite song of the whole show, and it was one that always had a special place in her heart. When she was younger she would imagine herself singing it to Adora, in a very similar situation to this one. She swallowed and fondled the wire of the mic, willing herself to get through this would making a fool of herself.

The crowd hushed themselves. Catra's hands shook.

DT counted Adora in with three nods of their head.

Clearing her throat, wide-eyed and shaking, Adora started to sing.

I've heard it said that people come into our lives for a reason

Bringing something we must learn

Catra's eyes shot up, surprised at how good she sounded. Her voice trembled, and she stumbled over the first few words, but the pitch and tone were almost note-perfect.

And we are led to those who help us most to grow, if we let them

And we help them in return

Adora looked to Catra, full of uncertainty.

Well, I don't know if I believe that's true

But I know I'm who I am today because I knew you

As Adora sang the chorus, Catra took a moment to stare at the crowd. Bow and Glimmer were clutching each other with tissues in their hands. Perfuma was standing at the bar, swaying along with the tune. Catra tried to concentrate. Her part was coming up next, and she barely felt capable of breathing, never mind singing. Adora's part was coming to an end, and with a mischevious smile, she sang to Catra:

Who can say if I've been changed for the better?

But because I knew you

I have been changed for good

A short piano break gave them breathing room. Catra counted herself in, and as she started singing her verse, she met Adora's gaze.

She was singing to *her*, after all. These words weren't hers, but she felt them.

It well may be that we will never meet again in this lifetime

So, let me say before we part

So much of me is made of what I learned from you

You'll be with me like a handprint on my heart

Catra's throat gave an unexpected croak, but feeling encouraged by the softness of Adora's face, she sang the next part with fervour.

And now whatever way our stories end

I know you have rewritten mine by being my friend

The audience cheered at Catra's strong note. Smiling – genuinely, this time – Catra sang the chorus as if this was her shining moment – as if she was the star of the show, acting the role she had always dreamed of acting.

Alongside the person she wanted more than anyone else.

She was unstoppable, and her heart soared with the truth she felt in the lyrics.

The piano and strings increased in intensity as they went into the bridge. Catra wasn't sure when it happened, but she was right beside Adora now, who was holding out her hand for Catra to hold. She took it and clenched it tight, singing:

And just to clear the air

I ask forgiveness for the things I've done, you blame me for

Adora held on painfully tight, and her voice wobbled as she echoed:

But, then, I guess we know there's blame to share

And then they sang together:

And none of it seems to matter anymore

They sang the chorus in harmony. Catra matched Adora's highs, and Adora matched Catra's lows, succinctly in sync. They were standing so close together, as if the music was drawing them in like a magnet. Catra, with her hand in Adora's hand, only inches separating them. She could see the flecks of mascara on Adora's lashes. She could see the thick grey rim on her blue iris. She could feel her breath on her face.

Who can say if I've been changed for the better?

I do *believe that I've been changed for the better*, they sang.

And because I knew you, Adora injected in a whisper.

And because I knew you, Catra replied, equally as expectant.

Then they sang together, stretching the last word:

I have been changed

There was a natural breath in the song.

Catra forgot how to think. Her voice died in her throat. It felt like a string was pulling her in and she couldn't fight against it. Her lips were centimetres away from Adora's, and Adora was staring at her as if she was seeing her for the first time.

Her eyes were so rounded, and they flicked down to Catra's lips.

"For good," Adora said, forgoing the mic completely, and speaking it directly to Catra.

The room faded out and there was only the two of them in the middle of the world. The cheers and catcalls went unnoticed. Catra could only see Adora's lips as she inched forward, and she could only feel the radiating warmth of Adora's body so close to hers –

"Wow! What a performance!" DT said, clapping as they walked towards the stage.

And that was it – the spell was broken.

Adora jumped away, her cheeks flushing as she practically threw the mic at DT. Meanwhile, Catra stood there, stock still, unable to process what had just happened.

"I'm not sure if I feel jealous or flustered," DT went on, using Adora's mic now. "How can anyone follow *that*performance?!"

"I CAN," Glimmer yelled, pushing through the chairs to make her way to the stage. "Sure, they have sex appeal, but *I* have Taylor Swift." She snatched Catra's mic from her hands. "DT, play it."

As Bow shouted, "Why do you only like break up songs when we're in a long-term relationship?!" reality caught up with Catra.

They had almost kissed.

And it wasn't one-sided. The song – the tension – the longing, it was in *both* of them.

Catra's thoughts whirled as she put the jigsaw together.

Did Adora…?

Where was she?

Catra stumbled off the stage, glancing wildly around. When she passed the sound system, DT said, "Hey, kitten. She went outside." They winked. "Go get her."

Twenty-one years old

The Honours Ceremony

After a briefing with the press office, Adora retreated to her room.

The army seemed *very* concerned with the public interest in her. She wasn't allowed to speak to journalists without a representative, and she assumed it was in case she accidentally let something slip about the confidential She-Ra project.

Adora had no interest in the media or attention of any kind.

She barely had the strength to have interest in herself.

Sitting at the foot of her bed, she stared at the honours award and considered if it was all worth it.

At the cost of her heart breaking, she had saved Etheria. That was a fair price, considering the death toll and general destruction the Horde had caused.

But it didn't *feel* fair.

It didn't feel fair at all.

Adora cried until she had no tears left. She cried for Catra, she cried for Mara and the rest of her team, and she cried for herself.

Was her future destined to be this – to be an experiment for the military? To be forever bound to an agreement she was coerced into signing?

And along the way, all she would do was hurt people and disappoint them.

She'd done what she wanted to – she'd saved everyone.

Catra was alive. She hated her, but she was alive. And she would be okay. As she said earlier, Catra had never needed her.

So, where did Adora go from here?

Colonel Hope had made it clear that she had little choice for the next three years. Anything could happen in that time – and with no war left to fight, what would they be using her for?

Adora didn't want to be a tool anymore.

Adora wanted to be free.

She wanted to want something for herself.

No matter the consequence.

Present day

Catra found her sitting on the steps outside.

"Hey, Adora," she said, clearing her throat as she sat on the step beside her. "I think we need to – wait, are you crying?"

Over the years, Catra had only seen Adora cry a handful of times. Even when they were kids, and she was sick or hurt, Adora never shed a tear. Unsure of what to do, Catra wiped her hands on her jeans and took a big breath to calm herself. She watched as the tears freely flowed down Adora's pink cheeks and how she angrily wiped at her eyes with the back of her good hand.

"Sorry," she said, voice shaking. "I didn't mean – I got carried away. Sometimes I want" – her blue eyes flicked towards Catra and away again – "*things* I can't have. It's stupid of me."

Catra's heart was beating so intensely that it echoed in her head. She thought back to the song and how Adora had looked at her in

a way she had only ever dreamed of.

So soft and hopeful and *wanting*.

With wide, unblinking eyes, Catra asked, "What… things?"

Adora shook her head and wiped the tears from her cheeks again.

Catra was doing her best to be patient and to think this through properly. All her life she had assumed Adora didn't want her in the same way. Adora had never implied that she wanted anything more than a friendship with Catra. Even after the kiss in the Arms factory, she had the chance to say that it was something more – something other than 'oh shit, we're both going to die here.'

No, instead Adora said she had kissed Catra because she *wanted* to.

Adora had a problem wanting things.

Especially things she couldn't have.

Did she think that she somehow couldn't have Catra?

Why?

Of course Adora could have her; Catra's heart was Adora's to give or take as she pleased, and that was the way it had always been.

Catra placed a hand on Adora's shoulder. Closing her eyes with a silent wince, she tried to hype herself up for this conversation. It wasn't going to be easy, but *one* of them had to come clean. They couldn't do this forever.

"Adora, we need to talk," she said, feigning calm. Inside, she felt like a tornado was whipping around her organs. "I think we need to – uh, discuss how we feel. Discuss what we want."

Hiccupping a sob, Adora pushed her hand away. As she turned to face her, the blonde's face was a painful mixture of hurt and

anger. “Catra, *please*. You don’t know what you’re saying –”

“No, I do.” Doing her best to control the urge to deflect and get defensive, she chewed the inside of her cheek before saying, “I know what I want, and I know what I’ve wanted for a long time. I’ve been honest.” She paused. "But I don’t think you have been.”

“I can’t.” Adora paused, trying to regain control of her emotions. “I don’t deserve it. You shouldn’t want anything to do with me. I’m no good for you. You said it yourself a while ago. And you were right.”

Catra frowned. Was Adora still holding onto the Heart of Etheria project? It didn’t make sense. Hadn’t they gotten past that already?

Why would Catra walk away again? Someone would have to *drag* her away at this point. “That’s not true,” she argued. “I didn’t mean it back then, and besides, we’ve changed. We’ve grown up. It’s different now –”

Adora met her gaze, saying, “It won’t end well –”

But Catra had had enough. She grabbed Adora’s good hand and held it tight. Meeting her watery blue eyes, and refusing to look away, she said, “Don’t you get it? You mean the world to me, Adora. You always have. Even during our time apart over the last five years.” As Adora’s breath rattled, Catra held her closer. “I tried my best to hate you, and for a while I thought I did. But you’ve been back in my life for what feels like five minutes and I’m falling for you all over again.”

Adora blinked once. Her head gave the smallest shake, as if she couldn’t believe what she was hearing. “You… want me? After everything?”

Catra nodded. With a smile, she pushed down the emotion bubbling in her throat. *Stay cool,* she told herself. *Hold it together*. “It’s like I said – we’ve grown up. There’s always been something in our way, and I don’t blame you for that. Not anymore.” She

glanced down at their joined hands. “I understand if I’ve misinterpreted – or if you don’t feel the same –”

Adora tilted Catra’s chin up with her cast-covered hand. Her smile was cautious, but sincere. “I want you too. I always have, even when I didn’t know it.”

Catra’s heart nearly burst. She laughed, properly laughed. She couldn’t believe it – it was too good to be true –

But then Adora tugged on her shirt collar and brought her back to earth. “But, Catra, listen – I’ve never really left the army behind. It’s still… in me.” Her lips crumpled. “And I don’t know how to break free from it. I don’t think I can, and I don’t want to drag you down with me.” Very quietly, she murmured, “I never want to hurt you again.”

Catra nodded slowly. She assumed she knew what Adora meant – after all, she was also hung up with PTSD from their time in the military. It was hard to separate the past from the present sometimes. But it wouldn’t always be this bad, or this fresh – she was certain of that. And if they had each other, if they fought it together, they would be unstoppable.

“We could be free, if you wanted,” Catra said, watching Adora closely. “We could start again and completely leave our past behind. Forget the army and Weaver and our childhood. We’ll no longer be Corporal Greyskull and Corporal Areli. We can be just Adora and Catra. We can let ourselves want, let ourselves have. Then, we could have each other.”

Catra wrapped an arm around Adora’s shoulders. The blonde placed her head on Catra’s chest and held on as if her life depended on it. “How do I let myself want this?” she muttered.

Oh, Adora.

Adora with her stupid face and her stupid morals and her guilt for choosing anything remotely selfish.

“Why don’t you try taking it?” Catra challenged.

Adora looked up.

And Catra, praying to the stars, leaned down and captured her lips in her own.

Let this work, she wished. *Please, let this work out.*

Adora’s lips were soft and warm, and for a moment Catra was lost in the bedazzlement of shock and victory. When she felt Adora’s hand grip the nape of her neck and pull her closer, she was lost in a personal heaven. Catra, with a hand in the silky strands of Adora’s hair, brushed a thumb over the scar running down her cheek. Adora sighed, and the sound sent a flood of heat through Catra’s stomach.

Just as she pushed closer, desperate to feel as much of Adora against her as possible, the door to the bar creaked open, and the two women jumped away from one another as if someone had electrocuted them.

The echoes of Bow singing *Teenage Dirtbag* drifted out into the street, as did the bitter smell of smoke coming from a disgruntled Mermista’s blunt. She glanced between Catra and Adora, and, raising her eyebrows, drawled, “Don’t stop because of me.”

Growling, Catra grabbed Adora’s hand and helped her up from the step. As they walked past, Mermista snarked, “The bathroom here is a good place to make out, if you’re interested.”

“And how would you know?” Catra asked, still holding Adora’s hand.

Sea Hawk, in all his drunken glory, stumbled outside with his hair looking severely tousled. “My dear Mermista,” he called. “I was waiting for you in the bathroom.”

Catra and Mermista glanced at one another.

A mutual understanding passed between them.

“Not a word,” Mermista warned.

Catra, smugly wrapping an arm around Adora’s waist, replied, “Likewise.”

When the back door closed, the two women were left alone in the dark corridor. Catra stretched up to reposition the Santa hat on Adora’s head. The blonde, chewing on her lip, gripped onto the loophole of Catra’s jeans.

“Catra, listen –”

Catra put a finger against her lips. “Adora, be honest with me. Do you want… this?”

Do you want me like you said you did?

If you want me in the way I want you, then this shouldn’t be difficult. This should be easy.

“I do,” Adora said, frowning, and glancing to the floor.

“Then, what’s the problem?” Catra tipped her chin up. “Let it go. We’re going to be okay.”

Adora still looked troubled. She struggled with herself for a moment and, as if she was doing something that was forbidden, she looked around before resting her forehead against Catra’s. “You promise?”

There was enough broken promises between them to fill a room. Sweeping a loose strand of hair out of Adora’s face, Catra whispered, “I promise,” and gave her a quick kiss. Adora’s eyelids fluttered and her lips instinctively chased after Catra’s warmth.

Catra smirked at her, and a proper smile won over Adora’s hesitancy.

“I can’t believe you *like* me,” Adora teased, a tongue poking out between her teeth.

Catra rolled her eyes, but she felt far from annoyed. If anything, she was dazed; as if she’d spent the last half an hour staring into a dazzling light and now she didn’t know what was up or down. Reaching up for another kiss, Catra muttered, “You always ruin it.”

And as their lips danced once more, Catra had a thought that chilled her to the bone:

I can’t lose this.

It would break me.

Chapter End Notes

This chapter might not be to everyone's tastes, but I hoped you enjoyed it nonetheless. As you've probably already noticed, the namesake of the story is mentioned in this chapter - it was inspired by We Can Be Free If We Want It by Nothing but Thieves, which explores the concept of freedom equaling leaving your past behind and moving on; our past holds us back and limits us from the things we want now. It made me think of how some people's happiness/freedom is dependant on other people (i.e. Catra here), and so I posed the concept as a question: we could be free, if you wanted? Catra's freedom depends on Adora choosing it, and that's one of the main things being taken from Adora.

With that rant over, I'd recommend listening to For Good from the Wicked soundtrack because it is literally the most perfect song for these two. I almost added a trigger warning for people who find it hard to communicate their feelings so use music as a tool (myself, I mean myself).

Once again, I wrote this chapter so quickly because of all the nice comments I received this week. Thank you, really. They cheer me up so much.

Stay safe,

Cx.

Agreements

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Twenty-two years old

All Adora had was a rucksack and her mobile phone.

Over the past few weeks, she had been removing money in small amounts from her savings account and hiding it away in a worn copy of *The House of Mirth* by Edith Wharton. She had a few items of clothing, a reusable water bottle and dried fruit in her rucksack, and she'd left everything else behind.

Including her medal.

When you were on the run, it was best to travel light.

Adora was scheduled to return to active-duty next week – and by 'active duty' they meant new She-Ra experiments. During her last days on leave, she had overheard conversations and tactfully talked to the right people, and she kept hearing the same thing – and it was something that made her skin crawl.

She had heard whisperings that they wanted to turn She-Ra into a weapon; a weapon to deter future attacks from neighbouring countries or uprisings from within.

It was something that kept her up at night, tormenting herself over her future. She-Ra and the failsafe had saved a lot of people and had come at such a high cost. The thought of turning something that was meant for good into a weapon was twisted. It was sick. Adora couldn't do it. She wanted to *save* people.

She didn't want this. She never wanted this. She didn't want any of it anymore – the fame, the attention, the glory. The only thing she wanted right now was a hand to hold, a shoulder to lean on.

She wanted Catra, but Catra wasn't coming back.

So, without a plan or a friend to her name, Adora left last night and swore never to return. She was aware – painfully aware – of what they could do once they discovered her missing for her morning check-in. The consequence of abandoning your post was life in prison.

She didn't care. At least in prison she would be free of the burden. At least in prison they couldn't use her as a weapon.

Adora had healed, but she was physically a shadow of her former self. She was thin, almost bony, since losing most of her weight during surgeries and sickness. She had little to no strength in the left side of her body, and she frequently felt the residual pain of her chronic injuries. Night terrors kept her from sleeping, and constant episodes of disassociation kept her anxiety bubbling underneath the surface, always lurking.

Adora was always a few steps away from a panic attack.

As she crept through the forest, she did her best to use the sounds and smells of nature to ground her. The military had requested that she see a therapist once a week, and so far, she had done everything she could to avoid it. Adora didn't want to remember or recount what had happened. Hell, she wanted to forget it happened at all.

She wanted to forget *herself* most days.

In terms of where she was going, she had no idea. It was difficult to get far without showing her identity, meaning anything that required a bank card or passport was out of bounds. Instead, she had paid for a bus to Brightmoon and intended to walk through the forest until she found the port. At the port, she could potentially find someone willing to take her out of the country without asking any questions.

If that didn't happen, then she would circle back and think of what else she could do.

Adora's hip gave a sudden sharp, biting flare of pain. The bullet wound had caused an infection, and ever since she trouble with the joint and inflammation. She staggered against a tree, propping herself up against it, and tried to give it a stretch.

Ah – nope, ouch. That wasn't working. She needed to sit down.

Holding in a groan, she tried to lower herself to the ground, but her back screamed in protest. Adora's breath quickened, and she searched in her pocket for some painkillers. Her breath started to come in quick gasps, and for a moment she was scared of adding a panic attack to the list of current failures.

Another part of her mind was trying to disconnect from everything altogether – her vision started to blur, and as panic settled in her heart, Adora's mind tried to transport her elsewhere, as if this was happening to somebody else and she was just a bystander. She could almost see herself from the outside, crouched against a tree in the middle of a forest, wheezing and zoning in and out of reality. It would be so easy to detach herself limb by limb from the real world – maybe it would stop the emotional pain she carried with her in her chest. Maybe it would help the overwhelming sense of uselessness that plagued her.

Lost in the middle of a forest with nowhere to go and no one to call, Adora was once again overcome with how alone she was in the world.

"Hey – are you okay? Do you need help?"

It was a man's voice; one she didn't recognise. Adora, squeezing her eyes shut, pulled herself up again. "I'm fine," she muttered, waving him off. "I'm okay."

"You don't look okay," said another voice. A woman; young by the sounds of it. "Here, let us help."

Adora opened her eyes to see a young couple (were they a couple? They seemed very close) come into view. The man wore a crop top and joggers and held out an arm with a large toothy

smile on his face. Meanwhile, the woman (short with pink hair and wearing a white top with sparkly shorts) tried to take her other arm.

It was January. They weren't dressed for winter. It wasn't sensible.

Adora had a lot to focus on, but this was currently her main concern. What were two people doing in leisurewear in the forest in the middle of January? Weren't they concerned about catching a cold or getting stranded without something warm?

"I'm fine," she reiterated, standing on her own. Help wasn't wanted or needed. "But thank you."

"Do I know you?" blurted the pink-haired one. She put her hands on her hips and pouted. "You look familiar. Do you go to the university?"

"Uh, no." Adora was eager to get away. It was strange to think that people her age – most people her age – were studying and hadn't seen the things that she'd seen. It pulled her out of her mind for a moment and caused her heart to pang. "I don't know you, so…"

"But you *do* look familiar. We've definitely seen you somewhere," the crop-top boy pushed. He offered her a hand to shake. "I'm Bow, by the way. And this is Glimmer. We're trying this hiking trail, we heard that it's – wait, are you *sure* you're okay?"

Adora's vision had started to spin. The pain in her side was too intense. It was making her queasy. "Yeah, I'm –" She began to cough dry hacks that caused her stomach to heave. The pain was so vivid, and she was so far away from safety. She shook her head and tried to concentrate. "I'm sorry –"

"Don't apologise!" the one called Glimmer said, reaching out to hold onto her shoulders. "You're clearly sick. Here, come home with us –"

Adora tried to pull away. “I can’t –”

But Bow had already clasped onto her other arm. “Please, we can’t leave you here like this.”

She was stuck in between them with nowhere to go. In no state to argue, Adora allowed herself to be led down the hill and into the Glimmer girl’s pink car.

Before she passed out, her last thought was: *this was the friendliest kidnap ever.*

Present day

Adora slept well, but she woke up anxious. As she blinked against the dark, her fingertips ghosted her lips and she had only one thought: Catra.

She couldn’t make sense of it. Catra, beyond all reason and doubt, still wanted her. Catra *wanted* her. After everything that had happened between them, Catra still cared.

And it broke Adora’s heart.

They had finally found a time where they hadn’t missed each other like ships in the night. They *could* be happy; they *could* have each other. That’s what had happened last night when they kissed – the realisation that they could and they should, because why not? What was stopping them? They’re two grown women who can make decisions for themselves.

Adora’s hand then trailed over the failsafe scar where it was etched onto her chest.

Only, it was more difficult than that, wasn’t it?

There was still something between them, and it wasn’t unrequited feelings. It was a secret. A significantly large one, and one that

she was certain would tear them apart again. It was Adora's secret, and if it broke Catra's heart, it would be all her fault.

It wasn't fair.

There was only one thing for it, and it wasn't an easy thing to do: she would have to come clean.

Adora would have to tell Catra everything – about the Heart of Etheria project, She-Ra, and the obligation she made after the war.

Catra needed to know. She *deserved* to know.

If they were actually going to have a shot at this, at being together, Catra needed to know.

What happened after was anyone's guess. Adora's more cynical side imagined that Catra would disown her completely after being hurt one too many times. If that happened, so be it. At least Adora would be free from guilt. At least she would have one last opportunity to do the right thing.

Adora got up and stretched, trying to pull out the sickness that was heavy in her stomach. She would go to the gym to take out some of her frustration, and then she would call Catra. The secret of She-Ra had been repressed in her for so long that it was going to be tough finally getting it out. Catra had offered her freedom, and in a way letting go of this would give her a sense of relief – but only by burdening it onto someone else.

But then, that had always been the problem with Catra and Adora – if one of them fell, it wasn't long before the other followed.

Twenty-two years old

Adora came around to the overwhelming stench of sweet, flowery perfume. Having no recollection of what had happened or where

she had fallen asleep, she lifted her head from an unbelievably airy pillow and squinted against the light. "Where…?"

"We're in my mum's house," said a pink-haired girl, causing Adora to jump out of her skin. Where the hell did she come from? Adora pressed her palms into her eyes and tried to remember. She wasn't going to make it very far on her own if she kept blacking out. If she ended up in hospital, the military would definitely find her. The pink-haired girl said cautiously, "You fainted back there, are you okay?"

Slowly, it started to come back to Adora. The crop top boy – Ben, or something? And the pink-haired girl – Diamond, maybe? They had rescued her from fainting in the forest, like the pathetic wimp that she was. She would need to get a better hold of herself next time. It was difficult coping with chronic pain without a reliable supply of painkillers. But it still wasn't good enough. She had allowed herself to be rescued, to be found. She was lucky that her rescuers seemed harmless.

"I'm fine," Adora said, trying to smile. "And, uh, thank you."

Desperate to move on and to keep moving, she shimmied towards the edge of the bed, doing her best to ignore the spinning sensation in her head. As she reached for her bag, she heard:

"Where are you going?"

Adora looked around; crop-top boy and pink-haired girl were staring at her, both equally as confused as one another.

"I – well, I need to go," Adora said, still moving. "I can't stay here."

"Do you need a ride? Do you need help getting somewhere?" the boy asked with a kind, gentle smile that lit up his eyes. Adora was taken aback.

Why were they being so nice? They had no reason to look after her or ask if she needed anything – she didn't know them. What

were they getting out of helping her? In the army, you helped your colleagues because it was required of you – you were a team, a formation, and if one of you went down it could bring the whole team down. Adora hadn't met anyone outside of the army since she left school at sixteen and, well, school was cutthroat. People weren't nice unless they wanted something, and that was just how Adora assumed it was in real life.

"I, um. I don't know." She shook her head and stared down at the rucksack in her hands. "I just need to… go."

But the crop-top boy put his hands on top of hers. Adora met his soft brown gaze, so sincere. It had been quite a white since someone had looked at her like she was a *person* and not a tool. She wasn't sure how it made her feel. Her jaw clenched.

"Hey, what's your name?" he asked.

"Adora," she said, reluctantly.

"That's a nice –"

"Oh!" The pink-haired girl stood up and thumped her friend in the arm. "Bow, it's the – you know." She clicked her fingers. "The soldier!"

Crop-top boy, Bow, frowned. "The – wait!" he turned around again, pointing at Adora like she was a mythical creature that had popped up out of nowhere. "That's why you look so familiar!"

That was something Adora kept forgetting – thanks to the news coverage, people who didn't know her *knew* her. It was going to be hard keeping a low profile. Stunned, and slightly embarrassed, she scratched the back of her neck. "Oh. Right." She sighed. "Yeah. That's her – I mean me."

"What are you doing in Brightmoon?" The girl asked, holding onto Adora's forearm and looking her over. "Shouldn't you be resting? No wonder you're ill."

As if electrocuted, Adora immediately jumped up from the bed. She felt a twinge of panic when the girl flinched and looked hurt. "I don't really –" Adora shook her head; she didn't want to get into it. She just wanted to leave. "Listen, thanks for your help. I really appreciate it. But I need to go now."

But still they wouldn't let her leave. Bow stood up too, and hovered near the door, staring at her as if she was a glass ornament about to break. "Adora, what's going on? You collapsed in a forest, you're severely dehydrated, you only have clothes and fruit in your bag –"

"You looked through my bag?!" Adora squeaked, grabbing her rucksack to make sure they hadn't taken anything.

Bow grimaced. "Glimmer was trying to find some ID in case we needed it."

Adora glanced at the girl – Glimmer – and noticed her concern had turned into suspicion. Glimmer, with her arms crossed, asked, "So, what's going on? Anyone would think you're on the run or something."

Adora's eyes nearly popped out of her head. She spluttered, and tried to cover it with a fake laugh, placing her hands on her hips and rocking on her feet. "Ha!" she coughed loudly. It was hard to remember how to act naturally. "Right. Yeah."

There was a minute of awkward silence and then –

Glimmer gasped and flung a hand over her mouth. "Wait! You *are* on the run, aren't you?" Squeaking, she hit Bow's arm and yelled, "Oh my god, Bow – we've caught a war hero fugitive!"

Bow immediately responded by flapping his hands in the air. "What do we do? What do we do?!"

As they hyperventilated at one another, jumping around the bed, Adora anxiously paced in front of them. She thought about going back and facing the experiments – she thought about having no

say over her bodily autonomy. She couldn't handle it; she would have to reason with them. "Guys, please, just let me go." Her breath rattled in her chest. "I can't – I can't go back there." Quieter, still, she said, "Don't make me go back."

Adora wasn't sure when she started crying, but shame made her turn away to hide her face as she wiped away her tears. She flinched at the feeling of a large warm hand resting on her shoulder. "Hey, it's okay," said Bow. "We're not going to do anything you don't want us to. We can help you."

Adora looked around, confused. "Help me? Why would you help me? You don't even know me."

"You *saved* Etheria," Glimmer said, as if it was obvious. "We'd do anything, no questions asked."

They'd… help her? Without reward or reason? Subconsciously, Adora's hand ghosted her chest, over the failsafe. "How can I trust you?" she asked.

It would be useful to have someone help her out of the country, even if it was as simple as booking her a plane or boat to somewhere else. Adora wanted to say yes, but she held herself back. It was still risky, and she had no reason to trust them.

"Are you hungry?" Glimmer asked suddenly, as if they weren't discussing anything illegal. "We need to discuss this over snacks."

"Do you like cheesy crackers?" Bow added, eyes wide with curiosity.

Adora was getting whiplash from this conversation. She blinked a few times, making sure they were serious and not making fun of her. Yet, they were so warm and light and untouched by the darkness of the world, and Adora heard herself snort and say, "I mean – yeah, I'm not crazy."

"Ah – ha!" Bow pointed at Glimmer, like it solved an ongoing argument between them. "I *told* you everyone likes cheese

crackers!”

Glimmer rolled her eyes. “Fine. You’re both wrong, but fine.” She looked at Adora. “Do you want anything else? Water? Real food?”

Adora hesitated. “Do you have any painkillers?”

Glimmer clicked her fingers. “I’ve got it covered.”

And as she left the room, Bow patted the spot on the bed beside him wearing a broad smile. Adora felt her shoulders contract and her anxiety ease; maybe, just maybe, she *could* trust them. Maybe it was time to ask for help.

Present day

Adora received a text around noon.

Catra 11.58

Hey, can I come over?

And Adora would’ve been a fool to say no.

Catra said she would be twenty minutes, so Adora made herself useful by tidying the house. Her home was well-kept and full of items that held a special place in her heart, but she was prone to leaving things in random places after becoming distracted by something else. She wanted to give Catra the best impression; she was the first person other than Bow or Glimmer to visit her here, after all. As she cleared some papers from the top of the fridge, she noticed a letter on top of the pile that made her heart sink like a stone in a pond.

It had arrived a few days ago from the Etherian military, reminding her of when and how she should check-in to re-enlist her contract, and what was expected of her upon entry into the barracks. Just reading the word ‘pre-screening health check’ had almost sent her spiralling into a panic attack. The thought of

people near her, with their hands on her body, and their medical equipment and their –

Adora shivered. She binned the rest of the papers and ran upstairs with the letter. Safely stuffing it in her top bedside drawer, she then sat on the edge of her bed with her hands gripping her knees. *Not yet*, she said to herself. *You can't re-enlist yet.* Not with so much unfinished business.

She would come clean to Catra – she would tell her about She-Ra, and the experiments, and the agreement. Everything. Hopefully they could then spend the next few weeks making the most of the time they had left together.

Maybe Catra would even wait for Adora during her rest periods.

No – that wasn't fair. Adora shook herself. Catra deserved to be free, she'd earned that much. Despite how much she wanted this, Adora knew the right thing to do was to let Catra go. She could move on, and Adora could – well, she would have to cope with it.

There was no way out.

And then there was the small issue of telling Bow and Glimmer.

As her heart strings pulsed with guilt and disappointment, Adora returned downstairs to put on the kettle in the kitchen and settled into one of the chairs. She thought about everything she could've had – Catra, a life with Catra, and a… future. For the last few years, the future was an opaque screen she had never been able to see through. Occasionally, she would let herself daydream and imagine what she would do if she was completely free of the army. Would she still be a teacher? Would she able to commit to someone – someone like Catra? Or would she finally be able to feel *herself*?

These thoughts were swimming in her mind when she heard the doorbell.

Okay. She could do this. It was time to be honest – it was time to tell Catra.

With every step towards the door, Adora pumped herself up for the confrontation.

When she opened the door, and she saw Catra's bright smile and shining eyes, her resolve dissipated completely.

"Hey Adora," Catra purred.

Adora couldn't help but match her cheeky grin. *This* was her person. Catra's good mood could shine a light on Adora's darkest. "Come in." She stood to the side, suddenly embarrassed. "And, uh, welcome, I guess."

Catra stepped inside, openly ogling the hallway. As Adora led her into the kitchen, she noticed the brunette's eyes linger on the framed photo of Adora, Bow and Glimmer beside the stairs. "This is cosy," she said lightly. "How did you find this place?"

"Oh, it's an interesting story." Adora gestured for her to sit, and Catra took her time inspecting Adora's kitchen gadgets. Putting on the kettle, she said, "Before I left the army, I was notified that someone was looking for me, but because of privacy policies, I couldn't know who or why. As it happened, Mara's last remaining relative – her great aunt, Razz – requested to meet me to… well, you know." Adora poured the hot water into two mugs, and as she gestured awkwardly with her hands, she almost splashed the boiling water onto herself. She put the kettle down and leaned against the counter. "I was there when Mara died. Razz wanted to thank me for bringing her body back and making sure she wasn't left behind. We exchanged numbers and after I left, I visited her every so often."

Catra was watching her closely with her chin resting on the back of her hand. "That's very kind of you."

Adora shrugged it off and continued making the tea. "I was lonely, and she was an old lady living by herself near the woods. It felt

like the right thing to do. Anyway, during one of our visits she mentioned that Mara used to live next door when she wasn't on active duty, and she asked if I wanted to buy the house from her. I was living with Glimmer and Bow at this point, but they were starting to look for a place for themselves." She gestured vaguely around them. "So, I bought Mara's house."

"Adora the homeowner," Catra said with emphasis. "That sounds *so* sexy."

Adora blushed, but not because she was flustered. She handed Catra a tea with a sheepish grin. "Well, uh – Razz doesn't really know that house prices have tripled in the last few years. She offered it to me for the amount that she paid for it when she bought it for Mara. Even then – she's never really *asked* me for it."

Catra gave a sarcastic gasp. "You stole a house from an elderly woman?!"

"I didn't steal anything!" Adora squeaked. "Razz gave it to me, and in return I visit her at least once a week to make sure she's okay. She bakes me pies and I clean her house and buy her groceries." Adora settled into the chair opposite, wrapping her hands around the warm cup, and muttered, "It's an agreement of sorts."

It was the closest thing she'd had to a grandparent, and she didn't want Catra teasing her for it. Razz meant a great deal to her – even if she was frustrating to communicate with at times.

As it happened, this wasn't the Catra she remembered. This was Mature Catra, who only took a sip and teased, "And I thought you were a strong moral character."

Adora felt the herbal tea sour on her tongue. She pushed the mug away and said, staring at the table, "That's not the only thing you've gotten wrong about me."

"Oh yeah?" Catra's eyes flashed mischievously. "What's next – are you going to tell me how you didn't pay for candy you stole from

the pick ‘n’ mix?”

And it would be so easy to let this continue – their easy banter interlaced between serious conversations, catching up on time they’ve missed. But Adora couldn’t do it – she couldn’t keep up the charade. It’s killing her slowly, like a poison spreading outward from her heart.

Catra deserved *so* much more than what she could give her.

So, Adora took a deep breath and met the brunette’s cautious gaze. “Catra… we need to talk.”

Catra’s easy, laid-back persona was also somewhat fake, because the reaction to those words were instantaneous; she sat up straight, dropped her smile and put up a hand. “Adora, please. If you don’t want me, just say.”

“It’s not that,” Adora said quickly. It still felt strange to say it out loud without fear. “I do want you. More than anything.”

Catra shivered slightly. Her nostrils flared, and when she spoke next, her voice was strained. “Then, what’s the issue?”

Say the words, Adora told herself. *Tell your story*. It might not be too late for Catra to understand – they might even walk away from this as friends. In some ways, this was Catra’s story too, even if she didn’t know it yet. If they both felt this way, and they’d already been through this together, then this concerned her just as much as it did Adora.

Pulling the last scraps of her bravery together, Adora started, “I need to – I don’t – this is hard for me.” She gave a frustrated sigh. “I have a hard time talking about… things. I haven’t told anyone this before.”

Catra sat forward, capturing Adora’s gaze. Her eyes were hard and bright showing that she was both open and closed at the same time. She studied Adora for a moment, like she was trying to find something to latch onto. Then, she said, “Can I say something?”

Adora nodded.

"Can it wait until after Christmas?" She asked the question so delicately, so uncertainly, that Adora thought she had misheard her. Catra glanced down, as if ashamed. "I just want a moment with you where we can be ourselves – where we can just be *happy*. I've dreamed of just having" – she paused, considering the weight of her words – "*this* for so long and I'm not ready for it to be over yet. We can enjoy the holidays together and then, if this issue is still a thing, we can discuss it in the new year." She looked up again. "How does that sound?"

Adora felt a flood of emotions at once.

Relief that Catra was listening. Affection and support for her honesty and how they made her glow with warmth. Guilt – but that was nothing new.

And pure exhilaration at the prospect of having Catra for a little longer.

With a shy smile, Adora fumbled with her fingers and asked, "You… want to spend the holidays together?"

It was Catra's turn to blush. She flicked the hair out of her eyes and shrugged. "I mean – if you want to – I don't have plans, like ever, so –"

"Okay," Adora interrupted, unable to hide her giddiness. She was practically fizzling with renewed excitement; Catra wanted to spend Christmas together. Catra wanted to spend time with her like they used to. Catra still *wanted* her.

No matter for how long it would last, Adora would make sure the next two weeks were worth it.

"Okay?" Catra repeated, a little dumbstruck.

It was cute. Adora liked seeing the faint pink blush on Catra's cheeks and how she fidgeted to avoid eye contact. Feeling like

she had the upper hand for once, she leaned across the table, offering Catra a hand. "Yes," she said. "Although…"

Catra reluctantly held onto Adora's hand, sinking her nails into her skin. "What?"

Adora grimaced. "I usually spend Christmas day with Glimmer's family, so you'd have to come along." She paused as Catra's eyes narrowed. "Which means, you'd probably have to make up with Glimmer before then."

Shaking her head, Catra muttered, "The things you ask of me, Adora Greyskull."

Adora poked her tongue between her teeth. "Is that a yes?"

"*Yes*." Catra interlaced her fingers through Adora's. "Fine. I'll talk to her."

They sat together in silence for a moment. Adora allowed herself to relieve part of the tension in her shoulders; Catra was right, they didn't have to do this now. They had a few weeks before Adora had to re-enlist, and they would revisit this difficult conversation in the new year. Who knows what would happen over the holidays?

And why couldn't she allow herself this small piece of happiness if it meant Catra being happy too?

At that thought, Adora gushed, "We're going to spend Christmas together. Like we used to."

A flash of sadness crossed Catra's face. Her fingertips traced a path across Adora's skin. "The first of many, if I have anything to do with it."

Adora gave a non-committal hum. "Can I kiss you?" she asked instead, feeling a light buzz at the prospect of just *having*, just *taking*.

“I’d be offended if you didn’t, princess.”

With slow, deliberate movement, Catra got up from her chair and settled in Adora’s lap. She fit so perfectly, like their bodies were made to be moulded together. With her hands on Catra’s waist and her warmth filling her up, Adora thought that – just for a moment – if she had a future at all, it was right here, staring back at her.

Twenty-two years old

As it happened, Glimmer’s mother was a very powerful woman.

Not only was she a board member of one of the most successful all-ability schools in the country, but she had experience in both the legal and medical fields. She knew most of the CEOs in Etheria, and she had connections across every industry.

Adora had told Glimmer and Bow the necessities of her situation: the army wanted to extend her contract and have her return to active service, and she didn’t want to. Her only way out was by running away.

Glimmer had immediately asked her mum for help. Angella, with her kind eyes and graceful smile, had offered Adora a chair in her office to discuss the pressing issue.

Adora had been expecting reprimands and judgement. However, all she received was sympathy and advice.

Angella told her that her army contract was indeed legal-bounding, but the fact the military were pressurising Adora into active service so soon after a life-altering event was exploiting their duty of care. Angella recommended that Adora spoke to an external therapist, who could revoke her active-duty commitment on grounds of mental health.

And so, Glimmer introduced Adora to her friend, Perfuma; a recent addition to Brightmoon School and newly qualified

therapist. Glimmer and Bow were in their last year of university, and both of them had already secured places in Brightmoon School for their teacher training. Angella wished for Glimmer to take over as principal when she was ready – something that had caused a history of conflict between parent and child.

Perfuma was patient and understanding – unlike the military specialists Adora had already spoken to. She didn't push for details into Adora's life, and she didn't say anything overly intrusive; she allowed Adora to discuss how she was feeling and listened to her concerns without interruptions.

After a few sessions, Perfuma wrote a letter to Angella stating that Adora was showing signs of severe PTSD, dissociation, agitated depression and anxiety. She also noted that Adora was not fit to work any job with her current mental health concerns, never mind returning to active duty in the military.

The day after Angella started to put together a legal case in Adora's honour, the military discovered her location.

Adora was arrested outside Glimmer's house.

She was carted off to a military prison on the outskirts of Thaymor. She was handcuffed and put in a small windowless grey room. Adora ignored the table and chairs completely and opted for leaning against the far wall and staring at the metal floor. Oddly, she felt numb. Devoid of emotion. She would've thought that a scenario such as this one would've triggered a panic attack or a fit of disassociation.

But Adora was *so tired*.

After everything that Angella and Glimmer had done for her, she still managed to screw it up and get caught. She could see no end to this: the military wanted She-Ra, and as long as it lived inside of Adora, they would never let her go.

They could use her as they pleased – even if turning her into a weapon was their new aim.

Adora wasn't sure how long they kept her in the interrogation room. When her eyes started to get drowsy, Colonel Hope entered with a small nod of her head. She gestured to the table and chairs.

"Adora, take a seat."

Adora sat without comment.

Hope crossed her arms and, unblinkingly, stared across the table at the Corporal. Her smooth brown skin shone in the grey light of the interrogation room, almost making her look like some sort of hologram. As ever, she showed absolutely no emotion. After a moment of dead-eye staring, she spoke in her signature monotone voice.

"Out of all my soldiers, I never would've guessed you'd be the one to betray us." She titled her head to the right. "Adora, you are away that you've abandoned your post?"

"Yes," Adora said, curt and firm. She was not going to be guilted into feeling remorse, either; after countless discussions with Glimmer and Bow, she was starting to understand that her feelings were *also* valid. The army didn't care about her feelings, they never had – she was just doing what she had to in order to protect herself.

Hope then asked, "And you're aware of the consequences?"

Life in prison – yes, she was aware. Adora's stomach clenched at the reminder, but she did her best to remain unflinching. Life in prison was nothing compared to the alternative. She couldn't hurt anyone else in prison. "I don't want to be a weapon," she said instead, glaring at the table.

"A weapon?" Hope echoed.

"I know that was the next step in the She-Ra experiments," Adora said, still unable to look up. "You were going to try to harness She-Ra's powers to create a living weapon – something that could

create a hybrid of the Horde's technology and our technology to use against future enemies of Etheria." The bitter hiss of resentment tainted Adora's tone. She put her hand over her heart, just above the She-Ra implant. "I don't want to be a weapon. I wanted to end the war – I wanted to help people. I didn't want this."

Hope, then, did something unusual. Her eyebrows jerked towards her hairline, and her lips pressed together, as if this information surprised her. Adora watched, fascinated; she could see the Colonel weigh up each word in her mind as she tried to find the right way forward.

"It is true that we plan to turn She-Ra into a hybrid weapon, but only to use as a defensive tool." She met Adora's stare and gave the smallest shrug of her shoulders. "You wouldn't be responsible for any of it."

"It's in *me*," Adora retorted, voice cracking. Turning She-Ra into a weapon meant turning her into a weapon. They were one and the same at this point. How couldn't they see that?

"And I think you're forgetting your place in this," Hope replied, suddenly hard in both tone and expression. "You are a soldier. These decisions are made by people of much higher ranks than you, Corporal Greyskull. It is not your responsibility to question your superiors or their motives." She paused to sit forward. "Abandoning your post is one fault, but insubordination is treason."

Adora gaped – she couldn't help it. Her heart thudded against her ribcage and threatened to break through. "Treason?! I'm not –"

Hope raised a hand. "Silence," she snapped. "When you ran away, you stole classified intelligence and military property." She gestured to Adora's chest where She-Ra resided. "Who knows what or who you would've given that information to? It jeopardises the safety of our country." Hushing herself, she then

asked, "A life in prison because of desertion is one thing, but do you know what the consequence of treason is, Adora?"

The use of her personal name in the context made Adora's skin crawl. "No."

Hope's eyes flashed with anger. "*Death*. Only a handful of people – mostly politicians – have been successfully tried for treason in Etheria's history. It would be a fall of grace for Adora Greyskull, once the saviour of Etheria as the media have dubbed you, to face charges of execution." She paused again for emphasis. "Don't you think so?"

I don't want, I don't care.

If death was supposed to be a deterrent, then it wasn't a very effective one. First, the army had used her death as a bargaining tool – to promise her glory, to die a hero to save her country. Now that she had survived and she wanted nothing else to do with glory or heroics, death was being used a threat. Either way, the army had wanted to kill her. Either way, it seemed, she was going to die for the army.

Mara had been right, but Adora was too late. She didn't get out in time, and now they were going to destroy her.

Adora could go along with She-Ra and turn herself into a weapon, which would be a betrayal to herself and to everyone she saved. Or, she could continue to refuse to cooperate and face, as Hope called it, an 'execution'.

Adora's heart was heavy; she just didn't want this anymore. Any of it. She didn't want to think or *be*. She just wanted to be left alone, in the quiet, where it was peaceful.

And in the moment, it was hard to feel anything other than resigned to her fate. Whatever happened, so be it. If she had to die for a cause, let it be her own one.

"I understand, Colonel Hope," she answered quietly.

A moment of silence passed between them, and Adora thought that was it – the decision had been made, and her fate was, once again, written for her by a stranger's pen. But then, Colonel Hope said, as if every word was begrudged:

"However, I have discussed this with other senior members of staff. With your apparent – and open – opposition to our plans, we have drafted an… agreement." Adora looked up, confused. Hope interlaced her fingers. "The media have taken a great interest in you, and we don't think it would be appropriate for Etheria's great war hero to be put in prison or charged with treason. Not so soon after our liberation from the Horde. It might make our politics… complicated. So, we are willing to broker a one-time deal."

Adora's back straightened. She eyed the room, searching for something watching or listening into their conversation. With visible reluctance, she asked, "What do you want me to do?"

"We will allow you to take temporary leave. This might be years, or it could be only a few months. You will have the full equivalent to a redundancy package; free education, private health care and mental health support. In other words, you can live a civilian life."

It was too good to be true. Adora's eyes narrowed. "But?"

Hope titled her head again. "You can live a civilian life until the She-Ra experiments are needed again. You will keep the She-Ra chip, and when you are requested to re-enlist, you will do so, no questions asked." When she looked down, Adora noticed that her superior didn't look happy about this arrangement. If anything, she looked like she was being forced to say this against her will. "We would, essentially, be placing the rest of your tour on hold for the time being, and when you're needed, you will serve the remainder of your contract. We will check in with you once a year, and update you on our plans, but apart from that, you can live a normal life."

This was a huge offer.

Adora’s mind reeled.

She could be free for as long as the army allowed her to be – if this meant years, Adora could research her contract and the validity of her rights under the She-Ra experiment. She could keep in contact with Angella, who could potentially find her a way *out*. This bought her time and, if she had anything to do with it, she would make sure that she would never set foot in the army every again.

But she needed to know the alternative.

“And if I don’t accept?” she asked.

Hope's facial expression gave nothing away. “You will be tried for abandonment and treason."

For a moment – just a moment – Adora felt like saying no. Let them put her in prison. Let them make a spectacle of themselves by executing their once great war hero – maybe then she could find peace, freedom and people would see Hope’s version of the military for what it was.

But if Catra was here, she would kill her for even considering it.

Knowing she was going to regret it, but without ever knowing just how much, Adora inhaled deeply and said, “Okay. I’ll do it.”

Chapter End Notes

> Sorry for not updating last week! I had a busy time of it; I passed my driving test (alexa, play olivia rodrigo), bought a car, and my dog had a stomach bug. When my furbaby is ill I can't focus on anything else. As a result, I'm not at all happy with this chapter.
>
> Thank you all so so much for your support, it means everything to me. I read and smile at every single one of your comments.

Things are hotting up, so see you next week ;)

Stay safe,

Cx.

Traditions

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Present day

Catra was expecting Adora to tell Glimmer about their new Christmas plans – but she wasn't expecting Glimmer to contact her *first* to say they should talk.

It was the last day of school before the holidays. There was a buzz in the air that came with holiday freedom; the students had no real classes, and the teachers had no structure to their teaching. Catra spent her last day telling the kids to read or entertain themselves while she sat at her desk searching for last minute Christmas gifts for Adora.

Adora had been sneaky, giving her a sentimental present for her birthday, but Catra wanted to be sneakier. Even though she had a hard time admitting it, she felt a thrill at buying Adora a gift – it was, in a way, an extension of her affection. It was a symbol of better times ahead, together, and the promise of it being the first gift of many. She wanted to impress her, and yet her brain was void of any good ideas.

So absorbed in her searching, Catra almost missed the soft rap of the classroom door. She hadn't heard the lunch bell, and when she looked up at an empty classroom, she tried not to look surprised. Glimmer let herself in – it was her school after all, but Catra still found it rude – and lazily sat on a student's chair in front of her.

Her smile was tight. "Catra."

Aware that it wasn't the time for sarcastic nicknames, she replied, "Headmistress."

Glimmer pulled a face. "Don't do that, that's gross. It makes me sound old and stern." She sighed, leaning over to fiddle with the cup of pens on the teacher's desk. "We need to talk. For Adora."

"For Adora," Catra agreed.

They stared at one another, and neither of them budged. Catra began to tap her index finger against the table. Glimmer blew out a long breath. The silence stretched on, unyielding, until Glimmer said:

"Well, go on. What do you have to say?"

"Me?" Catra squeaked. "*You're* the one who said we should talk."

Glimmer narrowed her eyes. "*You're* the one staying over at my family home because Adora is infatuated with you."

"Infatuated?!" Catra blubbered, unable to completely comprehend the meaning of that word. "Adora's not – we're – it's not –"

Glimmer massaged the space between her eyebrows. "Look, Catra, I know we haven't known each other long, and our professional relationship is completely overshadowed by a blonde-haired idiot, but I *feel* like I know you already." She met Catra's gaze, softer than before. "Adora told me everything about you – everything but your name. She made you sound like the love of her life and, frankly, the person she described is much different to the person that I see. Don't take that the wrong way."

"I'm struggling to see how I can take that the *right* way, to be honest," the brunette huffed.

Glimmer glazed over it, and went on, "I think – I hope – that we both want the best for Adora –"

"And you don't think I'm what's best for her," Catra put in, temperature rising.

"No," Glimmer snapped, putting up a finger to shush her. "I didn't say that. I actually think you're made for each other in a sappy star-crossed lovers' way, and that's exactly what worries me – this isn't a fantasy with an inevitable happy ending. This is real life, and it's cruel most of the time." She paused, looking genuinely concerned. "You've hurt Adora once before, and I'm scared of it happening again."

Despite how Catra could see the sense in what Glimmer said, it still riled her up. Defensively, she argued, "Adora's hurt me plenty of times too –"

"Yes, I know. But Adora is my *friend*, and it took us a long time to get her back on her feet after… everything." Glimmer offered a small smile. "I want to get to know you for yourself, Catra. I want to see what Adora sees. So, I'm sorry. For being confrontational and over-protective. There, I said it."

Catra felt a sparkle of victory, but it quickly soured on her tongue. Her therapist had told her countless times that communication was the only way forward, to progress with people and make healthy relationships. Feeling spiteful and resentful didn't do anything other than poison your own thoughts, your own spirit. "I'm sorry too," she said eventually. "I didn't mean to lash out at you. I've just never seen Adora rely on someone else before – she never relied on me, not really. It made me jealous, I suppose."

"Apology accepted." Glimmer flashed her an award-winning grin. "I'll let my dad know that he needs to add another chair at the dinner table this year."

"He won't mind, will he?"

"Are you kidding? The more the merrier." Before Glimmer got up to leave, she pouted and pointed a finger at the brunette. "I'm happy you're making Adora happy, but if you ever break her heart, I swear to any god out there –"

Leaning back on her chair with her arms crossed, Catra challenged, "What if she breaks my heart, eh?"

"*Hmm*," Glimmer hummed, walking towards the door. "There's *always* an argument that ends in tears every Christmas, and I'm refusing to let it be me this year."

Twenty-two years old

Since the end of the war, the Etherian army continued to upgrade their technology at an alarming rate. It seemed that they had stolen most of the Horde tech and adapted it to fit their own needs.

Combat training, for example, was no longer against fellow soldiers. Instead, the soldiers fought against holograms and specially trained robots.

This gave Catra very little to do.

She sat on the viewing balcony with her legs dangling off the side as she watched her soldiers training in the arena. They were privates, newly qualified from their cadet course, and eager to face some real action. Many of them, Catra had learned, were inspired to join the military after the success of the Etherian army in the war. They wanted a little bit of the action for themselves.

They were idiots, in other words. The war was over, and they were kidding themselves. There was no glory in war, in seeing your friends die or become permanently injured on behalf of political agendas. Their whole military career would probably be spent on relief missions, and she doubted they would be as 'thrilling' or 'entertaining' as the Etherian army had promised them solider life would be.

Freida missed her target, and instead of hitting the hologram, she hit the medic, Nathaniel. As Nathaniel's chest pad lit up red, Stevenson stepped in front of him, probably to cover his fallen colleague, and instead, placed himself directly in the line of fire of

the hologram to their right. Catra groaned and punched off the simulation before leaping down into the arena.

Her team jumped as she landed squarely in front of them.

"You," she pointed at Nathaniel, "should've been *behind* your team. You're a *medic*. You cover and retrieve." She pointed at Freida. "You should've been clearing the simulation before entry, and because you didn't, you're now dead because this guy" – Catra pointed at the robot directly above them – "would shoot you as soon as you entered the building. Not to mention you shot your own fucking medic." Scoffing at Freida's shameful red cheeks, Catra turned to Stevenson. "And *you* just got a bullet through your thick head because you were trying to be heroic rather than smart."

Catra stepped back and faked clapped. "Well done, team! Thank fuck we don't have you guys on active duty, otherwise the only way you'd be coming home is in body bags."

Stevenson had the nerve to say, "Permission to speak, Corporal –"

"Permission denied," Catra dismissed with a flick of her hand. "Hit the shooting zone before the showers, I don't want to hear your pathetic excuses." When they hesitated, she shouted, "*Now*!"

As they scrambled away, Catra turned on her heel and left the simulation zone. She wiped the back of her hand over her forehead and tried to calm down. Some days it felt like each team she taught was worse than the last. She was *certain* that she and Adora weren't like that when they were –

A flash of cold, burning fury pumped through her veins at the thought of that name. She marched through the corridors, shutting off her thoughts completely. Maybe she would need to head to the shooting zone herself before dinner. Physically exhausting herself seemed to be the only way of finding respite most days.

That and drinking.

As Catra walked the corridor back to her quarters, she noticed a few people trying to catch her eye, or glancing quickly before looking away. It did nothing but make her silently fume. She was used to getting stares, and sometimes even the occasional passing compliment, like 'thank you for your service'. The media might not have paid her any attention, but her colleagues did. Within the first few weeks following the *incident*, she had managed to kick and scream her way out of people giving her anything akin to sympathy. Now, she only got respect. Catra had never had outright respect before. It was tough to get used to, but it had quickly boosting her ego. She had grown up poor in a children's home, bullied by her carer, reactive at school because of passive racism due to her skin colour, and had fought her way up the ranks in the army. Her hard work had finally paid off. If people weren't intimidated by her achievements on the battlefield, they were intimidated by her status as an off-duty trainer. Either way, Catra didn't need to worry about people *hurting* her anymore.

Catra shared a lounge room with Scorpia. Not planning to stick around to socialise, she walked past her colleague, who was anxiously pacing in front of the sofa. Before she could escape into the confinement of her room, Scorpia called out:

"Hey wildcat, did you hear?"

Stopping, Catra rolled her shoulders and looked around. "Hear what?"

Scorpia shuffled from foot to foot. "About, you know. A-Adora."

Catra practically snarled and walked on into her room. She slammed the door with a mighty loud *thud*. On the other side, she heard Scorpia shout, "Sorry, I know we agreed never to mention her, but I thought you'd be better hearing it from me than someone else!"

Ignoring her, Catra forcibly unbuttoned her blouse and threw it on the bed. She ran her hands through her hair and breathed in deeply. She didn't want to even *think* about *her*; she wanted her

gone, erased from her mind forever. The rage Catra felt whenever someone brought *her* up was scary – it wasn't who she wanted to be. Sometimes the brunette found it hard to contain her anger, and she frequently lashed out when she was alone. So no, Catra hadn't hear anything about *her* – people knew better than to bring it up around her. *She* could fall off the edge of the world for all she cared. Catra wouldn't even blink.

In. Out. In. Out. Catra breathed in through her nose and out through her mouth to get herself back under control. She sat on the edge of the bed and tried to think with a clear head. Scorpia, she reluctantly admitted, had a point. If something had happened regarding *her*, Catra would hear about it eventually. It would be better to hear about it now, get all her anger out in private, and then continue to be emotionless if she heard about it in the future.

Why did Scorpia have to be so *sensible* all the time?

Taking her time, Catra changed into gym clothes and brushed her hair. She had made the decision not long ago to grow it out; she missed her thick waves that the army had encouraged her to cut off. When she felt something resembling calm, she left her room and faced Scorpia in the lounge.

"What is it?" she asked, body coiled like a spring.

Scorpia clenched her hands, shocked at seeing Catra emerge from her room. She cleared her throat, and said carefully, "Adora's gone."

Catra's heart gave the smallest clench, and she hated herself for it. "What do you mean?"

"She was supposed to re-assign herself for active duty, and she didn't. She ran away." Scorpia's eyes were rounded, fearful. "They think she's deserted."

For a moment Catra thought something else by hearing the word *gone* – but never mind. She honestly, hand on heart, didn't care

what Adora did. Adora was more than capable of looking after herself and herself only. She had abandoned her post, so what? Hopefully she would never come back. Hopefully Catra would never see her stupid idiot face again. Anger rose up through her stomach, and she had to stamp it down by physically turning away. *Of course* Adora thought she could get away with whatever she wanted – even something as illegal as desertion. Her privilege tainted every decision she made.

"She left us *all* behind in the end, huh?" Catra muttered, more to herself than her colleague. Bending down, she pretended to tie her shoelace to avoid Scorpia looking at her face. She wasn't sure what emotion she'd see there.

"It's in the newspapers – they're asking if anyone knows where she –"

"Well, I don't, if that's what you're implying," Catra snapped, standing up. "Good fucking riddance to her."

And then Catra left without looking back. Never mind the shooting zone – she needed some hand-to-hand combat.

Present day

Glimmer and Bow spent Christmas eve and Boxing day at Bow's family home, leaving Adora and Catra to have some alone time before the big family affair. Catra stayed over at Adora's on Christmas eve, and they reclaimed their old tradition of stealing hot chocolate and eating too many mini marshmallows until they made themselves sick. As grown adults, however, they didn't need to steal anything, and as they sat in the living room piling into their chocolate stash, Catra felt an ache in her chest. There was something sad about reliving a beloved memory and not being able to capture the real essence of what made it beloved in the first place; the real thrill of the experience was in stealing the goodies under Weaver's nose and not getting caught. It was having a moment by themselves, wishing for independence. Now

that they had all the time they wanted, and enough money to see them right, the brunette found herself wishing for something else.

"We should start new traditions," she said, curled into Adora's side as they watched crappy reality television.

Adora was quiet for a moment. "Tradition implies that this is the first Christmas eve of many together."

Quirking her head, Catra stamped down the seed of doubt trying to gain roots in her chest. Adora wanted her, and she believed her when she said it. But there was something not quite right. Something tickling her sensitivities. Adora was here, physically, and yet it felt like only part of her was here.

"I didn't realise I was so intolerable," she teased. "If you want this to be our last Christmas eve together you should tell me now, Adora, before I go all soft on you."

Adora chuckled. "You're the opposite of intolerable."

"So, I'm just tolerable?"

"No, the opposite of intolerable is – wait, hold on, that wasn't the compliment I thought it was." Catra looked up in time to see Adora's eyebrows pull together in concentration. She looked so cute when she was confused or thinking. "You're, uh – why can't I think of word? You're… exceptional! Ha!" She almost knocked the hot chocolate out of Catra's hands as she pumped the air. "See – now *that's* a compliment."

Scoffing, she slapped Adora's arms down so she could continue to lean against her like a cat curled up against a radiator. "It's a good thing you're pretty, because sometimes I think there's nothing going on up there."

Adora smirked. "Are you saying you're only into me because of my looks?"

Catra wiggled her eyebrows. “I’ve been looking for a brawny babe to keep me warm at night.”

A muscle twitched in Adora’s cheek. She glanced down at her hands and muttered, “Not sure I have much of either anymore.”

“Huh?”

Adora shrugged, and did that thing with her nose that implied she was feeling self-conscious. It was a slight wiggle, and she’d done it since they were kids. “Never mind, I’m being stupid.”

Sitting up, Catra looked her straight in the eyes. “No, what is it?”

The blonde took a long gulp of hot chocolate, which surely burnt her throat. She stared at the brown-stained mug and trailed her finger over the handle. “I’m not as strong as I used to be, am I? And then there’s… me.” She gestured down at herself, as if what she was saying was obvious. “I’m covered in scars and – well, some of them aren’t pretty.” Her next words were barely audible. “If you didn’t know me from before, I doubt you’d even look at me the way I am now.”

Catra felt a glint of her old personality raise its weary head – in particular, the instinct to lash out and *attack*. How could Adora think she would be so shallow? Did she really think Catra cared about *looks*? But, sensibly, she realised quickly that this wasn’t about her at all. Adora had said before that she believed them to be in different ‘leagues’ when it came to looks, so this was another indication that Adora truly couldn’t see herself for what she was – what she had to offer.

She hadn’t always been like that. Adora had never made a big thing for looking good, but she had taken pride in looking presentable and had nothing to complain about. So, this was a new insecurity – thanks to the war.

And it was completely, and utterly, bullshit.

“Is that seriously what you think?” Catra asked, straining to keep her voice under control.

Adora glanced up, then, and looked concerned. She reached out to hold her hand. “Listen, Catra, I didn’t mean to ruin the mood – just forget it. These are my issues to deal with, and on the scale of things –”

She pulled her hands away to point at her friend. “No, you listen to me, Adora Marie Greyskull –”

“That’s not my –”

“Shush.” Catra silenced her by shoving a finger up against her lips. When Adora’s mouth snapped shut – she was still so influenced by direct orders – she ran her thumb over the blonde’s lips. Cupping her cheek to keep her eyes locked on her own, she said, “You are beautiful inside and out. Do you know how rare that is? You have such a good heart that it shows on the outside, in everything you do. You’re smart – if not an airhead sometimes – and *gorgeous*.” Embarrassed (it was still so hard being open), Catra added a tease for good measure. “And besides, you’ve always been the one into muscle, not me. I know how strong you are” – she placed her other hand over Adora’s chest – “in here.”

A few emotions scattered across Adora’s face; hurt, confusion, disbelief. But she finally rested on that stupid, beautiful look of hope that made Catra’s heart flutter.

“You’ve gone soft,” she whispered, leaning her cheek into the brunette’s palm.

Catra’s laugh filled the room. “I *did* warn you.”

And they kissed, so softly, that it made her whole body clench. It was chaste and sweet; a promise, a guarantee of sincerity. Catra hummed as they parted and ghosted her hands down Adora’s sides as the blonde held onto the nape of her neck.

“I still can’t believe I get to kiss you now,” Adora whispered, a tongue poking out between her teeth. “My cute little –”

“Nothing about me is cute or little, how dare you.” For good measure, Catra pressed her nails into the softness of Adora’s skin. “I’ve been told I radiate big dick energy and I’d like to keep it that way.”

Adora raised her eyebrows and pressed a quick kiss against Catra’s nose. “So cute.”

Huffing, Catra shoved her away. “Shut up!”

“Make me,” Adora flirted, a glint in her eye.

So, Catra leaned across and kissed her again, ensuring to add a bite or two this time.

Fifteen years old

Adora had a lot on her mind when she came home from school that day.

They had to make their subject choices for their exams, which would influence their university choices. Adora had never been into the idea of university; sure, she liked to learn, and she was good at it, but university was costly. Someone like her would never be able to get in or live comfortably once there unless she won a scholarship. Recently, scholarships were few and far between, and only reserved for the best of the best. She was one of the best achievers in her school, but in the country? She didn’t like her odds.

Besides, Adora was more athletically inclined. She liked using her body and pushing herself to her limits.

And if she wanted to be free – if her and Catra both wanted to be free – from the children’s home, and Weaver, as soon as possible, then the army was the perfect escape route.

As they got changed and had dinner, Adora realised that Catra also seemed deep in thought. The brunette was nibbling on her bottom lip as she threw a bouncy ball at the far wall in their bedroom – something that annoyed Weaver endlessly. Adora watched her with an air of curiosity. It was almost their regulated bedtime, and Catra showed no intentions of sharing what was on her mind.

So, Adora flopped on her best friend's bed and intercepted the throw of the ball. Catra looked around, frowning in annoyance.

"What's wrong?" Adora asked, giving the ball back. "You're never this quiet unless something has happened."

Weirdly enough, Catra's cheeks blushed. She snatched the ball and said, "It's nothing. I was just trying to figure something out."

"Can I help?"

"You'd do the opposite of help," she murmured, looking away.

"So, you don't want to talk about it?"

Catra mused it over like she was chewing on a tough thought. She sat up with her legs crossed, and her eyes were suddenly bright and alert. With eager curiosity, she asked, "Did you hear about Rogelio and Lars?"

Lars was a boy in their class who liked to pick fights. Adora knew Catra and Lars didn't get on, so by association, of course Adora hated him, too. But she hadn't heard anything about Rogelio and Lars. She shook her head.

Catra nodded like she already knew that. "Lars was giving Rogelio a rough time during a football game, and it got a bit physical."

Adora frowned and her body sagged. "If I had known –"

"You know Rogelio can handle himself, dummy." She rolled her eyes, exasperated. "Anyway, Rogelio broke Lars' nose. When the

teacher, Mr Fitzpatrick – you know the one with the bleached hair and creepy smile? – found Lars with a broken nose, he went nuts. But, when he asked what happened, Kyle took the blame for Rogelio." Catra huffed a laugh. "Everyone knows Kyle wouldn't be able to take on Lars, but Mr Fitzpatrick believed him."

"Are they okay?" Adora asked, clenching her hands together.

The brunette shrugged. "Weaver's not happy. Kyle has been suspended."

"What?!" Adora almost choked on her own sharp inhale. "Is that why Kyle wasn't at dinner?"

"Yep," Catra said, popping the *p* and smiling. "It feels good not being the one in trouble for once."

Adora said nothing as she stared at her hands. She didn't know why what Kyle did for Rogelio had caused Catra to think so deeply, but it was now causing the blonde to do the same. Being suspended on behalf of someone else was a big deal – especially knowing the repercussions from Weaver. And yes, sure, Adora had covered for Catra occasionally, but that was different. It was *Catra*. Adora would protect her from the world if she could, even though her best friend would never allow it. So, why did Kyle try to protect Rogelio? Was it the same… feeling? It was confusing, the more she thought about it, and in the end, she blurted:

"I don't understand – why would Kyle do that for Rogelio?"

Catra lay back against the wall, and even though she looked casual, it was obvious that there was deliberation in her movements. "He has a crush on him, doofus," she said. "He'd do anything to impress him."

Mind whirring slowly, Adora blinked a few times. "A crush?"

"Yeah, you know. A crush." Catra's cheeks reddened again. "He likes him… romantically."

Adora felt her own face darken. “I know what a crush is, Catra.”

“Yeah, well, you didn’t sound so sure there."

So, Kyle protected Rogelio because he liked him. *Liked liked* him. This was news to Adora, and one that felt strangely… welcome? Lately, most of their classmates were talking about crushes and gossiping about who kissed who at parties. She had never taken an interest in the gossip, or given it much thought herself, but she knew that most of the rumours had involved a girl and boy. This was the first time she’d heard of a gay crush.

She sat for a moment and tried to figure out how Kyle *knew* he had a crush on Rogelio. Was there something she was missing? If her fellow classmates were going crazy over crushes, and kissing, and everything in between, why hadn’t she stopped to consider it before now?

Adora leaned against the wall beside Catra, and asked, “Well, how do you know?”

The brunette turned to the side to look at her. “How do I know what?”

“That Kyle has a crush on Rogelio.”

“It’s obvious.”

“It is?”

“Not to you – you’re –” Catra gestured vaguely with her hand, as if that made sense. When Adora recoiled at her sharp tone, the brunette reconsidered. Awkwardly, she expanded, “He gets all flustered when he’s around. He always wants to be with him. His face lights up when he enters a room, okay?” Snapping back to irritation, she added, “Pay more attention.”

Adora was painfully aware of how hot her face was, and the more she thought about it, the more it spread. Her entire body felt on fire. Why? Well, because Catra had described how Adora felt most

of the time she was with her best friend. And there was no way – no possible way – that she had a *crush* on Catra. She just loved being around her, loved being her best friend. That's all there was to it.

Adora shook her head and spluttered, "I thought that was just – yeah, I guess I'm an idiot."

Catra smirked. "You said it, not me."

But there was a pit in Adora's stomach, and it felt like everything inside her was falling in. Trying to sound casual, and to keep the conversation going, she asked gently, "Do you know if anyone else has a crush?"

Raising a single eyebrow, Catra said incredulously, "Yeah."

"Like who?"

As stiff as a rake, Catra spat it out, like it was the most disgusting thing she'd ever heard. "Daniel has a crush on you."

Adora's mouth hung open. "On me?!"

"Yeah." Catra sat forward, watching the blonde carefully.

"Why?!" Adora demanded.

"I don't know!" Laughing at the horror etched on her friend's face, Catra lightly shoved her shoulder. "Ask him yourself. Everyone knows about it."

Adora shoved right back. "Do you?"

"Obviously, dummy, I just told you –"

"No – do you have a crush?"

Catra paused. "Nah."

“Oh.” Adora wasn’t sure if she felt happy or annoyed about that. “Would you tell me if you did?”

Catra narrowed her eyes. “Why would you want to know?”

Adora stuck out her bottom lip. “We tell each other everything else.”

“Well, do *you*?” crossing her arms, Catra mirrored her grumpiness. “Do you have a crush you haven’t told me about?”

Embarrassment flooded over her in a wave. Adora looked away and tried to act natural. Her hands clenched again. “I haven’t really – I haven’t really thought about it before.”

And she meant it – she hadn’t. She didn’t know why, maybe she was just wired differently that everyone else. Maybe she was broken in some way. Whatever the reason, Adora didn’t know how she would *know* if she had a crush. She liked most people in her class, some more than others. Her favourite person was Catra, but that was nothing new. Catra had always been her favourite person. Did she feel the same way about anyone else? No, but that was why *Catra* was her best friend.

Her best friend, who was staring at her with a mixture of fondness and exasperation. “Of course you haven’t.”

“I haven’t!” Adora argued, and then, in a sweetly innocent tone, she asked, “What would it be like, anyway?”

“What do you mean?”

“How do you know if you have a crush?”

It was a simple question, but one she wouldn’t have the guts to ask anyone else. She knew that Catra wouldn’t make fun of her for not knowing what seemed to come naturally to everyone else – Catra made fun of her a lot, but never anything so personal. Instead of scoffing or rolling her eyes, it was the brunette’s turn to look pensive.

Very quietly, Catra answered, “I don’t know – you’d feel all happy inside when you’re around them. Like your stomach is all jittery. People call it butterflies, you know? You’d think about them a lot. You’d always want to talk to them, to be near them. They’d feel like the centre of the universe – what?”

Adora was no longer paying attention. Her cheeks were so red that she tried to shield them with her palm. She met Catra’s curious stare and said, “I’ve felt that before – the butterflies.”

“You have? When?”

Adora couldn’t believe she was saying this. “With – with you, sometimes.”

“With me?” Catra squeaked.

“Yeah, I thought it was just a feeling.” Adora wanted to run and hide somewhere, but her mouth kept going. Oh god, she was never going to live this down. She wanted the ground to swallow her whole – she wanted to ask Catra to forget this conversation altogether. “I thought it was normal.”

The last thing the blonde expected was for Catra to give a loud, gloating cackle. She rolled on her back and laughed endlessly. Tears rolled down her cheeks and she made no attempt to wipe them away. When she sat up again, she pushed Adora over.

“Get out!”

Catra launched herself on top of her friend, pinning her to the bed. Adora tried to flip her off but it was no use. “Hey, stop it!”

“You’re such a sap,” Catra teased, ruffling her hair and pulling it out of the ponytail. She looked so smug, hovering above Adora, with her eyes shining and chest rumbling.

Adora’s mouth felt very dry looking up at her. It was as if there was a string connecting them, holding them here, together. Pulling them in.

“Catra?”

“Yeah?”

“What happens if your crush also likes you?”

“Well, you know. You’ve seen it on tv and stuff.”

Adora frowned. “Like a relationship?”

“Yeah. Kissing and – what’s with that?”

“With what?”

“You’re all red again.”

Enough was enough – Adora needed to get herself under control. She sat up and nudged Catra off so they could sit beside each other.

“You haven’t thought about kissing?” Catra pressed before sighing. “You’re *so* hopeless.”

It wasn’t that Adora hadn’t thought about it – she had. She was curious about it, and it was something she occasionally daydreamed about. It was just that kissing required another participant and the only person Adora could conjure in her mind was Catra.

Hence the blushing.

“Is it weird?” Adora brushed her arm against the brunette's. “That I don’t, you know, think about this stuff as much as everyone else.”

Catra eyes were round, and her lip curled to one side. She leaned into their shared warmth. “No. It doesn’t make you weird. I thought –”

When she cut herself off, Adora’s interest piqued. “What?”

"It doesn't matter."

But a steady tint of pink started to spread across the bridge of Catra's nose and down her cheeks.

Adora felt victorious. "Now you're blushing!"

Catra pushed her away again. "Shut up, dummy."

"Tell me!" Adora urged, grabbing her wrists so she couldn't escape.

"Fine – I thought for ages that the butterfly thing was normal, too. Alright?" she tussled with Adora before winning her hands back. "I only felt it when you were around, so I thought it was some stupid – hey, stop laughing!"

But Adora couldn't stop. "*You like me*," she sang between giggles.

"I do *not* like you!" Catra retorted, throwing a pillow at her for good measure.

"I think you just admitted you did."

"We're never talking about this again."

They tussled for a few moments, each of them testing their strength against the other. When they eventually tired themselves out, they lay side by side on the bed. Catra reached over to the bedside table and flicked off the light, nodding to the alarm clock: it was ten o'clock. Lights out before Weaver told them.

Lying in the dark, in silence, but still completely awake, Adora asked, "So, why did the Kyle and Rogelio thing get you thinking?"

There was a slight tremor to Catra's voice. "I saw them kissing just after school. And I guess – if you laugh one more time I will *hurt* you – I was wondering when I would get to, you know." She shrugged, and murmured, "Have my first kiss."

A first kiss.

Most of their classmates had already had already experienced it and were onto their third, or fourth, or perhaps much more. *Relationships* and such. Adora had never had a crush, and when she thought about kissing, she only thought about kissing Catra. It was a nice thought – one she revisited often.

They could –

Couldn't they? If Kyle and Rogelio could – if everyone else was already gossiping about it –

What was stopping *them* from kissing?

Adora's body felt very hot again and a wave of enthusiastic nerves flooded over her. Yes, the more she thought about it, she absolutely wanted Catra to be her first kiss. The idea terrified her and excited her in equal measure.

Kissing Catra – why couldn't it be a reality? She was sure their other friends had kissed each other; it was completely normal. Wasn't it? It *felt* normal. It felt like experiencing another thing with Catra.

"Do you want to?" she blurted, louder than she meant to say it.

"What?" Catra bolted upright, and even though it was hard to see in the dark, Adora could make out her shock. "Me and you?"

Adora sat up, too. She crossed her legs and squinted, hushing her voice so Weaver couldn't hear them. "I mean – I think – it would get it out of the way, right?"

Catra was quiet for a few long seconds. Then she said, breathless, "Yeah, it would."

"And it would be good practise."

"I agree."

“We’ve always been – you know. Together.”

Catra inched closer. “We have.”

“And I’m sure best friends kiss all the time, right?” Adora encouraged, also inching forward.

“Definitely.”

She could feel Catra’s breath on her face. “It wouldn’t be weird.”

They were so close.

As Catra’s lips hovered over her own, the blonde heard her say, “Adora, stop talking now,” as she closed the space between them.

The first thought Adora had was how *soft* it felt. Their lips moulded together like putty, muted and tender, like they were afraid to hurt one another. She could taste Catra’s breath as they found a rhythm and oh – it was nice. The feeling. It made her feel warm and safe, and her stomach danced around with those aforementioned butterflies. And then – oh, Catra opened her mouth and suddenly their tongues collided – and Adora took a large inhale through her nose.

It was like someone zapped them with an electricity, and they both pulled away at the same time, mirroring each other’s surprise. “Wow,” Adora said out loud.

“Don’t ruin it,” the brunette responded. An easy, embarrassed laugh echoed from Catra’s chest and Adora heard herself laugh too. They lay down together, staring at the ceiling, listening to each other’s giggles.

So that’s why everyone is obsessed with kissing, Adora thought.

Present day

Adora drove them to the Amaris family home early on Christmas morning. Catra dozed in the passenger seat, head lolling against the window. She was not a morning person – not since leaving the army, anyhow – but there was a small, sleepy and resentful part of her that enjoyed the thrill of spending Christmas with a *family*.

Glimmer's parents lived on the edge of the Brightmoon district, which was roughly two hours away from Adora's house in Thaymor. By the time they got there at eight o'clock, Catra had managed to waken herself up. She leaned over to press a soft kiss against Adora's jaw and stretched her stiff limbs against the seatbelt.

"Wow," she said, peering out the windscreen with bleary eyes. "I *knew* Sparkles was rich."

Adora pulled a face as she parked up. "Yeah, apparently the Amaris' are related to royalty, or something. Glimmer doesn't like talking about it much."

Rich, really, was an understatement, judging by the scale of the manor in front of them. It almost looked like a castle, with its spires and pale brick exterior. Catra automatically felt her shoulders contract at the thought of Glimmer's parents, and what they must be like. It wasn't that she *resented* people having money – as someone who came from nothing, and had been dirt poor for the first decade and a half of her life, she was judgemental of those with affluence who had no idea how the other side of society lived. In her experience, those with status and fortune tended to neglect those who didn't, and as an orphan, both disadvantaged due to her skin colour and ropey childhood, she had encountered prejudice from people on every step of the social ladder. However, people at the top of the rich list were always the most insincere.

If her experience in the army was anything to go by, people with the most power and status were the most callous.

It was often said those that sought out power and fortune were the ones who weren't fit to wield them. Catra had yet to see that proven wrong.

So, yes, she was apprehensive about meeting Glimmer's parents. It almost felt like she was being introduced to a girlfriend's family for the first time.

Judging by how Glimmer talking about how much her mum and dad loved Adora, it might as well have been.

Glimmer and Bow were waiting for them at the entrance hall with their arms linked around one another. If her hand hadn't been in Adora's, Catra would've scowled at their public display of couple-y cuteness. When Glimmer gave a brief tour of the house, Adora's eyes were glued to her, watching for each and every reaction. She looked like a kid waiting for approval, and Catra was reluctant in giving much away.

They stopped in front of the lounge. Glimmer looked very serious. Her smile faltered and she glanced from Adora and Bow. "Catra, there's something you need to know about my mother."

Catra, frowning, let go of Adora's hand and crossed her arms. "What is it?"

Glimmer took a deep breath. "She's sick, and she doesn't like people bringing it up. So, please, don't mention anything. And don't stare."

Catra blinked a few times. "Of course. Sorry, no, yeah. Uh – I understand."

In truth, she didn't understand. Parents were a concept she had trouble understanding – but sick parents? Catra mentally shook herself. She found it difficult to conceptualise how it would feel for your primary caregiver to need… well, care. She felt guilty, as she always did when she had a gap of knowledge over something so universally understood. As she glanced to the floor, she sensed Adora's fingers trail up her arm to rest on her shoulder.

It was okay. Adora was here. It was all okay.

The lounge had a giant Christmas tree, decorated with gentle pinks and lilacs, at its centre. The whole room had a pastel theme, from the ornaments to the furnishings, making it seem a lot cosier than Catra had been expecting.

Glimmer's parents were sitting on a sofa together. Her dad – a short man with long black hair and a moustache – stood up to greet them, and extended a hand out to the newcomer.

"This is Catra, Adora's girlfriend," Glimmer told them, sounding slightly smug.

"Micah," he said in response. Catra shook his hand, all the while furiously blushing at being called Adora's *girlfriend*. She wasn't sure what they were, exactly – or what they had ever been to each other. They hadn't talking about anything regarding their relationship, or lack thereof. Admitting feelings for one another was already a step further than either of them had expected. After Micah had shook Catra's hand, he turned to gesture to his wife. "And Angella. Welcome, Catra. We're happy to have you."

Catra gave an awkward half-nod to Angella, who was sitting on the sofa and smiling softly. She had very kind – if not tired – eyes, the brunette noticed. And she had absolutely no idea how to behave in front of a *family* at *Christmas*.

"Thanks for the invite," she said, hoping to ease some of the tension in her chest. "Adora has a lot of nice things to say about you."

"Adora is a like a daughter to me," Angella said. "And Bow is like a son. They've both made my Glimmer very happy, which, in turn, has made me happy." Her smile brightened. "But I've heard a lot about you, Catra."

Swallowing, she squeaked, "You have?"

Adora pulled on Catra's arm, breathing out a forced laugh. "Yeah, you know. I might have mentioned you. Once or twice."

"Many times, in fact," Micah teased.

Catra, with a glint in her eye, smirked at her apparent *girlfriend*. "Many times, eh?"

And oh, she *loved* seeing Adora squirm. "Presents! When are we doing presents this year?" the blonde blurted, looking for help from each person in the room.

Christmas at the Amaris' was a quiet affair. They purposefully disregarded the religious symbolism in the holiday, and instead focused on making it a celebration of winter. They went for a walk around the gardens after they prepped dinner, and came back to find Casta, Glimmer's aunt, waiting for them in the kitchen. She had knitted everyone a jumper – even Catra (it had a cat's face on it) – and made herself useful by correcting recipes in Micah's handwritten notes.

In the afternoon, Angella went upstairs for a nap (but Catra suspected it was mostly to get away from Casta for a little while) and Micah and Casta stayed in the kitchen to finish dinner. Glimmer, Bow, Catra and Adora talked in the living room and helped set the table.

Their dinner could've been a banquet, for the size and scale of it. Catra had never seen so much food in one place. While she was eating a good helping of stuffing, Catra felt a wave of longing wash over her as she looked up at the table. Some people had a family and family events; some people experienced this all the time. This was what it felt like to be supported, to be loved. She looked across the table at Adora, who was already staring at her; she'd spilt a little bit of gravy on her red jumper, and her face was rosy with the warmth of the house. It was nice. Happiness suited her.

After dinner, it was time for presents – which, apparently, required most of the table to go and prepare for. When Catra asked if she could help, three people, including Adora, stopped her from getting up from the table. Casta cleared the dishes, leaving Catra alone in the dining room with Angella.

Since she had returned from her nap, Angella looked exhausted. There were purple shadows under her eyes and a frailness to how her arms wrapped around herself. Catra had noticed that Glimmer's mother had used a wheelchair during their walk around the gardens, but aside from that, there were no other indications that she was sick.

They sat in silence, and the familiar creeping sensation of awkwardness filled the void of conversation. Catra looked across the table and smiled; Angella was already looking at her, with gentle observing eyes.

"This must be strange for you," she said after a moment.

"Ah, yeah." Catra scratched the back of her neck. She couldn't say 'I dreaded coming here' without it sounding offensive. "I've had fun – don't take it the wrong way, but I'm not used to family dynamics."

Angella smiled fondly. "Adora was the same when I first met her."

And there was that expression again – sad and nostalgic whenever Angella mentioned Adora. Curiosity twisted inside Catra's very full stomach. To continue the conversation, she replied, "I hope you don't mind me asking, but why did you take Adora in?"

"What has she told you?"

"Not much." In fact, nothing. They had barely talked about what happened during their five years of separation. "Just that you helped her out after she left the army."

Angella hummed. “There’s a lot you need to catch up on, I see. Well, yes, I knew *of* Adora. Her bravery was the leading story for many months after the end of the war.” She indicated with her hand. “But that wasn’t the reason why I ‘took her in’, as you said.”

“What was the reason, then?”

“She reminded me of my husband.” Angella sighed and glanced to her lap. “He fought in the war too, in the beginning. He went missing in action not long after Glimmer was born. I noticed many similarities between the two: they both grew up in unstable environments, they joined the army young. They were *used* by the army when they were young.” Her lips turned into a tight line. “And they paid a large price for their service. I wanted to help her. Micah wanted to help her.”

This was news to Catra, but now it made sense to her why Brightmoon encouraged applications for teachers with a military history. It must’ve been a policy Angella included as part of her role on the Board. But another detail stood out to her.

“You said Micah went missing in action?”

“Yes. For a few years I thought he was dead. As it happened, he had gotten injured during a battle and woke up with amnesia in the enemy camp. For a few years he was a prisoner of war until the Etherian army brokered a deal with the Horde for his release. They offered him no compensation or support.” She gave a nod in the brunette’s direction. “I’m sure they offered you little as well, Catra.”

“Education and training. Mental health support.” And when she said those things, she meant they offered the bare minimum of each. “But no, they only offered me those things because of who I was – what I did. My friend, Scorpia, didn’t get anything when she left.”

Angella shook her head in sympathy. “Well, when the time comes for Adora to –”

But she was interrupted by the slamming of the kitchen doors being flung open by Adora, looking slightly ruffled, her cheeks pink with cold. Just behind her, Glimmer and Bow stood with face-wide grins.

"It's ready!" Adora shouted, breathless, her eyes shining.

Catra looked from Adora to Angella. "What's ready?"

"Your present!" Adora said.

"Why would you – what have you done?" Catra got up, slowly, as alarm bells rang in her head. The blonde quickly hurried over and grabbed her hand, pulling her towards the doors.

"Don't get mad."

"The fact that you're asking me to not get mad is making me mad."

"Come outside."

"*Adora*."

She allowed herself to be led, but only because she didn't want to cause a fuss at the family's house. The cold hit her like a punch in the face after spending so much time in the warmth, and she shivered against the onslaught. Adora looped her arms around Catra's waist, and as they turned the corner towards the driveway, Catra saw it.

Micah was supporting a black and red motorbike with a ribbon on the seat.

Catra pulled out of Adora's hold, and shouted, "You bought me a bike?!"

She wasn't sure how to react.

She was angry – *livid* – because of Adora's generosity – because of how Adora still knew *exactly* what she wanted. She was annoyed at *herself* for thinking she could ever win a gift competition when Adora never really wanted material things, or had interests in gift-worthy hobbies. She was embarrassed at everyone staring, and she was – fuck it, okay, *yes*, she was over-fucking-joyed that Adora had bought her a goddamn motorcycle.

Who wouldn't be?!

"It's second-hand!" Adora defended, probably sensing that Catra's first reaction would be anger. "And quite old, but it runs well – according to the guy who sold it to me. You might need to modify it slightly, which shouldn't be an issue – you loved engineering in the army. But, well, I always wanted to buy you one because I knew you always wanted one." She turned away slightly, looking sheepish. "And then I saw your car at work, and I thought –"

Catra wasn't listening. She had bought Adora books and a pair of special edition boots by her favourite brand. They might show that she knows her, but they didn't compare to a motorcycle. And she knew – Catra knew that her ex-best friend-slash-girlfriend would go inside and open her present and act like Catra had bought her something worth a million dollars because she was Adora, and she was stupid, and Catra *hated* how much she loved her –

So, Catra swept forward in one graceful motion, rested one hand on Adora's waist and the other on the swell of her neck, and pulled her in for a kiss. There was so much she tried to say with that kiss, but she knew there was so much that it *couldn't* say. It couldn't say that she was scared of the future; it couldn't say that she knew there was a wedge of something still between them, and that she assumed it was whatever Adora had tried – twice now – to tell her.

If they could freeze this moment – if they could stay like this, here, forever – well… that would be nice.

Chapter End Notes

This one got away with me. But hey - we need the fluff, right? Next chapter is... intense. You know that explosion that's been simmering for a while? It's a-coming.

Once again, I looove reading your comments and receiving kudos! They keep me motivated and focused, and they never fail to make me smile, so thank you.

Two scenes in this chapter were inspired by fan-theories: the first one is the quote 'stay up all night whispering about... stuff' from the canon show, and the second is the overwhelming amount of fanfic out there that features Catra with a motorbike. Yes, I see you. We love morally dubious characters with leather jackets, no helmets and a motorcycle. It's a trope that needs to stay and I'm willing to continue it.

Until next time, stay safe,

Cx.

Headshot

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Twenty-two years old

The army drops Adora off where they found her: Glimmer's house.

She's ushered inside by Glimmer and Bow, but she's too out of focus to listen or respond to their concerns and questions. She's finding it hard to concentrate, like the world is out of tune with her body. She hears the words, but they don't mean anything to her. She can feel their soft touches, their concerned stares, but they're foreign and numb.

No, they aren't numb. She is.

Too much has happened in such a short space of time, and Adora is disassociating again. Her mind wants to switch off, to reset, to make it right through numbing and drowning her emotions and reactions. It would be easier if she just wiped what happened from her memory; it would be easier to build a wall around the things she didn't like, the facts she didn't want to face, so she could deal with the here and now – the reality that kept hurting her.

Adora sleepwalked into Angella's office after she shooed away Bow and Glimmer, telling them that Adora needed space; Adora needed security. Their questions weren't helping, and their concern was overwhelming. Angella sat Adora down in a chair and locked the door. She offered her water and dry biscuits, and then they simply sat in silence.

When some time had passed, Angella finally said, "When you want to talk, you can talk to me. Any time of day, any time of night – there is no rush. I'm here. We're all here for you, Adora."

To her own surprise, Adora heard herself reply, “They made me a deal.”

It burst out of her, like a wart breaking the skin. It was ugly, it was true, and it ached in her chest. Angella had done so much to help Adora, and for what? There was nothing she could do now that Adora had signed her life away.

Angella’s eyes were round with curiosity. “Were you coerced into signing?”

“Yes.”

“And what was this… deal?”

How much to tell her? There was so much they still didn’t know. Adora had told them about the Heart of Etheria mission and what had happened afterwards. However, she hadn’t told them about the failsafe or She-Ra. In her accounts, she described the failsafe as she had to Catra; it was an item she carried.

She hadn’t told anyone that it was an item she carried *inside* of herself.

“I’ll go back, when they need me,” Adora said, her tone without inflections. “They’ll let me go now if I re-enlist at some point in the future to make up for the lost years on my contract.”

“Hmm.” Angella tapped a pen against her desk. “A tough agreement to fight in court. But I must ask, why are they so insistent that *you* re-enlist? What is it about you, Adora, that they want? That they can’t get from someone else? Any other soldier would simply be put in prison – it’s happened before. So, why are you the exception?”

Why are you the exception?

Adora felt those words burn behind her eyes. Her tongue felt fat in her mouth, and all she could do was give a one-sided shrug.

Angella hummed again. She rose from her chair and placed a hand on the blonde's back, Carefully, she said, "I will do everything in my power to help you, but you have to understand that I can only help you if you are honest." When Adora looked away, Angella patted her shoulder. "At least this agreement has given us more time to deliberate how to fight it. You will have your freedom, Adora. If it's the last thing I do."

It was only a week after Adora was arrested that Angella took sick.

Glimmer's mother, who was so full of life, opportunity and responsibility, had to let go of most of her causes. Her health had to come first, and so, she stepped away from most of her jobs to spend more time with her family, healing.

As the weeks dragged into months and Angella's condition didn't improve, Adora's coerced agreement was, rightfully, forgotten. Angella's health was the constant priority, and Adora didn't dare remind anyone of the looming bell toll that counted down her days of freedom.

This was her cross to bear, and the Angella's family had already given Adora too much. All she could give them in return was support, and no voluntary mention of her future.

When the time came to fight it, she would have to do it alone.

Present day

Adora and Catra stayed over at the Amaris' mansion and left at the same time as Bow and Glimmer the next day. Adora drove them home, and Catra made arrangements with Micah to collect the motorbike in a few days' time – when she figured out where to actually put it. Adora dropped Catra off at her flat, and for that Catra seemed grateful; she knew that the brunette needed time to decompress after solid hours of socialisation, and the Christmas dinner probably took a lot out of her. Adora, herself, felt like she

needed to catch up on sleep and have time alone to gather her thoughts.

Dinner at Glimmer's had gone better than she expected, and she was overwhelmed at Catra's reception to her present. Adora's body was stiff and achy, exhausted by the busy few days. But there was a darkness to everything; a shadow lingering underneath the brightness, and it was dulling Adora's mood.

This is all temporary, her mind reminded her, unbidden. The feeling of happiness, of contentment, of having Catra to hold as her own – it was all going to snatched from her because of a contract she was forced to sign five years ago.

It wasn't fair, but these things rarely were. As much as she tried to enjoy what she had now, it was impossible to ignore that she was already missing them before they were gone.

It would've been kinder to stay alone, as much as it pained her to think it.

Her sulking was forgotten altogether when Catra texted her a few hours later asking if she could come over.

When the brunette showed up in a fresh pair of clothes and a cheeky smile on her face, Adora simply raised a brow and smirked at her. "Back for more already?"

"That look you're giving me is promising things I don't think you can keep, princess," Catra purred, shutting the front door behind them.

Adora's hands landed on Catra's hips, pulling her in by the loops on her jeans. "Why don't you try me and see."

The glint of mischievousness in Catra's eyes made Adora shiver before she closed the gap between them. Their lips found each other, fierce in their command for dominance. Adora gently pushed her against the wall of the hallway as their tongues

pressed together, and she trailed a hand down the brunette's back, along her spine, feeling out the territory.

They separated for a moment, and Catra let out a tiny hum of disappointment. Adora felt the sound light something within her; she felt hot and restless, and it wasn't long before she was kissing Catra again, this time as if her life depended on it.

Catra clung to her, and the feeling of her lithe body next to Adora's was wonderful. She could feel the swell of her breast against her own, the plane of her stomach rocking against her hips. Adora felt the foreign feeling of *want*; it was something she had always struggled with in past relationships, since she found it hard to decipher what physical attraction actually was – it was a feeling that only came, in her experience, with love and trust and *knowing*someone. To want them physically, she had to want them emotionally. That took time.

But this was *Catra*. She'd be embarrassed to admit that Catra was her sexual awakening; she had never known how it felt to want someone before she figured out that's what she felt when she was close to her best friend. Feeling Catra's body against her own, feeling her hands on her body, kissing her with passion and intent – it felt *right*.

It felt like she wanted more.

Catra pulled away unexpectedly. Her cheeks were pink and her eyes half-lidded. She looked gorgeous with her hair ruffled and the blush seeping down her neck. She was something to admire and behold, hold tight and cherish. Adora tried to chase her lips again, but the brunette shook her head.

"I can't," she said.

Adora's stomach twisted. "Did I do something?"

Catra sighed with a hint of a whine. "No – it's me. I don't want to push you. But if we keep kissing like that, I" – her cheeks

darkened, and she looked down – "I just don't want to push you too far."

Oh. Adora cleared her throat. "I don't – I think" – she grabbed Catra's hand and met her eyes, sincere – "I want to. If you want to."

Catra blinked a few times. "You're… ready?"

"It's you. I've wanted you for forever, long before I knew what it meant." Adora smiled. "But I also don't mind waiting."

Catra's surprise quickly turned into another teasing smirk. "I don't think I properly thanked you for that Christmas present."

Adora's heart was beating so hard that she could feel it in her throat and in her head. When Catra placed her hands on her waist and pulled her in for another kiss, she thought her mind had short-circuited altogether. They only stopped to go upstairs to Adora's bedroom. They sat on the bed, a little sheepishly, until Adora leaned in to kiss the brunette again. She fell short when she noticed Catra's wide-eyed stare, eyes dancing with both irritation and amusement.

"What is it?" Adora murmured.

"It's weird," Catra replied, sitting back to get a good look at her. "Thinking about you doing this with someone else."

"Really?" Adora quirked an eyebrow. "You want to have that conversation… now?"

"I guarantee mine is more embarrassing than yours."

"Alright." Adora nodded. "Challenge accepted."

Catra twirled her hand. "After you."

Okay. A change of pace, then. Adora could keep up with that. She fumbled with herself a few moments as she tried to figure out

where to begin. “I’ve had a few short-term relationships, nothing massive. When I first started dating, I struggled to – you know. Keep up.”

“I don’t know,” Catra clarified innocently.

Adora glared at her. “I struggled to enjoy sex, is that explicit enough for you?” When the brunette tilted her head in a silent question, Adora went on, “I was having sex because I knew it was expected from a relationship. I did enjoy it sometimes, but most of the time I didn’t want it for myself, I wanted it because my partner wanted it. And I couldn’t make sense of it – I thought I liked my partners. So, why did I want to have sex with them? I thought I was screwed up in some way.” Adora glanced down at her hands. “I talked to Glimmer and Bow about it, and they told me it was normal. They told me everyone experiences sexual attraction differently, and there was no ‘right way’ about it. Perfuma was my therapist for a while, and she was the one that figured out I only wanted sex when there was a strong emotional connection already there, and since I didn’t have that with any of my previous partners, that’s why I never wanted it.”

Catra nodded thoughtfully. “That explains a lot.”

Adora nodded with her. “I had one relationship after that with a girl called Starla. We dated for around a year, and I knew how to approach it that time. In fact, Starla understood and felt similarly, so we navigated it together.”

Shuffling a little closer, Catra leaned her chin on the blonde’s shoulder. “Thank you for explaining that to me. But I do have a very important follow up question.”

“What?”

“Have you slept with anyone we know?”

Adora gasped and playfully shoved her away, shouting, scandalised, “*Catra*!”

Who raised her hands in a surrender. “Hey – I’m just asking! You’re very attractive, if you haven’t noticed, and you work in a school with people who noticeably find you attractive –”

“That is not true!”

“It is *so* true – I’ve seen the way Mermista checks you out. And then there’s *Huntara* –”

At the mention of her name, Adora completely crumbled. She buried her face in her hands and fell to the side, groaning. Catra burst into a shocked gasp and chased after her, pinning her down with her legs around the blonde’s waist. “I knew it! I knew something had happened with you and Huntara!”

Adora made no attempt to struggle. “It was a disaster, and you’ll have to pry the details from someone else because I’m never mentioning it again.”

“You have to give me *something* –”

Smiling wickedly, Adora said, “Never.” Then she managed to sit up in one swift motion, keeping Catra balanced over her lap. She grazed her lips against the collar of her throat, and in between kisses, said, “You need to tell me about your experiences now. You’re not getting away with not telling.”

“Hm.” Catra put her hand under Adora’s chin to draw her back up to eye level. “I’ve had no significant relationships, just flings that have lasted a grand total of one night to a couple of weeks.” Glancing down, her fingers absent-mindedly ran across the scar on Adora’s left cheek. “During my worst, I used to bring girls home and fuck them, imaging they were you. How’s that for a confession?”

“Hate sex?”

“It wasn’t pretty,” Catra said, scrunching her nose. “I regret bringing this up now.”

Stroking the brunette's back, Adora murmured, "Let me help you take your mind off it."

Catra rolled her eyes but leaned in all the same. "Your *lines* are the worst."

When they kissed again, there was an instant *zing* in Adora's body. With Catra straddling her, she felt instant heat wherever their bodies touched. She just couldn't get over how beautiful she was – and the fact she was here, with *her*, and kissing her back with the same intensity, the same longing. It made her feel dizzy – it made her feel giddy. Her hair was silky soft through her fingers, and her skin was smooth and warm, and all Adora wanted was more – all of Catra, in her beauty, in her grace, reacting with little sounds to gentle touches and careful kisses.

Catra, of course, was the first one to get handsy. As Adora's lips moved to the brunette's neck, kissing down to her collarbone, Catra used her leverage over the blonde to push her back onto the bed. Soaking up the attention Adora gave her neck, Catra pushed her hands underneath Adora's loose cotton vest, and lightly trailed her fingertips across the planes of her stomach. It was such a soft touch that Adora shivered and found herself opening more of her body to the touch. She allowed Catra to lift off the vest, but she was never one to be outdone, and before Catra's mouth found her skin again, Adora sat up, recapturing the brunette's lips.

As their tongues clashed in an open-mouthed kiss, Adora palmed Catra's left breast, pinching in *just* the right place. Huffing, Catra bit down on the pressure point above Adora's clavicle, and she arched into the twinge of pain, unable to withhold a small moan. Adora's hands moved to Catra's hips, and she squeezed. When she made to remove Catra's shirt, the brunette slapped her hands away.

Adora caught Catra's eyes, alight with a heat she knew she mirrored.

“Lie down for me,” Catra whispered, pulling Adora’s bottom lip through her teeth.

“Hmm.” Adora used her weight to push herself on top. She left perfectly placed kisses behind Catra’s ear, on the base of her neck, in the valley of her breasts, until she popped one button out of her shirt at a time, getting lower and lower. “I don’t think I will. I’m not done yet.”

When she reached the last button, just above her bellybutton, Catra ran her long fingernails across Adora’s scalp and coaxed her lips back to her own. Then, she took Adora’s wrists in one of her hands, and turning them over very slowly, she tugged on the waistband of the blonde’s joggers.

“I’d be happy to argue,” she said, snaking her hand lower and lower, keeping Adora’s wrists above her head, “but I have better things to do right now.”

Twenty-three years old

It was almost a routine at this point.

Every weekend, Catra would go out with a group of colleagues from the army. They would start in a bar and end up in a club or two. Catra would drink the same drinks – rum or vodka, sometimes straight and sometimes with mixer – and she would chase after the same girls. She would let them take her home, sleep with them, and then leave immediately. After she stumbled home in the early hours of the morning, Scorpia would stay up and wait for her, ensuring she made it to bed – or, usually, the bathroom, where she would throw up her stomach contents for the remainder of the morning.

It wasn’t fun, and she didn’t look forward to it. This wasn’t a hobby or an interest; it was a coping mechanism.

Alcohol blended the rough edges of the world; it made her mind foggy and her body spin with energy. She was an essence of

herself when intoxicated – she didn't need to think or decide or worry about anything. She could simply *be*.

The wordless music thumped straight through Catra's body, feeling like a second heartbeat. The flashing coloured lights made her sway and blink against the throbbing bodies in the club, and with her sight, smell and hearing overwhelmed, it sent her into a blissful oblivion. She moved in time with the music, and her mind pushed along like a stopping train, only registering what she needed to understand. Whenever her mind wandered, even just for a moment, she would beat it into submission by knocking back another drink.

She rarely blacked out from the alcohol consumption anymore. It was both a blessing and a curse.

A familiar face came into view; white-blonde hair and kind brown eyes. She said something in Catra's ear, but it was impossible to hear anything over the drumming bass. Catra allowed herself to be led to the sitting area, where a burst of cold night air hit her in the face, causing her to immediately shiver.

Scorpia sat facing her, a frown on her face. "How are you feeling, Wildcat?"

Catra heard herself snort; a sharp, unpleasant sound. "What kind of a question is that?" she slurred.

Scorpia leaned in closer. "You don't look well tonight. I thought I'd check in."

Rolling her eyes, Catra pushed herself up, managing to keep her swaying to a minimum. "Whatever. This was a…" as her stomach coiled, she took a moment to breathe in and out again. "…waste of my time."

She left Scorpia sitting there, and despite her drunkenly state, Catra knew that her friend looked upset. Honestly, she didn't know why Scorpia stuck around – Catra wasn't a good friend, and she didn't try to be. In fact, she actively treated people like shit so

they wouldn't rely on her, so they wouldn't get too close. She didn't *want* or *need* friendship – she didn't want or need a relationship.

Catra was just fine by herself.

When she re-entered the club, her eyes immediately landed on a girl – a girl she knew extremely well.

A girl she hadn't seen in two years.

She recognised her straight away, even though her eyes were blurry and her mind slow. Her hair was tied back in its signature ponytail, and her body moved in perfect time with the rhythm of the song. Her hands were in the air as she swept her ponytail away from her face. Catra caught the side of her face – a flash of blue eyes before she turned away again.

Abandoning all self-restraint, Catra marched through the crowd. They parted around her like the Red Sea, as if they knew there was a magnet drawing her in, a compass pointing her North, to the girl who had ruined her life.

Catra reached out and pulled Adora around by rough grip on her forearm –

Only to see that it wasn't Adora at all.

Her face was too pointy, her lips too thin, and her eyes weren't blue at all. It must've been a trick of the light – a moment of absent-minded longing.

"What the fuck," the not-Adora said, snatching her arm back. "Who the hell are you?"

Catra's mouth snapped shut. Her shock zapped into defensive anger. "Calm down, will you? I thought you were someone else."

But something had changed within her; something didn't feel right. As she turned away, aware of the awkward glances thrown

her way, a deep pit opened up in her stomach. Why? Well, because, for a brief moment Catra had thought she'd seen *her* – and for that brief moment she had felt something akin to *relief*.

And now regret was crashing down around her.

Catra stumbled to the toilets and was sick in the bathroom stall. When she emerged, Scorpia was there, waiting for her.

"I think you're right," Catra told her friend. "I think I have a problem."

Present day

Catra woke up to the feeling of warmth and security.

And the overwhelming scent of *Adora*.

She flipped on her stomach and stretched out, feeling for a warm lump under the covers. It was pathetic, really, how she was unable to control the smile plastered on her face, or the pleasurable ache left over from their activities. When her hands ghosted across the edge of the bed without finding what she was looking for, Catra opened her eyes and turned to the side.

Where was Adora?

Sitting up, she scanned the bedroom. The alarm clock on the bedside table told her it was three o'clock in the morning. The witching hour. What would Adora be doing at this time?

Sensing something was wrong, Catra hastily pulled on a pair of shorts and a hoodie that were sitting on top of Adora's fresh laundry pile. She tiptoed out of the bedroom and down the hall, quietly calling, "Adora?"

No reply. So, slightly louder, she repeated, "Adora?"

There was nothing but more silence, and then a very low, “In here.”

The bathroom, by the sounds of it. Catra stopped a hair’s breadth away from the door. “Can I come in?”

A pained, “Yeah.”

Catra’s stomach swirled at the sound of it. She slowly pushed her way in.

Adora was sitting on the edge of the bathtub with her head in between her legs. She was wearing a loose dressing gown that was falling down her shoulders. One hand was clutching her side, the space just above her hip, and the other was held against her forehead. When she looked up at Catra, it was clear from her red-rimmed eyes that she had been crying.

Catra immediately dropped to her knees in front of her. “Hey, what’s wrong? Panic attack or chronic pain?”

A flicker of shame crossed the blonde’s pinched face. She held out a hand, palm up. “Bit of both. Stay, please.”

Squeezing her hand, Catra sat on the bath beside her and loosely wrapped an arm over her back. “I’ve got you,” she whispered. “I’m here.”

Catra wasn’t sure how long they stayed like that; all she knew was that her bum was starting to hurt from pressing into the smooth edge of the bath, and her legs had pins and needles. She didn’t dare move, though. As long as Adora needed her, she would stay there, rooted to the spot. If it helped, it was worth it.

Adora’s breathing slowed as she began to come around. Her blue eyes darted to the side, sharing a small smile with the brunette. “Sorry,” she whispered, her words almost slurred. “The pain in my hip started to flare up not long after you fell asleep. I tried not to wake you. You looked so peaceful.”

Catra grinned, despite feeling like the worst person in the world. Perhaps they had gotten carried away – she hadn't given Adora's injury much thought. She should've been more careful, she should've remembered Adora's pain. "You never need to apologise. Is there anything I can get you? Do you take anything for it?"

"Yeah, uh" – Adora frowned as she tried to think – "the pain meds are in my top drawer."

Already getting to her feet, Catra nodded. "On it."

She quickly padded back to the bedroom and took a moment to sit on the bed and take a few deep breaths. Adora had scared her – and it hadn't been her fault, of course it hadn't, but the adrenaline was still pumping through her veins, making her fingers twitch and her knees shake. There was something unnerving about seeing Adora like this; vulnerable and pained, held back by her own mind and body. All the times she had helped Catra during their teenage years, when Catra was experiencing abuse at the hands of Weaver – they flashed in her mind's eye. Adora used to hold her until the tears subsided. She used to steal her food so she wouldn't go to bed hungry. She would offer a hand whenever she sensed Catra getting anxious or upset. It was always *Adora* helping *Catra*.

For many, many years Catra had resented her for it. She hated how Adora insisted that she could help, long after they'd left the clutches of Weaver. She was her own person, and she could stand by herself, whole and complete – not the same little girl from the foster home.

But now… Adora needed help. It felt wrong, as if the universe had gotten it twisted. In Catra's mind, Adora was invincible.

And did Catra really have the ability to be caring and supportive, like Adora had been for her? She wasn't sure. It was troubling.

Lost in her own thoughts, Catra roughly pulled open the drawer of the bedside table and rummaged around for a container of pills. She saw a flash of orange plastic as she flipped a letter out of the way –

And that was when she saw it.

The familiar insignia of the Etherian Special Forces.

Catra was not a nosy person. She didn't want other people sticking their nose into her business, and she couldn't care less the secrets and lies other people kept in their closets. But here she was, lifting a letter addressed to Adora in December of this year, with the subject title: *Re-enlisting*.

It was a shot to the head.

The bedroom fell away. All that kept Catra rooted to reality was the white paper and black ink of the letter she had clutched in her hand.

She didn't read it. She didn't need to.

Everything she needed to know was in that one word: *Re-enlisting*.

Catra's throat felt like sandpaper as heaving breaths caught in her chest. Slowly, the world around her started to fall back in place, only it was darker, more grotesque. Her skin crawled, like something was trying to break free from inside. With her head spinning, she grasped the letter in her hand, in a fist, and marched towards the bathroom.

"Adora?" a voice called – *her* voice, coming, unwillingly from her croaky throat.

The blonde was exactly where she left her, and she looked up with blue eyes brimming and a fond smile on her pinched face.

Then she saw the letter Catra held in the air.

And she inhaled the smile, exhaled a wobbly frown. “Catra –”

“What’s this?” A ragged breath in, a ragged breath out. “Why do you have a letter from the army about re-enlisting?”

“I – fuck.” Adora’s hand shielded her eyes. She scrunched them shut and rubbed her forehead. “You weren’t supposed to see that.”

The knot in Catra’s stomach twisted tighter. And tighter. Her vision narrowed to one spot, and it was the space just above the cupid's bow on Adora's top lip. “Is this some kind of joke? You’re not –” she swallowed a laugh; she’d left most of herself back in the bedroom, and now her body felt heavy and large. Her mind hadn’t caught up yet – it was trying to make up its own excuses, its own reasoning. “Tell me you’re not.”

As the seconds ticked by, one after the other, Catra found herself begging. “Adora? You’re not.”

On shaky legs, Adora used the sink to help her stand. “Catra, listen, I can explain.”

But Catra backed away. Gripping the letter so tightly that her knuckles turned white, she asked, slightly detached, “Is this what you’ve wanted to talk to me about? That you’re re-joining the army?” She shook her head – it didn’t make sense. None of this made sense. “No, this has to be a mistake – I know you. You *wouldn’t*.”

And then Adora said words that made Catra’s world cleave in two.

“I am. I have to.”

Catra’s eyes never left Adora’s face. They were frozen in the moment, staring at each other across the small bathroom. Adora’s hands were clutching the dressing gown, wrapping it around her body, where her neck was still red from Catra’s kisses. Her blue eyes were round and teary, and her lips were pulled back in a grimace.

Catra could only imagine that she looked the same.

"How could you?" she croaked, and her throat bobbed with the weight of the lump forming there.

"I'm sorry," Adora said simply.

Resigned.

She was resigned. *This* was what she had chosen – this was her decision. Catra hadn't been included in it, and she had been cut out of the process. Adora was choosing the army again; Adora was choosing duty and glory and loyalty.

But the loyalty was never to *her*.

"Fuck. *Fuck*." Catra's whole body was simmering, and as the air in her lungs scorched her chest, she turned away, doing her best to keep her mind from clouding with the fury that was rising within her. "I can't believe – you're more of an idiot than I thought. I can't even look at you right now."

"Catra, please, I –"

Adora reached for her, and as the blonde's fingers made contact with her skin, the knot in Catra's stomach stretched so tight that it snapped in half.

"Get off me," she hissed, rounding on her. The beast was out of the cage; the years of therapy, the years of self-restraint and control had vanished. Catra let it out, she let it all out; the *anger*, the *fury*, the *spite* that she had spent so long carefully suppressing, so long trying to control. "Do you have no respect for yourself – after what they put us through? After what they put *you* through?" Each word hit like a dagger, and once they were out, they were impossible to put back in. She glanced at Adora, at her shaking hands and her doleful eyes. "Look at you, you won't survive *two seconds* back in the Special Forces. I thought you were better than this. I thought we were –"

I thought were something. I thought we were becoming so much more.

"I tried telling you," Adora argued, "I warned you –"

Catra laughed; properly this time. It was cruel and hard. "And I guess I'm the fucking idiot for thinking people could change. I keep crawling back to you, and you keep breaking my heart worse than the last time!" She shoved the crumpled letter into the blonde's hands. Her entire body was shaking; she was a volcano ready to erupt. Or break down. "Never again though," she swore, "I'll never trust you again for as long as I live, I promise you that."

Adora followed her as she walked into the bedroom. Despite having her back to her, Catra could hear the pain in her voice. "I didn't want you to get caught up in this, Catra. This is the last thing I wanted. I didn't want us to end this way, I wanted –"

"No, you'd rather sign up to die and leave me alone the hard way, is that it?" She spun around, her hands in the air. That's what this was, wasn't it? She couldn't watch her best friend, the love of her life, sacrifice herself for another cause when she could just *live*. Cold and hot, cold and hot, the anger kept coming, kept steaming out of her very pores. "How did you *think* I'd react when I found out?!" she barked. "Well, I'm not going to stick around to watch you kill yourself a second time, Adora." And the next words fell out before she even had a chance to think them. "Why can I never be *enough* for you?"

Adora flinched as if she'd been hit. Her lip wobbled. "That's not what this is."

"Then what is it? Huh? You heard about this new threat – Prime, isn't it? – and you wanted to regain your title as Etheria's little hero? Life in the shadows with a tarnished reputation not good enough for you anymore?" As she scoffed, she turned back to grab her things, glad for something to do that hid her face. It was burning just as much as she was. She couldn't handle looking at Adora one second longer – *she had no right* to look so hurt, so

upset, when this was her decision. It wasn't fair. "It's pathetic. *You're* pathetic."

But as she walked to the door, desperate to escape, she was called to a halt.

"Is that it?" Adora said, her voice rising an octave. "You're just going to walk away without hearing *what*, *why* or *how*?"

"I don't want to hear *anything* you have to say right now!" Catra yelled, spinning around with her bag in her hand. She met those blue eyes for one last time. "I never want to see you, I never want to hear from you and I never want to *think* about you ever again." She didn't want to walk away, she wanted to stay and rage and rage and rage. But this wasn't good for her, and Catra was tired, so tired of dealing with Adora and everything that came along with her. She had spent too long working on herself to lose it all now. So, she walked out, and barely able to contain her voice long enough to get the words out, she said, "Goodbye, Adora. For good this time."

Chapter End Notes

...yay?

Comments make my day, and thank you so much for reading.

Stay safe,

Cx.

Transitions

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Adora heard the front door slam shut, and knowing she was truly alone, she collapsed on top of her bed and closed her eyes.

It was hard to think past the burning, aching pain running down the left side of her body. A mixture of exhaustion and physical exertion had caused her to neglect the stretches and painkillers that usually kept it to manageable levels. Between what had happened with Catra – before and after finding the letter – and the feeling of bone-deep tiredness, her mind was cloudy and her head heavy, and all she wanted to do was curl in a tight ball and sleep for a millennia.

She couldn't, however; if she somehow managed to sink past the pain in her side, the pain in her chest, throbbing over her figurative heart, would keep her up for the remainder of the night.

So, Adora embraced the pain. She let it wash over her in waves until there were no thoughts, just feelings stirring aimlessly in her mind. One of the feelings at the forefront surprised her – anger.

It had been a long time coming, but Adora was angry. She was so sick of apologising, she was so sick of being labelled as the bad guy, and she was so sick of hiding. Of accepting things, and being *good*, and being receptive to other people's concerns and fears and feelings. It wound itself into a tight ball in her stomach until she had to open her eyes to bite it down and blink it away through angry tears.

She was tired of listening to her without getting a chance to speak.

Adora loved Catra, and she couldn't imagine saying those things to *her*. Hadn't she tried to be honest, despite how difficult it was

for her? Catra said she would listen, she said she would wait to hear the full story – and she hadn't. She walked away because she came to her own conclusions, once again.

If Adora always cut Catra out of her decisions, then Catra always cut Adora out of her reasoning. It wasn't healthy for either of them.

Adora had always had problems communicating, especially with what she wanted. It was her biggest problematic flaw. She so easily went along with what everyone else wanted or decided for her, and that was never enough for Catra. Catra wanted all of Adora; she wanted to be her only choice, her only decision, and that wasn't fair either.

No one ever gave Adora a voice. No one properly listened to her.

And she was angry. She was angry at Catra for assuming and reacting badly, and she was angry at Catra for walking away because it was hard – because if she couldn't have Adora on her own terms, then she didn't want to know her at all, even as a friend. But she was especially angry at Hope and everyone else in the army who had used and abused her for their own gain, and who never listened, never sought consent, and who had gaslighted her for so long that it was difficult to truly think about.

Catra had changed, and Adora had been proud of her self-improvement. She was less reactive and confrontational, and knew how to deal with her emotions much better than the Catra she had known previously. But she still managed to jump to her own cynical ideologies, cutting off Adora's narrative and saying hurtful things. Adora was older now, and despite how she disregarded herself most of the time, she had developed some self-respect.

She didn't like how Catra had treated her, and that was okay. She was allowed to feel that way; she was allowed to have other feelings than just guilt and regret. She was allowed to feel angry, and most of all, she was allowed to want things for herself. As an

old friend had told her: she was worth more than what she could give to other people. Adora had never truly understood it at the time, but she was starting to see it. She could do the right thing because she wanted to, she could be a good person because she wanted to, and she could do things for herself, without the input of others. Just because her army superiors told her what the right thing was didn't mean she had to agree. Just because Catra made cruel assumptions about her didn't mean they were true, or she had to listen to them. She didn't need to reduce her worth to what she could offer, or what other people could take and take from her.

Adora had agency, just by being herself.

And she wanted to be free.

And that was something she would have to do alone.

Glimmer 14:28

My dad wants to know if you're coming over for NYE too

Also you haven't picked up your bike yet

Glimmer 17:01

Hello? Rude

It was a time sensitive question

My dad takes canapes very seriously

Glimmer 19:45

Adora's not answering her phone either, are you together?

Catra

Is everything okay?

Glimmer 20:17

This isn't helping

I know you don't know me properly yet

But you should know that I keep pestering people until they reply to me

Glimmer 20:20

I mean it Catra

It's over when I start calling

20:52 three missed calls from Glimmer

Glimmer 21:06

If you're not going to answer then block me

I'm going to keep calling

Catra 21:12

blocked

Catra answered on the fifth ring when Glimmer called her again. She didn't know why she answered – it would've been very easy to actually block her, and then hand in her notice at work through a letter or email. Catra had spent the last few hours locked in her dark room, alternating between crying and sleeping.

She had gotten everything she ever wanted from Adora; but what was the point of having something to hold, without ever getting to keep it? She felt sick from hurt and anger in equal measure, but as the day fell into night, the anger started to turn inward. She hated herself for falling for Adora again when she promised herself that she wouldn't. She hated herself for walking away all over again – and she *especially* hated herself for the words she had said. There was just something inside her – something she had a hard time controlling – that wanted to injure when she was hurt, and that need to lash out before someone lashed out at her. It was something that she thought she had moved past and left behind – probably in the same section of her life that had parted from Adora the first time and had promised 'never again'.

So, when Glimmer persisted and called her yet again, Catra found herself answering the phone. Perhaps it was because, deep down, she was craving company. Or, perhaps, she wanted someone else to lash out at.

And at that thought, the self-hatred cut deeper.

"Leave me alone, Sparkles, or I will actually block you."

"What's wrong?" said her annoying squeaky voice. "Why aren't you with Adora?"

There were so many answers she could give. *Adora hasn't changed. Adora broke my heart again. Adora, once again, didn't choose me.* Instead, she mumbled something like, "It's done."

A pause on the other end. "What do you mean 'it's done'?"

Catra squeezed her eyes shut, glad that no one could see her facial expression right now. "I'm done with her. I never want to

see her again." She scoffed, as if something was funny. "You can take this as my official resignation, as well."

"Wait – woah, hold on. What the hell happened?"

"Like you don't know," she sniped. That was another thing, wasn't it? Glimmer would've known – they all would've known that Adora planned to go back to the army, and yet no one told her. They'd all kept it from her like she was excluded from the pact. It made her skin crawl with the familiar feeling of vulnerability. She was *always* the last to know, the last to be considered, and the last to be consulted.

"Don't play games, Catra," Glimmer retorted, sounding equally as pissed. "If I knew, why would I be acting like this?"

Right, so Glimmer just needed reminding. Unable to hold back the venom in her voice, Catra said, "She's going back to the army."

"She's…" the line went silent. And then, Glimmer gave a croaky gasp. "What?!"

Catra couldn't hide her shock. Sitting forward on her bed, she raised her eyebrows and muttered, "So, she didn't tell you too, huh?"

Glimmer's tone immediately shifted to demanding. "How do you know? Did she tell you?"

"No, I found the letter in her drawer." Catra tried to keep her voice steady.

"What did she say?"

"Nothing. I walked out as soon as I saw it."

Glimmer blew out a long breath. "Shit. She didn't tell us." And then, as if to someone else in the room, she whispered, "It must be… the contract."

There was an urgent mumble in the background. Catra's ears perked up. Frowning, she interrupted, asking, "The what?"

"I have to go," Glimmer hissed.

"Wait, what –"

But it was no use. Glimmer hung up immediately, leaving Catra all alone in the dark. She flipped her phone from one hand to the other as she tried to make sense of what Glimmer had said – the *contract*. For some reason, Catra began to feel very uneasy. Sensing that this probably wasn't the last she would hear from her boss and Adora's best friend, Catra turned off the vibrate on her phone and put it on full sound. She placed it on her bedside table and lay down on her side, waiting.

Adora was knee-deep in paperwork by the time she heard Glimmer knocking down her door.

She could tell it was Glimmer from the pattern of the raps, in other words, her furious slamming against the wood, almost using enough force to break through.

Adora sighed. If Glimmer had managed to talk to Catra in the last twenty-four hours, then that would explain her eagerness. However, this was Glimmer; she could be reacting like this because Adora had missed her last phone call.

Taking the time to ready herself to have company, Adora traipsed downstairs and tried to fix her hair to give the impression of put-togetherness. As soon as she opened the door, the onslaught began.

All she needed to hear was "Catra said" and she automatically switched off. Glimmer ranted and ranted, but Adora heard very little of it. Questions like "why didn't you tell me?" and "when did this happen?" were lost in the spewed frets and worries streaming out of her best friend's mouth and gave her little chance to respond.

Then, Bow calmly put his hand on Glimmer’s shoulder and said, “Stop, Glim. She needs some space.”

Adora smiled her thanks at him.

Glimmer led her through her own house, sitting them in the confines of the small living room. Adora sat on the sofa while Glimmer sat on the armchair, Bow leaning on the armrest. Adora found herself looking anywhere but at them; it was easier to face the conversation that way, without looking into the hurting eyes of her friends.

She could feel Glimmer radiating chaotic energy from across the room; in that respect, she always reminded her of Catra. Always strong emotional reactions, always led by the heart rather than the head, always simmering under the surface wanting to explode. Sometimes it was comforting to know someone cared with such ferocity – right now, it was unwelcome and unhelpful.

“Adora, can you tell us?” Bow asked carefully. “What’s going on?”

She didn't have a choice now, did she? Honestly, she wasn't sure why she kept it from Glimmer and Bow for so long. Of course, she wanted to avoid stressing Angella, with her condition, but she was pretty sure that Glimmer would've let her tell her mother about it in her own time. Why, then, had she kept it to herself?

There was the easy answer: Catra. Catra had distracted her, and for a brief moment she thought she could evade the contract and live a normal life. But no, Catra had come back into her life at the same time as the army. Her past had crept up on her unexpectedly, and she had wanted to keep some part of herself whole. Glimmer and Bow had always been the best part of her. They were so loving and carefree and passionate. She didn't deserve them, and she didn't want to distract them from their own lives. Glimmer had only recently taken over Brightmoon school - who was Adora to distract her from that? From her future with Bow?

These were Adora's mistakes - Adora's consequences. She would protect her friends as much as she could.

However, she also knew something else, something that was much harder to swallow: they cared for her, and it wasn't fair on them to disappear into the night, after everything they had given her. She was going to tell them because it was the decent thing to do, right after she told Catra, who, unlike Bow and Glimmer, was directly involved in the consequences of the contract.

"It happened," Adora said, numb. "The army want me back."

She could *feel* Glimmer seething. She stared at the floor, willing it to swallow her whole. The guilt that forced its way down her throat was, quite frankly, unwelcome. After the argument with Catra, Adora was not in an amicable mood, or willing to feel the shame of others. As the thick silent air descended between them, she heard Bow say;

"We knew this was going to happen, right?" When no one answered, he went on, "So, what can we do to stop it?"

"Maybe we'd know if Adora had told my mum sooner," Glimmer interjected.

And just like that, the floodgates opened.

"I can deal with this myself," Adora argued, doing her best to stop her temper from flaring. "Angella is sick, she doesn't need me making it worse –"

"What part of 'we all want to help you' don't you understand?" Glimmer nearly shouted. "It's been so long – we thought they'd forgotten, or they were never going to want you back, or you would've told us something else by now to let us help you!"

Adora's face flushed crimson, partly out of shame but mostly out of embarrassment. She knew that people wanted to help if she would allow them, and the fact that it was still hard for her to talk about was humiliating. Now, it was too late – and her fear of

burdening Angella with her illness probably looked like ungrateful mistrust. She had screwed this up in so many ways, just because she couldn't talk about the *real* problem.

Catra was proof of that.

"How long do we have?" Glimmer pushed.

Adora fumbled with the sleeve of her shirt. "They want me to re-enlist by the end of January."

"Roughly a month, then," said Bow.

Adora nodded, and for the first time, she looked up. Glimmer was rubbing her forehead, caught between being upset and angry. Bow met her gaze, his brown eyes wide and teary. With her heart clenching at the sight, Adora muttered, "I'm sorry."

No matter how hard she tried, she kept hurting those closest to her.

"Don't be," Glimmer replied. "We can do this – we're the best friend squad. We can do anything. But Adora" – she glanced to Bow and back again – "we need you to be honest with us. You need to tell us the truth about why the army want you so desperately. It's the only way we're going to be able to fight them." Quietly, she added, "It's now or never."

Well, Catra didn't listen, no matter how hard Adora tried to tell her – and how difficult it was to talk about. Glimmer was right; if she didn't speak the truth now, she probably would never again. It had been five years since they'd became friends in the unlikeliest of scenarios, and not once had they judged or pushed her too far for information. They were supportive; they were her friends. Over the years, she had told them certain details about what had happened during the Heart of Etheria project, but she had left out important pieces that they ought to know.

Mainly, that *she* was She-Ra and the failsafe was inside *her*.

So, gathering up what little courage she had left, Adora prepared herself to come clean. After this, there would be no more secrets between them.

"Okay," she said, clenching her hands. "I'll start from the beginning, then…"

Glimmer 23:31

You need to talk to Adora

It's never been more important

Catra 23:39

no

Glimmer 23:40

Now is not the time to be immature, Catrina

Catra 23:41

That's not my name

Glimmer 23:41

Whatever, I'm being serious

Go get your girl before she's gone for good

Catra couldn't quite believe she was calling her boss, and the principal of Brightmoon, at ten minutes to midnight on a Saturday. Since their last phone call, Catra had been pacing around the flat listlessly, trying to find something that would ease the hollow pit in her stomach. Something felt wrong, and she didn't know what it was. Her mind kept racing with the possibilities: why hadn't

Adora told her sooner? Why hadn't she told her precious best friends – her employer – the family that took her in?

Why was she going back to the army at all?

It wasn't making sense, no matter how much Catra's subconscious told her the cynical obvious: Adora wanted more glory, Adora had never really left the army way of thinking behind.

And yet, Catra had accepted a long time ago that Adora *wasn't* motivated by glory. She wanted to do what was right, constantly, and it just didn't make sense that *this* would be what she thought was right. Not after the army had exposed themselves for who they really were – a corrupt institution praying on the desperate.

All of this led Catra to believe that there was something else going on – something that Adora had tried to tell her, but she had walked away from.

"What do you know?" Catra demanded down the phone, neglecting the formalities of 'hello' or 'how are you'.

"You need to talk to her," Glimmer answered cryptically, her voice hoarse. "I know you're upset, but what you think is wrong. Very wrong. She needs us now more than ever."

Catra closed her eyes as she winced. Her mind conjured the image of Adora in her dressing gown, bent over the bath, gasping for air. The horror and recognition in her eyes as Catra held the military letter up for her to see.

After a few moments, she replied, "You said something about a contract."

"I did, but I shouldn't be the one to tell you."

"I can't go back to her," Catra argued, temper flaring. "The things I said –"

"Suck it up," Glimmer chided, sharp enough to make Catra flinch. "Stop repeating your bad habits because they're easy. Trust me, I know. I was pissed at her too, but now – well, I get it now. I'm saying this because I care – about you as well as Adora. You need to know what's going on, and she needs you to know the truth. If you decide you still want nothing to do with her after that, well… no one will stop you." She sighed. "I'll have you relocated to a different school and that'll be it. You'll never hear from any of us again."

The sense of *wrongness* lingered, and as her self-hatred intensified, Catra felt her stomach twist with a sickening lurch. If she had anything in her stomach, she was sure she would've brought it up. Why couldn't the universe let her be happy – why couldn't she just have Adora? Why was there always something in the way?

And the worst part? Catra wondered for a brief moment if it was all worth it. She had been happy before seeking out Adora again – she was living her own life, fighting her own battles, settling her own successes. Yes, she missed Adora and she longed for her, but that was nothing new. It was easy to miss and long for something that was out of reach, with nostalgic rose-tinted memories to keep you warm at night. But this? The weight of guilt, and the constant fight to *keep* and *have* were almost too much.

A smarter person would've walked away and cut their losses.

A braver person would've stayed from the beginning and fought from the start.

And despite the image she portrayed to other people, Catra did not feel brave or smart. She felt scared – scared of losing what mattered most to her, and most of all, she felt resentful for having to fight for what she wanted. For *whom* she wanted.

"I'm so sick of… hurting," she muttered, more to herself than to Glimmer.

“She’s not your enemy, Catra,” Glimmer said softly. “She never has been. You’re on the same side. And now we *all* need to put it right.”

Chapter End Notes

Sorry for the delay, I truly struggled with the tone in this chapter. As you've probably noticed, there are no flashbacks - stylistically, I wanted this chapter to be caught in the present, between all the characters who are on the verge of change and consequences. Therefore, it's a little shorter than previous ones.

This chapter marks the transition into the final act! There's somewhere between five and ten chapters left, and we have a lot of plot to get through. Hopefully you'll follow me through to the end.

Thanks for all of your kind words and affirmations! I love hearing your thoughts; they make me fall in love with the characters all over again.

Stay safe,

Cx.

Promise

Chapter Summary

Arguments and angst up ahead - you have been warned...

Catra showed up on her doorstep wearing a smart blouse and a pair of tight-fitted jeans. She could've called beforehand (she should've), but she had spent far too long trying to figure out what to wear, and in her sleep-deprived state, she couldn't find the right words, or the motivation to say them.

Her goal today was to find out what had sent Glimmer into a spin – and to, finally, let Adora tell her side of the story. She had composed herself before leaving so she wouldn't react or lash out to what she would hear because, let's face, it she wasn't going to like *anything* that Adora was going to say. With that in mind, and the initial shock of Adora's re-enlisting pushed under the surface, she was ready and willing to listen.

Endings didn't always have to be slammed doors and broken promises. If Catra still didn't like what Adora had to say, she could walk away after an adult conversation and cut her losses, with both of them knowing where they stood.

She sighed at the thought and tucked in the back of her shirt into her jeans. This was part of her internal debate, after the self-hatred had somewhat dissipated; *would* Catra be able to walk away?

Catra sucked in a breath and prepared herself to knock on the door. She had brought a peace offering (an apology gift?) in the shape of yet another book. Her sweaty palm clamped itself around the spine as she leaned forward to rap on the wooden door. She held the breath as she waited, silently willing it to open.

When Adora finally opened the door, Catra's breath stuck in her throat. It had been two days since they had last seen each other,

but once her eyes had fallen onto the soft glow of blonde hair, the bright blue eyes that pierced right through her, she was overwhelmed with a new flood of emotion. *This was the woman she loved*. This was Adora; beautiful, sweet, stupid Adora, and Catra's entire essence felt attuned to her. A brief flicker of their activity two nights ago flashed in her mind's eye: Catra's weight on top of Adora's body, and the mewls of pleasure that *she* had caused. But Catra blinked and the memory faded, replaced instead by the cold cruelness of their current reality. For a moment, she was sure Adora was going to shut the door in her face – and, well, *that* was new.

"Adora, wait," Catra said, taking another step closer. "I think we should talk."

And Catra felt a shiver cross over her skin as Adora said coldly, "*You* think we should talk."

Blinking a few times, the brunette tried to figure out what the problem was – she was here, wasn't she, trying to put up a white flag? "Yes?" she answered, uncertainly.

A muscle twitched in Adora's cheek. "What if *I'm* not ready?"

"I – I don't" – Catra stumbled, because this was definitely not something she was expecting. Her mind raced over every other argument they had had during the years, because this had never happened before. Adora was always the patient, sensible one, always the one open to listening and *fixing*. Hostility on Adora's behalf was a new thing, and something Catra had no idea how to react to. As the seconds ticked on, her mind continued to draw a blank.

Adora was *pissed* and it was making Catra squirm.

Sensing her floundering, Adora opened the door wider and said quietly, "Come in."

With her head down to hide the embarrassed flush of her cheeks, Catra brushed past Adora on her way into the hall. She stood

awkwardly beside the stairs and, once again, her mind conjured up the memories of Adora kissing her here, beside the front door, her cheeks tinted pink with the cold, and her eyes drowsy with affection. In the present, Adora closed the door and gestured for Catra to step into the kitchen; her postured was stiff, and her eyes downcast.

Once at the table, Catra jerkily pushed the book across to Adora. "I thought you'd like this."

Adora's face was expressionless. "A book."

"*The Song of Achilles*." Still no reaction, so Catra blurted, "It's gay."

Adora nodded. "I've read it."

"Oh," Catra tried not to let the disappointment show. "It's good. I thought you'd like it."

Adora said nothing, and she stared at the book as if it were an unwanted visitor. Biting her lip, Catra reassessed how appropriate *The Song of Achilles* was; two people who couldn't live without the other, and their demise revolved around one of them asking to go to war to save the pride of the other.

Maybe Adora was insulted – maybe it was another reminder of their situation, of their conflict. Catra felt like snatching it back, but really, she knew it wasn't the *book* that was the problem. It was *them*.

Rather suddenly, Adora asked, "Why are you here at all, Catra? You were pretty clear that you never wanted anything to do with me ever again."

There was a slight wobble to her voice, and it made Catra's tongue feel too fat to talk. So, Adora was upset. That made sense. Catra was *hurtful*; she was sharp and jagged and, sometimes, cruel. She had hurt Adora before, but it had never lasted long – she'd always gotten over it.

When Catra was younger, she never apologised for *anything*. Over the past few years, she had learnt how to – starting with Scorpia, who she had probably hurt the most. It was difficult and uncomfortable, but it was something other people needed. Most of the time Catra didn't even mean the things she said, she just knew how to make others hurt.

Adora would never – and has never – done that to her.

"I was… wrong," Catra said to the table. "I'm sorry. For everything."

And she meant it; she just wished it would show on her face. She wished, not for the first time, that showing certain emotions – the softer ones – came naturally to her, and she didn't feel like she had to mould her face and her reactions to suit the tone. She was *sorry*; her heart practically bled with it, and she was willing to put aside her own hurt to let Adora know how much she regretted her reaction.

Adora shuffled on the chair. She looked ready to burst at the seams. "You said some pretty hurtful things."

"I was upset," Catra said, wincing at the intensity of her tone – it almost sounded like an accusation. *You made me upset. You're responsible for my reaction.* In reality, she was just defensive; she was upset, of course she was – she had just found out the love of her life was abandoning her again.

Catra shook herself. No. She had to stop thinking like that or they weren't going to get very far today.

"That's not good enough," Adora murmured, blushing. "I'm not your punching bag."

Catra held her breath to stop herself from saying anything else that was stupid or insensitive. Right now, it was very hard. She was upset that she had upset Adora. This was on her, and she had to accept it. "I know, and I'm sorry," she said, looking up. "I was feeling vulnerable, after – you know. And confused. I'm trying to

be better. You have every right to be angry at me.” She gave a nervous laugh and rubbed her forearm. “Although, I’m not used to it.”

Adora frowned. “Used to what?”

“You being angry at me. It’s always been the other way around.”

“I’m not very good at it. Being angry, I mean.”

“Your glower at the front door was pretty spot on.”

“You think so?”

Catra huffed a breath and offered a smile. “Oh yeah, definitely. I nearly shit myself.” Adora gave a short laugh, and Catra went on, encouraged by the break in the blonde’s detachment. “So, I wanted to apologise, and I wanted to say that I’ll listen. I promised I would, so here I am.” She couldn’t quite believe the words she heard herself say. Her throat croaked. “I want to know why you’re going back to the army.”

Adora's face contorted. Catra wasn't sure if she looked in pain or relieved. The blonde stood up, anxiously clenching her hands together. “I wasn’t expecting this. Can you - uh, can you wait here a moment?”

And before she could respond, Adora escaped into the next room, leaving Catra to stare at the book she brought and wait in silence.

Twenty-four years old

Catra woke up with an arm around her stomach and ruffled hair tickling her nostrils. Groaning, she rolled over and pushed the body away from her, grabbing the covers back.

“Get off me, you big lump.”

The sleeping mound murmured something like 'fuck you' before pushing themselves up to rub at their eyes. "You're a selfish asshole. Some people wake their bed guests with breakfast."

Catra scoffed. "If that's what you're looking for then you're in the wrong bed."

Fara looked at her then, wearing the type of smirk that said *I know exactly where I am*. Her short hair was sticking up at the back, and her long fringe, which usually covered her eyes, was swept into a messy quiff. She always looked hot as fuck like this; her lips bruised, her eyes dancing with a challenge. It was familiar; it reminded her of better days.

Fara pouted and leaned against the headboard. The duvet fell away from her chest, but they were both a long way past modesty at this point. "You know, I've never met someone so *repulsed* by cuddling before."

"I'm not *repulsed* by it," Catra retorted, rolling her eyes. "I'm just not into it. And since when do you care?"

"I don't, it's just an observation. Like how you always get grumpy when I ask you personal questions."

"I have a suggestion; why don't you stop asking questions?"

"Alright, so I suppose we're not going to talk about what's happening later, then."

Catra stiffened. She wiped a hand across her face and looked away. She felt Fara crawl towards her until their arms were nearly touching.

Reluctantly, Catra said, "I've spent the last three years begging for this to be over. Now that it's here, I…" she shook her head and fell silent.

Today was the day Catra left the army.

Her contract was up – it was over. They had tried to get her to renew it for another tour, but she was adamant in her refusal. Yes, she was a good teacher and a great leader, yet she also had no interest in the military anymore. She hadn't for a long time, if ever. Being good at something didn't mean you had to *like* it.

She had spent the last few years putting in minimum effort and reaping rewards for her past successes during the war. In her free time, she drank too much – although this, admittedly, she was getting better at handling. Having spent so long dreaming about freedom – about civilian life – now that she was facing it, the future seemed scary and distant.

Catra had absolutely no idea what she wanted to do with her life.

But she also had no desire to talk to *Fara* about it.

Fara was still actively serving in the army and had no desire to move on from it anytime soon. She had joined at sixteen like Catra and had only just been made a Lance Corporal for the Engineers. Sometimes it was easy to forget that some soldiers had never seen active warfare – not, at least, as often as those in the Special Forces.

Fara draped an arm over Catra's chest and trailed a gentle finger across her collarbone. "They're going to miss you losing your temper in the camp every day."

Catra hummed and raised her eyebrows. "The cadets and juniors won't."

Fara pressed a soft kiss to the base of her neck. "*I* will."

Catra's entire body stiffened as her stomach lurched. As if electrocuted, she swung her legs over the side of the bed and got up, reaching blindly for her dressing gown. Refusing to look in the direction of the bed, she walked to the bathroom and muttered, "Be back in a minute."

Catra stayed in the bathroom until she heard Fara get up to leave. Maybe it was a mistake to allow Fara to stay over – it was making their whole arrangement feel… Strange. Once she was certain Fara had left the room, Catra got dressed in a pair of joggers and a loose sweatshirt to see her off.

Fara and Scorpia were talking at the door. Dressed in her clothes from last night, Fara had her car keys in her hand whole she flattened her hair with the other. Her eyes glanced over Catra – up and down and back up again – and she gestured to the door.

"Right, I'm going." There was something in her eyes; a hint of *want*, or perhaps, just determination. "Will I come over tonight?"

Catra thought about it. She felt Scorpia's eyes on her, and the room felt too hot. Eager to disappear back in her bedroom to get ready for her last day at work, she shrugged. "Yeah. Sure."

Fara smiled but said nothing more. Catra didn't wait for the door to close behind her; as soon as she could, she padded over to the kitchen to grab a quick breakfast. Dry cereal or toast – something to stop the anxious aching.

Scorpia was hovering by the door. Nervously, she sang, "So, Fara. *Fara*. Fa-ra."

Catra cringed with her back to her housemate. "That's her name."

"She's staying over a lot."

Once again, Catra pulled a face and said innocently, "Is she?"

"It's been going on for a few weeks now." Scorpia's tone was dry. "It's quite… regular."

Sighing, Catra turned with her coffee in one hand and the other resting on her hip. "We have a *thing*."

Scorpia raised an eyebrow. "A thing?"

"That's what I said," Catra challenged, huffing.

Scorpia was trying to get at something – she had never liked Fara, and that was rare for someone like Scorpia who loved everything and everyone. Catra didn't know why the two of them never clicked, but she assumed it was something to do with when they were younger – when Scorpia had had a crush on Catra, and Fara tried to start a rivalry with her.

Catra, at the time, had been forcefully oblivious to it. She had never particularly liked either of them in *that* way – but then, there was only one person she had ever wanted romantically. At that reminder, Catra took a long sip of caffeine.

Scorpia went on, undeterred. "Is this thing exclusive? Are you, you know, seeing other people?"

Catra shrugged, hoping that it would show how much she didn't care or hadn't thought about it. "I don't know. We haven't talked about it."

Leaning forward with her arms resting on her thighs, Scorpia narrowed her eyes as she watched her housemate. "I think you like her."

Catra let out an involuntary squeak. "I do *not* like her!" Embarrassed by her outburst, she turned away again and tried to focus on making breakfast. "It's sex, that's it. Don't make it weird."

"I can tell she really likes you, Wildcat."

Ah. Right. So Scorpia was warning her that Fara was *catching feelings*. It wasn't that Catra didn't like Fara – she obviously found her physically attractive, and it was nice (as bad as it sounded) for someone to like Catra more than she liked them. She appreciated the attention, and as a person, Fara was tolerable. Fara was jagged and rough like her, and she didn't give a shit about what other people thought. Fara had plenty of previous relationships with both men and women, and this made Catra – who had never

had a relationship – feel oddly *secure*. Why would someone like Fara, who had been loved and loved in return, settle for someone like Catra, who openly could offer nothing?

If she was stupid enough to catch feelings, then that was on her.

"That's her problem," Catra muttered, stabbing the toast with the buttering knife. As she walked past with the toast in her hand, she caught Scorpia's concerned expression.

Ugh. It was exhausting having someone who cared about you in your life.

"Listen, she knows the deal," Catra offered. "I'm not into relationships or – or anything like that. I'm not a *romantic* person."

Scorpia put her hands up. "I know – and I'm not judging – but I think it would be good for you. To be loved and allow yourself to love –" Catra rolled her eyes and continued bolting for the bedroom. Scorpia called after her, "Hey, okay, I know, I'll shut up now. Just be careful, Catra. I know you can walk away from things quite easily, but that doesn't mean other people can."

Catra stopped at the threshold, nibbling on the slice of toast. "Yeah. I know what I'm doing."

But her ears were burning and her cheeks were flushed because, now that Scorpia mentioned in, Fara *had* been staying over more. And Catra had only somewhat complained.

Maybe Fara wasn't the one catching feelings after all.

Maybe Catra *was* letting her guard down.

"Okay," Scorpia agreed, satisfied.

"Okay." Still too ashamed to meet her gaze, Catra asked the floor. "So, I'll see you at the leaving party later?"

She heard the smile in Scorpia's voice. "Wouldn't miss it for the world."

Present day

Adora returned with tea and biscuits. Honestly, Catra was surprised she came back at all – she was gone for so long that she assumed Adora had escaped through a window.

Catra took the tea with thanks but didn't drink it. Adora sat across from her, clutching the cup like it was the only thing stopping gravity from claiming her.

Eventually, Adora took a deep breath. "Okay. So. There's a lot you don't know."

Catra guessed that much. Schooling her expression so that it was a perfect neutral mask, she asked, "About what?"

"The army." Adora cringed a little. "Specifically, my role in the Special Forces."

Catra's eyebrows flicked up. She nodded, long and slow; she wasn't particularly good at this. She was trying to reign herself in because she knew how difficult this was for Adora, and how this wasn't about *her*. Whatever this was, it was an Adora-thing, and she wanted to be present for it. "Okay. I'm listening. Take your time."

They were both quiet. Catra patiently waited for Adora to find the right words, and Adora tapped her index finger against the side of her mug, staring into the middle distance. Eventually, Adora's brow furrowed, and she started. "You remember that I was there when Mara… died?"

Catra gave another nod.

"Well, after that…" The blonde gave such a small, soft sigh that Catra barely heard it. She watched carefully as Adora looked up,

meeting her gaze head on. “I was asked to join the Heart of Etheria project, to take over Mara’s role in it. I said yes – of course I said yes. But I didn’t know what I was exactly saying *yes* to.”

“Wait – sorry, but Mara died long before the Heart of Etheria mission happened,” Catra pointed out after a quick bit of mental maths.

“Yeah.” Adora’s eyes were round, beseeching. “This has been going on for a long time.”

A very long time. Since they were – what, nineteen or twenty? They were best friends back then, and the thought that Adora had kept something this big from her for that long made Catra shiver. *This isn’t about you*, she reminded herself. Putting her own feelings to one side, she tried to ask as neutral as possible, “And this never came up before?”

Adora looked pained. “Catra, I – they made me sign contracts. I wasn’t allowed to tell anyone *anything* about this.” She glanced at the table. “Technically, I’m still not allowed to, but I’m *way* past caring at this point.”

“Sorry.” Catra shook herself. Of course – this wasn’t just Adora she was dealing with, this was the *army* and Adora. She managed to steer herself back on track. “Right. Okay. Continue.”

Chewing on her bottom lip, Adora stalled again. When she did manage to get the words out, they were clunky and rushed. “Do you remember the software that they developed to bring down the Horde technology?”

“Yeah, uh – She-Ra, wasn’t it?”

Adora nodded. Her blue eyes clouded over as she recounted memories. “Mara was the first host of She-Ra. The First Ones mission went wrong, and she died before they managed to gain access to the information that they needed. When I took over the She-Ra experiment for the Heart of Etheria project, they adapted

it to include a Failsafe." Catra's lips parted to form an 'o' as she realised Adora meant the failsafe – the one they had argued over during the mission that separated them. Adora gestured to herself as she said, "The Failsafe would only respond to the host of She-Ra."

Wait a minute, that meant -

"And that's why you couldn't give it to me, even though you were injured," Catra said, and as she said it, the reality of the situation dawned on her.

Adora's tone was apologetic. "And that's why I couldn't have given it to you, even if you wanted it."

Catra rubbed her forehead. "Fuck."

This was giving her a headache. Unbidden, flashes of memories from the Horde's Arms Factory came back to her; specifically, Adora clutching her gunshot wound as Catra begged her for the failsafe so they could complete the mission. *I can't give it to you*, Adora had told her at the time. Her heart gave a painful squeeze as she remembered it and how she had interpreted it. She thought that it had just been Adora's pride talking – not that the failsafe wouldn't respond to *her*.

Adora wasn't being arrogant or selfish. She was literally the only person who could do it.

"Neither of us were expecting to survive the Heart of Etheria project, but I was so sure I was going to die because of what happened to Mara." Adora shrugged and her lips pressed together in a hard line. "I wanted to save you because you didn't need to die. No one knew how She-Ra would react a second time, and I didn't want it bringing us both down."

Once again, Catra was overcome by how *stupid* and *needless* their five years apart had been. Her palms grew sweaty, so she rested them on her thighs, clawing a the fabric of her jeans. She felt sick. "If only you'd said – if only you could've told me –"

She would've understood why Adora couldn't give it to her – and she would've done more to help, to ensure her friend made it to safety. As the possibilities cycled through her mind, Adora gave a sad but amused chuckle. "You wouldn't have reacted well, Cat. But I – there's more. It gets more… complicated."

Catra gestured for her to go on, all the while biting her own tongue. Anything she had to say could wait.

"After the Heart of Etheria mission, no one was expecting me to survive." Adora glanced from Catra's hands under the table to her own as she talked. She looked older as she talked about this; more worn, aged. Like someone with the weight of the world on their shoulders. "When I did survive, the plans… changed. They wanted me back on active duty, and they wanted to continue the She-Ra experiments."

Adora wasn't offered camp and desk duties like Catra was? That didn't make sense. Catra gave an outraged huff. "But that's not –"

"I know, and they didn't care. I wasn't fit for active duty, and being a guinea pig was the last thing that I wanted to do after what had happened." Subconsciously, Adora wrapped an arm around herself in a motion of comfort. "Then I heard about the nature of the new experiments and I -" she grimaced "– it wasn't right. It wasn't ethical, and I didn't want any part of it."

It clicked as soon as Catra pieced it together. "You ran away."

"Yeah. I deserted." Adora gave a shaky sigh. "That was when I bumped into Bow and Glimmer. When the army finally caught up with me a few months later, they gave me a few options. Colonel Hope told me that deserters are usually sentenced to life in prison. But given my role in the army, and the intelligence that I… *carried*, the charge against me would be raised to treason." She looked up to see Catra's reaction. "She threatened me with a death sentence."

A death sentence.

Catra had heard the rumours as a cadet, and even by some of the older soldiers when she was a Private; a Colonel, not so long ago, who had been a double agent. He had leaked secret after secret to the Horde, and when he was caught, they executed him. Catra had assumed it was a baseless threat – something to scare people from doing the same thing. No one since had caused such an upset to the army – or posed such a threat to the country.

But Adora, the war hero, was threatened with treason?

Why the hell would she pose a threat to the *safety* of Etheria?

Adora went on, talking through Catra's silent musings. "The place I was at, I honestly didn't care what they did to me. But then, Hope said they were willing to compromise. I could live a civilian life with their support as long as I signed a contract saying that I would re-enlist for the She-Ra experiments whenever they wanted me to. She said it could be days, months or years, but one day I had to return to finish my tour. I signed it, hoping that I would be able to find a way out before then, but I – well, here we are." Adora leaned against the chair, sagging, like the life was drained from her. "Five years later, and they're calling me back. So, that's why I have to go." Her eyes became bloodshot as tears started to gather, clashing with the bright blue. "That was the letter you found."

Tick-tock. Tick-tock.

The sound of ticking kitchen clock echoed between them, sounding too slow to keep up with the pounding of Catra's heart.

Catra remained very still because she had no idea how to react. Stuck somewhere between the flight or fight response, she was frozen. Tension bubbled under the surface, but she wasn't sure what emotion it would turn into.

There were a lot of things to process here.

Namely, that Adora didn't want to go back to the army, and she never had. She was stuck, trapped and coerced into an agreement

that sounded unlawful and manipulative – and those were only the PG words for it.

Fuck.

Everything was slowly slotting into place like a jigsaw puzzle. Why Adora had PTSD over Mara, why Adora had reacted the way she had during the Heart of Etheria project, why Adora had continued to keep Catra at an arm's length for so long. She hadn't been allowed to want or have anything – the army owned her, and Catra had no idea why they thought they could get away with it.

And through it all, Catra wondered: what would've happened if she had been there for Adora over the past few years? Would she have found a way out for her best friend?

If Adora asked her to run away from the military and flee the country as a fugitive, she would've. She would've done it all and everything in between without looking back.

But she hadn't.

Catra had never let Adora explain and had never given her the time of day to put things right. Yes, she hadn't known better. But now?

What would she do now?

Voice croaking, Catra muttered, "I'm… so sorry."

"It's okay –"

"No, it's not – fuck, Adora, they've used your life like a pawn on a chessboard! Nothing about this is okay!"

There it was – the tension bubbling in Catra's stomach.

Anger.

Of course it was anger.

Adora held out a hand. “Catra, please, don’t get upset.”

But she was and she *couldn’t help it*.

Adora didn’t deserve this – Adora didn’t deserve anything bad happening to her, ever. She was kind and sweet and naïve – she always wanted to do the right thing. And the army ruined it, they ruined everything –

Catra tried to take a deep breath to calm herself, but it just enraged her more. She wanted to break something, to tear it up, to throw something at a wall and stomp on the fragmented pieces until they were dust. Shouting past the lump in her throat, she demanded, “Why you? Why does it have to be you? Why can’t they give She-Ra to someone else – why don’t they change the Failsafe, let someone else use it –”

“They can’t.”

“Why not?!”

“I *am* She-Ra,” Adora said, and she was crying now. She slammed the flat of her palm against her chest. “The Failsafe is *in* me. That’s why they were able to charge me with treason – when I ran away, I stole classified equipment – a weapon that can destroy countries – because it’s *in me*.”

Twenty-four years old

Catra got through her leaving ceremony by clenching her teeth and smiling at everyone she hated.

Catra got through the unofficial leaving party afterwards by drinking rum straight and escaping to the smoking area.

Most people here she hoped to would forget one day. Aside from a handful of comrades in the Special Forces, Catra had tolerated her colleagues over the last three years, and she hoped she would never have to tolerate them again.

Scorpia managed to save her a few times when someone asked about *her*, and if they still kept in contact. Whenever someone asked what Catra had planned for the future, she laughed and said 'let me get over my rest period first'.

The only activity Catra truly *enjoyed* was reading, as recommended by her therapist. She'd never been into reading before – that was always a *Her* thing – but now, she found escaping into fantasy worlds and other people's lives fascinating and *freeing*. Unfortunately, no one was prepared to pay her to read books for the rest of her life.

"Teaching," Scorpia had said. "I heard that's what Ado – I mean, someone we used to know is doing now they've left the army."

Catra didn't like talking about *Her*, and she definitely didn't like thinking about her, but she was on her mind tonight, and it was weighing Catra down.

They had joined the army together eight years ago and this was how it had ended. As one of her old cadets (now a fully-fledged soldier at the young age of eighteen) discussed what department he wanted to transfer to, Catra nodded absently, unable to rid herself of a deep-set feeling of guilt and disappointment. She remembered her first day in the army; getting her uniform fitted, finding a bunk, meeting her training team. She remembered *Her*, and their nervous excitement, imagining it was the first day of the start of their lives.

Catra finished the remainder of her rum and hopped in the next available taxi, leaving the party without saying goodbye to anyone. If they wanted to keep in contact, they could contact her. She was done with it all.

When Catra got home, she shrugged off her jacket and sat on the sofa. Fara had texted her a few hours ago to say she would be over soon. She padded to the kitchen and drank a glass of water. Holding onto the empty, cold glass, she sat down again.

And she sighed.

Minutes passed – it wasn't clear how many. The rum had suitably addled Catra's mind, giving her a surge of liquid confidence and resilience. When the door opened and Fara walked in, setting down her bag beside the door, Catra simply watched her for a few moments. Fara approached the sofa with long, swaying strides. Reaching up to pull her down, Catra captured Fara's lips with her teeth, and they started the dance that they had rehearsed countless times before.

It was rough, it was sloppy. Catra felt a *want*, but her mind drifted elsewhere when lipgloss lips bit their way down her neck and calloused hands opened her shirt. Her thoughts felt in between places of reality – some were present and others were far away, disengaged and tangled with the thoughts of someone, somewhere else.

It wasn't until Fara pulled away, stroking Catra's hair out of her face that she landed back in the living room of her apartment, feeling *very* sober.

"How was it?"

Catra blinked a few times. "Huh?"

"The party," Fara said with a roll of her eyes.

Fara was working a late guard duty shift. Catra was glad she hadn't been at the party. "Fine."

"You looked handsome at the ceremony." Fara stroked along the brunette's jaw. "With your medals and your cap."

This sent a sharp, jagged dash of irritation straight into Catra's churning stomach. "Why are we talking right now?" she hissed.

Fara sat back, but still held onto her shoulders. "You just went through a big moment in your life. Other people would want to talk about it."

For a few seconds, all Catra did was stare.

And then she stood up and scoffed, slipping out of Fara's grip.

She heard the other girl tease, "Ooh, I have broody Catra tonight. I can't wait to – hey, where are you going?"

Catra's feet had started taking her in the direction of the bathroom. With her open shirt draped over her shoulders, she said, loud and clear, "I'm going to shower. Go home."

"Excuse me?" Fara replied, with a sharp tone to her pitch.

Catra turned on her heel, staring her directly in the eye, merciless. "I said go home. You shouldn't have come over tonight."

"Who do you think you're talking to?" Fara retorted, standing from the sofa.

Catra shrugged, deadpanning, "You're the only person here, so."

"You're a fucking asshole, you know that?" Fara scorned, her face flushing red. She sent the brunette a look of pure disgust. "I don't know why I put up with you."

"Then don't. No one is keeping you here."

"What is this to you, Catra?"

That was a good question, and one Catra had prepared an answer for. Inside, she was squirming with self-hate and repulsion. More than that, she felt the claws of doubt and fear sinking their way into her nerve. From what Scorpia had said earlier – to what had just happened – Fara acting like she knew her, Fara acting like she cared, Fara calling her handsome – it was too much.

She felt trapped. She wanted out.

This was all a mistake.

"Honestly?" Catra said, and instead of sounding venomous, she just sounded resigned. "A one-night stand that dragged on for too long. I don't *want* or *need* a girlfriend, Fara." Her tone changed to accusatory. "I thought you knew what this was – you've known me for – how long now? When have you ever seen me interested in *domestics*?"

Fara's eyes bulged. "Who said anything about being *girlfriends* or domestics? You really think I'd want to be your girlfriend when you can't even talk about how you're feeling? Or when you don't even ask me *how I am*?" she yelled. "I thought we were friends – and friends don't tend to treat each other like shit, or use one another when they're feeling a little *lonely* or a little *depressed*."

Shit.

Maybe, just maybe, Catra had misread this situation.

Did she care, though? Really? Whatever was going on between them, Fara had gotten too close. And despite what she just said, Catra was uncomfortable with how *comfortable* they were getting.

"Friends don't tend to fuck, either," she pointed out with absolutely no remorse.

But Fara was already fixing her appearance and was reaching for her bag. Good. Her brown eyes were watering, and this didn't affect Catra in the slightest. Fara, with one hand on for door handle, said, "So, yeah, you're right. No one is keeping me here. But a word of advice, Catra: you're out of the army now. If you treat people the way you treat your friends, then you're going to wake up one day very lonely. Not everyone is as patient as me or Scorpia." She opened the door before slamming it. "Don't bother calling."

Catra felt the echo of the slammed door vibrate underneath her feet. She shrugged off her shirt and headed to the bathroom. Instead of showering, however, she sat on the edge of her bed and rested her head in her hands.

It was better this way. To be alone.

Tomorrow she would wake up and all of this would be over. She would wake to a new chapter of her life, free from everything and everyone who reminded her of the army. Moving on was difficult, especially with the ghosts of yesterday singing you to sleep every night.

Sometimes it was easier to harmonise rather than reject them.

So, tomorrow, she would research teaching courses funded by the military.

If it worked for *Her*, it would work for Catra. But that, she promised herself, would be the last time she would *ever* think of Adora.

Present day

Catra gaped.

She stared, open-mouthed, as Adora pulled down the front of her jumper to show the faint white outline of a scar. It was jagged and square like a mechanical heart. Catra had seen it when Adora took off her sports bra but she had thought – she thought it was just a mark, an imprint of something – something inconsequential. Something that didn't matter.

"It's – *this* is it?" Catra squeaked.

Adora nodded and covered it up again, cheeks glowing with shame. "I didn't consent to this – none of it. They said something about a minor procedure, and then I woke up in hospital and I –" she shook her head bitterly. "It doesn't matter. The She-Ra chip, the Failsafe – it's in here, and there's nothing I can do about it." Her lip jutted out, and Catra felt her heart snap as she met those sad blue eyes, so lost, so helpless. "What can I do, Catra? Tell me. What can I do?"

Catra couldn't help herself.

She had no idea where they were or how they were - but right now that didn't matter. Adora was distressed, and it was distressing Catra. She got up from her chair and kneeled in front of Adora, taking both of her hands in her own and holding them tight. When Adora pulled her closer, Catra wiped away a tear from the blonde's eye. “What will they do to you?" she whispered softly. "If you go back?”

Adora sniffled, shaking her head. “I heard that they wanted to expand on She-Ra’s powers using the advanced Horde technology. They want to turn it into a weapon. And now, with this new power – Prime – rising up, that’s exactly what they’re going to use it for. *I* am the weapon – I’m their way to prevent a full-scale war. And you know the worst part? I agree with their argument; sacrificing one person to save hundreds." Her voice broke. "But I’m just so tired.”

“Adora, no," Catra chided. "That’s what they want you to think. Prime won’t start a war with us unless we start one first – and the government have been eager to win more territory for a while now. You are not a player in their game. You are so much more than that." She reached up to cradle Adora's head, pressing a kiss to her crown. "We will find a way to get you out of this, I promise you. Even if I have to kill every single last one of them to –”

“*Catra*.”

“We’ll work this out," she amended. "And I’m sorry. I’m so sorry for not giving you a chance to talk. I’m sorry for the things I said. And I’m sorry we didn’t work this out sooner. I’m so, so sorry.”

Adora pulled away to look a her. She reached out to place a hand against Catra's cheek. “I do love you, you know. I spent so long thinking about where we would’ve been if none of this had happened." As Catra leaned into the warmth of her hand, Adora added, "But I’m glad you’re here, now. I’m not sure I would have the strength to do this without you.”

Catra shook her head. She wasn't used to saying these words - only thinking them.

They needed to be said, especially as Catra's heart was soaring and breaking at the same time.

“You would because you’re Adora. You have Sparkles and Arrow Boy behind you, and you have me." She pressed her forehead against Adora's and closed her eyes, saying the next words as if they were a promise. "All of me. I love you, and I always have. We’re going to get through this, okay? We’ll find a way out of this. They’re not going to take you, not this time.”

Abstract

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Present day

Adora fell asleep that night in Catra's arms. Catra held her close and listened to her soft breaths, simply sinking in the feeling of her warmth and the weight of her body. It was impossible to think that *this* girl, the one who stole food for her when they were kids, the one that ran away with her as teenagers, the one who fought alongside her during wars – this girl, here, in her arms, had been secretly abused by an institution for *years*, and Catra had known absolutely nothing about it.

Catra, herself, had her own demons. Adora knew that better than anyone, other than Scorpia. Her childhood had been chaotic; growing up with Weaver's emotional and physical abuse in the children's home, combined with the early bullying in school because of her skin colour and because of being from the children's home. It had made her defensive and mistrustful – quick to lash out and even quicker to judge. That, combined with a traumatic experience in the army and… well, she hadn't been well for a few years. She had coped through alcohol and flings with women, and, mostly, pushing everyone away – even people she liked. She had PTSD, depression and anxiety – and yes, she had gained control over all these problems through therapy and actively committing to change, but it had been a tough, lonely road, fighting the world from inside her own mind. It never got any easier, she had just… learned to live with it.

But Adora – Adora was different. From the offset, she was the favourite in the children's home. At school she was popular and friendly and academically well-rounded. In the army, she had excelled – but so had Catra. In their respective fields in the Special Forces, they were esteemed and capable. There had been

no evidence of systematic abuse. What was more, Adora had kept it so well hidden.

Adora had fought her own battles alone and, unlike Catra, she hadn't been able to move on in any shape or form.

Two words kept circling her mind, and they weren't pleasant.

Treason and *execution*.

She thought of Adora in prison. She imagined visiting her behind bars and talking through a glass screen, just out of touch. She pictured waking up every day alone and knowing that for the rest of her life she couldn't have Adora – not really. Would Catra find someone else? Would she move away, start a new life in a different country, fall in love with a stranger?

Her thoughts continued to spiral.

Treason.

Death sentence.

Would the army have really charged Adora with treason or was it just a threat to manipulate her?

Would they do it again, if Adora refused to re-enlist?

Her mind stalled – stuck on the image of Adora dead, before her time, killed by the institution she had laid down her life for – murdered by the state for wanting to live, to be free, to be a person –

Catra's stomach lurched, and she lurched with it. As soon as she moved, Adora's hands moved against her, reeling her back in. Not wanting to wake her, Catra settled back down again and tried to get a hold of her breathing.

Think something else. Anything.

How would they do it?

No – not that.

How could she *fight* it?

Catra's claws gripped into Adora's back. She meant it when she said she would do anything to ensure Adora was safe. Nothing and no one was going to take her away again – she had made a promise. Whatever happened next, Catra would scheme and plan and work a way out of it.

Adora moved her head to rest it against Catra's chest, and it was just in the right position and the right angle for the steady weight to cause Catra to instantly relaxed. Still holding on, her eyes began to flutter, and she let sleep claim her, willing it to be kind to her this time.

Twenty-two years old

"How did the writing exercises go?"

Adora glanced at her notebook. "Uh, not good."

Perfuma held out a hand. "Can I see?"

Perfuma had given Adora writing prompts as part of her therapy session. Since Adora struggled to verbalise and name what she was feeling and why she was feeling it, Perfuma thought that it might help her to voice her feelings through written words. At first Adora thought it was a good idea; she struggled to process how she felt through talking, and the thought of writing it to no one in particular was refreshing. There would be no one waiting for a reaction to the words she wrote, and she didn't need to worry about getting emotional when explaining things.

In reality, Adora had spent most of the afternoon writing one or two words and doodling along the lines. The entire page was

almost covered in little drawings of hearts crossed out and spindly-looking trees, and lots and lots of boxes.

Perfuma made a long ‘humming’ sound as she stared at the notebook. “Underneath ‘say something kind about yourself’ you wrote ‘Don’t know’.”

Adora scratched the back of her neck. “Well, I… don’t know.”

What kind of question was that, anyway? *Why* did she have to say something kind about herself? Lying about how she felt about herself wasn't going to help her. It would only feel disingenuous. If the prompt had been about things she could improve, or things she could do better, then she'd be able to write an endless list.

But Perfuma's therapy was all about self-love and kindness. Yes, most of it had been beneficial so far. Adora was thinking twice before judging herself in the present, and she was actively trying to hold herself to the same standards she held other people; in other words, she was trying to *forgive* herself for things out of her control.

When reflecting on her past - especially her recent past - well, Adora had trouble accessing any of it. Meditation had helped her stress and anxiety disorders, but the progress had been slow and she was known for being impatient.

“For ‘name an achievement you had in the last three years’ you wrote ‘not dying’.”

Perfuma said it with a straight face that Adora snorted. She looked at her friend-slash-therapist and said, “I thought that was funny.” When Perfuma still didn’t laugh, the blonde added, “Because I was supposed to die.”

Perfuma closed the notebook with a *snap*. “Yeah, I got it.”

Imagining Perfuma writing ‘*using humour as a deflection for traumatic experiences’* in her session notes after this, Adora cringed inwardly. To save the situation, she said, “Listen, I don’t

think writing is for me. Exercise has helped my grounding activities – it makes me feel here, present. Like a person. I managed to read a book for *pleasure* the other day, and not just as part of my teaching studies. Oh – and my teacher training is going well." She shrugged. "Can't we just leave this part?"

"Adora." Perfuma leaned forward; she had never looked so serious. "You've made a lot of progress, and I'm proud of you. We're all proud of you. But we need to process your thoughts and feelings around certain… events to help you in the long-term." The therapist glanced at the notebook in her hands, flicking back to the pages of doodles. "I do, however, have another idea. How do you feel about painting?"

Present day

The next morning, Glimmer called for an emergency intervention.

Adora and Catra were invited over to Glimmer and Bow's apartment. It was in the prime of Brightmoon, between the beach and the shopping district. Located on the top floor, they had a view that stretched into the far horizon, and the constant sound of waves on their glass-enclosed balcony. Adora loved it here; she loved how the apartment was open-plan and airy, and despite its busy location, quite quiet. It was a far cry from the apartment she had lived in with her two best friends while they were at teacher training – that had been smaller and decorated with bright, obnoxious colours. Since then, Glimmer's taste had matured – also, her mother hadn't allowed her to decorate.

Speaking of Angella, Glimmer had invited her to the 'intervention' as well. Glimmer had asked if she could confide in her mother about the contract and everything in between so that they could ask for legal help. Of course Adora had said yes - Angella had already done so much for her the first time. She had already kept so much from her in the beginning. Telling Angella the full story took a weight off Adora's shoulders.

They sat around the dining room table; Catra was on Adora's right, Glimmer on her left, and Bow and Angella across the table from her. Angella looked better today, Adora noted; she had travelled down to the apartment by herself, and there was more colour to her cheeks.

Adora was doing her best to appear *present*. She took regular deep breaths to ground herself, otherwise her mind was trying to blur the edges of reality that way it had when her dissociation had been particularly bad. Having Catra close to her helped, and she was in a familiar location with people she cherished.

However, it was also hard controlling the level of regret that was creeping into Adora's senses. Despite how freeing she had found coming clean about the failsafe and She-Ra to be, there was still a part of her that regretted opening up about it at all.

Facing these fears - the consequences of her own actions - was tiring, though. Adora stared at the table, unwilling to look back at the sad, pitying, worrying eyes trained on her. There was an atmosphere in the apartment; *a tension that screamed we're trying to act normal in abnormal circumstances.*

Glimmer started with a heavy sigh. "Okay, so… Adora has a problem."

Fumbling with his fingers, Bow mumbled, "That's an understatement."

"Well, how would you like me to phrase it, Bow?" Glimmer snapped. "*Adora's life is fucked unless we find a loophole in this legal contract*?"

"Language, Glimmer," Angella chided. As her daughter glared at her boyfriend, Angella refocused her attention. "Adora, do you have a copy of your contract?"

"Uh, yeah," Adora said, nodding. She glanced between everyone at the table, never resting on one person. "I have it somewhere. I tried to study it myself, but it didn't go well."

"I'll need to see a copy of it before I can give you proper advice, you understand that, don't you?"

"Of course, yeah." Adora squinted as she tried to remember that main clauses. "It has three parts: one, that I have a personal responsibility – or something – for the military-owned failsafe inside of me. Two, I agree to re-enlist for active duty when they need me, and the third is the non-disclosure agreement making sure I don't spill the beans on classified information."

Angella nodded while she listened. She leaned her arms on the table and clenched her hands. Pulling Adora in with her gentle movements, Angella pinned her with a serious stare. "I think I told you before that this was going to be tricky, and I didn't know the extent of the problem at the time."

Ducking her head down, Adora's arms started to tremor. She pushed them under the table, just in time to hear Catra say, "Do you think it's doable? Do you think we can find a way out of it?"

"The only route I can see is the long-winding road of legal action," Angella answered honestly. "First, we would have to claim the contract itself was unfair and unlawful. If that succeeds, we will have to challenge the individual clauses." Her tone shifted. "Tell me, Adora, are you on any medication? Are you still seeing your therapist?"

"Uh, no and no." Adora pulled a face – an apology, because she knew what was coming. "The only medication I take is for the chronic pain in my leg."

Huffing, Glimmer whined, "*Adora* – you told us –"

She raised her hands in a surrender. "I know, and I'm sorry. I just didn't feel like talking about anything, and the anxiety meds were making me… hazy."

It was true; after Catra's birthday, Adora had stopped taking most of her prescribed medication. To change the dose, she would have to go back to her clinical therapist, and that was the last thing she

wanted to do. The past few months had been filled with panic attacks and anxiety because of the military correspondence, and she had a feeling the meds were making her worse. She hadn't told anyone because she knew Glimmer would react like this, and for as much as she loved her best friend, sometimes she didn't feel like being interrogated over personal decisions.

Angella brushed it off with a wave of her hand. "Still, you have a long-running history of mental health problems from your time in the military, and we can provide medical records to prove that asking you to re-enlist is unfair treatment and will substantially impact upon your health."

"What about the failsafe?" asked Bow, nervously glancing between the women.

"Well, that's the part that's worrying me," Angella said. "They are, indeed, correct that they own the military equipment in Adora, but how it got there and how long it's stayed there is arguable. In terms of legal jargon, we won't have much to go on, and I doubt we'll find many court cases about the ethical concerns of technology being placed inside a living host." She turned her attention across the table. "Do you have any proof that they put the equipment inside of you against your will, Adora?"

"Ah – no." Adora frowned, aware of how far the military had gone to protect themselves and their interests. "They made me sign a contract for that too. I didn't know what was happening, and they didn't tell me… anything, really. But I'm sure they covered themselves in the contract."

Angella sighed. "Hm. Indeed. I think the only way we can win that argument is by proving that it's unethical to not remove equipment from the host when the host no longer wants – or consents – to being part of the experiment. And then there are the experiments themselves, and if the military should've used a human host at all."

There was a moment of silence. Adora felt Catra's hand walk across her thigh and hold onto her knee. The blonde looked up, trying to smile, but it didn't reach the rest of her face. Catra's eyes widened, and then she glanced away again.

"You sound worried, mum," Glimmer said suddenly.

"I am." The older woman caught all their attention. "I'm not going to lie to you, Adora. This would be a mighty case to take to court, with many layers and many counter-arguments. It would be a case for the ages – it could set the precedent for legal and ethical future military experiments." Angella's tone dropped an octave. "Once the NDA is dealt with, the media will almost definitely want included in the action."

It was all just… too much. Adora fumbled with herself as she felt Catra's hand tighten on her leg through her jeans. She was giving everyone here *so* much hassle, so much stress. It wasn't worth it – they didn't have to do it. She thought she was going to burst with the rising pressure in her chest - the panic stirring in her nerves.

Trying to get the words out, Adora mumbled, "I don't want – I don't want to cause any trouble."

"Do you think that it's right, what they're doing?" Angella asked softly, and her gaze was full of something Adora couldn't place. "Would you want it to happen to anyone else?"

"No," Adora admitted, vehemently shaking her head - but that didn't mean she wanted everyone here - her friends, her family - to put themselves through hell to save her.

"Change doesn't happen overnight. Sometimes change has to be enforced. They've pulled out all the stops to control you." Angella sat back in her chair, as if it was final. "We have to do the same."

Catra briefly let go of Adora's leg as she asked, "What happens if the case, at any stage, fails?"

And it was a very good question.

The only thing worse than putting everyone through an intense, personal court battle was putting them through it to ultimately face disappointment. Adora watched Catra's jaw clench as they waited for an answer, and her own heart *thwacked* against her ribs.

Catra didn't deserve this.

Catra would be better without me.

"It depends on where or why it failed," Angella said. For the first time, she looked away. "If it failed at the very beginning, and the court believed the military were in their own right to create a contract for Adora to sign instead of the charges against her… It's very likely that the contract will stand, or become void."

"What does that mean?" Glimmer asked, her eyebrows furrowed.

Angella hesitated. She opened her mouth and then closed it again. Very slowly, she replied, "The military might charge Adora with the initial claims of abandonment and treason."

Adora's head felt light and airy. She reached out for Catra under the table, and their hands found one another mid-air as Catra silently reached out to her too. It was unclear who squeezed the other more.

It wasn't worth it, Adora decided, distracted by the stuttering heartbeat pounding in her head. She may as well re-enlist and give it her best shot at the end of January. It would cost less money, give everyone less stress, and stop the inevitable – the army winning – all over again.

Adora didn't want to go to prison. At least if she re-enlisted, she had a small chance of getting out one day. There was no escape from a charge of life imprisonment - or worse.

Trying to keep her voice from shaking, she started, "I don't think –"

"Shut up," Catra snapped, whipping around. With the brunette's eyes burning holes straight through her, she insisted, "You can't go back there, Adora. You can't."

Angella raised her hands in a motion that said *calm down*. "I'm not going to promise you anything – any of you, but I promise you I will do everything I can so that Adora is treated fairly."

But Adora was undeterred. "Angella – you're not well. And the cost of this stuff –"

"Catra is right, Adora," Angella interrupted, frowning. "We want to help you. More than that, I want to see the army get what they deserve. None of this is right. They know it, we know it. We just need to prove it."

Heart still racing, and panic truly setting in, Adora crossed her arms over her chest, letting go of Catra's hand. Every fibre of her body was telling her to cut all ties – to go it alone from here. To save everyone. It was hard to reason with herself when the alternatives were just as dangerous as the reality she was facing. And now she had dragged down everyone dear to her.

She hadn't felt the sharp claws of self-hatred in a long time, but she could feel them starting to sink into her skin.

"So, what do we do?" Bow asked, trying to sound perky and helpful to ease the growing tension.

"The four of you don't need to do anything," Angella said. "I'll review Adora's contract and get in touch with the right people." Then, directly to Adora, "When are you due to re-enlist?"

"In a month."

Adora didn't need to meet Angella's gaze to know how disappointed she would be.

“A month isn’t enough time. Can you delay it?”

Biting her lip, and giving a very small shake of her head, she muttered, “I don’t think so.”

Angella gave a long hum. “I’ll put in a petition as soon as I can. Hopefully that will stop them from taking their own action. In the meantime, enjoy the holidays. And try to find a reason to smile. All of you.”

That was another thing to add to the ‘things to feel guilty for’ list Adora was creating in her mind: she had ruined everyone’s Christmas. She was aware that Catra was watching her closely as Glimmer and Angella got up from the table and embraced each other. Just as she was about to escape to the bathroom to try and calm down (and avoid Catra's astute eyes), Angella called,

“Adora, can I speak to you privately?”

Nodding, Adora shakily offered a smile. She let her hand graze Catra’s shoulder as she walked past, following Angella out of the room and into the hall. She sensed that Catra was musing over something, and Glimmer would probably start a pep talk once her mother left for the day. Knowing it would be a while before she could recharge her brave face, she stood in front of Angella and met the kind woman’s eyes, desperately trying not to crumble.

“The others, especially my daughter, can be very – well, you know how they are.” She reached out to rest a supportive hand on Adora’s upper back. “But I want to check in with you to ensure you’re okay.”

“I’m okay, Angella,” Adora insisted. There was so much that she wanted to say, but she was drawing a blank in the wake of saying them. “Thank you.”

Angella nodded, but her eyes clouded. She paused. “I’m proud of you for speaking out about this, but I want you to know; if this case goes forward, you’ll be scrutinised. It could get nasty.

Everything you say, everything you do – especially when the media get involved. I want to make sure you're prepared."

Adora shuffled uncomfortably. "I'll try to be."

Honestly, she was struggling to see past anything other than the repercussions of her failed re-enlisting. It still wasn't too late to back out of any of this.

And she *knew* Catra was going to give her hell for thinking like this when they were alone again.

"And you won't do anything rash, will you?"

Adora quirked her head. "Rash?"

There was another pause, longer this time. Angella dropped her hand and clasped it with the other. "Anything that you will regret?"

Adora wasn't sure what she met. Blinking, she promised, "No, of course not."

Angella sighed before turning back to the door. "Such a large amount of responsibility burdened on young shoulders," she said, more to herself than her companion. "I'll do my best for you, Adora. You have my word."

Twenty-two years old

When Perfuma had sent her home with paints and various sizes of canvas, Adora thought it was *Perfuma* who had lost it.

How was she supposed to *paint* what she felt?

"Think of what the colours represent – how shapes interact with one another, or a what zones of the scene are in shade, and which ones are in light. Unleash yourself onto a blank canvas and process the results. It'll be all internal, but, at the moment, that's

where your emotions are. Try to coax them out in your own surroundings."

Adora sat down with her canvas propped up against the kitchen wall and various shades of paint leaning on the kitchen counter. She frowned at the blank frame and tried to *think* of how she felt and what she could draw to represent it.

She thought back to when they were kids, and Adora had drawn a pink floaty blob to represent love. That – that was what emotions felt like to her. They were indiscernible, but potent at the same time. Some were murky and others were vibrant.

Just like colours.

Adora did a quick online search for abstract art. It led her onto expressionism, and the line that sometimes fell between the two. She looked at pieces by famous artists and amateur, and everything she looked at made her *feel* something. It was like a firework had gone off inside her brain.

She immediately picked up the paintbrush and started to work, letting her mind guide her; she painted sunny yellows and passionate orange, and then she ruined them with ragged strokes of black and blue. The greens and rust browns in the centre called to her, and was drawn to the depth of the black contrasted with the prime of the yellow. She continued for hours, adding and correcting, styling and coercing the colours and shapes depending on what she felt – on what she wanted to *express*.

When she was done – and already feeling emotionally exhausted – Adora put down her paintbrush and put on the kettle. Turning back to examine the canvas, her breath caught in her throat.

The left side of the canvas was distorted by the right; the light, brought to life with primary colours, was destroyed – tainted – by the mixed hues of browns and blacks and greys. A red slash tore its way across the centre of the image in an angry diagonal line.

It was how she felt right now – it was her grief, her perseverance, her redemption. It guilt – so much guilt, but it was clouded by the tangle of webs that had collected in her mind.

Yes, she had processed what had happened *to* her. But she hadn't processed what *effect* it had on her.

Adora sat in front of her painting, too numb to feel anything. It was all in front of her anyway, staring back at her, a representation of her trauma. It wasn't until Glimmer and Bow came home to the apartment that she finally snapped out of it, as if someone had cut the strings on her emotions.

"Adora? What –"

Adora silenced them by pulling them both in for a hug. She was crying, but it wasn't sad. It wasn't happy, either. It was relief.

Chapter End Notes

> It's been a while, but I'm back with mediocre content! I'm doing my best to keep regular weekly updates, but I got somewhat of a promotion at work, and I'm once again facing the eternal struggle of 'make more money to indulge in capitalist expenditure' versus 'having free time to do things I actually like doing'. Alexa, play 9 to 5.
>
> From here, the story gets less *angsty* but keeps the same intensity. There will be one sightly dark/triggering scene in the future, but it will be brief and I will warn you well in advance (unless I scrap that scene altogether, which is tempting ngl).
>
> Thank you for reading! The response last time blew me away. I read every single comment and I reply to as many as I can.
>
> Stay safe,
>
> Cx.

Splinter

Chapter Summary

Warning for cringe-worthy use of the phrase 'daddy'.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Catra marched down the halls of the camp as fast as her heavy boots would take her. There was a commotion in the mess room – by the sounds of the loud voices carrying down the corridors, it was most likely a fight. Readying herself for a shouting match with the junior soldiers, she almost barrelled into a large uniform in front of her. She had to do a double take to recognise Scorpia.

“What the hell –”

“Easy there, wildcat. I don’t think you should go in there.”

“Get out of my way, Scorp,” Catra snapped, trying to sidestep her. “What’s going on in there?”

Scorpia blinked at her a few times. “You don’t remember what today is?”

Catra paused. She thought about the date and the connotations of what it meant. It was just a normal Tuesday, wasn’t it? Tuesday meant bad rations for dinner and weapon training with the senior privates after lunch. She narrowed her eyes at her friend. “Don’t play games, Scorpia. What do you mean?”

“Well, today’s the day,” Scorpia said, and her voice was low, almost like she was upset. “Today’s the day it happens.”

“What happens?” Catra demanded. Her patience was at its limit. She pushed her friend out of the way and marched into the mess room.

Soldiers of all different ranks were watching the television screen, talking in loud voices. A red banner across the bottom of the news channel said 'breaking news'.

The headline read: *War hero, Adora Greyskull, put to death for treason*

Catra's entire body went cold.

"They did it this morning," Scorpia said in her ear, but Catra hadn't heard her follow her into the room. "The appeal didn't work. She was pronounced dead by lethal injection at 9:04am."

As Catra turned on her heel, she heard her breath catch in her throat. The room started to spin. She fell to the floor as a crying-fit overtook her. All the things she didn't say. *All the things that were left unresolved between them. She would never see Adora again – she would never have a chance to –*

Gasping sobs hurt her throat and made it hard to breathe. The thick and fast tears streaming from her eyes made her feel like she was drowning. She gasped and heaved and tried to break through –

Catra woke up crying.

She wheezed as her eyes opened to the blackness of the room. Her eyes stung with tears. She sat up in bed, her hands shaking, as she squeezed her eyes and tried to regain her senses. *It was just a dream*.

It had felt so real.

As she looked up and around, she noticed Adora was no longer in bed with her. That didn't make sense. She had stayed over at Adora's house, hadn't she?

Leftover panic from the dream started to crawl up her throat like a spider crawling up a drain. As her breathing picked up and the tears continued to flow, she yelled, "Adora?! Adora!"

There were footsteps, and then the sound of the light clicking on at the door. Blinded by the absence of darkness, Catra shielded her eyes. She felt warm hands on her, all around her, encasing her in a hug. “I’m here,” Adora whispered against her hair. “I’m here, I’m sorry. I couldn’t sleep.”

Catra held onto her so tightly, not saying a word. She focussed solely on the blonde’s smell – her usual scent mixed with something earthy – while she let her mind catch up with the rest of her emotions.

It was a dream.

Adora was here.

It wasn’t real.

“What happened?” Adora asked when Catra eventually calmed down.

“Nightmare,” the brunette mumbled. She was embarrassed now that reality had caught up with her. Pulling away to look the blonde in the face, she said, “It doesn’t matter.”

Adora frowned and it pulled on her eyebrows, giving her an adorable dopey look. When she opened her mouth to say something else, Catra noticed a pink mark on her cheek. She reached out to wipe it away, but it didn’t budge.

“Why are you covered in paint?” Catra asked at the same time as she noticed Adora’s old t-shirt was thick with different colours of the stuff.

And that’s what that smell was – *paint*.

“I couldn’t sleep,” Adora replied, as if that made sense. She gestured to the paint all over her. “I thought I could do some art and get rid of some of the… feelings I’ve been holding onto.”

Yes, Catra could've questioned it: why now, in the middle of the night? Why wasn't she sleeping? But she – sort of – understood it. Sometimes creative things took hold of you in the strangest, most inappropriate times. When she was younger, she had also felt the same way.

Escapism called when the demons knocked on your door.

"You've never shown me your art before," Catra commented lightly, grabbing the hem of Adora's top.

She heard Adora's hesitation. This wasn't something she could push – she knew that. Adora deserved privacy and an outlet to her emotions that didn't involve anyone else. But Catra would be damn-well lying if she said she wasn't curious to see Adora's art.

Adora offered her a red-stained hand. "Come on."

She led Catra into the spare bedroom across the hall. As the door creaked open, it was clear that this room was somewhere between an office and a storage unit. A white sheet covered half of the floor, and on top of it was a chair, an easel and a small circular table littered with bottles of leaking paint.

Then there was the painting Adora had been working on.

From the centre, there was a burst of pinks and reds and oranges. It looked like an explosion, with the edges decorated with sharp, jagged black triangles. Adora had used different brush strokes for different colours, meaning the black edges were thick and layered, while the centre was thinner and more fluid.

Catra had no idea what to think of it.

"It's not finished," Adora said, twisting her hands as she walked towards it. "I'm not sure if it will ever be finished."

"What is it?" Catra asked, bending over to get a closer look. Every stroke appeared to be deliberate. There was clearly a lot of effort

put into the thought process, that much was clear. She just had no idea what it was.

"Sad."

Catra tilted her head as she stood up straight. "Sad?"

"Sad happy," Adora amended with a wistful shrug. "It's how I'm feeling right now."

"But… what *is* it?" Catra tried to clarify, squinting at the canvas. "Is it supposed to be something?"

She was definitely missing something. When Catra used to draw, she used to draw things and people – fantastical places that would take her far from reality. Adora's painting – to her – looked like shaded colours and mysterious shapes. Things that didn't make sense.

"Nah. It's just a feeling." Adora rubbed her arm, in a way that told Catra she was embarrassed. "There's nothing literal about it – that's why it's abstract. It's my version of expressionism."

Catra continued to frown at the piece. She wanted to *understand* – it was something of Adora, of course she wanted to relate to it. Sitting backwards on the chair, she faced the painting. "How does it work?"

That seemed to do the trick, because Adora *lit up*. She perched on the edge of the workstation, and with gleaming eyes, she pointed to specifics as she explained.

"Colours have meaning, depending on my mood. Pink, for example, is happy. Happy or love." She gestured dramatically with her hands. "But some days I want to slap it on the canvas with a scraper and bury it with tones of grey or black."

Catra nodded and had to fight the smile that wanted to creep onto her lips. She loved this version of Adora – bright and passionate, eager to discuss a deep topic or an abstract idea. She

could listen to her talk all day about something she was passionate about.

"So, it's like one big metaphor," Catra surmised.

"Yeah, kinda," she muttered, but it was clear that she'd moved onto a different conversation in her head. Leaning across the table, Adora rested her chin on her hand and pierced Catra with a keen stare. "What does it make you feel when you look at it?"

Snorting in amusement, Catra leaned back in the chair and thought about the artwork in front of them. It didn't make her *feel* anything. She just saw pretty, complicated colours. "Honestly? Confused." She pointed to the middle. "The centre almost looks like a lesbian flag, but the black shards ruin it." When Adora laughed at her, she narrowed her eyes. "What's so funny?"

The blonde hesitated. Biting her lip, she shrugged her whole body. "You're in here. Somewhere between the shades of red."

Catra's heart leapt. "I'm – what?"

"When I started this, I was thinking of us. Of how you make me feel. The shards and shadows are the dangers lurking." The blonde brushed it off, as if she hadn't said something that had made Catra's *entire chest burn*. "It's not done yet, though. It's just what I was feeling when I woke up and couldn't get back to sleep."

Adora had painted them.

Well – not them. Not their physical selves. This wasn't a cute portrait of Catra; it somehow felt much more. This is what Adora felt, in the swirling warm, lovey colours. Her emotions were laid bare for them to see.

It made Catra's skin buzz and her heart melt. "Me, huh?" she muttered, looking back at the painting with a fresh pair of eyes. It was beautiful. "Us."

"I've painted us before," Adora gushed quickly. Her cheeks were pink. "One of the only pieces I ever sold was a painting called 'Conflict'. It was how I felt the last day we met – at the honour's ceremony. I didn't want to sell it, but the guy offered me a crazy amount of money for it, and I was only going to bin it anyway."

"Why would you bin it?"

"I couldn't look at it after it was done. There was too much hurt in it." She shook her head and shared a sad smile with the brunette. "The best part? The guy bought it for his husband – he thought it was beautiful and passionate. That's the beauty of art, though, isn't it? Interpretation."

Catra gave a thoughtful hum. "Have I always been red?"

"No. You're red now. You were purple before."

"Is it like a traffic light system? Red for when I'm good, purple for when I'm bad?" As she got up from the chair, Catra wiggled her eyebrows. "Just tell me you want to establish a safe word, Adora."

It was worth it just for the shock that sprung on Adora's face. Catra couldn't help the uncharacteristic giggle that fell from her lips as the blonde reached for a soggy paintbrush and flicked paint-soaked water at her.

"Is that a no to the safe word?" she teased, lunging for the paintbrush so she could strike a revenge attack.

"What else?" Adora said, leaping out of the way. "You want me to call you *daddy*?"

To her horror, Adora's low, mocking tone sent a jolt of *something* down Catra's stomach. Her entire body *twitched*. With her cheeks blazing red, she froze where she stood.

Was that –

Why did that do it for her?

And of *course* Adora noticed.

Pointing the paintbrush at her partner, she cackled madly. "Oh my fucking –"

"It was the way you said it!" Catra defended with a hiss. "Don't kink shame me!"

"I can't believe the power I have in my hands." Adora's eyes gleamed. "Just you wait – the next time we're in public, when you least expect it, I'm going to lean over and whisper for everyone to hear –"

Catra scoffed and crossed her arms. "You haven't even called me 'girlfriend' in public yet without gushing like a loser, so let's not get ahead of ourselves."

It was Adora's turn to freeze. "Girlfriend?"

There was an awkward silence.

Catra cleared her throat and decided it was the perfect moment to wipe away the water stains the paintbrush had flicked onto her vest. "That's what we are, right?" she glanced up as the panic set in. "Right? Or have I just taken the best friend thing too far again?"

Adora shook her head so quickly that it looked like her neck was going to snap off. "No – I, yeah. Yeah. Girlfriend."

But all Catra heard was the blonde's dull, vacant tone. "You don't sound too sure," she pointed out.

"It just sounds…" – pausing, Adora struggled to find the words – "not enough for what we are."

Something in Catra's chest exploded and then put itself together again. She felt full – full to the brim with love – with adoration for the girl in front of her. Trying to maintain her cool – and the upper

hand – she decided to snark, "Do you always expect a proposal after the first time you call someone daddy?"

Once again, Adora's eyebrows shot up her forehead and her mouth gaped like a fish. "I'm not – that's not – shut up!"

Catra reached out to grab her *girlfriend's* hand. "I love it when you get all flustered."

"*You* make me flustered," Adora said, pouting, as Catra pulled her in for a kiss.

Their lips were slow and savouring. Catra rested her hands on Adora's hips and just sank into the warmth that felt like *home*. She hummed happily as the blonde playfully nipped on her bottom lip, and she pulled away to look up at her while a million thoughts ran through her head.

Adora had painted them. Adora was scared of the dangers lurking – of the blacks and greys tainting her vision of love. Catra thought back to their conversation earlier with Angella, and her stomach sank to the floor. *Nothing was ever simple*.

"What's that look for?" Adora asked, running her hands down the brunette's back.

"I can't believe this is us now," she murmured. "I never imagined we'd be standing here kissing and talking about art."

Adora clicked her tongue. "That's not what that look is for. You want to talk about something."

Catra raised her eyebrows. Of course, she was an open book in front of her oldest friend. Every day there was less space between them – less to hide. "I want to talk about what happened earlier," Catra said slowly. "With Angella. Are you ready?"

"What is there to talk about?"

"You were acting weird. I get that you feel like people are going out of their way to protect you – really, I do. I wouldn't like it either." She brushed blonde strands of hair out of Adora's face. "But I'm just worried you're going to retreat into your shell like I used to do or do something stupid like running away again."

Adora took a moment to lean into the strokes of Catra's caresses. "I wouldn't run away this time. Not without you, at least."

"You only need to say the word and I'll book us the next available flights to the farthest country," Catra said, meaning absolutely every single word.

But Adora smirked, assuming the brunette was teasing. "Tempting."

"Take this seriously," Catra sniped, harsher than she intended.

Adora huffed a breath though her nose. Her smile vanished. "Okay. I'm listening."

"What can we do so you don't get restless?"

"It's not that I'm restless. It's just – I want to help. I want to be proactive about this. All the legal stuff – I can't really do anything, it's all down to other people. Professionals. I want to do *something*."

Catra nodded while she spoke, stroking her thumb against her hip as she considered it. This was Adora being honest – and she personally knew how hard it was to open up in situations where you felt vulnerable. She respected it, and she felt respected. "Okay."

Adora quirked her head. "Okay?"

"I think that's reasonable, and I'm sure Sparkles and Arrow boy will agree. How about we talk to them tomorrow, see what we can do together to find another way to fight this?"

Adora looked… surprised. Catra assumed that she probably got hassle from Bow and Glimmer – especially the latter – about her need to be an active participate in everything. And whilst Catra didn't understand it (and sometimes didn't like it) she knew it was important to how Adora ticked, and she had come to terms with it. She smiled encouragingly as Adora said, "Alright. Deal."

"Deal." Tugging on the drawstrings of her shorts, Catra tried to pull Adora from the room. "Now, come back to bed. I want cuddles before you do your morning run and yoga."

Adora allowed herself to be dragged, but she also rolled her eyes. "You're so *needy*."

Catra laughed. "This is me holding back," she warned.

And it was the truth – every second Catra spent not touching Adora felt like a second wasted. They'd already wasted so much time – every wasted moment from here on felt like sin.

Adora whispered in her hear as she wrapped her arms around Catra's waist, "I wasn't complaining."

Winter sun peeked through the blinds, drenching the bedroom in yellow splendour.

Adora woke up well-rested, despite only sleeping because of Catra's warmth surrounding her. For a brief moment when she woke up, she imagined that *this was it*. Catra would be beside her in bed forever, and there was nothing else to worry about.

But, as it did every morning, reality gave her consciousness. For the past few days there was a constant pit in her stomach. When she was with Catra, simply lying in bed or distracted by intense make-out sessions (they hadn't *slept* together since before the argument, although she was trying not to dwell on that too much) the pit in her stomach was the size of a pinprick. It was still there, but it was tolerable. For the rest of the time that she was awake,

however, the pit was a gaping hole, making her feel constantly queasy and – well, scared.

She was petrified.

No matter what way she looked at this, she didn't see a way out. After the conversation with Angella, she realised there were three options: one, she goes back to the army and endures whatever plan they have for her. Two, she puts everyone she knows into an awkward situation by fighting the contract legally, which will probably result in the army willing through deceit and bulling – and then what? She re-enlists anyway, or worse – she's charged with treason and abandonment. The third option was the same as the second, only with the unlikely probability that she *won* the legal battle.

What would that even mean?

Would she be free?

These concerns – this fear – circled her subconscious so often that it was affecting her regular thoughts and feelings. In brief moments where she was alone, she felt powerless and deep-rooted self-hatred. She had *almost*cried in the shower because her heart rate raced, and her head spun, and she was certain she was experiencing another panic attack. Even though she had managed to get it under control, she was ashamed at how weak and vulnerable she felt.

Her thoughts were turning darker when she wasn't keeping busy.

And it was a bad sign.

So, she was grateful that Catra invited Bow and Glimmer around for lunch to discuss what they could do to help Angella's legal plan. Tomorrow was New Year's Eve, and while they would see each other for the party at the Amaris' house, they probably wouldn't have the opportunity for serious conversations like this one.

“You’re not trying to talk us out of helping you, are you?” Glimmer asked, her eyes narrowing, as Adora passed a tin of biscuits between the group.

Adora sighed. She would if she could, but she also knew the situation was too far gone to suggest it. “No. Besides, I’m not a complete idiot. I’m going up against the military – even *I* know I can’t do that alone.” She paused. “And the alternative – just going back and fulfilling the contract – isn’t something I… want to do.”

“Character growth,” Catra said with a smirk. Adora lightly elbowed her.

“I still think the legal case is the best option, Adora,” said Bow between a mouthful of chocolate digestive. “It buys us time to think of something else if it starts to – you know.” He looked at Glimmer nervously. “Go wrong.”

“Which won’t happen,” Glimmer said forcefully.

“But that’s what we wanted to talk about,” Catra pointed out. “What else can we do? We need a backup plan – something we can work on while Angella does all the legal stuff.”

“And to keep me busy,” Adora added. “I want to help. I want to feel like I’m doing something other than just giving evidence.”

“You’re not just giving *evidence*,” Glimmer chided. “You’re exposing the Etherian military.”

Bow gave a thoughtful hum, clearly on board with thinking outside of the box. “We could build a bunker. Somewhere Adora could hide in case they come looking for her.”

“I don’t want to hide,” Adora said in a small voice.

“Besides, there’s probably a tracker in that chip inside her,” added Glimmer, pointing to her friend on the sofa. “I reckon they’d be able to find her no matter where she goes.”

Adora frowned and rubbed at her chest, just above her scar. She hadn't thought of that. Over the years, she had grown accustomed to feeling foreign in her own body, or like she didn't have complete control. It had been a long time since she'd been reminded of it so viciously, however. It took her a moment to regain her ability to act normal.

"Thanks for that, Sparkles," Catra hissed, not unkindly. Her hand found Adora's on the sofa and squeezed it.

"I'm just being honest," Glimmer said, obviously growing frustrated. "All of our problems come back to that fucking failsafe."

"If only we could just pull it out like a splinter," Bow said wistfully, leaning his chin on his hand.

Catra blinked a few times at Adora. "We can't just take it out, can we?"

As everyone turned to her, Adora sank into the sofa. Her hand ghosted the top of the scar again. She thought of the surgery they had conducted to put it in her – she'd been knocked out for it, and it had taken a while to heal. Was that because of how difficult the procedure was, or because of the complicated technology? It was impossible to tell – she'd been spared the details. "I think it's pretty deep in there," she muttered, thinking aloud.

"Can you feel it?" Glimmer asked, just as quietly.

"Sometimes." She felt embarrassed discussing something that had been a secret inside her for so long. It still felt forbidden, taboo. "It used to glow whenever I got too emotional. But it hasn't done that since – well, since it activated."

Since the Heart project. She could feel Catra's eyes trained on her.

"And that was in the Horde Arms Factory?" Bow guessed, scratching his chin.

"Yeah." Adora gave a nervous chuckle as she remembered it. She didn't know how else to react – she was awkward. "It lit up the room. It brought *down* the room." Gesturing to the long, ugly scar on her cheek, she added, "That's how I got this scar."

She looked at Catra, then – realising that she had never told Catra of how she'd gotten her most obvious reminder of the war. Of *that* day.

Catra met her eyes, and there was something soft and uncertain in them.

"What are you thinking?" Adora whispered.

Catra gave a half-shrug. "We can't… take it out, can we?"

Glimmer brushed the suggestion aside. "We just went over this –"

"No, I mean, if we had the proper tools and we didn't damage it," added Catra quickly. She swept her thumb over the back of Adora's hand.

"Are you talking about surgery?" Bow grimaced.

Catra hesitated. She didn't say yes or no, she just continued her musing, "Adora could return it to the army, and then what could they do? She returned the equipment, and she can't serve any more active duty because of her health conditions. What would they do then?" She shook her head. "They couldn't do anything. Their argument would be invalid."

It was a good point, but Adora was sure it was something Angella wouldn't approve of. Would it hurt the legal case? Potentially. They would need to look into it more themselves.

And then there was the idea of surgery. Of removing the failsafe – of finally have her… Adora gulped as she thought about it. *Finally having my body back*.

Suddenly, the failsafe felt like a parasite. A living, breathing thing inside her, sucking the life away from within. Her skin crawled with repulsion, and she looked away, trying to hide how obviously uncomfortable she was with the idea.

If it worked, it would be worth it. Anything would be worth being free.

Bow look impressed, but still reluctant. “That’s not a half bad idea.”

“It’s too dangerous,” Glimmer argued. She gave an exasperated sigh. “There must be a reason the army haven’t taken it out of Adora. We would have no way of knowing how it would react and what it would do. And what if we damaged it?”

Bow frowned at his girlfriend. “But if we knew what we were doing…”

“Adora’s safety would obviously be the priority.” Catra glanced back at Adora, hopelessly. “We’d need someone who really knew technology, and what kind of person knows how Horde-grade technology works outside of the army?”

There was a pause.

Then, Bow and Glimmer looked at each other at the same time, and both said, “Entrapta.”

Chapter End Notes

> A few things to note: the main one being, I've done a rough outline of what is left in this story, and I'm doing my best to keep it at 30 chapters. It *might* end up being 35, depending on how much I can fit into the remaining chapters. I don't want everyone to be overwhelmed by content, but I also don't want to drag the story out longer than it needs to be. It's a tough line to tow.

Secondly, there will be some legal jargon (and some medical stuff) in the next few chapters and I want everyone to know that it probably won't be accurate because I'm not well-versed in legal or medical speak. There have been killer robots in this story, but please suspend your disbelief for a while longer as we discuss courts and legal battles! I'll do my best, but it's not a strong suit of mine.

Thirdly, thank you all for remaining supportive! I'll be updating the playlist sometime soon, and I'm on tumblr, occasionally, sharing updates. Every time I receive a comment it brightens up my day by a significant amount. I'm sending hugs to all of you.

Stay safe,

Cx.

Fireworks

Before meeting Bow and Glimmer, Adora had never been a fan of New Year's Eve, or the celebration of a *new year*. It was – if anything – her least favourite celebration; at Halloween, she used to stay up late watching scary movies with Catra. Christmas in the children's home was miserable, but the twinkly lights had made it feel special, and they'd gotten a feast during her time in the army. New Year, however, was a reminder that another year was coming, very similar to the one before it. They hadn't celebrated it when they were kids, and they usually got drunk and played games while in the army – which was standard practice on nights on leave away from active duty.

Glimmer Amaris, however, *shone* on New Year's Eve.

She helped her mother host a party like the ones depicted in *The Great Gatsby*. They invited everyone they knew, and they hosted actual *caterers* to feed the masses. During her first time attending, Adora had never seen something so excessive.

Adora had prepared Catra for a spectacle, assuming that she would *despise* it. Whilst, yes, admittedly, the grandeur was an estimate of the Amaris' wealth, it was also a gesture of how they treated their friends and family – they viewed it as a way to give back to those they cared about, and Adora thought that was special.

When she mentioned this to Catra, however, the brunette scoffed.

"It's an excuse to get pissed and I'll take it," she had said while cooking dinner. "But I will also absolutely scorn everything and anything there."

Adora thought that was fair game.

One thing that they were *both* excited for was that the dress code called for formalwear. They got ready in their respective homes,

and then Catra picked Adora up in her car at five o'clock. It would take them two hours to drive and Adora had made a *playlist*.

Yes, Catra had already bullied her for this.

Heart thumping against her ribcage, Adora opened the door a little breathlessly. There she was, standing in front of her, like a beacon of light. Her *girlfriend*.

Catra wore a tuxedo jumpsuit. It was black with slim-cut trousers and a silk top that looked like a blazer with nothing underneath. The V-neck cut down to her sternum. Her hair was pulled back in a ponytail and she had painted her lips a deep red. Adora didn't know how to react. Catra was gorgeous; she looked like a model. Adora found herself staring at the gleam of brown skin in the valley of her chest. Catra chuckled and put her hand out, pulling herself into the hallway.

"I never thought I'd wear this," she muttered with a gleam in her eye. "But now I'm glad I did."

"I never thought you'd wear something *like* this," Adora gushed, leaning back to get a good look at her. If she could capture a screenshot in her head so she could replay this moment, it would be *glorious*.

"It's… feminine," Catra offered with a shrug.

"But not too feminine," Adora supplied, patting her lapels. She met the brunette's mismatched eyes and heard her heart *sing*. Unable to help herself, she said, "Words can't describe you, Catra."

Catra rolled her eyes and tugged on the blonde's hand. "Come on, let's go."

Adora hesitated. When she gave herself one last glance in the mirror, she was surprised to see she was pouting. How did *she* compare to Catra?

Adora was wearing a white dress that Glimmer had picked out for her. Red lace ran from the bust to the waist, and it had a – gasp – slit on one leg, leaving it totally exposed. She had kept her hair down but pulled back the sides in a princess style. Adora liked it – loved it, even. But she felt self-conscious.

And a tiny bit of her was aware that Catra hadn't said anything.

Not like she expected compliments – oh no. Not when Catra looked like *that*.

She saw Catra's hands slip around her waist in the mirror before she felt them. Catra rested her chin on Adora's shoulder and pierced her with a smoky look in their shared reflection.

Adora's cheeks instantly fired up.

"What's wrong?" Catra muttered. "You look amazing, babe. Did I need to say it? I thought it was obvious." As she kissed the base of the blonde's neck, she added, voice husky, "You have an effect on me."

As full-body chills attacked her senses, Adora latched her lips onto Catra's and pulled her in for a kiss. Catra met her with fervour; she gave a slight moan as Adora's tongue pushed its way into her mouth and backed her up against the mirror. Catra's hands moved from her hips to her ass, bringing their hips flushed together. Adora was light-headed.

Their interactions had been somewhat limited since their argument. Adora wasn't one to initiate, always cautious that she didn't want to make Catra uncomfortable or misread the situation. Catra hadn't initiated anything either; and while Adora was aware of this, and felt a little pent-up about it, it was clear from the heat in *this* kiss that Catra hadn't initiated because she didn't *want* to.

There must have been another reason.

Adora pulled away first, desperate for some air. Catra's hand had found itself on the top of her thigh through the slit in the blonde's

dress. As they separated, Catra gave it a playful squeeze.

She knew what that did to Adora.

"Wow," Adora said, still breathless. She straightened the lapels on Catra's outfit.

"And you almost ruined it. Almost," Catra snarked, looking very satisfied with how flustered she had gotten her girlfriend. Glancing at her watch, she said, "We should get going."

Adora held onto Catra's lapels. She kept staring. "We should."

There was *something* dark and lusty in Catra's eyes tonight. It was making Adora feel a lot of things. Catra stroked Adora's neck, and as she leaned in to whisper in her ear, she left a soft kiss against her collar.

"Have I ever told you what I thought the first time I saw you in a dress?" she whispered.

Adora's cheeks were blazing. She swallowed deeply. "That was only a few weeks ago, wasn't it? When we visited Mara."

Catra left an open-mouthed kiss to the base of her neck. "I found it difficult to look you in the eye because of how *hot* you made me."

Adora bit her own lip. She wanted Catra to keep kissing her – she wanted to be pushed up against the wall with Catra's hands all over her body – she wanted to be left with her legs shaking, her heart racing –

"You're being ridiculous," Adora replied, an octave too high.

"I'm not." Catra kissed between the valley of her breasts, where the failsafe scar was hidden by the fabric of her dress. "You have no idea how I see you, Adora."

And with that, Catra pulled away completely and offered out her hand.

Adora stared at it for a few moments. Her skin was burning and she was undeniably turned on. She cleared her throat and looked from Catra's hand to her eyes.

Catra smirked.

So, Adora decided to have a little fun of her own. She had an effect on Catra – she had said so herself.

She took the brunette's hand and led her outside.

Just before they reached the threshold, Adora muttered in Catra's ear, with her other hand tightly gripping her waist, "It's a shame we have a party to get to, otherwise I would've asked you to take me on the stairs."

Adora walked towards the car, smug in how she knew Catra was watching her as she descended the steps.

Catra was feeling restless. After a two-hour car ride – most of that time, Adora had kept her hand on Catra's thigh which was *very* distracting – she was glad to stretch her legs. As soon as she laid eyes on the lit-up manor in front of them, however, a part of her died inside.

Adora wasn't exaggerating when she said Glimmer's family went overboard for New Year's Eve.

Music was blasting from the house. There were people in the gardens and lots of voices carrying through the evening breeze. It was cold too – but Catra simply used that as an excuse to pull Adora closer.

There was a barbeque on the porch and its smoke made Catra's eyes sting. In the distance, near the pond, was a spiked hot chocolate stand and various outdoor party games. How was it

possible to *know* this many people? They were crawling everywhere, laughing and drinking, like this was a funfair and not *someone's house*.

"Well?" Adora prompted as she guided them indoors.

Catra's tongue felt too big for her mouth. "Yeah. You weren't wrong. This is some Gatsby shit." She chewed over that thought. "I never did like Gatsby."

"You aren't supposed to. People who celebrate it read it wrong. Don't even get me started on the romance part of it – how can anyone think that's healthy?"

"No, I know *that*, but I thought it was a terrible book."

"I'm sorry – what?"

"You heard me. I understand the sentiment – greed and depression, the US is corrupt, yadda-yadda. But it was flowery language masking Fitzgerald's self-interest."

Adora stopped walking. She pinned Catra with a 'you can't be serious' glare. "You take that back right now."

It was kind of hot. Honestly, since she had first laid eyes on Adora in that dress, Catra was struggling to keep her libido in check. "What are you going to do if I don't, princess?" she challenged.

Adora raised an eyebrow. "Hmm, you might find out later."

"Ugh, get a room."

Both women turned to see Glimmer and Bow approaching them from the drink's counter. They were wearing matching outfits, which was gross, but totally on brand for them. Bow's shirt – pink and cropped – was cute, but Glimmer's pink and lilac off-the-shoulder dress made Catra's nose involuntarily twitch.

"You have plenty of them, mind if we disappear for a while?" Catra snarked, wrapping an arm suggestively around her girlfriend.

Glimmer rolled her eyes. "Not yet. We have something to do first. Guess who's here?"

"Who?" Adora asked.

"Entrapta," Bow said, and there was a contagious enthusiasm in his smile.

Adora looked taken-aback. "She came this year?"

Catra crossed her arms over her chest. "I don't think I've actually had a conversation with Entrapta yet. She's the Head of Computer Science, right?"

"Yeah – she's *super* smart," gushed Bow. "The greatest techmaster I've ever met."

"Bow used to study History, you know," Glimmer added, fondly stroking her boyfriend's arm. "Then he met Entrapta during our teacher training and she taught him almost everything he knows."

"Well, do you think we should ask her about" – Adora glanced around the room before whispering – "*you know*? Here? Now?"

"It's the perfect opportunity," said Bow.

"You're going to make her year with the technology stuck in your chest." Glimmer clawed Adora away from Catra's protective stance. "Come on, I last saw her in the gallery."

Catra gave a sulky huff as she watched Glimmer drag Adora away. Bow fell into step as they followed their girlfriends, shooting Catra a soft, knowing smile.

In a month, Adora could be lost to the army again – potentially forever. The fact that midnight was only a few hours away – and

therefore, another new year – was giving Catra a permanent jittery feeling deep in her bones.

Would this be her last new year with Adora?

Catra shook herself. It was easy to fall into old patterns, past mistakes – cynical thinking that made her frustrated and tightly wound. She didn't want that. Adora needed her.

But this Entrapta conversation was going to be *hell*.

Even though it was her idea, Catra hated the idea of trusting a non-medical professional with the health and safety of her girlfriend. Yes, Bow trusted Entrapta – that didn't mean Catra did. She had only seen the Head of Computer Science once, and that was in the background at her birthday drinks in the *Crooked Rainbow*.

The Gallery was a large open room in the back of the manor that had – you guessed it – paintings showcased on the walls. As they walked through the room, Adora pointed to a canvas on the opposite wall. It had the placard that read *Friendship*. It was messy, with bright whites, aquas and purples.

"That's one of mine," Adora said excitedly. "Angella bought it when I –"

"Hi guys!" called a voice from the bottom of the gallery. The purple-haired girl was bounding on her tiptoes and waving at them. "I waited here, just like you said."

The four of them hurried over to where Entrapta had set up a small tech stand. Judging by the equipment she had laid out, it looked as if she was monitoring the security cameras in the house. Catra shot Adora a questioning glance, but Adora simply shook her head.

"Thanks, Entrapta," said Glimmer kindly. She gestured to one of the viewing benches in the middle of the room. "Do you want to sit? There's something we need to discuss."

Entrapta sat beside Glimmer and Bow with Adora and Catra facing them. Entrapta's eyes were bright and interested. She met Catra's gaze and gave a wide smile.

"Uh, hi," Catra said awkwardly. "I don't think we've properly met yet."

"We haven't, but, *oh* I know a lot about you," Entrapta gushed, taking out a small touchscreen tablet from her pocket. "Did you know that since you've been at Brightmoon, Adora's productivity has decreased by 46%, and her breaks in the staffroom have almost quadrupled!"

"What a weird coincidence," Glimmer said drily.

As all eyes landed on Adora, including Catra's own devilish smirk, the girl in question blubbered nonsensically. "How do you – how does…?"

"Entrapta developed the school's internal servers and security systems," Bow said fondly. Then, he reconsidered, and frowned. "When we gave her permission to monitor stats and patterns at the time, we didn't know she would monitor everything. *Everything*."

"Entrapta, who's gotten the best student grade outcomes between me and Catra?" Adora asked, sitting forward.

Catra snorted. "That's unfair, and *unethical*, Adora –"

But Entrapta answered, undeterred, "Catra's student pass grade is 7% higher than Adora's."

"Wow. Never mind." Basking in the hot glow radiating from Adora's embarrassed face, Catra leaned back and smiled. "I like you, Entrapta."

"That's a highly illogical declaration considering we have both only just been introduced." Entrapta paused, as if remembering something. "But thank you."

Glimmer shook her head, as if annoyed by their shared pettiness. "Okay, so –" her eyebrows pulled together and she rounded on the blonde " –wait, you *really* fail people in Art?"

Adora scoffed. "Yes, actually, because it's a *proper* subject."

"Entrapta, can you send me Adora's latest teaching report?" Glimmer asked, still glaring across at her best friend. "I want to have a look at that. Anyway, there was something we needed to ask you. But it's sensitive." She eyed the other three. "You wouldn't be able to tell anyone else."

Entrapta's eyes shone. "Oh! A secret!" Pausing, she asked, "Does that mean I wouldn't be able to tell Hordak?"

"No," Glimmer answered quickly. "Especially not him."

Catra leaned over to whisper to Adora. "Who's Hordak?"

"My lab partner," Entrapta supplied, beaming.

"We think he's her boyfriend," Adora whispered. "He's ex-military too, but for, you know. The other side."

"Ex-Horde?" Catra nodded slowly. "Oh. Now that *is* interesting."

"I can hear you," Entrapta pointed out, loudly.

"You're a whizz with Horde tech, Entrapta," interjected Bow, probably trying to distract her from Catra and Adora's rude whispering. "So, can I pose a hypothesis to you?"

Entrapta nodded, her eyes wide and glittering.

"Let's say a piece of tech was implanted into a living host. It was specifically designed to corrupt Horde systems by using the matter of the living host."

Even before he was finished explaining, Entrapta had started to shimmy in her seat and flurry her hands in the air. "I know exactly

what you mean!" she gushed. "There was debate amongst the tech community as to how Etheria managed to win against the Horde. The Horde's systems were far more advanced than anything Etheria had ever produced – but they had *one* weakness. Many of us believe that Etheria won by exploiting that weakness by using a *living* host, as you called it, to corrupt the Horde systems – which was how Etheria won the war by targeting the communications transmitter. It would've technically been possible to use the Horde's technology against them by creating a strand of code so unique and so *powerful* and protecting it in a living shell, making it untraceable to the Horde's systems. The Horde underestimated *people*. It was an easy thing to do, given the size of their robotic empire." Blinking back at the dumbstruck faces staring at her, she added slowly, as if to make them understand, "But yes, your hypothesis is reasonably sound."

"Great," Bow said, looking between his friends. "Right. Ah – so… let's say the host wanted to remove the implanted chip that was inside of them. Is it doable?"

"Has it been activated?" Entrapta quizzed. "Has it ever fused with a live Horde interface?"

Everyone looked to Adora, including Entrapta. "Yeah," she croaked. She took a deep breath. "Yes."

"Fascinating!" Entrapta glanced to her tablet and began scrolling through articles. "Hmm… All debates concluded that a living host would *not* survive. The amount of energy needed to corrupt a Horde system is significant, and thus, would burn the host's physical energy – their own body – for a heat transfer of malleable energy." She looked up, at the blonde, and said in a hushed, awed voice, "But yet, Adora is here, sitting in front of us."

Adora's cheeks blazed. She shook her head, confused. "How did – I didn't –"

"Oh, sorry, are we still pretending we're discussing the hypothesis?" Entrapta groaned, and added forcefully, "Then

yeeees. If *someone* survived, then it is plausible the tech can be removed. Unless it's fused with *someone's* nervous system."

"How did you know we're talking about Adora?" Catra demanded, aware that she sounded overly protective. Her hand clasped Adora's on top of her thigh.

"As I said, this has been debated by the tech community for *years*. Adora was known for bringing down the communication transmitter that ended the Horde – ended the *war*. There have been rumours all along that she was involved in a secret experiment with Horde-esque tech."

Bow sighed. "Well, the more you know…"

But Glimmer put her hands up, and still frowning, asked, "Can you go back to the part where the tech might be *fused* to her nervous system?"

Entrapta cackled, completely disregarding the other people in the room. She stood from the bench and spun around. "This *is* exciting! The hypothesis is true! Sitting before me is *living* proof that codes can be directly implanted into a human host with tremendous success! A-ha!" She ran towards the blonde, tapping wildly on her tablet. "Adora, I need to run tests – I need to *know* –"

"Wait, Entrapta, there's time for that." Bow put his arm out to stop her. When Adora glared at him, he added, "Potentially. Listen, Adora wants the chip the military put in her *out* of her. Would you be able to help us do it?"

There was a pause.

And then –

"Absolutely!" Entrapta yelled, brimming with energy. "Will it be successful? Who knows! Not me! That's what makes this experiment *brilliant*!" She squealed. "Hordak's going to be so pleased!"

"Wait, no – no Hordak," Glimmer said, also standing up. For the first time, she looked angry. "This is between us, alright?"

Entrapta's smile immediately flattened. Quietly, she said, "But Hordak is my friend. He knows more about Horde tech than anyone else I know. He'd be able to help."

"He's a war criminal!" Glimmer argued.

Adora shrugged, muttering, "Technically, so am I."

Catra glared at her.

"He was part of the intelligence service that worked for the Etherian government that helped bring down the Horde!" Entrapta insisted. "If anyone knows anything about this tech, it's *him*!"

"We don't know if we can trust him, Entrapta," Bow said patiently. And then to Glimmer, he said, "And it should probably be up to Adora."

Everyone looked at Adora, who hung her head and stared at the ground.

They left Entrapta to her social experiments in the gallery and joined the main celebrations in the dining hall. The only thing that drew Adora's attention away from the sway of Catra's hips was the banquet of food they had on the far side of the room. There was every type of food she could think of, and some of it was placed at the front – deliberately – because Angella and Micah knew it was her favourite. Slipping her fingers through Catra's, Adora tried to bolt in the direction of the food, when she noticed who was approaching them across the hall.

Angella made her way through the crowds to find the four friends. Her hair was down, and her cheeks were rosy – something Adora hadn't seen on her in a while. Bow gave a mock salute as Angella stood between them, a smile for each of them. Then, she placed her hands on top of her daughter's shoulders.

“Glimmer, I think one of your friends has started to strip in the pool,” she said airily. “He’s drinking a bottle of champagne from the bottle and serenading a young woman.”

Glimmer shielded her eyes with her hands. “Sea Hawk?” She groaned. “Ugh, why isn’t Mermista stopping him?”

Angella’s eyes sparkled with mischief, but her tone was one of disapproval. “She’s passed out on a pool float, I believe. He hasn’t noticed yet.”

Glimmer sighed. “I’ll go get them.”

“Take Bow,” Angella said quickly. “And Catra, my husband would like to talk to you about your motorcycle in the garages. He’s done some updates on it for you since you were here last.”

“Oh – yeah.” Catra blinked a few times. She hesitated and met Adora’s gaze. “Sure. Thanks.” After her silent question of ‘is that okay?’ to Adora, and Adora’s minute nod of her head, Catra said, “I’ll meet you back here, okay?”

“Adora’s in good hands,” Angella promised. "We'll find you."

As ever, Angella was the master of deflection. Adora watched as Glimmer led Bow to the swimming pool and Catra left for the garage. It was clear that Angella wanted to speak to Adora alone, and that fact made her lose her appetite. If she wanted rid of her friends, then that only meant one thing. Once they were out of earshot, Angella gestured for the two of them to walk outside. Adora wiped her sweaty hands on her dress.

No matter how much she tried to avoid it, everything tonight was reminding her of the army – of her fate. If that wasn't symbolic of the year to come, she didn't know what was.

“How are you, Angella?” Adora asked, trying to stop her own fidgeting. “It’s a wonderful party as always.”

There was a tense pause. They waited for a group of laughing men to pass as they exited the manor.

The night air stung Adora's cheeks. She'd been in the warmth for too long.

“I’m concerned, Adora.” Angella placed a delicate hand on the top of her back between her shoulder blades. “I’ve put together a legal team and we’re currently examining your contract. We hope to have an official petition filed by the third week in January.”

“The week before they’re expecting me to re-enlist,” Adora summarised.

“Yes.” Angella stopped once they reached the gates leading to the garden. She faced Adora with her hands crossed. “All I can advise at the moment is for you to keep a low profile. I’m hesitant about letting you go back to teaching after the winter break.”

Angella shook her head a little desperately. “I’m better at keeping busy, Angella. It wouldn’t do me any good hiding away.”

“Yes, well, I expect you to restart your therapy sessions, at the very least. When it comes to preparing for the court case, it’s going to bring up a lot of negative experiences for you. I want to make sure you’re comfortable facing those conversations.”

“I will – I’ll get on that,” she promised whole-heartedly. “Thanks, Angella. For everything.”

It didn’t feel like enough. It never felt like enough. A few metres away, Glimmer’s echoing yells disturbed the sleeping birds in the trees. Adora glanced over to see Bow trying to help a drunken Mermista off a pool float. The sounds of her friends and their normal lives made Adora’s heart clench.

She was once again reminded of the feeling of looking in from the outside. She was here, in spirit. But she wasn't one of them.

“I don’t want your thanks,” Angella said, once again, sounding worried. “I just want you to be safe and healthy. Once the petition is filed, the military have no reason to contact you again – unless it’s to acknowledge the court case. If for – whatever reason – they try to pressure you into talking to them, or they warrant for you to be arrested, you must stay strong. Don’t give into them. They’ll use anything you say against you.”

In the background, a loud splash told them that Bow had fallen into the pool.

Glimmer and Sea Hawk started laughing.

Shaking her head, Adora frowned. She stumbled for the right words. “Do you think that will happen?”

“Perhaps. It’s too early to say. I wouldn’t put it past them to do anything in their power to spook you.” Angella paused. Her eyes were wide, and her lips held a secret smile. “I’m glad you found Catra again. I can see you make each other happy.”

“She definitely makes me happy.” Adora looked away. “But I can’t help but feel like a burden to her.”

Would she have said that to anyone else? Probably not. If anyone knew what it felt like to have a complicated relationship with a soul mate, it was Angella.

Catra could lead a normal life without Adora – she could finally move on and start again. Did Adora want that? No, of course not. She was selfish; she wanted Catra.

But was it fair to drag her – and all her other friends – down because of her own hardship?

Absolutely not.

It was a cold, hard fact in Adora’s mind: Catra would be better off without her. And it kept circling her brain like a puzzle begging to be solved.

“Can I offer you some personal advice now, Adora?” Angella asked after a moment.

Adora nodded.

“Sometimes when we’re in love, we’re blinded by it. All we can see is that person, as if our centre of gravity revolves around them. If something happens to them, or we’re in some way separated, we might act… irrationally. All we want to do is protect them, and we’d risk anything to see it through.”

Adora guessed where this was going. “I’m not –”

But Angella held up a hand. “I’m not referring to you, Adora. I’m referring to Catra. You have a lot going on – a lot of difficult hardships that you have to face. Sometimes it’s *just* as difficult for the person by your side as it is for the person facing the hardships. Catra would do well to remember that we are also there for her, too.” Angella did Adora the grace of pretending not to notice her wobbly lips or her loud sniffle. Instead, she carried on, “I would tell her this myself, but I think she would respond better if it came from you, no?”

Adora nodded. Wasn’t this what she had dreamed of since she had found the Amaris family? Angella accepting Catra into their strange found family. They weren’t alone anymore – neither of them. And as much as that knowledge scared Adora, given her personal situation, she knew Catra had always longed for somewhere to belong. She knew what Angella’s consideration would mean to her.

“Also, I wanted to add – watch out for Catra yourself.” Angella started walking around the corner towards the garages. “I know you would anyway, but I’m afraid she’ll react impulsively or irrationally if it looks like things aren’t going well for you.”

“She won’t,” Adora said, wiping at her eyes. “I’ll make sure of it.”

Angella looked satisfied. She nodded towards the garage, where Micah and Catra were crouched next to the motorbike. “Let her

know we’re here for her if she wants to rage against the world." In a very small voice, she added, "Some days I feel like doing it too.”

The two women looked at each other - in complete understanding. It felt peaceful, and Adora was grateful for it.

When Catra spotted Adora approaching, she jumped on the motorcycle and posed for her. Adora laughed – but honestly, it was insanely hot. Catra in a jumpsuit. On a motorbike. With a cigarette in her hand.

Speaking of cigarettes –

“Micah, are you *smoking*?”

Adora hadn’t noticed Micah in the background, resting his arm on the back of the bike and hiding a glowing cigarette behind his back. When he laid eyes on his wife, he discretely tried to puff out a lungful of smoke.

It completely gave him away.

“Now, dearest, don’t be mad –”

Angella rounded on him. “You gave that filthy habit up *five* years ago, Micah!” Then, as an after-thought, she added, “No offence, Catra.”

“None taken.” Catra shrugged and wiggled her eyebrows at Adora, pretending to rev up the engine. “I was thinking of getting a tattoo sleeve, just to complete the look, you know?”

Adora leaned on the handlebars. She was mesmerised by Catra for a moment – sometimes, she just liked to watch her, especially when she was being a cocky little shit. Her eyes held the moonlight, and her skin was slightly flushed with the cold night air. She was stunning.

And she was *hers*.

For better or for worse.

“You can borrow my leather jacket,” Adora said. Her eyes fluttered as Catra placed a hand at the base of her neck.

“I have plenty.” She leaned in, ghosting her lips against Adora’s. “I think I said before, but I look good in leather.”

Adora eyed Micah and Angella who were only a few feet away. Sensing her reluctance, Catra chuckled and backed off.

“Sorry,” Adora said quickly. “They’re the closest thing to parents I’ve ever had. Feels a bit weird.” Feeling gutsy, she whispered, “But I’ll make up for it when we’re alone later.”

Despite Catra’s cheeky grin, something flashed across her face – a look of uncertainty, almost apprehension. Adora frowned. She swept a thumb across Catra’s cheek, coaxing her to meet her gaze. “Hey, what’s wrong? We don’t have to. I just thought –” Adora’s cheeks felt very warm. “Never mind.”

“No, I want to – *believe me*, I want to.” Catra bit her lip. She took a drag of cigarette before throwing it to the ground. “I was just scared, I guess. Of hurting you, after last time.” In case Adora didn’t remember, she added, “You took a panic attack and had a problem with your leg. I don’t want to hurt you.”

Adora shook her head. “That wasn’t you, Catra. I was overwhelmed and I’d forgotten my medication.” She gave a teasing smile. “Besides, it was worth it.”

Catra huffed a laugh, still sounding uncertain. “You’re such an idiot.”

“I’ll tell you, okay?” Adora said instead. “I promise I’ll let you know if the chronic pain starts to flare up.”

It was wonderful, Adora thought, feeling open enough to *communicate* with Catra. The air had somewhat cleared between them, and they could breathe again. Adora couldn't tear her eyes

away as she leaned into her girlfriend's warmth. Any inch that separated them was an inch too many.

Grinning, Catra wrapped her arms loosely over Adora's shoulders, leaning against the bike. She was full of mischief. "You're just desperate for me, aren't you, princess?"

"Fucking hell, do you two ever stop?"

Adora jumped as if electrocuted and Catra squeaked. She wasn't sure how long Glimmer, Bow, Sea Hawk and Mermista had been standing there, but they had definitely overheard too much. Catra's cheeks darkened, and she looked adorably cute all embarrassed and awkward as she tried to regain some of her dignity. Adora couldn't help but continue to touch her, so she rested her hand on her waist.

Catra wasn't the only one looking sheepish; Sea Hawk was oddly quiet standing beside Mermista – and then Adora why noticed why: Mermista's dark purple lipstick was smudged across her mouth. Sea Hawk's face was also suspiciously covered in purple lipstick kiss stains; they covered his face, his neck, and continued past his collar. So much for being *just friends,* they weren't even trying to hide it now.

Meanwhile, Bow was soaked from head to toe and holding the remains of his pink shirt. Glimmer looked suitably grumpy about it.

"Aren't we all a sorry sight," Catra muttered.

Glimmer narrowed her eyes.

But before she could snipe back another comment, the sky lit up with fireworks – or, what looked to be fireworks.

They were completely silent.

Catra slipped off the bike and gaped at the sky. Hundreds of coloured orbs – reds, greens, blues, yellows – circled the black

sky, lighting up the Amaris manor and the surrounding lands. They swarmed together until they assembled into a formation – counting down the seconds until midnight.

“Entrapta usually sends a bot to do this for us,” Adora explained. “They’re drones. We’re not the only ones with PTSD at this party, and Angella likes how they don’t disturb the animals because they're silent."

“Amazing,” Catra breathed.

And like the first time Adora saw them, Catra was probably thinking the same thing she had: the drones they saw in the army did so much damage. They killed, they ransacked, they terrorised. And yet here they were, the same flying robots, providing entertainment to a few hundred people at a New Year’s Eve party.

It was a strange world.

As a giant 3 lit up the sky, Adora whispered in Catra's ear, “Will you be my new year’s kiss?”

2

“Only if you promise it’ll be the first of many,” Catra replied, her eyes glinting in the drone light. Adora’s heart pounded in her head. She couldn’t promise that. They both knew it.

Adora glanced at the sky. “If I promise to try my best, is that good enough for you?”

1

Were they talking about New Year’s kisses anymore?

Were they *ever* talking about what they really meant?

“That’s more than enough,” Catra murmured, her voice thick.

And as the drones wrote ‘HAPPY NEW YEAR’ between the stars, Adora kissed Catra like it was the beginning of their story and not the end.

Morals

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Adora stared at herself in the bathroom mirror.

Specifically, at her neck, where there were multiple bruised *bite marks*. "Catra," she muttered to herself.

She walked from the bathroom to the bedroom and, with her hands on her hips, stared daggers into the sleeping figure curled underneath the duvet. "Catra," she called. When her girlfriend didn't move (although Adora could tell that she was awake – her nostrils were twitching), she said, louder, "*Catra*."

Adora counted exactly five seconds. When Catra still didn't acknowledge her, Adora threw herself on the bed, flumping on top of the sleeping lump and pressing all her body weight into her.

"Oof." Catra's head perked up, and with one eye closed and the other eye blinking blearily at Adora, she slurred, "Wha'? Is someone dying?"

Adora narrowed her eyes as she leaned on her elbows, hovering over her. "*I'm* a threat to your life at the moment."

A smirk caught on Catra's lips. She stretched past the duvet, purposefully rubbing her leg against Adora's. "Fighting talk for a princess."

"Look at my neck!" Adora said, gesturing to the bruises. "I can't go to work with *this*!"

Catra feigned disinterest as she looked upon the marks of her own doing. "You're right. You can't. You'll be the talk of the school."

“Catra!” Adora complained, collapsing on top of her to rest her chin on the brunette’s chest.

“Hmph. So whiny.” Catra’s sharp nails trailed along Adora’s scalp. “Maybe you should stay in bed with me all day instead.”

“We’re friends with the principal. We can’t get away with excuses.”

“So, we tell her straight: sorry, we can’t come in today. I’m marking the other side of Adora’s neck so it matches.” Catra laughed as Adora playfully pinched her arm. “Hey! It’s your fault for being so unbelievably–”

“Don’t –”

“Annoying.” Catra’s eyes sparkled. “Or sexy? Annoying *and* sexy.”

“You’re a brat,” Adora argued, pouting. She sat up, subconsciously hiding her neck with her hair.

Catra winked. “Don’t you know it.” Pushing herself further up the pillow, she grabbed at Adora’s hand to stop her from fussing. “It’s fine. Just wear a turtleneck.”

“It’s embarrassing.” Adora countered. “I haven’t had a hickey since I was a teenager.”

Catra was rubbing at her eyes, only half-listening. “It’s not a hickey, it’s a bite – wait, who was giving you hickeys when we were teenagers?”

Adora felt blood rush to her face. “Uh –”

Catra’s eyes were wide, her eyebrows drawn. “*Adora*.”

The blonde looked at her wrist, where there was no watch. “Look at the time, I really have to –”

She tried to escape, but Catra was quicker. Holding onto her wrist, Catra pulled her back, encasing her with both of her arms. “Who

was it?"

"It was nothing – it was in the army –"

"*Who*?"

"Remi! It was Remi!"

"Roid Remi?! Fuck – I know you have a thing for muscles, Adora, but really? Remi? There wasn't a single thought behind those eyes."

"She was a terrible kisser too. Just kept pushing her tongue down my throat like –"

"Alright, you can stop now."

"All I could think was: what is she trying to do? Lick my tonsils? It was just in there, like an unmovable object –"

"I don't want to hear this –"

"And the hickey bled for *days*, I have no idea what she did to" – Catra put a finger against Adora's lips, leaving the blonde to squawk an affronted – "*you* were the one who asked."

"And I learnt my lesson; I'll never ask again." Catra left a small kiss on the base of her neck. "Now, come on. We're going to be late for work."

"I'm going to regret your offer of staying in bed all day, aren't I?"

"You have no idea how much."

The first day back after the winter holidays was always the hardest. Not only was this stretch of the school term the most challenging, but there was a depressive atmosphere in the air after the excitement of New Year and Christmas.

Adora hadn't given lesson plans much thought, so she spent the morning discussing the spring exams with her students and asking them to think of ideas for final pieces. The theme for this year was '*natural beauty*'. While most of her class thought to target the 'natural' part of the theme by suggesting landscapes and still life, one of her student's, Poppy, was planning on adapting the theme to suit her interest of gothic horror. At the moment, she was sketching a skeleton sprouting flowers and dripping in blood.

Adora thought Catra and Poppy would probably get along.

Speaking of her girlfriend, Adora received message from Catra just before break time.

Catra

Come over to my class at break, I'll make us coffee

Adora

Got any snacks?

Catra

I'm offended you had to ask

I'm a giant snack

Adora

Well I can't wait to get a spoonful

Mouthful?

Did that work for you?

Catra

no

Adora was still smiling as she wrapped up her class early. She made it to Catra's classroom for the bell. As Catra's students filed out and into the hallway, Adora leaned against the door frame, doing her best to look disinterested to avoid the teenagers' attention.

Catra was last out. With her arms crossed over her chest, she smirked across the hall at the blonde. "Miss Greyskull," she purred.

"Miss Areli." Adora's cheeks burned as she peeked into the room to see a student taking their time to leave. "Is now still a good time?"

"Hi, Miss Greyskull," piped up Kevin as he walked towards them.

"Scoot," Catra said, shooing him away. "I have to teach Miss Greyskull how to read, and it's going to take much longer than a fifteen-minute break."

Adora's eyes bulged. "You – sorry, what?"

Catra shrugged, but her eyes danced with humour. "It's a good cover story." When they both looked to Kevin, Catra snapped, "Why are you still here?"

The boy bolted as if Catra was chasing after him. Catra smirked at Adora, placing a hand on her hip and nodding to the empty classroom. Adora, rolling her eyes, followed, closing the door behind them.

The Literature classroom was neat - much neater than the Art department. Various posters on the wall celebrated local and world-renown authors, and tiny little blackboards highlighted the difference between a verb, noun and adjective. Adora took particular interest in those ones; admittedly, she still didn't know the different between a verb and an adverb.

Her attention slowly drifted back around to her girlfriend, who was busying herself with a very posh coffee machine behind her desk. Catra had her back to Adora, and the blonde used the opportunity to wrap her arms around Catra from behind. As the brunette cleaned the filter on the coffee machine, leaning back into her warmth, Adora placed a precise kiss on the bottom of Catra's neck. The woman in her arms shivered.

"Don't start something you won't be able to finish," Catra warned, turning around to leer at her.

"We have – what, fifteen minutes?" Adora wiggled her eyebrows. "Plenty of time for *you* to finish."

"Closer to ten," Catra pointed out. "Ten minutes into *any* activity, and you're still trying to figure out what's going on."

"It's a wonder why you like me."

Catra squeezed Adora's upper arm. "I'm shallow." She reached up, her lips hovering over Adora's, only to glance behind the blonde's shoulder and give a high-pitched squeak.

Adora turned around, expecting to see Glimmer – but no. They were spared.

"Uh, hi." Adora sheepishly cleared her throat. "Can we help you, Entrapta?"

It was a mystery how Entrapta got into the room, because neither Adora nor Catra heard the door creak open. As two people who were trained to be hyper-vigilant of their surroundings, she was *sure* they would've heard it. For good measure, Adora eyed the ceiling, half-expecting one of the ceiling tiles to be loose with a rope dangling from it.

"Hi!" Entrapta bounded towards them, bouncing on her tiptoes, full of energy as usual. "Adora, I have it all set up for you. I thought we could start today – you have a free period just before lunch, which would give us *plenty* of time to –"

“Wait, sorry, what’s going on?” Adora asked, frowning. It felt as if she’d walked into a conversation halfway through it. “Is this about the… you know. The *thing*.”

“I’m talking about running tests on the military tech inside your body,” Entrapta said plainly. “I set up my personal laboratory and manipulated my digital timetable so I could spend the rest of the day focusing on it.”

Adora glanced at Catra and back to the tech teacher again. She wanted to do this now? In school?!

“What if someone sees?”

“They won’t. No one visits me.”

Beside her, Catra shuffled uncomfortably. “Well, now that makes me feel sad.”

“It’s probably because of my giant ‘do not disturb’ sign that physically shocks people if they try the door handle.” Entrapta shot them a brilliant smile. “No, we won’t be interrupted.”

“But wait – I’m not free during that period. I have full classes up to lunch,” Catra said. There was a beat, and then she added, “Because, you know, I teach a proper subject.”

“You teach a *core* subject, whereas Adora and I teach specialised subjects,” Entrapta pointed out. She shook her head slightly and took a few steps closer to them. “I can move it, if you want to be there Catra, but our next available overlap wouldn’t be until the end of the week. It could delay us significantly.”

Adora nibbled on her bottom lip. Preferably, she would want Catra there. Everything was easier with her company. “How long will it take, Entrapta?”

“No longer than an hour! Catra can join us during lunch if we’re not finished in time.”

Catra stroked her thumb over Adora's palm. "You okay doing this by yourself?"

Adora took a deep breath. "Yeah. Yeah, I'll be fine."

"Great!" Entrapta ran up to both of them, taking each of them by their arms and pulling them into a half-hug. "This is *exciting!*"

Adora was used to visiting the computer labs because Bow would regularly hang out there in his free periods, working on some new tech update with Entrapta. However, she had never been inside Entrapta's personal office.

Bright Moon wasn't a typical school; it was privately funded, and Glimmer was known for being eccentric in her spending. Entrapta was allowed – and sometimes took, without asking – her own freedom and personal limitations. She wasn't exaggerating, either, when she said her door was securely locked with a shocking handle. Adora found that out the hard way.

Entrapta greeted her with an enthusiastic wave. When Adora stepped into the lab, she immediately regretted not waiting for Catra to be free.

The room was dark; the main light source was the broad wall full of computer monitors, but that wasn't what made Adora's skin crawl. There was a seat akin to a dentist chair in the middle of the room, and surrounding it were different mechanical instruments – some of which looked like they could be torture devices. It didn't remind her of the army, no - it was a stark reminder that there was something in her - something that needed to be taken out. Something that didn't belong.

Anyone would feel unsettled by that.

Adora took a big gulp of air. "Is all this for… me, Entrapta?"

"Oh, no!" Entrapta said, dragging her along. She pointed at a giant handsaw. "Some of this is leftover from Hordak's robotic

limb experiments this morning. Say hi, by the way!”

Would Adora have noticed him lurking in the shadows unless Entrapta pointed him out?

Probably not.

He almost looked like a statue standing between the computer monitors, with his fake eye glowing red. The other distinctly human eye was blue, matching the colour of his dyed hair. His skin was pale with scars running down all visible skin; specifically, his neck down and his left forearm. His right forearm was – as Entrapta had already said – a robotic limb. As he walked towards them with his head slightly bowed, Adora recognised his limp; it was clear he had one, or two, prosthetic legs as well.

This was a man familiar with war.

Adora had heard plenty about Hordak, but she hadn’t actually met him before. He wasn’t the big, bad traitor Glimmer described, but he wasn’t the cute, fluffy pet Entrapta made him out to be, either. Maybe it was because of her own experiences, but Adora felt like she was looking back at a partial reflection of herself; someone permanently scarred from warfare who was still trying to recover from the scars, only some of which were visible.

“I’m glad to make your acquaintance,” he said, extending his robotic hand.

Adora took it, dumbstruck for a moment –

And then reality caught up with her. She rounded on Entrapta. “Wait a minute – not to be rude, or anything, but is he supposed to be here?”

“Hordak spends a lot of time in my lab,” Entrapta said casually. “He’s my lab partner.”

“But on school property? Does Glimmer know?”

By how Entrapta and Hordak froze, she already knew the answer.

Adora screwed her eyes shut. Not only was this Hordak, who Glimmer already disliked, but it was a breach of health and safety - not to mention *security* - for a stranger to be admitted onto school property without the proper background checks and permission. “Alright. Okay," she muttered. "We can worry about that some other time.”

“Great!” Entrapta practically flung Adora into the dentist chair. “We have a lot to do, and if we want to be finished by lunch time, then we have to get started!”

Adora’s eyes bulged as Entrapta strapped her into the chair by a buckle around her waist. The computer science teacher was so quick in setting up her equipment that Adora struggled to keep up. After electrodes were stuck to her pressure points, she was then connected to a range of computer systems manned by Hordak. Adora eyed him warily and tried to settle in the hard seat. *This will be worth it*, she assured herself. *It'll be over in no time*. She breathed in through her nose and out through her mouth and fought back the bile threatening to slip up her throat.

Entrapta tapped on her tablet, and Adora could see different statistics and figures on the reflection of her blackout goggles. Minutes passed in silence with only the tapping and beeping of mechanical instruments disrupting the still air between the three people in the laboratory.

Adora was doing her best to remain patient, but her anxiety was winding her tight. As her leg started to jig with impatience, she let out a light sigh, and asked innocently, “What’s happening, Entrapta? Anything?”

When the purple-haired teacher took her time answering, Adora wondered if she hadn’t heard her at all. Then, she saw Entrapta lift her goggles and look at Hordak. Expressionless, Hordak turned from his station and gave a low grunt.

Entrapta seemed to understand. She smiled at Adora. "The good news is we know exactly where the chip is located in your body."

Adora paused. "Okay. And?"

"It's too early to say whether or not we can remove it yet," Entrapta supplied. "We only know where it is because of the *very* strong signals it's still emitting, despite it clearly being dormant."

Adora flopped her head against the neck brace. That didn't sound good. She had a feeling that didn't mean something *good*.

Hordak came to her side. He held some sort of scanner over her chest. It flashed red as it worked. As he held it over her, his eyebrows furrowed, and his lips pulled back. Very carefully, he said, "The failsafe wasn't meant to be used in a human host. I'm sorry."

Adora blinked at him. "It's –" she stopped herself and wet her lips with her tongue. The tips of her fingers felt very cold. "Wait, I never mentioned She-Ra or the failsafe. I didn't say anything to Entrapta other than calling it a military chip."

Hordak's face remained impassive as ever. He slowly lowered the scanner to meet her eyes. "It's no matter. I've encountered the failsafe before. I know what it looks like."

He gestured to the x-ray prints Entrapta had uploaded onto the largest computer monitor. Adora sat up as much as the chair buckle would allow her.

There it was, for all to see – a small chip, probably no bigger than two inches, situated in the middle of her chest wall, shadowing the grey outline of her heart below her ribs like a moon eclipsing the sun. It was narrow and thick and, ultimately, unimpressive.

How could something so small be so powerful?

Adora felt the familiar grasp of panic clench her throat. She sat back again and let her eyes flicker closed in an attempt to escape

reality for a moment. It was difficult to look at it – seeing the failsafe on the screen made it real. It made it *all* too real. It was all-too tempting to dig her fingers into her chest and pry it out herself, consequences be damned. She was tired of feeling uncomfortable in her own skin.

Perhaps Hordak sensed her discomfort. Perhaps, he was just trying to bridge the awkward silence. For whatever reason, he said, almost conversationally, "You're doing the right thing."

"Am I?" she muttered drily.

"We all need closure – even war machines like you and I."

He put down the scanner and lifted another tool. Adora watched him carefully, like she was examining a particularly difficult puzzle. She wasn't as good as Catra was at seeing through people. Despite what she knew about Hordak – a traitor to his people, a war criminal, a spy fallen from grace – right now, he looked like a broken man trying to find answers.

"Do you regret it?" Adora asked after a moment. "Your role in the war, I mean."

"No. I did what I had to do."

"Yeah, I thought I did the right thing, too."

"No." His voice was hard. His eyes were stony; unblinking. "You are mistaken. I didn't do anything because I believe in *right* or *wrong*. I believe in science; I believe in technology. I did what I had to do to survive the war. To gain personal freedom."

Adora watched as he held a small beeping instrument over her chest. She frowned and her eyebrows pulled together. "But, you saved people – didn't you? I thought your intelligence helped the Etherians win the war."

"It did. *I* did not. I saved no one but myself." He paused and took a step back from her. A shadow of something crossed his face

when he saw her frown. “I can see this confuses you and I understand why. *You* were glorified as a hero, Adora Greyskull, when you were just the person the military chose to sacrifice for their own war gains. Me? I was the opposite. I was the person they villainised so they could excuse their unethical behaviour.”

Adora shuffled uncomfortably. “I still don’t understand,” she admitted.

She didn’t understand anything that he just said. Why would someone only help themselves if they had the opportunity to help others? How was he made a villain by the army? How could someone not believe in right or wrong?

For Adora, who was strictly governed by her own morals, and her own sense of right, it confused her as to how someone could live life *without* morals. Adora wanted to be good; she wanted to help people. She wanted the world to be a better place; fairer, happier.

How could someone see the state of the world and not want that?

“Adora!” Entrapta interrupted suddenly as she rolled across the room on her chair. “I have news.”

Flinching at the sudden loudness, Adora braced herself with a wince. “If it’s bad, can we wait for Catra to get here?”

“It’s not *terrible* – just slightly worrisome.”

“Okay. Fine.” She sighed and tried to sit up more. “Hit me.”

Entrapta tilted her head to the side. “Why would I hit you?”

Adora shook her head. “Tell me the results, Entrapta.”

“Oh!” Entrapta beamed. She held up her largest tablet and indicated different infographics as she spoke. “The good news is that the chip *hasn’t* fused with your nervous system, which means it can be safely removed.” She paused. “The bad news is that the radiation it’s emitting and the location of it in your body means

that if it's used again it will fuse with your nervous system, and if it's kept in long-term, it'll have negative effects on your health. Honestly, I'm surprised it hasn't burnt a hole right through your –"

Adora waved her hand in the air. She felt queasy just thinking about it. "Okay, thanks, Entrapta. I get the picture loud and clear."

"Don't you see what this means?" Entrapta gushed. "Once we run through this data, we'll be able to surgically remove the chip and examine experimental technology that no one has ever witnessed before! The data! The information! The –"

As she rambled, the door to Entrapta's laboratory swung open with a deafening creak, interrupting them. Adora peeked over Hordak's shoulder to see Catra skirting into the room, her eyes flicking wildly about. Adora let out a little huff of breath, *so* glad to see Catra again. She could relax a little knowing that Catra - the smarter one, the more cynical one - was here to see her through this.

When her gaze landed on Adora, a muscle in Catra's cheek twitched and she glanced to Entrapta. "What did I miss? I managed to get out early."

"Catra!" Entrapta said, loud and enthusiastic. "Hi! Meet Hordak!"

Blinking a few times at the hulking figure of Hordak, Catra frowned. "Wasn't he –?"

"Don't worry about it, apparently," Adora interjected. "It's a problem for future Entrapta."

Catra gave a low hum. With careful steps, she walked towards Adora's chair, warily eyeing the technology surrounding them. She crossed her arms as she reached Adora's side. "Well? What's the verdict?"

Entrapta pointed towards the x-ray on the large monitor, saying, almost whimsically, "The chip will slowly poison Adora from the inside."

Adora jumped with such force that the chair buckle snapped open. "Hey! You didn't mention that part before!"

On her other side, Catra's jaw clenched as her eyebrows rose to her hairline. "Right. So, that settles it. I'll claw it out myself if I have to."

"*Catra*," Adora warned.

"Don't *Catra* me. I'm not joking," she snapped. Then, to Entrapta, she asked, "We can get it out, right?"

"We can; it's located in the chest wall. It should be a simple surgery, but delicate. We don't want to disturb the chip."

Catra nodded. "Yeah, we don't want to damage the military tech. Otherwise, they'll just sue us, and we'll be no better off."

Shrugging, Entrapta half-turned back to her work desk. "Well, I didn't want to damage the chip because of how valuable the information stored on it will be – but your concern is perfectly acceptable too."

Catra tensed, but Adora put a hand on her forearm and stroked her thumb over her wrist. Catra's eyes met hers, and she could see the fear there. Adora understood it; she felt it too. *It'll be okay,* she tried to silently communicate. *We'll be okay.*

"Thanks, Entrapta," Adora said, still holding onto Catra. "I really appreciate it. And you Hordak."

Hordak turned his back on them as he put away the tools. "You don't want to thank me."

Catra helped Adora down from the dentist chair while Adora eyed Hordak curiously. In the background, Entrapta spoke while typing at a crazy speed on her laptop. "I'm going to run some tests on the data we sourced today. You should hear from me by next week on the results on how best to proceed."

Catra linked her hand with Adora's and tried to tug her away – but Adora hung back. Something wasn't making sense to her; she sensed something from Hodark, something confusing.

How did he know about the failsafe?

How had he encountered it before?

"Hey – Hordak?" Adora said, a slight edge to her voice. "Why did you apologise earlier? When you found out about the failsafe, I mean."

Hordak didn't speak while his robotic arm tapped against the metal table. Still with his back turned, he locked the box containing the scanner and other tools he had used, and said very slowly, "I apologised because I am partly responsible for technology they inserted in your chest. It was my information on the Horde that gave the military the insight into the She-Ra project. The failsafe itself was drawn from my own blueprints."

It took a few moments for the truth of the information to properly sink in.

When it did, Adora found her mouth was painfully dry. She shook her head as if to clear it, and said in a single breath, "You… designed the failsafe?"

Hordak bowed his head. "I needed leverage. The Etherian army had reason to believe that I had been leaking information to the Horde – that I was a double agent for the other side. They threatened to send me back, which would have been a death sentence. I had been keeping the failsafe blueprints up my sleeve for quite some time, knowing that they would eventually want too much from me. When they asked, I complied. I gave them the blueprints. Those blueprints saved my life and made me a free man." He turned to face them, his face completely neutral and void from emotion. "I don't regret what I did. I don't think many would regret that the failsafe worked, and that it ultimately ended the war."

Adora’s heart bruised her ribs with how fast it was beating. Her vision began to blur, and she had no idea why or how. For a few cruel seconds, she thought it was the beginning of a panic attack. *This was the man who was responsible for the failsafe.*

He traded in your freedom for his own, a voice echoed in her mind. It was callous; it was hurtful.

It made Adora's world start to spin.

And then Catra’s long nails bit into the soft flesh of Adora’s hand. Her voice wobbled with barely contained anger. “But – what it’s done to Adora – what they *did* to Adora –”

“To them, it was a small price to pay for winning a war,” he said simply.

Another missed heartbeat, followed by another straight after. Adora took a deep breath and did her best to remain level-headed.

Unwanted, she said to herself: *he's right. It was one for the many.*

“That doesn’t make it right.” Catra took a step towards Hordak, voice rising an octave. “And how is it fair that *you* walk free? Why didn’t they give *you* an ultimatum?”

“Sharing knowledge – intelligence work – goes both ways. They know they might need me in the future, but for now, they have tarnished my name. Ostracised me from society.” He turned away. “I do not blame them.”

Catra made to move after him again, but Adora gently pulled her back. “Catra. Catra, come on. Let’s go.” She started towards the door, desperate to escape the darkness of the computer lab. Desperate to disappear into a quiet corner and forget this ever happened. “Talk soon, Entrapta," she murmured as they were halfway out the door.

She didn’t wait for an acknowledgement.

The light from the school corridor hurt Adora’s eyes. She kept walking, dragging Catra behind her. Students passed them, and if they noticed them holding hands or not, she couldn’t tell. Her mind was full, buzzing, and a headache was brewing behind her eyes. Her stomach twisted with regret; honestly, she would have rather not known. After all, Hordak wasn't her enemy. Hordak didn't choose her to host the failsafe for She-Ra.

“Bastard,” Catra spat, coming to a halt.

She was, quite literally, shaking with anger. Adora’s mind cleared when she saw her in distress, and her own attention turned to calming down the situation. She put her hands on either of Catra’s shoulders. “It’s okay,” she lied.

“How can you be okay with *him*?” Catra immediately fired back. “If it wasn’t for him and his *information* –”

“He’s right, though, isn’t he?” The words were out of Adora’s mouth before she could stop them. When Catra raised her eyebrows, Adora took a step back and let her arms drop to her sides. “One life is a small price to pay for winning the war. Saving everyone.”

“Don’t do that,” Catra hissed. “Don’t let him get in your head. I thought we’d gone over this. You’re worth more than this entire country – you’re better than the lot of them.”

“You don’t mean that,” Adora retorted. “Sorry, I don’t *want* you to mean that.”

Catra’s chin jutted out. She crossed her arms, and her eyes sparked with a challenge. “What would you do if the roles were reversed?” she asked.

Adora frowned. “Huh?”

"If it was me they were trying to sacrifice for the *greater good*. What would you do?"

"Absolutely not," Adora answered, no hesitation. She scoffed. "I'd never let them do it."

Catra didn't look surprised by that answer, but she pushed on. "So, what would you do?"

She had no idea where Catra was going with this, but Adora played along. Scratching the back of her neck, she mused, "I don't know – offer to take your place?"

"A-ha!" Catra's smirk was mirthless. She took a step closer to her girlfriend and pointed her finger at the centre of her chest. "And that's where we're different, Adora Greyskull. You'd sacrifice yourself to save me. What good is that? Then I'd be miserable, and you wouldn't have saved me at all." There was a heat in her expression, and venom in her eyes. It made Adora feel a bit hot under her turtleneck. Catra went on, "Me? I'd sacrifice the *world* to save you."

It took a few minutes for Adora to process that. She couldn't tear her eyes off the brunette, waiting for a punchline or something to indicate that it was a joke. When it didn't come, and Catra looked as serious as ever, Adora rolled her eyes. "You're being stupid."

As Adora continued down the corridor, Catra caught up, and she was still going. "Fuck them all, I say. As long as we have each other, what's the issue? It's always been us against the world, anyway."

Adora clicked her tongue to make a disapproving noise. "You're neglecting the fact I'd be royally pissed off at you."

She could hear the smirk in Catra's tone. "No change there."

They were outside the staffroom now. Adora stopped in front of the door and studied Catra's face again. "I genuinely can't tell if you're joking or not," she admitted.

"Good." Catra looped a finger through Adora's belt loop. "You won't like the answer."

Adora couldn't help but match her smile. If Catra was trying to distract her from the awful truth they'd just learnt, then it was certainly working. With a cautious look to the staff room door, the blonde teased, her voice lilting, "Is this your long-winded way of telling me that you *like* me?"

It was Catra's turn to scoff. "*Like* you? Gross. No, I love you. But I don't like you – that's too far."

Adora hummed. "I'm swept off my feet."

They couldn't help it – their lips were like magnets. Before Adora realised what was happening, she was leaning into Catra's warmth and Catra's lips were slowly parting –

"We are in a *school* setting!" came a shrill shout from behind. "And we are *teachers*!"

Catra uncoiled herself from Adora. "I'm going to change your job title to cockblocker instead of headmistress, headmistress."

Glimmer *seethed*. Her nostrils flared so wide that it looked like smoke might escape from her flaming temper. "You're so lucky I like your girlfriend, Miss Areli, or you and I *might* have a problem."

Catra's tongue peeked from behind her teeth. "Well, don't promise me a good time." But her voice had lost its playful tone, and Catra's face was stony – in other words, Adora surmised, she was turning grumpy. "Anyway, Sparkles, we have some news. About the, you know. The *thing*."

She tapped on Adora's chest for good measure.

"You're not the only one with news," Glimmer whispered, glancing between them. "My mum was trying to contact you, but you didn't answer." She paused, ensuring no one was around to overhear

them. “The petition is on course to meet the deadline, which means we have provisional court dates.”

Adora nodded. “Okay, and?”

“They’re *after* the dates of your pre-enlisting health check,” said Glimmer.

“What does that mean?” asked Catra, turning to Adora.

“It gives them an advantage,” Adora said, unable to hide her disappointment. “When I don’t show up to the health screening, they’ll know something is wrong.”

“They should’ve received the petition by then,” Glimmer added hopefully. “We just don’t want them actioning anything in the space in between.”

Catra accepted this with a slow nod. “Well, it mightn’t come to that, right? You’ll have legal protection.”

To disguise the sickening nerves curling in her stomach, Adora gave a non-committed hum. She was supposed to enlist at the end of January, and the petition was due to be submitted in the third week of the month. It was cutting it tight as it was, and Angella had warned her against having any contact with the military between now and the petition.

But the worry was there – that if she didn’t attend the pre-enlisting health check, then they were within the limits of the contract to take *action* of their own. What would this action be? She didn’t know, but she didn’t want to find out.

Between this news and the confrontation with Hordak, Adora felt in the need for a lie down. She followed Catra and Glimmer into the staff room, feeling little appetite to eat the leftover pasta she had in the fridge. *I didn't do anything because I believe in right or wrong.* Hordak's words repeated in her mind until they were seared into her brain. She looked around at her friends; Mermista making the blackest coffee in the kitchen, Perfuma meditating at

the table, and Bow making everyone tea with the brightest smile on his face, and she felt, once again, detached. As if she were a shadow passing through, or an outsider always looking inside.

The only thing keeping her rooted and present was the warmth of Catra's hand in her hand. And as she held onto that warmth, and that feeling of *oneness*, of what was *right*, Adora sat down with her friends and pretended that everything was okay.

Chapter End Notes

> Sooorry for the delay. A lot of things have built up in my life, and despite trying to ignore them (some for many years) and hoping they will eventually go away, they haven't. It's not only zapped my inspiration, but it means I can barely concentrate long enough to read a full sentence properly. It's definitely impacted the chapter, but it will have to do.
>
> Thanks for all your messages, and I apologise in advance for the next chapter, which will undoubtedly take a little longer to write too. We're close to the end anyhow - not much more to go!
>
> Thoughts welcome and appreciated.
>
> Stay safe,
>
> Cx.

Arrest

Chapter Summary

> Content warning: this chapter contains mentions of PTSD and the police. For full warnings, please see end notes.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Adora watched the next few weeks pass by with an overwhelming sense of dread.

Her students and form group could tell something was going on; where her lessons had once been meticulously planned and prepared, she now taught the bare bones of a subject and left them to their own devices. She no longer participated in after-school MMA, and she didn't demonstrate painting techniques in her clubs. Her mind – if not focussed on Catra or being distracted by her girlfriend – was stuck in the drain hole of legal battles and her military past.

Angella had spent every other evening visiting Adora to discuss different aspects of the legal challenge. She was preparing her on what to say, how to act – what *not* to say, how *not* to act. Due to the petition against the Etherian government involving multiple aspects (first the contract, then the ethical, moral concerns), Angella advised that Adora not be too forthright with her answers when being cross-examined, should the military use her words against her if the first clause of the petition is overruled. It was complex, and it was draining and – most of all – an insider had informed Angella that the media had already sniffed out a hint of the drama and were waiting eagerly for an official petition.

Lately, Adora's only sanity *was* Catra. The moments they had in between their jobs and the court case felt pure and untouched – like they were stolen morsels of time they had to savour. Catra, at some point during the second week of January, had slept over one

night and never left. Although neither of them had agreed to move in together, Catra had taken over a few drawers in Adora's dresser and half of her wardrobe. In the back of her mind, Adora wanted to officially ask Catra to move in with her. She daydreamed of doing it in an over-the-top manner (she *loved* seeing Catra happy and flustered), but it seemed like the universe kept conspiring against them.

The third week of January was so intense that Adora nearly forgot her own birthday. The eighteenth was the deadline for the petition to be submitted, and the twentieth was the date of her pre-enlisting health screening. The petition would be processed on her birthday, meaning the court dates would be issued on the twentieth – just in time to avoid the health screening.

Everything was going to plan.

On the evening the petition was due to be submitted, Adora sat in her living room with Catra, Bow and Glimmer, while they all stared at Adora's phone in the middle of the coffee table. They were counting down the hours to midnight – Angella would call when the petition was submitted, and then they could all breathe a sigh of relief.

Glimmer was passing around a bottle of whiskey (only a quarter full) to pass in the time. No one was feeling particularly chatty, but Adora was fidgeting and finding it impossible to stay on the sofa. It was only when Catra rested her head on Adora's lap that she started to calm down. Her fingers threaded through Catra's hair, and as she took a swig of the whiskey and passed it to Bow, Glimmer asked very loudly;

"Well, what are we doing for your birthday?"

Adora blinked at her a few times, face blank. "Who's birthday?"

"*Your* birthday."

Bow pulled as face as he took a sip of whiskey, as he always did, and asked, "You didn't forget your own birthday, did you?"

Adora's legs shuffled under Catra. "I've been distracted."

"Well, what do you want to do?" Glimmer pushed, silently accepting the bottle from Bow.

"I don't know." Adora rubbed her temples. It felt inappropriate to celebrate *anything* with the court battle looming. "Nothing?"

"What did you do last year?" Catra asked, sitting up slightly.

"Just dinner at Glimmer's house with a few of our friends." Adora rolled her eyes, an amused smirk on her lips. "My birthday is too soon after Christmas, apparently. No one has any *giving* energy left."

Glimmer looked her dead in the eye as she knocked back the whiskey. With the bottle in her hand, she waved it around and proclaimed, "It's very selfish of you to have your birthday so soon after Christmas. I've said it before, and I'll say it again. You're the hardest person to buy for."

Adora gasped dramatically. "I never want anything!"

"Exactly." Glimmer passed the bottle to Catra while glaring at Adora. "You're difficult."

Adora leaned against the pillows. "At least I'm not spoiled," she muttered under her breath.

"What was that?"

"Nothing."

"I assumed Adora was just going to spend her birthday with Catra," Bow said, shrugging at his girlfriend.

"So did I," Catra replied, pointedly looking at the other couple.

Adora's eyebrows quirked up, and she glanced down at Catra in her lap. "Did you remember?" she asked, unable to hide the

surprise in her voice.

Catra scoffed. “Of course I remembered, dumbass.”

The girlfriends shared a *look* – Adora’s expression was warm, her eyes rounded, and her lips tugged into a smile. Catra grinned mischievously, and after she took a swig of whiskey, she looked as if she was about to say something interesting –

Glimmer groaned loudly, interrupting them. “Can’t we have her once in a little while?” she complained.

“I don’t like sharing,” Catra retorted. “I have abandonment issues.”

Ignoring that completely, Adora hadn’t taken her eyes off her girlfriend. She accepted the whiskey bottle but put it down on the coffee table so she could stroke Catra’s hair. “Did you have something planned?”

Catra’s smile was downright devilish. “Maybe.”

“What was it?” Adora pressed.

“Dinner. We’d skip the movie.” Catra’s voice dropped an octave. “Remember that thing you wanted to try?”

“We’re still here!” Glimmer shrieked, pretending to cover her ears so she couldn’t hear anything.

Catra sat up straight and opened her mouth, a retort ready on her lips –

When Adora’s phone started ringing.

All four friends flinched, as if they hadn’t been waiting all night for the phone to ring. Glimmer clutched Bow’s arm and Catra unwound herself from Adora so she could answer the call.

Adora's eyes were wide as she stared at her phone flashing on the table. She took a deep breath and pushed down the bile rising in her throat.

She picked up the phone and heard herself say, "Hi Angella."

"Adora." Angella sounded tired but relieved. "Sorry for keeping you up late – on a school night, nevertheless."

"It's okay, it's fine – well?" She hesitated, "Did you…?"

"We did. The petition is submitted."

Adora's heart skipped a few beats. Her whole body sagged, and when she gave the group a thumbs up, there was a collective sigh of relief.

The moment passed quickly, and Adora forced herself to continue. "So, what happens now?"

"We'll get the official court dates within a few days, but they should be the same as the provisional dates unless there's a complication with the petition." Angella's voice held a twinge of concern. "In the meantime, you *cannot* respond to any contact from the military, okay? You don't go to the health check, and if they try to contact you, you refuse their advances."

Adora nodded, as if Angella could see it. "I got it – I can't speak without a lawyer." She bit her lip. "But, Angella, what if they respond with their own counter-argument? What do I do then?"

"They probably will, which is why it's important you refuse contact with them between now and the court date." She paused, and the sound of ruffling pages could be heard in the background. "Don't worry, Adora. We've covered every avenue. Whatever they think they have up their sleeve, we have a case for it. Try to relax and take time off work if you need to. We all understand."

Adora sighed. With all the energy she had left, she said, "Thanks, Angella. For everything. Really."

Once the call was ended, Adora dropped her phone on the sofa and reached for Catra's hand. Then, to the others, she muttered, "It's submitted. It's done."

Perhaps it was just the impact of those words, or the certainty of what was going to happen next, but Adora felt the nervous energy in the room substantially rise. Beside her, Catra was perfectly still, which was usually a sign that she was internally anxious. She swept her thumb over her girlfriend's palm, hoping it would give her some comfort.

"No turning back now," Bow said, a look of grim determination on his face.

"I just hope I did the right thing," Adora admitted.

"You did," Catra assured. "Besides, Entrapta is probably going to get the chip out of you, with or without the legal case."

Bow looked to his girlfriend. "Which Angella still doesn't know about."

Adora hummed thoughtfully. "I still think that's a bad idea, Glimmer."

Glimmer shook her head. "We'll tell her, just not yet. One thing at a time. I don't want her to feel overwhelmed."

And the implication hung in the air – the implication that despite all this work and effort, Angella was still sick. Adora did her best to not let guilt weigh her down, and instead be thankful she had such great friends and a support network. Now that the petition was submitted, however, and she knew the battle to come – it was hard not to feel regret, for what was about to happen and what could've happened if she hadn't accepted anyone's help.

And with that thought, Adora took one last swig of whiskey and reassured herself this was the right thing to do.

The world seemed a little brighter when Adora woke up on her birthday. Catra was curled around her waist and delicate winter sunshine peeped through the bedroom curtains. She took a moment to assess her mood and her mind; beneath the fear of what was to come, she was happy.

Catra was here. She had friends and a good job.

If the military and the failsafe were out of the equation, she would be… settled.

Complete?

And, yes, Catra had only been *hers* for the last two months. But Adora had wanted this her whole life – and if Catra was to be believed, so had she. There was no doubt in Adora's mind that Catra was her soulmate. Were soulmates a thing? She didn't know – but if they were, that role belonged to Catra.

Marriage was something that Adora had never thought of before – not for herself, at least. She knew Bow and Glimmer were actively discussing it (and by that, she meant arguing; Glimmer was still waiting for a ring or a token, and Bow was still a fumbling, bumbling mess who didn't know how to propose), but Adora never thought it was for herself. Marriage was never the end goal for her; it didn't make a relationship *better* or more *official*.

She didn't even know what Catra thought about marriage. And, of course, it would be something that they could think about further down the line, along with other options of commitment.

Where was she going with this?

Ah, yes – Adora didn't know about marriage, but she was certain that if the universe allowed her to have a life beyond the military, then she would like to commit herself, wholly and truly, to Catra.

During lunch time, Glimmer had dragged Adora out of her classroom and into the staffroom to throw her a surprise party.

There was cake and balloons and chitchat. Despite hating the fuss and attention, Adora played along. After their forty-minute party was up, Perfuma packed up half the cake and sweet treats and helped Adora carry it to her car.

It was while they were alone together and Perfuma was happily chatting about her new succulent collection that Adora decided to bite the bullet and bring up a conversation she had been putting off for quite a while.

"– and Scorpia, she's great with the plants, you know? She's so gentle and loving – she even sings them to sleep when it's stormy outside. There's nothing better than a hot cup of chamomile tea and –" Perfuma paused and gave Adora a soft smile. "You want to ask me something, don't you?"

"Is my face really that obvious?" Adora joked.

Perfuma declined to answer. Instead, she folded her hands. "Go ahead. I'm listening."

Adora felt her temperature rise. She closed her car boot and leaned against it with her keys in her hand. "Right. Uh – so, Perfuma, I was kinda thinking… Well, I was wondering if you could, you know. Help me. If you could be my therapist again." When she saw Perfuma's eyes widen, Adora started to gush, "It's just that I don't feel in the right headspace to find someone new and get to know them – and my other therapist moved across town – and I'm already avoiding the topic, so I know I need someone to keep me in line – and you were so good last time –"

"Adora." Perfuma gently took her hand. Her touch was featherlight, but it still managed to make Adora feel warm inside. "You're not burdening me by asking me for help. It's my job, and you're my friend. It would make me happy to help you."

It was nice to hear those words – specifically, *you are not a burden*, because that was what she had been doing for the last month – burdening everyone around her. Instead of shying away

from them, she tried to accept them. Scratching the back of her neck, she looked back at Perfuma. "Are you sure? I know it's a lot – *I'm* a lot –"

"No." Perfuma chided her by pressing a finger against her lips. Adora stood there, her mouth slightly open. "You're enough, okay? We can start off slow again and take our time learning how to approach it together. How does that sound?"

Her gut reaction was to apologise again. Adora forced it down. She took a deep breath in through her nose and out through her mouth. When she was ready, she said, "Thanks, Perfuma. I really appreciate it."

Perfuma beamed at her. "And I really appreciate you coming to me for help."

As they began walking back to the school together, Adora tried to bring them back on track to their original conversation. She felt bad for suddenly interrupting it. "I'm glad that you're happy – with Scorpia and everything, I mean," she offered. "You seem really good together."

"Yes. We are. She's my person, and I can't wait to honour her."

Adora frowned. "Honour her?"

Perfuma looked from Adora to the school and back again. Quietly, she whispered, "I'm going to propose."

Adora babbled like a fish. "You're going to – what?"

"It won't be a traditional wedding – or a traditional marriage." Perfuma started talking faster as her enthusiasm grew. All the while, Adora's eyes grew wider and wider. "We're going to honour each other in a ceremony and promise to commit to each other's growth as individuals and together, as a family. We'll have a ceremony at the beach or the forest park, and swap our favourite flower." Almost as an after-thought, she added, "You'll be invited, of course."

Adora was still stuck on Perfuma's declaration of honouring Scorpia. "I – what – sorry – does she know this?"

"Oh, yes." Perfuma then smiled as if *Adora* was the one who wasn't making sense. "I know it might seem sudden, but we *know* we've found what we want. Why waste any more time?"

"But you've only known each other a few months – aren't you afraid? Of making a mistake?"

"Our love would never be a mistake. Even if it was temporary, it wouldn't be a mistake. If in ten or twenty years we decide to grow apart rather than together, then we've shared a moment in time together – a precious period of our life that we can cherish. We'll fulfil our promise to one another and move on." Perfuma blushed slightly, as she said, "That won't happen, though. Not with Scorpia."

"Wow." Adora blinked a few times. "That's kind of beautiful."

They stopped at the staff entrance and listened to the bell ringing for the next class period. Before they went back inside, Perfuma put her hand on Adora's arm to stop her. "There's nothing more beautiful than devotion and understanding. Like you and Catra, for instance. She's not the most verbal or emotional, but you can see her devotion when she looks at you."

Adora felt her cheeks immediately redden. There was no way – her relationship with Catra was nothing like Scorpia and Perfuma's. They'd known each other years – they were each other's… They were something else entirely.

And as for marriage – or even proposal – as Adora had mused earlier that morning, it wasn't the right time. It may never be the right time. They had each other now, in this moment, and that was what mattered.

"Catra, she's – we're different. It's always been complicated," Adora murmured.

And until she said it, she didn't realise how *sad* that statement made her feel.

Perfuma's eyes twinkled. "But you understand each other, no?"

"We do." Adora's tongue felt heavy in her mouth. "I think we do."

"It's never too soon or too late to tell someone how you really feel." Perfuma stepped away to open the door for her. "I'm glad you have each other, Adora. You're really good together," she said pointedly.

Perfuma's words lingered.

Adora could tell Catra was in a good mood when she drove them home. Catra's smile was as sharp as silver, and she kept sliding her hand up and down Adora's thigh as they waited in traffic. It was distracting, and between handsy Catra and her own heavy thoughts, Adora felt like she was going to *explode*.

"What are you – why are you looking at me like that?" Adora finally burst out when they were five minutes from home.

Catra's nails dug into Adora's knee. "I'm just excited for tonight."

Adora narrowed her eyes. "You're up to something."

"Too right I am." Catra huffed. "We haven't celebrated your birthday in *years*. We have a lot of time to make up for."

The pressure in Adora's chest squeezed her throat painfully tight. She coughed to the side, trying to clear it. Catra, probably thinking Adora was just flustered, grinned and settled her hand on the blonde's upper thigh.

You have to say it. You have to get it out tonight. Discuss it over dinner. Adora's hands fumbled with her car keys as they parked the car. *It's going to kill you if you don't say it.*

Adora had the feeling Catra was purposefully walking behind her as she unlocked the front door and let them into the house. Adora had just stepped into the hallway when she noticed something – a smell. Specifically, a food smell. Tomato and spice and… cheese?

Her eyes landed on Catra's. "What's that?"

Catra blinked innocently. "What's what?" When Adora scowled, she rolled her eyes and pulled on her hand. "Come on, dummy. You're supposed to go into the kitchen."

Adora allowed herself to be led, and as they got closer to the kitchen, the smell intensified.

The table in the centre of the room was laid out with dark red tablecloth and two flute glasses of champagne. In the middle, there were two gift bags – one small and one larger – and bags of takeaway food. Tealight candles not yet lit were sprinkled between the plates and gifts.

Adora heard herself squeak. "Catra!"

Catra stood by the table with her arms crossed. "Yeah, I expect praise. I've never done something like this for anyone." She smirked. "I don't know what you've done to me, but I spent my last free period sprinkling the bed with rose petals and picking up food-to-go from your favourite restaurant."

Before she could protest, Adora held Catra's face in both of her hands and littered kisses across her cheeks, all the while saying, 'you're the best' and 'I love you' and 'thank you'. Catra squirmed out of her grip, but not too far. She rested her hands on Adora's shoulder so that their hips were flush together.

"You can open one present before dinner, but the other one is for after."

Adora quirked an eyebrow. "Why can't I open the other one now?"

Catra narrowed her eyes. “It’s for *after*.” And like the perfect date, she pulled out a chair for Adora to sit and then handed her the small box. “Open it.”

“Someone’s bossy today.”

But Adora could see the gleam of excitement in Catra’s eyes. As her girlfriend started to plate the takeaway food, Adora untied the light blue ribbon around the small box. It felt weighted, like there was something heavy for its size inside. She waited until Catra had sat down facing her before lifting the lid.

The first thing Adora noticed when she opened it was the *sparkle*. A two-inch diamond sword sat on a bed of black velvet. Behind the centre of the sword was a gold circle, like a halo. It was beautiful. She picked it up and inspected it further. The closer Adora looked, she realised the gold circle was actually an outline of a wing. It reminded her of an old badge she used to wear.

“It’s a brooch,” Catra said, almost nervously. “You’re going to be wearing a lot of suits because of the court hearings. While I can’t be there beside you, I thought it might be – I don’t know, nice or something, if you had something from me *with* you.”

Adora didn’t know what to say. After feeling too much all day, she now felt strangely numb.

Catra went on, babbling now. “It’s a modern version of a Tara brooch. The sword represents strength and power, and the wing is for protection. I thought it was – but if you don’t like it, I kept the receipt – maybe it was stupid –”

“Catra, I love it,” Adora interrupted, holding the brooch in her fist. “It’s perfect. It’s…”

And hating herself for it, and feeling embarrassed, Adora realised a moment too late that her eyes had started to water. As she hurriedly, wiped them away, her heard Catra’s knife and fork clatter on the table.

“Oh – wait, don’t cry.” Catra’s voice was a tad too high-pitched. “You’re freaking me out. I don’t know what to do with happy tears.”

Adora shook herself and put down the gift box. “I just – we need to talk.”

She saw Catra’s face drop. The brunette shuffled in her chair and awkwardly cleared her throat. “That doesn’t sound good,” she muttered.

Adora brushed away her concerns with a flick of her hand. “No, it is. I have some things I need to say.” She took a breath to steady herself. “I was talking to Perfuma earlier and it made me realise a few things.”

Catra eyed her cautiously. “Okay.”

Adora didn’t know where to begin – she’d already approached the subject wrong by acting like it was something Catra should worry about. To steady her own nerves as well as Catra’s, she said, loud and clear, “I love you.”

Catra’s lips twitched. “You’ve said that before.”

“I know, but it’s different now. I had a crush on you for forever, and even though it took me a while to realise it, I never thought we’d have this. I never thought it would be so *easy*. Now that we’re here and this is us, I don’t want anything else.” Adora reached across the table to take Catra’s hand. She squeezed it tight. “I love you, and I hope this is my future. I want you to be my future.”

Catra glanced at the table. A slight blush adorned her cheeks. “Well, I –”

Adora interrupted, “I’m not done.” She paused and waited for Catra’s attention to land back on her. When their eyes met, Adora continued. “Perfuma said a good relationship is understanding and devotion. And there’s something I want us both to understand.”

Running her thumb across the back of her girlfriend's hand, Adora asked, with her voice shaking, "Catra, will you live with me?"

There were a few intense seconds of silence.

And then Catra broke it by pulling back to give a loud laugh. "I've been living here for the last few weeks, Adora. I haven't set foot in my apartment for three weeks."

"But I want it to be official." Adora tried to fight back a smile as she watched Catra crack up in front of her. "I want you to know that this is your home."

Catra's tongue poked between her teeth. "You want me to help you pay the mortgage," she teased.

Adora, pretending to be grumpy, pulled her hand away from Catra's and flopped against the back of her chair. "I'm being serious here; this is a big deal for me!"

"I know." Catra sighed. With her eyes still dancing, she got up from her seat and draped herself over Adora's lap. Taking the blonde's cheeks in her hand, she said, "It's a big deal for me too, but you're too cute when you're being all sentimental and upset. Yes, I will move in with you. I'll pick up the rest of my stuff at the weekend, okay?"

Adora's heart fluttered against her ribs. "Okay," she agreed.

Catra kissed her, short and sweet. Rubbing the nape of Adora's neck thoughtfully, she gave a low hum. "While we're riding out this feelings train, I just want to say that I feel the same. I want you to be my future as well." She laughed again, her face lighting up. "Not going to lie, I thought you were going to propose or something."

Adora's cheeks immediately flushed. "No! No. I'm not crazy."

"I didn't realise marrying me would be so offensive."

"No – I don't – that wasn't –"

"I'm teasing you," Catra said, playfully nudging her. "Relax. Now, are we going to eat the food before it gets cold?"

"Yes, sorry." Adora allowed Catra to disentangle herself from her lap. "No more declarations."

Catra smirked. "We'll save them for later when you find out what's in the other bag."

Glancing to the bigger gift, Adora quirked an eyebrow. "What *is* in the other bag?"

Catra winked. "Eat your dinner and find out."

Wrapped in blankets, Catra had a warm, squidgy pillow underneath her. It was morning, and she heard the alarm clock somewhere in the back of her mind. When her squidgy pillow tried to move, she dug her claws into the soft flesh.

"Catra, we have to get ready for work."

Catra pressed her face into Adora's stomach. "Don't wanna." Feeling a hand play with her hair, she gave a contented sigh. Rolling over, and taking the blanket with her, she muttered, "Fine. You have permission to go."

"I'm going to do some yoga. Should I lay you down a mat?"

"No."

"I'll cook you breakfast."

Catra thought about it for a second – but she could feel the lull of sleep drag her eyelids down, and the bed was so *warm*. Even when Adora got out of bed, Catra could steal the heat from her spot for another few minutes. "You'll cook me breakfast anyway,"

she murmured, purposefully stretching under the covers to draw them closer to her skin.

Adora left a small kiss against her hairline and then climbed out of bed. The sound of her girlfriend pattering around the room was comforting, and when she heard her disappear downstairs, she reclaimed the blissful peace of drowsiness.

Another thirty minutes and then she would get ready. They hadn't cleaned up the dishes from Adora's birthday dinner last night, and the thought of doing them before work made her sink further down the bed.

It wasn't clear how long had passed. As Catra lingered somewhere between sleep and consciousness, she heard the faint sound of someone knocking on their front door.

She lifted her head an inch to squint at the alarm clock.

It was 6:30am.

It took her a few seconds to realise that something was weird about that. Who visits at 6.30 in the morning? Even Sparkles and Arrow Boy had the decency to wait until eight o'clock for impromptu visits.

She strained to listen with only one eye open.

Adora was at the door.

There were voices.

The voices – men, by her first impression – grew louder and more insistent.

Catra didn't think. Feeling that something was wrong, she leapt out of bed and pulled on a pair of shorts and a hoodie that was discarded on top of the laundry basket.

Just as she clambered for the bedroom door, she heard shouting.

Catra ran.

"Adora?" she called. "Adora!"

From the top of the stairs, there was a clear view of the front door. Two policeman – one tall, and one short and stocky – were manhandling Adora into handcuffs. When she spotted Catra, Adora looked over her shoulder, frantic, and shouted, "Catra! Don't!"

Catra saw red.

Everything in her vision blacked out – everything apart from the pinprick of light that was Adora's blonde hair. She bolted down the stairs and launched herself at the closest policeman – arms flailing, she yelled, and she kicked, and she screeched –

"Let go of her! *Let her go*!"

In the background, the short officer recited a mantra; *you are under arrest for obstructing military operations, military desertion and disobeying lawful military commands. You have the right to remain silent* –

"Catra," Adora shouted over him. Her blue eyes were so wide, and her hair was coming loose out of its messy bun. She struggled against his grip to speak to her. "Catra – call Angella. Catra, listen to me –"

But Catra wasn't capable of listening to anyone.

"You bastards," Catra spat, throwing her fists at the other officer who was blocking her way to Adora. "You fucking –"

"Ma'am," he said, trying to take her arms. "Ma'am, you're interfering with an arrest –"

And so Catra elbowed him in the nose.

The bone cracked. The blood gushed. And still Catra wasn't satisfied.

Her breath came in short, sharp pants. Her vision was blurry. Her entire body felt like hot needles were dancing under the skin.

She knew the beginning of a panic attack when she felt one.

Catra heard Adora calling for her as the police officer kneed her to the ground. Something hit her in the face which caused her jaw to slam painfully shut. They used cable ties to secure her hands behind her back and the cut the circulation around her wrists. With her cheek pressed against the wooden floor, she had no other choice but to stay perfectly still.

It reminded her of an army operation – covered in rubble – being pressed down by the weight of brick and stone –

Tears streamed down Catra's face as they roughly pulled her to her feet. She tried to blink them away, but they kept coming. Adora was no longer here, and as they dragged Catra outside and towards a second police car, she did her best to clear her head and swallow down the panic bubbling in her chest.

Adora needed her. She needed to be present; she needed to be rooted in the moment. This was her first panic attack in *years* – all because of bastard men in uniform.

She needed to breathe. In through the nose. Out through the mouth.

She also *really* needed to kick the police officer in the shins as he forced her head-first into the back of the police car.

"Fucking fuck," he swore as he hastily secured a seatbelt over her. Then, into his radio, he said, "One-four. An acquaintance of the arrest warrant assaulted a police officer and tried to obstruct her arrest. We have her in the second vehicle. Over."

"Rodger that, one-four. Over."

The police officer got into the front seat and waited for his colleague. With her heart throbbing in her throat, Catra pressed her forehead against the car window in the hope to see a glimpse of Adora. There was another police car parked against the curb. She couldn't see anything because of the tinted windows.

"Who issued Adora's arrest warrant?" Catra spat, and her jaw gave a painful *click*.

The officer eyed her in the rear-view mirror. "You know we can't tell you that," he drawled.

Catra struggled against the seatbelt. "You have no grounds to arrest her –"

"Listen, alright? We get a warrant; we do our job." He rested his hands on the steering wheel. "If you have a problem, take it up with a lawyer. In the meantime, why don't you keep your head down and be a good girl?"

"Fuck you," Catra snarled. And oh, if she could reach him – if her hands were free –

"You're just making it worse for yourself," he muttered.

His colleague got into the car and slammed the door behind him with unnecessary force. "We have to take this one to the station," he said.

Catra leaned forward. "Is Adora going to the station? Where are you taking Adora?"

Both men ignored her.

The acid taste of bile stung Catra's tongue. As the police car drove off, Catra pressed her face against the window, searching for a sign of Adora – anything would make her feel better, *anything*. They drove past the other parked police car, but she could only see the officer on the passenger side talking into his radio.

With an angry sigh, and feeling very close to tears, Catra sank into the seat and stared directly ahead. The orange glow of the car radio told her it was 6:47 AM on the twentieth of January.

Her stomach twisted.

Catra knew *exactly* who was behind Adora's arrest warrant.

Chapter End Notes

Content warning: police arrest, police violence. Panic attacks and reference to PTSD.

This chapter (and another one coming up) I stalled writing because of the sensitive nature of the final scene - but, really, did anyone think the army were going to go down without a fight?

Hope you enjoyed, and thank you for all the wonderful comments last time around.

Stay safe,

Cx.

Ultimatum

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Brightmoon Police Station

By the time Catra was allowed to make a phone call, it was close to ten o'clock. Without her phone, Catra didn't know who to call, so she asked security for the number of Brightmoon School and to be put through to the principal.

The phone rang three times.

"Good morning, you're speaking to Glimmer Amaris, principal of Brightmoon School. How can I help you?"

Catra paused. She had been dreading this part. When they left her alone in a cell to obsess over what had happened, she thought long and hard over who to call and what to say. Rubbing her eyes, she said quietly, "Sparkles."

"Catra?!" Glimmer gasped. She sounded furious. "Where the hell are you? You and Adora didn't show up for the assembly or for first period – you haven't answered our calls – I literally just sent Bow out to look for you."

Catra twirled the phone line. What she really wanted to do was pull the phone from the wall and hit someone around the head with it. The frustration and the *hatred* burning through her was reminisce of when she was younger and angry at the world.

Nothing had changed, had it? The world kept giving her reasons to hate it.

"We were arrested." She turned her back on the police officer at the desk, who was no doubt listening in. "I'm at the police station."

"You were *what*?!"

"You need to call your mum." Catra bit her lip. "I don't know where they brought Adora."

"You mean, she's not with you?"

"No." It was taking all her effort to stay restrained. She was trying to be responsible – for Adora's sake. One more wrong move and she wasn't going to be useful to anyone in this situation. Still, Catra snorted humourlessly. "I was arrested for assaulting a police officer. They had an arrest warrant for Adora. She's not here."

Glimmer was quiet for a moment. "It must've been –"

Catra interrupted, "Yeah, the army. It's the twentieth – they didn't even give Adora a chance to show up for the health screening."

"They must've received the court petition and decided to act." Catra could hear Glimmer moving around her office. "Shit. Right, okay. I'll phone my mum. We'll come get you and take it from there, alright?"

"Hurry, Glimmer." Catra was really trying not to sound *too* desperate. "Please."

Once the phone was back on the receiver, Catra was escorted back to her cell. The only thing keeping her calm was knowing that if she acted out, she would make the situation worse. It felt like a chord running down her spine was pulled tight, and the rest of her body was tensed, ready to unravel. She rolled her eyes when she saw that the Custody Sergeant was waiting for her inside her cell. She watched the woman carefully before stepping inside.

"You'll be pleased to know we're letting you go unconditionally," said the Custody Sergeant, standing up to lean against the doorway.

Catra's face was as blank as the white wall she was standing beside. "Why?" she asked, voice sharp. "I attacked a police officer – that's the only crime you take seriously, right?"

The woman didn't react. "Your file told us you're a veteran. A veteran with quite a collection of war medals, at that. Consider it a thank you for your service."

Catra smiled. It was bitter and cruel. She shouldered past the Custody Sergeant and into the hall. "The other woman you arrested? She was a veteran too. But that doesn't fit into your narrative, does it?"

"Adora Greyskull's arrest warrant was issued under a court martial – it wasn't a police matter." The Custody Sergeant glanced down at the radio on her belt. "She was taken to a military facility on the outskirts of Thaymor. Do you know the one?"

Narrowing her eyes, Catra snarled, "Why are you telling me this?"

"I was informed that she listed you as her next of kin," she said. "I was told to let her next of kin know her whereabouts."

Catra froze. The bitter, hateful resentment pooling in her gut gave her a sour taste on her tongue. Her hand started to shake at her side, so she clenched it shut and tensed it into a fist. Knowing the Custody Sergeant was observing her, she turned on her heel and walked back down the corridor.

Why can't we just be happy?

"Can we get you anything?" called the Custody Sergeant. "A taxi?"

"My things back," Catra said, not looking at her. "A friend is picking me up."

"Can we offer you a hot drink while you wait?"

"No." Catra was doing her best to stop her voice from shaking. "I'll wait outside."

It took Glimmer half an hour to pick her up.

By that time, Catra was shivering outside the police station, too numb to feel chilly anymore. She was wearing the clothes she was arrested in: a pair of shorts and a hoodie. No shoes. When passers-by on the street gave her funny looks, she had to stop herself hissing at them.

Glimmer pulled up in her obnoxiously lavender car. Bow was in the back, and he opened the door for her. Catra slipped inside, shutting the door with more force than what was considered polite, and asked gruffly, "Where's your mum?"

Glimmer looked at her in the rear-view mirror. Her eyes were wide. It wasn't clear if it was because of frustration or worry. "It's over a two-hour drive to get here. The best she can do is talk to them on the phone as Adora's representative until she can reach us."

"Are you okay?" Bow asked, nudging the brunette. "You're a little bruised up."

Catra's cheekbone hurt like a bitch, but she wasn't about to complain about it. As she clipped on the seatbelt, she muttered, "I'll feel better when we get Adora."

"We should've seen this coming," Glimmer said, restarting the engine. "Those fuckers are going to stop at nothing to get their own way."

All Catra could do was give a non-committal grunt. She crossed her arms over her chest and stared out the window as they drove through the town. Faceless people passed by in a blur, and before she knew it, Catra was zoning out completely. Her mind wandered, and she felt a terrible sick fear latch onto her stomach –

Then she felt Bow place a careful hand on her arm. "What did they say when they arrested her, Catra?"

There was a heaviness in the air; an expectation. Catra blinked a few times. The only things that she remembered vividly from this morning was the sound of blood rushing through her ears and the hot rod of anger lighting up her body. The other details, like Adora's pleading eyes and the sound of her shouting, were more distant and distracting.

"I don't know – it was all so quick," Catra answered after a moment. Her throat was dry. "I think they said something about… obstructing commands. Desertion."

Glimmer hummed. "My mum said they're probably just trying to scare her into pulling out of the petition."

The thought of it was hot and heavy in her head. Adora – alone, pressured, feeling guilty – could do something stupid without someone there to drag her out of a bad decision. She hated the idea of Adora alone – of Adora being manipulated by those who wanted to use her; abuse her. It had happened with Weaver, and then again with Hope. They needed to get her out as soon as possible.

Bow, very kindly – and at this point of knowing him, Catra found his giving, generous, and understanding spirit *annoying* – offered her a bottle of water. She took it without saying thanks, as she usually did to establish a small inkling of control over an act of kindness. As the cold liquid gushed into her mouth and heightened her senses, she felt bad. She felt uncomfortable in her own skin.

Her hand tightened around the water bottle, and she looked back at Bow with a challenge set on her face. "She named me as her next of kin."

Bow stalled. "What?"

"Adora," Catra croaked, almost annoyed that he didn't get it instantly. "She told them I was her next of kin."

In the corner of her eye, she saw Glimmer flinch in the driver's seat. Bow's brows pulled together and the smile lines around his mouth creased. "Is that – are you – I mean, how do you feel about that?"

His tone was so gentle. So empathetic.

Catra's anxiety skyrocketed. She stared directly at him as her hand started to shake. "I'll kill them," she promised. "If they do anything to her, I'll kill them."

Her first tear fell as Bow reached for her. With the seatbelt holding him back, he wrapped an arm around her shoulders and pulled her head onto his chest. With his other hand, he took the water bottle and put it safely back in the cupholder. One tear turned into a whole lot of tears, and before Catra had the dignity to pull away, she had drenched the front of Bow's shirt with quiet sobs. Every so often, he patted her head and said *nice* things. "You're not alone," he said. "We'll get through this together."

Catra didn't *not* like Bow before. He was Adora's friend, and like Adora, he had a definite view of right and wrong, and he stubbornly resolved to be good and kind in a world that targeted good and kind people.

Now? Catra didn't just like him. She respected him.

He was a good guy.

"Thanks," she eventually said, pulling away to wipe at her eyes. "And sorry for the – you know."

She gestured vaguely at his shirt.

"This old thing?" he said, looking down. "It's not even cropped, I don't care."

When they arrived at Thaymor camp, Catra felt like she was going into battle all over again. She has no intention to leave without Adora – even if that means getting arrested all over again.

Glimmer, Angella already on the phone, marched towards the outpost reception. The boy at the gate couldn't be older than nineteen – Catra recognised the fear in his eyes as he fumbled for words while Glimmer demanded to speak to his superior. He darted behind the desk to radio in the request, and all Catra could do was quietly seethe in the background with her arms crossed over her chest and her eyes darting around the reception.

It hadn't changed much since she was last stationed here as a private officer. They had spent a few nights in Thaymor for a vehicle training. Catra had gotten to drive to a tank. At the time, she and Adora weren't on the best speaking terms, and as she waited for the supervising officer to report to the reception, she idly wondered how Adora had found her own vehicle training experience.

"I'm around twenty minutes away," Angella said over the phone. "Micah is driving as fast as he can."

The boy returned with his supervising officer –

And Catra's heart sank.

It was Cobalt.

"Corporal Areli," he said with a tight smile on his broad face. "It's been a long time."

Catra tried her best not to roll her eyes. Stiffly, she said, "Cobalt. I'm not surprised you're still here."

"It's *Colonel* Cobalt now," he corrected, shifting his hands behind his back, probably to draw attention to his shiny badge. "This is my outpost."

He was a Captain when she had joined the army, and he had made their life a living hell during their first few years of training. His tactics were ruthless and his command unyielding. He had put Catra on cleaning duty more than was deemed fair by their other superior officers. She still resented him for it.

"Yeah, well, I'm no longer in the army so that means nothing to me," Catra responded drily. When his lip twitched in response, she demanded, "Where's Adora?"

He paused for a moment. Then, as if reading an autocue, he said, "Corporal Greyskull has been sanctioned under article 23 of the court martial clause. You may not speak with her."

"Hi, I'm her lawyer here," Angella spoke up from the loudspeaker of Glimmer's phone. "My client is protected under the right of a fair trial, as stated in the Court of Law, listed as article seven, line nine. Court of Law overrules martial law, and your arrest warrant was, quite frankly, illegal, and I *will* be referring it to the court case for further investigation."

Cobalt glanced between the three of them, before his eyes landed on Glimmer's phone. He bowed his head. "One moment, please."

And then he disappeared through the back doors.

Catra stood by the service desk, waiting for him to come back. They waited another fifteen minutes, by which time Micah and Angella had pulled up outside the outpost. Cobalt only returned when Angella demanded to speak with him. He shot Catra a curious look and escorted the lawyer into the camp, leaving Catra, Bow and Glimmer alone again.

Micah asked to speak with his daughter outside. He appeared concerned, and perhaps a little annoyed. Catra tried to swallow her own pride. She didn't *want* to ask anyone for help, and she knew Adora would feel the same. Angella and Micah had offered – and persisted – to help, despite Angella's health problems.

It was another ten minutes before Angella appeared again, wearing a look of sheer determination on her face.

"They know they made a mistake, and they did it to prove a point," Angella said, speaking directly to Catra. "She's being released."

There was a collective sigh of relief in the room.

Nodding, Catra felt her body unclench. At some point, Catra would have to tell Angella how fucking grateful she was that someone cared as much about Adora as she cared. She muttered a word of thanks as Angella ushered them outside to the carpark.

"You're lucky that your charges were dropped," Angella commented, ghosting her hand over Catra's shoulder. "A relevant conviction would have jeopardised your future as a teacher."

Catra hadn't thought of that, and she felt her stomach twist. "I wasn't thinking," she murmured, glancing over her shoulder, waiting for Adora to appear. "I was just… angry."

Anger wasn't a good look on her. Anger brought out a side of Catra that she didn't like – a side that she wanted firmly kept in the past. When she looked to the side to see Angella's reaction, she found the older woman giving her a sympathetic smile.

Then, Glimmer slapped her across the back. "Adora, look!"

Not caring that they had a full audience, Catra spun on the spot. She huffed a breath between a sigh of relief and frustration before running towards her girlfriend. Adora stopped outside the front doors of the outpost and opened her arms wide, ready to accept her. Catra pelted into her, grabbing her by the waist and breathing deeply into her neck. She felt solid; real. She was safe.

Adora brushed the side of Catra's cheek, where there was surely a bruise forming under the grazed skin. "Catra – are you okay? Your face –"

Catra clung on, unable to say anything. Adora pressed a soft kiss against her cheekbone, and brushed the split on the middle of her lip. Blinking hard, Catra tried to hide more tears. Adora pretended not to notice, and instead, kept her arm around her as they walked towards the rest of the family.

“Let’s go somewhere and sit down,” Angella said, shooing everyone to their cars as Glimmer and Bow tried to join in on the hug. She glanced at Adora. “Do you need a moment?”

Adora shook her head. “No, I’m good.”

While Bow and Glimmer headed back to the school, promising to catch up with them later, Angella and Micah took Catra and Adora to a small café in Thaymor that promised to have ‘the best coffee in town’. Catra – without ever letting go of Adora’s hand again – ordered a black coffee and some pancakes. Adora, on the other hand, only asked for a cup of coffee.

This wasn’t the first sign that something was wrong with Adora. She had been suspiciously quiet since leaving the army outpost, and any attempt to engage conversation with her had been unsuccessful. At first, Catra thought she was being quiet in front of Angella and Micah, but as Micah excused himself to go to the toilet, and Angella had to go outside to take a phone call, the silence between them made little sense.

“What happened?” Catra pressed as her stomach growled with the smell of food around them. “What did they say to you? Start from the beginning.”

Adora glanced across the café, her chin resting on her hand. “There’s not much to tell. The police said they were arresting me under martial law. I tried to deny it, but they persisted. In the car, they told me they were bringing me to the outpost in Thaymor.”

Micah returned from the bathroom and gave Catra a cautious glance, obviously overhearing the latter part of the conversation. “What happened there?” he asked, arranging their cutlery. “Did they make you sign anything? Make you agree to anything?”

Adora shook her head, her movements slow. “Nothing really. They were just” – a flicker of anger crossed her expression, but she

quickly recollected herself – "it doesn't matter. You got me out, and that's the main thing."

Catra could smell bullshit, but she didn't feel the need to interrogate Adora about it – not yet, at least. Not in such a public setting. She would wait until they were home alone again and once their nerves had settled down. Catra, herself, still felt very rattled.

The waiter brought their coffee before Angella came back. The older woman looked tired; stressed, as she sat down beside her husband. She waited for the waiter to place their meals in front of them before telling them the news.

"The media know," she announced, locking eyes first with Micah, and then with Adora. "The arrest this morning was rather public. An investigative journalist from *The Magic Herald* just phoned us asking for a copy of the petition."

Catra squeezed Adora's hand. "Is that good or bad?"

"The media will undoubtedly be on Adora's side," Angella answered confidently. "They'll pull up the coverage from five years ago from Adora's Honours ceremony. If we play this correctly, they'll focus on Adora's heroics, paired with her unfair treatment. It will make light work of the military's case."

Adora said nothing. She clung onto Catra's hand as she took a long gulp of coffee. Acting as her mouthpiece, Catra asked, "That's all good then, right? Why am I getting the sense that it's not?

Angella sighed and rubbed the bridge of her nose. "We don't want them getting *too* involved. Media involvement in a court case can hinder the investigation, and the army will be able to argue that the jury has been swayed by a public case. We'll tell them what they need to know for now. We just have to ensure that nothing confidential is leaked too soon."

Micah patted his wife on the back. “You’re doing a good job, Angie. Let’s not rush this too soon.”

As Angella smiled sweetly at her husband, Catra looked towards Adora. She followed her girlfriend’s gaze, where it lingered across the café at a little family; two parents and two children, one in a highchair and one sitting on the father’s knee. The baby was playing with their food while the older child waved a toy soldier in the air.

Catra glanced away and pierced her pancake with a fork. There was a lump forming in her throat, and it wasn’t because of the coffee.

Earlier that morning – Thaymor Camp

Adora was in a conference room, handcuffed to a chair.

She had never spent long in the Thaymor outpost before – if she remembered correctly, the last time she was here she had been a private. What age had she been then – seventeen? Eighteen?

Too young, no matter the number.

The room was chilly – or maybe it was because Adora was still in her yoga pants and a vest top. Even though she was sitting uncharacteristically still, her insides were a raging volcano.

Her mind’s eye kept replaying the moment Catra’s face was crushed into the floor by that dickface of a police officer. She subconsciously tugged at her left arm – the one handcuffed to the chair – as she thought about what she *would do* to the police officer if she ever saw him again. In that moment, Adora had little regard for herself and her own situation.

She was undoubtedly screwed.

But she had promised herself that she wouldn’t bring Catra down with her, and yet that seemed to be all she was doing.

How could Adora keep her safe when it felt like the world was out to get them?

The conference room door swung open. Adora didn't look to see who it was – she had a fair idea who would do this to her, legal or not.

Colonel Hope – sorry, *Brigadier* Hope sat facing Adora across the table. She hadn't changed much since they had last met under similar circumstances five years ago. Perhaps her eyes were darker, her frown lines more pronounced. Her robotic stare still sent chills down Adora's spine.

"Corporal Greyskull," she greeted, her monotone voice echoing against the khaki green walls. "Hello again. It's been a long time."

Adora didn't take the bait. She remembered what Angella had said – *don't tell them anything*. She intended to heed that advice. "Why am I here?" she asked, doing her best to act like this was nothing more than a major inconvenience.

Hope's voice and face gave nothing away. "You broke your contract," she stated matter-of-factly. "We told you what would happen if you broke your contract." Raising her chin, she leaned towards the table. "Why did you do it? Do you not want to help your country anymore?"

Adora blinked a few times. "I can't talk to you without a lawyer," she said, trying to keep her voice free from the anger boiling in her veins.

Hope regarded her for a moment. "I see. Well then, let me talk to you. We issued your arrest warrant based on a number of allegations. Let me go through them with you now."

Adora remained perfectly still, like an animal being hunted as prey, while Hope shuffled through the papers in her file. With every passing heartbeat, Adora felt another crack in her resolve.

"Obstructing military operations. A serious offence under court martial." Hope looked up from her papers. "If found guilty, it can range from ten years to life in prison, depending on the severity of the crime."

Adora said nothing.

"And then we have military desertion, which you're familiar with," Hope continued. "This would be your second account of desertion. That makes two life sentences, am I right?"

Adora still said nothing.

"Disobeying lawful military commands. That's another ten years." Hope closed the file and sat back in her chair. "I don't think we need to discuss the previous charge of treason, do we?" Adora glanced away, and Hope clucked her tongue. "I didn't think so. Overall, you owe us for more than two lifetimes worth of crime."

"I don't owe you anything," Adora snarled.

"I'm giving you an option, *Adora*," Hope said, placing emphasis on using her civilian name. "If you pull out of the petition, we'll work with you on developing a new contract." Her eyes were bright; her tone turned forceful. "Just one more experiment with She-Ra and the Failsafe. How does that sound? One more mission and then you can live a full civilian life."

Adora breathed in through her nose and out through her mouth. What she really wanted to do was snap the chain of her handcuff and throw the chair across the room. Hope's manipulation techniques could have worked on her before – they *had* worked on her before – but not now. She had something to fight for now – a future. Hope was trying to rile her up, and it was working. But Adora would never give her the satisfaction of showing it.

What was more, there was an implication in Hope's tone. She was bargaining for Adora's cooperation, and it was different than last time. Why did they only need her for one more experiment? Five

years ago, they had been desperate to have her finish the contract. Why the sudden change of heart?

"Why?" Adora asked aloud.

Hope tilted her head. "A lot has happened in the last five years since we came to our last agreement. We had time to think and plan." Folding her hands on the table, her piercing blue eyes peered into Adora. "Anyone can see that this is a good offer. It's generous – considering your alternative; life in prison and a trial for treason. Death."

Adora nodded to herself – she was curious, very curious, what their new plan was and what it had to do with her, in other words, the failsafe. Her heart was thumping so loud that she could feel the rush in her ears. She thought about how easy it would be to say yes, and to give everyone involved in her court case peace.

But then she thought of Catra.

And she would never choose duty over her ever again.

"What do you say?" Hope prompted.

"No." Adora held her chin high and set her face into the perfect neutral mask. "I won't say anything else until I speak to my lawyer. But the answer is no."

There was silence.

Then, Hope's eyebrows raised an inch. "Disappointing." Tapping her finger against the table, her eyes narrowed slightly. "I'm going to paint you a picture of what this court battle is going to look like, Corporal Greyskull. Every single element of your life is going to be scrutinised. Every tiny detail – every secret you've kept, every word you've said – it's all going to be used against you. The world will be watching and judging. They'll see you as a fallen hero, pariah of Etheria, too selfish to do what needs to be done. Your friends and loved ones will be targeted – and some may sell you out to their local newspapers to make some quick cash. You'll

lose your job. When the army inevitably wins the case, you'll be stripped off your title. You'll be put in prison, and you'll never see daylight again. You'll be the second person in recent Etherian history to be successfully tried for treason. Do I need to say what will happen next?"

Her words cast a shadow over Adora, but they didn't touch her. Instead of seeing her superior, her old leader, she saw a desperate woman who was losing control over her last remaining pawn. Adora didn't so much as flinch. "You don't scare me. You're only reassuring me that I'm doing the right thing, Brigadier Hope." Lowering her voice, Adora continued, "Congratulations on the promotion, by the way. How many people had to die for you to get it?"

Adora could count on one hand the number of times she had seen Hope display real emotion. This was one of those times. Her entire body recoiled, as if Adora had struck her with an electric rod. With a rush of venom, she spat back, "It's a shame Mara didn't live beyond the first She-Ra experiment."

Adora froze. "What?"

"She was much more malleable, until the end. Sometimes I feel like she recommended you for this role because she knew you'd ultimately reject our methods." Hope scoffed. "One last chance to scorn me."

There was something there.

Something hidden.

Adora could hear it in the Brigadier's voice. Intrigued, and a little perplexed at a human display of emotion, Hope placed the files under her arm and rose from her chair. Her face was once again completely void of anything – not even a slither of contempt.

Her eyes, however – her eyes had a spark of life Adora found unfamiliar in her.

“I’ll see you in court, Corporal Greyskull,” she said before leaving the room.

It was early afternoon by the time Adora and Catra got home from the cafe.

Catra changed in the bedroom while Adora took a shower. Now that she could see herself in the mirror, Catra understood why Adora was concerned about her face. The graze on her cheekbone had developed into a puffy, purple bruise, and she had another bruise on her jaw near the split in her lip. It didn’t hurt – not yet. It was probably something to worry about tomorrow.

It was as she was brushing her hair that reality started to dawn on Catra. She had a knot near the base of her neck which caught on a thistle of the hairbrush. It hurt when she pulled it, and as she reached around to try to untangle it herself, she felt her shoulders sag and the energy drain from her body.

Sitting on the edge of the bed, Catra let herself slump against the pillows. Her knees pulled up underneath her and let the feeling of being bone-tired settle in her chest. Everything felt heavy, and it wasn’t until she heard Adora open the bathroom door that she realised she had been crying again.

“…Catra?”

“Fine – ‘m fine,” she mumbled, wiping her eyes aggressively. “It’s just been a long day.”

Adora’s hair was wet, and she was wearing nothing but a towel wrapped around her torso. As best as she could, she creeped along the bed until her hands found Catra and she pulled her into a hug. Catra rested her chin on her shoulder and let her eyes close.

Adora stroked her hair and whispered, “I’m sorry.”

“Don’t you dare,” Catra warned.

"And you should be sorry too."

Catra pulled away as if Adora had hit her. "What did you say?"

Adora frowned. "Never *ever* attack a police officer for me."

Catra pouted like a petulant child. "No. And I'd do it again."

Adora sighed heavily. Trying to distract her, Catra pulled on her hand, drawing her close. She pressed a featherlight kiss to her cheek, and said, "We don't have to talk about it now, but at some point we should talk about what happened in Thaymor."

A muscle twitched in Adora's cheek. Readjusting the towel, she crossed her legs and sat facing Catra on the bed. She looked withdrawn; pensive. After a few moments, she met Catra's gaze and shrugged. "They tried to get me to pull out of the court case. I was given ultimatums. Reminded of what would happen if I lost the case. It didn't work. If anything, it made me realise that I'm doing the right thing."

Catra couldn't hide her surprise. "That's a change of tune."

"Hope said something, Catra. Something about Mara." Adora bit her lip as she glanced to the side. "And I might be crazy, but it made me think of something."

"What was it?"

"Hope's never been emotive, you know that. But then when she spoke about Mara, it brought out a different side to her. For a start, she called her by her first name and not her title. And then" – Adora looked back, and she winced slightly – "she was angry. Bitterly angry. It reminded me of…"

Adora's voice trailed, and Catra quirked her head. "What?" she prompted.

"You," she clarified, an apology in her voice. "It reminded me of you when you were angry at me."

Catra paused. Her stomach flipped, and for a moment she thought Adora was saying something stupid or hurtful – and then a lightbulb switched on in her mind. "Wait – Adora, you don't think Hope and Mara were a… *thing*, do you?"

"I think I do," Adora said. "Maybe that's why Mara was chosen for the first She-Ra experiments. Maybe that's why Mara told me to get out of the army while I could."

Catra edged closed to Adora on the bed. "But, what are we saying here? Do you think Hope knew Mara would *die*? Why would she sacrifice someone she cared for?"

Adora shook her head and took one of Catra's hands in both of her own. "I don't know. They must've had a falling out, because Hope said Mara chose me to *scorn* her. Whatever happened, I think there's something there."

"Something we can use against them in the court case," Catra added excitedly.

Adora nodded, but she didn't seem to share Catra's enthusiasm. Sensing her discomfort, Catra slipped into the blonde's arms. "What's wrong?" she asked. "What are you thinking?"

"It's just a shame," Adora whispered. "How many lives the army has destroyed."

It took Catra few seconds before she could reply. Breathing in Adora, and holding onto her tightly, she promised, "Not us, though. It won't destroy us."

Chapter End Notes

> Happy Samhain, or should I say Oíche Shamhna! I'm posting this as I'm listening to fireworks over the lough, which is peak spooky season.
>
> I'm very sleepy after a busy week, but I present this offering earlier than I expected. I might go back and touch it up again

next weekend, but I'll let you know if I do.

Only a few more chapters left - next time, we get a glimpse at the court case itself and a few more discoveries are made.

As always, let me know what you think, and stay safe!

Cx.

High Court

Chapter Summary

> There's a content warning for this chapter, which can be found in the bottom notes because it contains a spoiler.
>
> This is a transition chapter, and formatted as if it were a quick series of events.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

9th March – Brightmoon High Court

Adora could feel a bead of sweat trickle down the collar of her blouse.

All eyes were on her.

She couldn't focus on any of them – not even the ones at the back, where she knew Angella and Micah were watching. Her vision pulsed in time with her heartbeat, and for a moment Adora thought she was going to black out. She gripped the chair she was sitting on, as if it was the only thing keeping her rooted in reality.

"I'll repeat the question, Miss Greyskull," said the Defence Barrister, somewhere in the background. "Did you or did you not sign a contract agreeing to take part in the She-Ra experiments?"

Adora licked her lips. "I did," she replied.

"And, did you or did you not sign a form of consent and a non-disclosure agreement for the failsafe technology to be placed inside your person?"

Adora's hands started to shake. "I did, but I didn't know what I was signing. I didn't know the extent of the –"

"Your honour," the Defence Barrister said, turning to face the judge. "Through her own admission, Miss Greyskull has agreed that she chose to partake in the Heart of Etheria project. She consented to be a host of experimental technology. As we have previously heard from her superior officers, not only has she broken all forms of conduct while she was a serving officer, but she has met the terms of the court martial that was issued against her." The Defence Barrister turned on his heel to face Adora. "Miss Greyskull deserted her post. She obstructed military commands, and now that she was faced with the consequences of her own actions, she decided to criminalise the decisions of the people who saved this country from the clutches of the Horde."

Adora shook her head. "I didn't – I'm not –"

The Defence Barrister silenced her with a raised hand. He narrowed his eyes as he homed in on her. "Do you regret your role in saving this country, Miss Greyskull?"

The question felt like a slap in the face.

Of course she didn't *regret* it. She had regrets. With Catra listening, she felt the blood rush to her face. Shakily, she said, "No."

"Then why are you intent on destroying the names of your superior officers who wanted nothing more than to end a war that had been raging since before you were born?"

"Objection, hearsay!" shouted Casta, rising from her seat. "Misleading question, your honour."

As the Defence Barrister sat down, Adora felt a chill fall down her spine. The room was both too hot and too cold at the same time, and she felt the urge to run – to get far away and find somewhere to hide.

Everything was going wrong, and it started when Angella had to pull out of the court case.

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22 January – six weeks before the court case

"So, tell us what's gotten my mum and dad so excited about the case," Glimmer said between a mouthful of noodles. "I heard they hired a private investigator and everything."

It was Friday night, which meant movies, drinks and takeaway at Bow and Glimmer's apartment. Now that she had some time to reflect and properly assess the situation, Adora was telling her best friends about what happened at Thaymor.

Adora frowned as she helped herself to another serving of rice. A long time ago, her and Bow had gotten into a long-standing competition to see who could handle the hottest curry every time they ordered from somewhere new. Adora could handle the heat, and she enjoyed the spice, but tonight's offering was making her feel a little hot under the collar. As she attempted to drown out the chillies with boiled rice, she savoured Glimmer's words – it was news to her that Angella and Micah had hired a private investigator. The last she heard, Angella had simply promised Adora that she would 'look into the situation.'

"We had a colleague called Mara in the Special Forces," Catra supplied, sensing Adora's hesitancy to talk about the subject. Mara had always been a soft spot for her, which Catra knew well. "Colonel Hope – now Brigadier Hope – said something about Mara choosing Adora to spite her. Adora thinks there's something there, like they were a couple or having an affair or something."

"From what you've told us about Hope, she doesn't sound capable of love," Bow said, also adding rice to his plate. His cheeks had a pink tint as he shovelled down more of the steaming curry.

Adora huffed a sigh. "I'm surprised too – but, I just have a feeling. If we can prove there was a conflict of interest, or another

element of corruption, then it has to go in my favour, right?" Pausing, she added, "And I'd want to do it for Mara – to get justice for Mara."

"What else did they say to you?" Glimmer asked. "Did they try to make you pull out of the petition?"

"Hope made a few threats –"

"I can't wait to see her rot in prison," Catra interrupted, stabbing a chicken ball with her knife.

Adora continued, unphased by her girlfriend's assault on the food. "But it's nothing I can't handle."

"Unlike that curry you're trying not to eat," Bow pointed out with a cheeky grin.

"Bow, you're literally shaking from the effort of eating it." Leaning over to pat his hand, Adora added, "It's okay, you can give up."

Just to spite her, Bow took another large bite.

Trying to match him, Adora did the same, and tried not to wheeze when the spice hit the back of her throat.

"I didn't know we were measuring dick sizes tonight," Catra said to Glimmer. "I forgot to pack mine."

"Have you ever seen them at the gym?" Glimmer asked, rolling her eyes at their partners. When Catra shook her head, she smiled. "They flit back and forth between enthusiastically encouraging each other to lift progressively heavier weights and competing against each other in bursts of cardio exercises. It gives me whiplash."

Catra pierced Adora with a hard stare. "Didn't you say you had to take a break from going to the gym on doctor's orders? Was it because of Mr Muscle Man over here?"

Adora looked sheepish. “Bow nearly put me in hospital.”

There was a clatter of a fork against a plate, and Bow shrieked, “You take that back!” His eyes started to well up with unshed tears. “I apologised! I’ve never felt so bad in my entire life!”

“There was a miscommunication regarding a punching bag,” Glimmer told an amused Catra. “Bow hit the punching bag, which hit Adora and knocked her out.”

“A tragedy,” Catra remarked, suppressing a smirk. “And by that, I mean it’s a tragedy I never got to witness it.”

Adora nodded sadly to herself. “One day, I’ll recover.”

27th January – five weeks before the court case

It was 4:37pm according to Adora’s classroom clock, and she was staying behind to mark her sixth year’s essays on Gustav Klimt. Her eyes slid over the untidy handwriting of one student who had clearly copied the Wikipedia page, and she tried not to lose concentration. Sometimes Adora’s brain tried to pull her in too many different directions; sometimes, just to concentrate on one thing, she had to busy her hands with something else or listen to something in the background. She was just about to reach for her headphones when the door of her classroom burst open.

“Adora!” Entrapta announced, letting herself in. “I’m glad you’re working late – I need to talk to you about a development.”

Putting down her pen, Adora eyed the computing teacher cautiously. “Is it safe to talk about *here*?”

Entrapta’s eyes widened. “Oh, right! Yes, I’ll try to keep it brief.” She sat on one of the tables at the front of the classroom. ”Hordak and I believe we’ve found the best method of removing the” – she stressed the next words – “*item you wanted removed*.”

“Really?” Adora felt her heartbeat in her throat. “You can do it?”

"With minimal impact on you and the chip," Entrapta gushed. "It's quite close to the surface of the chest wall, so we think the best way of freeing the fusion would be inserting a needle right into the –"

Adora waved her hands in the air. "Wow – okay, I don't need the details right now, Entrapta. But this is great. I appreciate all the hard work you've put into this."

"It's been fascinating! Hordak has written twelve different reports on how it works and the implications of a living person hosting technology way beyond the limits of natural energy consumption. It's going to help him in his quest to develop perfect robotic limbs." Pausing, Entrapta blinked at her expectantly. "So, when do you want to have the surgery? I'm free this weekend."

"Oh, um…" Adora shuffled in her chair. "Can we put a pause on it for the moment? I'd need to discuss it with Angella because of the court case and everything else going on."

"Okay! Just let me know!"

Adora watched as Entrapta, with her tablet in hand and her pigtails swinging, walked towards the door. A wave of affection hit Adora, and she found herself smiling fondly at the older woman. So many people had helped her recently - and despite how it was killing her inside, it felt nice to be *part* of something.

"Entrapta," Adora called before she disappeared. "Thanks again, for doing this."

Entrapta stared at her as if it were obvious. "You're my friend," she said before closing the door behind her.

3rd February – four weeks before the court case

It was Adora's last day of teaching.

Hopefully not forever.

It was agreed that Adora would have to take time off during the court proceedings. Glimmer had discussed it with the Board of Governors, and given the sensitivity of the court case, Adora was allowed leave with half-pay. At first, this had concerned her; she had things to pay for, and depending on how long the court case lasted, she may fall behind on her bill payments.

That was when her beautiful, intelligent, perfect girlfriend came in.

Catra said she could split the bills – they were living together, after all – and shoulder any other expenses over the coming months.

"I've always wanted a stay-at-home wife," she had teased with her contagious smirk.

"You don't like my cooking," Adora had pointed out. It had taken a few more seconds for Catra's full statement to sink in. When it had, she gave a loud *coo*, and exclaimed, "Aww! You called me your wife!"

Catra had stalked away, muttering '*idiot*'.

They were having a party in the staffroom; Perfuma had baked another vegan cake and Mermista had brought drinks, which Adora was pretty sure contained *some* alcohol. Most of the teachers had bought good luck gifts, while others, who knew Adora less, had signed a card. It was fuss, and Adora was very tired of being the centre of attention. When they got home from work, she was looking forward to hiding away in her and Catra's bedroom, where it was just the two of them and no distractions.

Helping herself to a second helping of cake, Adora walked back to the circle of chairs and overheard the tail-end of a conversation.

" – transferring from Erelandia."

"Who's transferring from Erelandia?" Adora asked, sitting down.

“Uh.” Bow looked like a rabbit caught in the headlights. He opened his mouth very slowly, and winced as he said, “The new Art teacher.”

“Your replacement,” Mermista helpfully clarified.

Adora felt like the chair was pulled out from underneath her. Between mouthfuls of cake, she gasped and stared at Glimmer. “You’ve replaced me already?!”

Glimmer was trying not to roll her eyes. “Adora, we can’t just stop teaching art –”

“Oh wow.” Adora said, sitting back to glare at all of them. “*Wow*. I can’t believe I’m so *replaceable*.”

“Statistically speaking,” started Entrapta, “Art teachers are some of the most oversubscribed –”

“Entrapta, no,” interrupted Catra, putting her hand on the computing teacher’s shoulder. “It’s not worth it.”

Adora had a retort ready on her lips when she felt a buzzing coming from her pocket. She got out her phone to see a missed call from Angella. Adora felt her skin prickle. It was during office hours, which only meant one thing.

“I need to take a call,” she told them, standing up. Pointing to her cake, she said, “No one steal my food.”

Purposefully, Catra went to take a bite, and as Adora walked past, she slapped her hand away.

The cold air was refreshing as Adora stepped outside. A few students were loitering near the bins – probably smoking – and quickly scuttled inside when they spotted her. Bracing herself (because Angella only called through the day when it was something important) Adora called her back.

She answered straight away. “Adora, I’m sorry to disturb you while on your break.”

“Hi Angella, it’s no problem.” Adora paced around the quad. “Everything okay?”

“Nothing is wrong, per se, but there is a… development I think you should know about.”

Adora leaned against the brick wall and stared at the sky. “Alright. Hit me with it.”

“*The Magic Herald* has released its first article about the court case. Its tone is neutral, thankfully, but a few more media outlets have picked up on it. Radio Moon has requested us to comment, and you know what that means.”

Frowning, Adora struggled to make the connection. “Um – no, actually, what does that mean?”

Angella sounded tense. “If Radio Moon, the biggest radio station in Etheria, wants to report on it, then the Etherian Broadcasting Company will run a story on it soon after. And once we delve into the realm of broadcast media, well… The audience will grow.”

Right, sure. The wider the audience, the more interest. Adora felt her fingertips tingle at the thought of everyone across Etheria seeing her face on the television and following the court case as if it were a reality show in a gossip column. The first time Adora had gotten media attention, she hasn’t been fully *present*. She was injured and recovering from the most traumatic experience of her life. Most of her quotes and interviews in the press were given by the military’s press office. The appearances she had personally made were few and far between. What was more, she hadn’t paid any attention to reading articles on her heroics, or watching news shows discussing her actions. She had separated herself as much as she could, so this felt like a whole new, scary world.

“As long as it’s neutral, right?” Adora offered instead, trying to reassure herself more than Angella. “Then it won’t affect the

case."

"Yes, yes. I'll send it to you now so you can read it. When the court case starts, however, we'll have to keep a closer eye on what's being released. That tends to be when tabloids take sides."

"Yeah, of course," Adora said, feeling the pit in her stomach rapidly expand. "Thanks for letting me know, Angella."

Before she hung up, Angella's voice lowered an octave and called her back. "And Adora – there's one more thing. We have information on Hope and Mara."

6th February – four weeks before the court case

"So, we were right?" Catra said, flicking through one of the reports. "Hope was having an affair with Mara."

Angella visited Catra and Adora that weekend to update them on the private investigator's findings. Angella, herself, appeared to be something of a PI when she sat at the kitchen table with a stack full of paperwork and case files. Adora was half-expecting her to pull out a magnifying glass and a Sherlock hat.

So far, Angella had confirmed that the private detective had found evidence – *plenty* of evidence – that Hope and Mara's relationship was more than professional. Angella was taking her time going through the documents and explaining what each one meant.

"Yes." Angella directed them to an army record showing shared accommodation. "At the time, Li Hope was married to a Military Commander of the Infantry Division. They were married for just over five years." She inclined her head. "Our PI spoke to one of Li Hope's ex-girlfriends, who said that Hope only married him for approval from her family. It is thought that they had an arrangement where they would both see other people."

If true, it wasn't the first time Adora had heard of something like this happening. It wasn't that the army was outwardly

discriminatory against gay couples – but it was well known that a heterosexual married couple went far in the military together. Marriages of convenience were common even among soldier divisions.

"When did the relationship with Mara start?" Adora asked.

"We spoke to one of Mara's friends outside of the army, Serenia, who told us quite a lot." Angella pointed them to a handwritten statement. "Given that Hope was Mara's commanding officer, there was a conflict of interest in their relationship. That, plus Hope's marriage, put strain on the relationship. It's thought they were together for two years in total, but when it ended becomes considerably more confusing."

As Catra took the statement to read it, Adora asked another question. "Were they together when Mara took part in the She-Ra experiments?"

"Going by the timeline Serenia was able to give us, yes. As it happened, she told us a lot about the She-Ra experiments too – although she didn't know the official name of it." Angella sat back with her hands clasped on the table. "Mara had apparently confided in her that Hope had asked her to take part in a new weapon trial for the army. She said that it mattered a lot to Hope, and that Hope wouldn't want anyone else to help her with the trial. Mara agreed, but soon after became frustrated at what was asked of her. She said that Mara felt used." Angella's face darkened. "The last time the friend saw Mara, apparently Mara had tried to report Hope for fraternisation, but the complaint was never investigated. It's thought that at this time, Hope and Mara were no longer together."

Catra's eyes were wide with a mixture of horror and excitement. "This is more than fraternisation. This is a major deal. The army prohibits *any* relationship – even friendships – with commanding officers and their soldiers in case there's favouritism or bribery."

Angella held up a copy of an army document. "To quote article 54, section 90 of the *Code of Conduct*, which states, "*relationships, (both opposite-gender and same-gender) are prohibited if they compromise the integrity of supervisory authority or the chain of command; cause actual or perceived partiality or unfairness; involve the improper use of rank or position for personal gain; are exploitative or coercive in nature; create an actual or clearly predictable adverse impact on discipline, authority, morale or the ability of the command to accomplish its mission"*."

Adora's hands gripped her knees. She was struggling to comprehend just how *big of a deal* these findings were. "So, basically, their relationship – and especially their involvement with She-Ra – was both illegal and exploitative," she surmised.

"Yes," Angella answered bluntly. Then, she fixed Adora with a keen stare. "What's more, Mara's friend is willing to represent this in court."

"Really?!" Adora burst out as Catra shouted, "You serious?"

"Yes. Apparently, she tried to get Mara's death investigated but the request was denied. She views this as her way of getting justice for Mara." Angella took a moment to pause, and her facial expression was still deadly serious. "And on that topic, Adora, I have another question. Is there anything – anything or anyone – that you think would make a difference to this case? Anything you've heard or thought about that could build up the picture of the Etherian Military being unlawful?"

Adora tried to think. She tried to think of everyone and anyone she came into contact with in the army. Now that the final preparations were being put together for the court case, Angella was assembling a panel of people who could testify in Adora's honour. Adora had struggled to give her any good suggestions, mostly because she was no longer in contact with people from the army, and partly because - as far as she knew - no one else knew about the experiments.

And then it hit her –

“Actually… yes.” Adora glanced at Catra. “But I don’t think he’d testify.”

Angella’s eyes danced with curiosity. “Who?”

“Hordak.” Adora licked her lips. “The creator of the failsafe.”

Angella was dumbstruck. “The creator of – you know who created the failsafe?”

“I didn’t know until recently. I only knew him as a double agent before. Our paths didn’t cross in the army.” Adora shuffled uncomfortably. “I really don’t think he’ll testify, though. I think he’s in the same sort of contract that I’m in to guarantee his silence.”

Angella was quiet. She looked between Catra and Adora before giving a long hum. “It’s worth a try. But, Adora, please – you have to tell me these things while you have the chance. It could make the difference between a win and a loss.”

It was on the tip of her tongue.

Adora wanted to tell Angella about Entrapta's research into removing the failsafe. It was practically willing itself to fall out of her mouth. And yet, for whatever reason, Adora couldn't get the words out. Something was holding her back and she didn't know why. It was a feeling she had that she couldn't shake.

"I will," she said instead. "I promise."

1st March – the first day of the court case

Adora had seen Brightmoon High Court before. She’d seen footage of cases on television, so she thought she knew what to expect.

Somehow, the cameras never captured the sheer scale of the place.

Everything was mahogany; and because of the darkness of the wood, it gave the halls and rooms an intimidating, dark essence – as if someone was always hiding in a shadowy corner or lurking behind a railing. The ceilings were painted green with wooden features, and copper lampshades hung from chandeliers and wall lights.

Brightmoon was a colourful, vibrant city, but its High Court held the darkness of the criminals that had walked through here.

The High Court was reserved for the most severe cases. The last treason trial had been held here, for example. Due to the fact Adora was making claims against the whole of the Etherian Army, Angella's petition had travelled straight through the variety of other processes and landed straight in the clutches of the High Court – and their most senior judge, Judge Norwyn.

Adora's hand clenched around nothing as they waited outside the High Court. Anything could happen once the case started – and the outcome was up to one man who she had never met before. Adora might walk into the court of her own free will, but she might leave it in handcuffs. These thoughts – each one spiralling more and more out of control – were responsible for keeping her up every night for the last week. Just when she felt her legs begin to shake, Catra rested her hand on Adora's waist.

"Are you okay?"

"Yeah." Adora tried to smile but it fell flat. She let out a shaky sigh. "Yeah, I'm okay."

Catra grimaced. Almost off-handily, she said, "I'm not."

Adora turned to fully face her. "You're not?"

"No." Catra's fingers traced the outline of the birthday broach she had given her. Something incomprehensible flickered on her face.

“I wish there was something more I could do.”

Adora put her hand on top of Catra’s and took it away from the broach. Adora had taken to wearing it on the left lapel of her blazer, close to her heart. “Just hold my hand,” she said. “That’s more than enough.”

Catra squeezed her fingers as Angella and Micah rounded the corner. Angella was wearing a grey A-line dress with a black belted blazer, and a cane, which she was heavily leaning on. Micah was matching her in a grey suit of his own, and had his hair tied back in a bun.

“Are you ready, Adora?” Angella said with a soft smile.

Adora breathed in a shaky breath. “Are *you* ready?”

“Yes,” Angella responded without any hesitation. “This is going to be the court case of the century, mark my words.”

As the court crier called for entry to the court, Micah left with Catra to sit in the viewing gallery with Bow and Glimmer. Angella rested her hand on Adora’s upper back as they entered through the right side doors, while the Defence entered through the left.

The first thing Adora’s eyes landed on was Judge Norwyn – specifically, the large platform he was sitting on. He was an older man draped in purple robes and watched keenly as they took to their own plinths. Angella pulled out Adora’s chair for her, and as she did, Adora glanced at the Defence. No one she recognised from the army was there – but she knew people like Captain Lonsfield were somewhere in the viewing gallery. She shivered at the thought of accidentally bumping into him in the hallway. If it was up to her, Adora would never see *any* of them ever again.

The court crier asked for silence.

Adora held her breath.

And so it began.

“Now begins the proceedings of the petition raised by Lady Angella Amaris against the Etherian Army and Intelligence Service on behalf of Corporal Adora Greyskull of the Etherian Special Forces Unit,” called out Judge Norwyn. “The petitioner, Corporal Adora Greyskull, is represented by the prosecutor Lady Angella Amaris, and the defendant, the Etherian Army, is represented by the defence counsel G. Rizzlor of the Military Court. All rise.”

There was a clamour of noise as everyone got to their feet. Adora clasped her hands in front of her as she bowed her head to listen to the court proceedings as listed by the court crier. They had been informed the Rizzlor – nicknamed Grizzlor – would be representing the Etherian army along with his posse of solicitors. He was a well-built man with a large mane for hair. His hazel eyes were so vibrant that they almost looked amber. Adora wasn’t intimidated by many people, but there was definitely something about him that made her feel uncomfortable sharing the same space as him.

When the court crier sat back down, Judge Norwyn called, “First, we will hear opening statements from the prosecutor, Lady Angella Amaris.”

Adora couldn’t hear anything over the racing of her own heartbeat thumping against her ribcage. Angella stood, and using a voice that was clear and authoritative, began. “Thank you. Your honour, you’ve read the petition and you know how complex and sensitive this issue is. In order to grasp the scale of the problem my client faces, we must dissect every line in the contract you can find on page two, section seven of your notes.” She paused to allow the judge to flick to the page in question, and then she went on, “Before we discuss the contract that was forced upon my client, first, let me paint you a contextual scene.

“Adora Greyskull joined the army when she was just sixteen years old. She was handpicked for the Special Forces at only eighteen, which broke the record for the youngest candidate to transfer to the SF. Her talent and dedication saw her partake in many successful missions, and she was known by many in her team as

being a leader – someone people looked to for guidance, despite her young age.

"It was during her time in the SF that she first tasted tragedy." Angella paused again, and her voice lowered an octave. "One of her officers, Lieutenant Mara Despondos, died in action. Adora carried her body back to her team, but she unknowingly carried much more than that. Soon after, a grieving Adora was asked to take part in a secret specialised mission known as She-Ra. While we will discuss the She-Ra experiments in much detail later, it's important to note that Adora's role in the She-Ra experiments ended the war with the Horde. This is how she became known as a hero at the age of twenty-one.

"What did twenty-one year old Adora face?" Angella gestured to her as she spoke. "Well, during that last mission, Adora survived bombs and a host of automated robotic weapons. She was shot in the stomach and managed to carry her friend to safety before depositing herself in the communications chamber to take down the transmitter. When the transmitter was down, she was buried under rubble and debris as the building came down around her.

"Adora's medical reports show that she suffered a concussion, broken bones, and that the gunshot wound in her stomach got infected after the surgery. She was in a wheelchair for half a year, and has long-lasting injuries from the ordeal. And that's just physically. Mentally, Adora had depression, anxiety, disassociation, and extreme PTSD. With no help from internal army resources, Adora battled these illnesses alone and was still expected to return to work when instructed by her superior officer. When she objected, she was forced to sign the aforementioned contract. Otherwise, she was threatened with charges of desertion – and worse, treason.

"Your honour, this is no way to treat a war hero. Adora didn't receive the proper care and attention she needed after preparing to sacrifice her life for Etheria. She was in no state, physically or mentally, to sign a contract with the Etherian army. As written in the military's own *Code of Procedures*, applicants or serving

soldiers must be "of sane and safe mind' when signing or renewing any type of contract." Glancing to the defence, Angella concluded, "Therefore, Adora's contract, signed in the presence of Colonel Li Hope, should be null and void on the grounds of mental health and wellbeing concerns, plus a charge made for a breach of Code of Conduct and Practises against the Etherian army."

The scribes working underneath the judge's platform were typing at their laptops, and for a moment, it felt like the room held its breath with only the sound of their quick clicking keyboards filling the gap. Judge Norwyn was scratching his chin, and when he looked up, he stared at Grizzlor.

"Thank you. And the defendant?"

Grizzlor cleared his throat as he stood to attention. Despite being a lawyer, Adora reckoned he must have served some time with the army himself. His rigid, legs hip-apart stance was the same one only a solider would recognise. He organised his notes, and then started to speak.

"Your honour, may I start by agreeing with the prosecutor. This is complex case, which the petitioner has broken into many different subsections and leading arguments. The prosecutor's client, Adora Greyskull, is known to many as the face of Etheria's victory over the Horde." He gestured at Adora before continuing. "We'll hear her side of events in due course, but I feel the need to remind you of something. This is one person – one version of events, one point of view – against the Etherian army. The Etherian army, led by people who have sacrificed their lives to save everyone on Etheria. When we discuss this court case, we must take a moment to consider that everything that happened, everything that is recorded, happened during a war. A long, bloody, fruitless war."

Grizzlor's eyes met Adora's, and she tried not to blink – to flinch – to react to his intimidating scowl. "Adora Greyskull was a soldier in that war, and her command came from the people who will be mentioned in this court case. Whatever the outcome, we must remember that the Etherian army did what they had to do to win

Etheria's longest ever war, with the intention of saving countless civilians. Everyone featured in this narrative knew what was at stake and what it was going to cost them. We need to think about the irrevocable damage that retrospective regret could do to a mighty institution such as the Etherian army." He looked back to the judge and bowed his head. "Thank you."

Once again, the sound of tapping keys. Adora swallowed and cast a side-glance at Angella, who's stony expression remained unshakeable. There was, however, a slight muscle twitch in the corner of her mouth, which Adora interpreted as frustration.

"And now we will hear from the prosecutor's first witness."

The session for the first day was spent with a lawyer Angella used to work with, and together they analysed and examined every line of Adora's contract. They went over, in detail, how every clause of the contract breached the army's *Code of Conduct* and *Code of Procedure*; Adora was entitled to retire from active duty after the Heart of Etheria project but was denied; Adora's mental health and wellbeing weren't in a such an order for her to continue with active duty; desertion and treason shouldn't have been used as threats against Adora to encourage her to sign the contract; and, most importantly, Adora's current mental health status determined she could not fulfil the contract now, despite the army calling on her to re-enlist.

"I know what you must be thinking, judge," Angella said in her closing statements. "Why? Why were the military's own codes and practises bent and overruled for Corporal Greyskull? What was so special about Adora Greyskull that the army would go against their own ethos to keep her in their ranks? The answer to that we will unravel as this court case continues, but in the meantime, please remember: the events we're currently discussing happened post-war." Angella looked towards Grizzlor. "Adora has every right to be free, as we all were once the war ended. Thank you."

Grizzlor must have interpreted the last line as some sort of challenge, because he immediately waved his hand in the air to

signal for an objection. Judge Norwyn brushed him off, and for that, Angella looked satisfied. She sat beside Adora, and gave her the smallest nudge that said *that went well*.

"Meeting adjourned," the judge proclaimed, using his gavel. "We will meet tomorrow at nine o'clock."

Adora allowed herself to slump against the back of her chair. Her eyelids felt tired, and her eyes were scratchy and dry. She rubbed at them as Angella collected her files, and when she looked up, she noticed Judge Norwyn glancing at her as he climbed down the steps of his platform.

Adora flinched, as if she had been doing something she shouldn't. It wasn't a bad look on Norwyn's behalf – no, it was more curious, as if he was trying to *read* her.

Caught up in her own thoughts, Adora didn't hear Micah, Catra and Bow and Glimmer approaching. Glimmer bound up to her and wrapped her in an enthusiastic hug. On her other side, Catra looked tense with worry. Frown lines had replaced the smile lines that Adora knew so fondly.

"That went well," said Micah, taking his wife's bags. "I really don't know how they're going to form a counter-argument against it."

"This isn't the part I'm worried about," Angella said, looking over her shoulder to see if Grizzlor was nearby. "We'll be sure to win the fact that Adora's contract does not stand on legal ground. It's the next part I'm worried about, especially after the Rizzlor's opening statements."

Catra took Adora's hand as they walked through the side doors from the court room. "What worried you about them?" she asked.

"He placed emphasis on seeing the army as an institution and protecting the rights of war-time code." Angella shook her head thoughtfully. She looked exhausted – as if the weight of the world was on her shoulders. "We'll have to play dirty to fight those arguments, and I was prepared to form a case against them. But

I'm worried that they're mentioning it so early. They must have their own comprehensive counter-argument."

"So, we'll have to bring up Hope and Mara?" Catra guessed. "And hopefully get Hordak to testify on our side by that time."

"Exactly," Angella agreed. "Let's just hope we have enough back-up plans."

3rd March – Brightmoon High Court

It was only three days into the court case that everything changed.

The Defence had tried to argue the validity of the claims of Adora's mental health problems during the time of the contract signing, but this was quickly overruled by the opinions of medical staff and assessment reports at the time. In the end, they could accept that the contract could be called into question – as long as the judge recognised that the charges of desertion and treason could be brought forward to replace the contract.

Angella, of course, had been expecting that.

At the end of the second day, Angella asked permission to bring forward a solicitor who specialised in martial law. Judge Norwyn agreed, and so on the third day, Angella took great pleasure in discussing the intricate details of desertion. In the solicitor's opinion, the contract went against the rules of martial law – the act of desertion could not be overruled by a contract and, if someone was of a weak mental state, a charge of desertion would likely be dismissed. When asked what the most severe consequence would be in that case, the solicitor said immediate dismissal.

In response, Grizzlor asked the witness about treason. He posed a leading question: if a soldier, without a shadow of a doubt, poses a threat to the national security of Etheria, does martial law take their mental health into consideration? No, the solicitor had said,

but it’s outdated. Treason hasn’t been an issue for Etheria in a long time.

Grizzlor asked no further questions.

And with that, the first part of the court case was over.

The meeting was adjourned until later that afternoon for the judge to make a decision.

Adora couldn’t stand it – the waiting. She couldn’t eat, she couldn’t sit – not even Catra could get her to calm down. Despite Angella’s reassurance that they would win this part – that Adora’s contract would be destroyed, Adora couldn’t help but imagine her reaction if Judge Norwyn ruled against her.

What would she do if he said the contract was legal and binding?

What would become of her then?

Hope’s words echoed in her head – and suddenly her warning seemed more real than ever before.

Once recess was over, the court crier called them back into the courtroom.

Adora took her place beside Angella, and when they stood for the ruling, Angella discretely held Adora's wrist under the table. Angella’s hand was shaking and felt clammy, but Adora guessed it was due to nerves. The closer she looked, however, Adora could see a light sheen of sweat on Angella's face. Frowning, Adora turned back to the platform and did her best to concentrate.

A scribe handed the judge a sealed envelope, as per court tradition. Judge Norwyn peered over his rectangle spectacles as he read from a thick sheet of cream paper. “I hereby declare that the *Agreement to Re-enlist* contract signed by Corporal Adora Greyskull for the Etherian Special Forces null and void on grounds of a breach of army codes and practices and negligence of a caretaker role,” he said, loud and clear. There was a small cheer

from the gallery. He continued, "I have asked for a follow-up inquiry to take place about the repercussions of this ruling, the details of which will be published in due course. Now, I believe the petitioner has a second charge against the Defence."

Adora forgot how to breathe. Tears sprung to her eyes and she felt as if she would faint. *They'd won the first proceedings.* What was more, Judge Norwyn had asked for his own inquiry – that was major. This was huge. This was a sign that he was taking this seriously - that he believed Adora's version of events thus far.

For a single second, Adora allowed herself to feel victorious.

And then reality crashed back down on her again when she heard Angella's next statement.

"Thank you, your honour," Angella said, and as she stood up, she held onto the table; her knuckles were white from the effort. There was a slight sway to her stance and her voice wobbled. "On behalf of my client, I would like to press charges of unethical behaviour and criminal acts against the Etherian army and Special Forces, to include unconscionable conduct, human experimentation, coercion and indecent relationships of fraternisation."

The Judge peered at Angella over his glasses. He paused, and then looked down at his documents. "Noted. And the Defence?"

"We are pressing charges of desertion and treason against Corporal Greyskull, your honour," Grizzlor said quickly, as if someone was going to interrupt him. "And these charges should be reviewed independently of the petitioner's claims."

Angella didn't look happy about that. Once again, the Judge paused. He sounded reserved. "Also noted. We will reconvene at the start of business next week. Given the nature of these charges, a jury will be appointed, and media attendance may be permitted. All agreed?"

Adora watched as Angella anxiously reached for her cane. "Yes, your honour."

"Agreed, your honour," Grizzlor said in the background.

"Court dismissed."

There was something wrong.

Adora could sense it.

Trying her best not to stare, Adora watched Angella pick up her files. The older woman's hands were shaking as she reached for her case, and as Micah and Catra rushed over, she took a moment to wipe a bead of sweat away from her upper lip.

Adora's concern was louder than Bow and Glimmer's joyous cheers as they ran to meet them. There was chatter, but it was all in the background. Adora was watching Angella with a laser-focus, and the more she seen, the more her anxiety grew.

As they walked from the court room, Catra asked the group, "What does that mean? 'Desertion and treason independent of our claims'?"

Angella was the one to answer. "It means…" she paused as she took a deep breath and repositioned her cane. "We could win the case – we could win it all – and Adora could still be charged with treason. It's a double-sword approach. If you bring us down, we'll bring you down." She met Adora's watchful stare. "You both go down together."

"The thing is, if we do win the case, then it'll be very straightforward to claim that Adora acted *because* of the unlawful conditions she was put in," Micah added, and as always, carried Angella's bags for her. "It just means another court case after this one, basically."

"And what if we lose?" Catra pressed.

Adora saw Angella sway again.

Micah pulled a face as he replied to Catra, walking ahead of the group. "Adora could still be charged with treason, yes. We can still argue that she acted because of the emotional toll she was under. It would just be more difficult to –"

Adora was ready when it happened.

She saw Angella's eyes roll back. She saw how all colour drained from her face and her hands began to twitch.

Adora lunged to catch Angella as she collapsed and gently lowered her to the floor.

"Mum!"

"Angie – Angie?!"

Adora held her – that's all she could do. She supported the head of the woman who had cared for her – who had loved her as one of her own – as the convulsions ripped through her body. At one point, Micah crouched next to her, and in the background, Bow called for help.

It was blurry – it was all a blur, as if Adora was watching through the lens of a camera. She couldn't tear her eyes away, and when Angella finally stopped shaking, Adora's hands continued to shake instead.

A medical team – if they were in-house or arrived via an ambulance, Adora didn't know – pulled her away. Somewhere in the commotion, Adora forgot how to stand. She sat on the floor, watching as the medical team worked on Angella in the hall of the courtroom, and absent-mindedly listened as someone whispered sweet nothings in her ear.

Catra. It was Catra sitting next to her, cradling her as she had done with Angella. As more of the scene came to Adora's attention, she felt Catra's warmth surrounding her and saw Micah

talking in hushed voices to a paramedic. Beside him, Bow was holding Glimmer.

The world very narrow, and her place in it felt obscure.

“My fault,” Adora croaked, surprised at her own words.

“She’s okay, Adora,” Catra said, stroking her hair. “They said she’s okay.”

Nothing about what had just happened was *okay*. Angella was sick – she had been sick for years now, and she had forced herself to *be okay* for Adora’s sake. The guilt Adora currently felt was unbearable. Her heart was breaking into tiny little pieces. She couldn’t look anyone in the eye – especially not Glimmer or Micah.

Using the wall to help her stand, and avoiding all eye-contact, Adora grunted, “I need air.”

And quickly escaped from the scene.

Chapter End Notes

Content warning: seizures

A slightly different (and less favourable) chapter giving an insight to the beginning of the court case. I don't want to spend too much time on legal jargon because it's not my forte, and it's not the focus of this story. Hopefully it wasn't too dreadful or boring to read!

Next chapter is the 'climax' of the story.

Thank you so much for your support.

Stay safe!

Cx.

Reclaim

Chapter Summary

> Content warnings can be found at the end of the chapter. This is for spoiler reasons, but please heed the warnings if you need to.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

TRAGEDY STRIKES GREYSKULL'S COURT CASE

GREYSKULL'S LAWYER COLLAPSES AFTER SHOCK WIN

GREYSKULL vs. ETHERIAN ARMY: WHO WILL REPLACE LADY AMARIS?

"And another one from the *Etherian Suns* tabloid," Adora said, leaning over the hospital bed.

Angella took the newspaper and held it as if it was poisonous. With her nose wrinkled, she read, "*And they all fall down: can Greyskull win without Award-Winning Amaris?"* she sighed. "That's not as catchy as they think it is."

"It's true, though, isn't it?" Adora crossed her arms over her chest. "Without you, I'm screwed."

Angella patted her hand. "We're on the right track, dear. What matters is that you have a strong case, and if argued in the right way, and narrated in the right fashion, we can win back your freedom. It doesn't need to be me who does it. A lawyer is just a storyteller, that's all."

Adora sniffed and looked to the side. She didn't need newspapers to tell her how fucked this whole situation was. For the millionth time, Adora felt the strain of guilt latch onto her, threatening to

pull her under. Before she could stop herself, she mumbled, "I'm sorry."

Angella shook her head. "I don't want to hear it. This was not your fault."

"Epilepsy can be triggered by stress – if I'd just –"

"Ah – ah, no," Angella cut her off, firm and resolute. "I don't want to hear it. Strokes caused my epilepsy many years ago, Adora, not you."

Still not convinced, Adora shuffled her chair closer. "What did the doctor say?"

There was a pause, as if Angella was weighing up how much to tell her. "I'm out of commission for a while, and I should go back to my relaxing hobbies of painting and writing," Angella said in a dry tone. "They're doing a few tests just to make sure something else isn't going on."

Adora nodded, more to herself than to continue the conversation. She glanced to the door – to where she had last seen her friends and Catra, who had given them some privacy. Holding in a sigh, Adora tried to smile back at Angella, who was staring at her intently.

"I heard you weren't well after my… collapse," the older woman said, frowning. "I'm sorry you all had to see that. I could feel it coming on me all day." She grimaced. "I had hoped I was just tired, but, alas…"

Adora crossed her arms over her chest. It was news to her that someone had told Angella about her… episode. She assumed it must've been Glimmer or Bow. A wave of anxious energy overcame her, and she found herself shuffling in the chair. "I could tell something was wrong," she said honestly. "I just spiralled a bit. I don't – it's weird, I just – I don't know how this works, you know?" Feeling her cheeks start to burn, she looked down and

added, “You’ve been like a parent to me, and now with the court case and everything – I want you to be well.”

Angella gave an airy sigh. “That’s a relief. All this time, I thought you wished me ill-health.”

“That’s not what I –”

“I know, Adora. You didn’t grow up with any worthwhile parental figures, and it’s hard to navigate new areas regarding family without ever experiencing it while growing up. And that’s what you are – family.” Angella’s voice shook slightly. “Glimmer is my biological daughter, and we have our differences. But I’m proud to call you my daughter also.”

Adora was too dumbstruck to know what to say. She’d never been called someone’s daughter before – that had never been one of her roles or one of her labels. Wordlessly, she got out of her chair and wrapped her arms loosely around Angella’s shoulders.

And then she heard Catra’s voice from the doorway. “Oh no, are we bonding? Alright, see ya –”

“Get back in here,” Glimmer chided, grabbing her by the scruff of her neck.

Bow burst out, “Did someone say group hug?!”

Adora turned around to see her three friends letting themselves into the hospital room. Catra sauntered over, offering Adora a bottle of water.

Taking it, Adora glanced around. “Did you find food?”

Catra poked her in the ribs. “Always thinking with your stomach.”

“Dad is trying to sneak in pizza,” Glimmer said, sitting on the edge if her mum’s bed and passing around chips and fried chicken.

“I ate the popcorn chicken in the car,” Catra confessed. She gave a half-shrug. “Sorry. I’m not sorry at all, actually, you usually eat them all before I even get to sniff them.”

Adora narrowed her eyes. “Betrayal.”

Catra perched on the armrest of her chair. “You all good?”

Adora smiled, despite how she felt hollow inside. Hoping it reached her eyes and it at least looked convincing, she murmured, “Yeah.”

“How are you feeling, mum?” Glimmer asked, holding Angella’s hand after fluffing up her pillows.

Angella looked tired despite how she said, “Much better after a rest, although I suspect that’s all I will be doing for the foreseeable future.”

Giving a quiet hum, Glimmer repositioned Angella's duvet. Adora found it hard to watch. She was just about to excuse herself to escape to the bathroom when she heard a loud male voice from outside the room.

All of them turned around as Micah burst through the door slightly out of breath and clutching his phone in his hand.

Angella opened her mouth to ask what was wrong, when he interrupted her with wide eyes, saying, “I’m just off the phone with Cas." He beamed. "She’ll do it.”

Adora and Catra looked at each other while Bow and Glimmer did the same. To her parents, Glimmer asked, “Did we miss something?”

Angella locked eyes on Adora and nodded to her husband. “Adora, we asked if Casta could take over representing you in the trial. She had to move around some dates in her own calendar, but she’ll do it.”

And just like that, they were back on track.

As if nothing had happened.

Adora shared a grateful smile with them and held in a breath. Despite everything, the trial would continue – and the knot in her stomach tightened until it was almost painful.

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48 hours prior - a few hours after Angella's collapse

Time had lost all meaning; it was just a concept binding people to the world, to structure, to society, and Adora felt detached from everything. She knew time had passed – her skin was cold; the kind of cold that had settled and numbed her skin – but she had no desire to move. Her throat ached and her eyes were swollen – a symptom of crying so hard and for so long that she felt physically dehydrated. Aside from these basic observations, Adora had no concept of *being*.

The world was a little blurry, like she was staring through a dirty window or walking through a dream. Everything was numb; she couldn't feel the bench under her, she couldn't register her own thoughts that came in short bursts. She felt like a cold, numb lump sitting outside, unaware of how she got here or where *here* was.

When fragments of reality came back to her, the guilt was so overpowering that she pushed them back down. Just for a moment – for a few hours or a few days – she wanted to *not exist*. Was that too much to ask for? She barely felt human anyway.

She wasn't surprised at the sound of footsteps or someone calling her name, but she did actively shy away from them. She didn't deserve anyone looking for her – caring for her – being there for her – any time someone got too close they seemed to get hurt in some way.

And any time she felt like she had won, the rug was pulled from under her.

I always find my place among the ashes.

"Adora. Adora? Shit, you're freezing." An arm wrapped around her shoulder. "Adora, snap out of it – you're scaring me."

It wasn't the words but the tone of voice that made her blink blearily at the person sitting beside her on the bench. The blurriness of the night moulded into the shape of Catra. Catra, who was holding her and wearing a deep frown. *She looks so much prettier when she smiles*, came unwanted into Adora's mind.

And then she finally felt the cold.

"Angella's okay, you know," Catra said, holding onto the blonde's chin so her eyes wouldn't wander again. "They got her just in time. Micah was scared it was a sign of another stroke, so they're keeping her in hospital for a few days." Catra's voice sounded strained. "And it is absolutely *not* your fault."

Shivering for the first time, Adora forced herself to look away. She couldn't remember walking to the park – she wasn't even sure which park this was – but her cheeks felt sticky with dried tears and her heart was aching. With a croaky throat, she whispered, "If it wasn't for the case –"

"You don't know that," Catra interrupted sharply. "Are you her doctor? No. Even if the seizure was caused by stress or something, it was Angella's choice to get involved in the case. You can't be responsible for other people's decisions or their actions, Adora. When are you going to get that into your head?"

Adora struggled for a few moments. This was a problem for her – an issue that she had fought with for a while, and the only person who had ever gotten through to her was Catra. But this time it wasn't working – this time, Adora could see the cause and effect. To her, this wasn't irrational. "I feel responsible," she murmured, with her head turned.

Catra gave a deep sigh. “I know. You feel responsible for every bad thing that happens in the world. That doesn’t make it true, does it?” Catra skirted closer until she was almost on top of her. “It’s been an eventful day, yeah? Bow and Glimmer are with Micah in the hospital. They’ve got the situation covered. How about we go home and warm up?”

Adora nodded but made no effort to move. Warm hands guided her off the bench, and as they moved, and the freezing air followed her, more shame danced through her body, souring any warmth Catra had shared.

“What happened, anyway?” Catra asked, breaking the silence. There was an edge to her voice. “I’ve been searching for you all evening.”

“Dunno,” Adora murmured, watching her feet walk across the gravel path and wondering how she had any energy to keep going. “I’ve blanked it all out. I think I just kept walking.”

“Panic attack? Maybe you should talk to Perfuma about –”

Adora stopped abruptly. Rubbing her forehead, she snapped, “I just want this over with, Catra. I don’t want anyone else getting hurt. I just want to know what’s going to happen to me.”

“We’ve one hurdle down,” Catra said, almost pleading. “That’s something, right?”

“But with Angella…” Adora almost choked on the lump in her throat. “What am I going to do now?”

Catra took a moment to look away, probably to recollect herself. Adora was reminded of why she wanted to do this alone in the first place. She didn’t want to bring Catra down with her – like Angella, or anyone else currently helping her.

“We’ll work it out, I promise,” Catra said, squeezing her hand.

Adora's lip wobbled, and she tried to cough to cover a muffled sob. Tears, hot and steady, leaked from her tired eyes. "I'm just so sick of – of *relying* on other people – I'm so sick of other people making decisions about my life – I don't even feel like I *own* my own body – I just want to – to –"

She grimaced and angrily wiped at her face.

In the next moment, Catra's arms were around her. "Sshh. I know. I hear you. I'm here."

Adora let herself be coddled, if only to hide her face for a while. Catra was there for her – all her friends were there for her – but that didn't make it better. It made it worse, it made it so much worse. Every day she was reminded of what she was about to lose.

Her body felt present, but her mind was elsewhere. As they walked through the park, Adora found the twilight haunting; somewhere between life and death, just like her.

8th March – Greyskull vs. Etherian Army, Brightmoon High Court

The proceedings were delayed by a day to allow the Greyskull camp to successfully replace Angella as the petitioner and prosecutor. Over the weekend, Casta and Adora had spent most of their time with Angella in the hospital, so they could go over the details of the case and discuss the very carefully structured narrative Angella had planned. Luckily, Casta had helped Angella write the petition, so she was easily caught up to speed.

Adora had never seen Casta at work before; she was methodical and focussed, and if Adora felt fully *present* in the discussions, she would've been impressed by her enthusiasm to help. However, ever since Angella's collapse, Adora had felt like something was broken inside of her. She found herself staring at the hospital floor, wondering how she would react if the judge ruled against

her – how she wouldn't be able to look any of her friends in the eye if she was publicly charged with treason…

Now that she knew the Etherian Army were prepared to bring her down, no matter the cost, as their counter-argument, Adora felt much more focussed on the alternative: Entrapta's extraction.

If the court case was obviously not going in her favour, then she would bring up the idea of Entrapta's surgery to remove the failsafe to Angella to gauge her reaction. It was the only card she had up her sleeve – the back-up plan for Angella's millions of back-up plans.

Hopefully it would never come to that.

Now, it was the morning of the second round of Greyskull vs. the Etherian army. Regretfully, Adora was on her own this morning; Glimmer, Bow and Catra were only granted one week's leave from teaching – their next week off, and the next time all three of them would be in attendance at court, would be for the final call for evidence. Angella and Micah (after Angella was given the all-clear from the hospital) were in the gallery, which was something. Although Adora didn't feel completely alone, she did feel an intense anxiety knowing that there was a full camera crew setting up inside and outside of the court room.

Before they left to attend their very different mornings, Catra pinned the sword brooch onto the lapel of Adora's blazer. "I'll be listening, okay?" she assured. "I'll be with you every step of the way."

Adora fumbled with herself, avoiding the mirror in the hallway. The last time she had seen her own reflection, she was disturbed by how lifeless her own eyes had looked. "I know. It's just a shame that, you know… But it's fine. It'll be fine."

Catra pointed at her. "I asked you if you wanted me to quit my job to be with you and you said no. Glimmer was going to fire and then rehire me."

“One of us needs to be earning money,” Adora retorted. “How are we going to live?”

Catra shrugged as she put on her leather jacket. “We could live off our savings.”

“Bold of you to assume I have savings.”

“Adora, I *know* you have savings. Did you think I was joking when I said I was planning for us to run away together?”

Drily, Adora wondered out loud, “Is that still an option?”

She heard Catra set her back down so she could reach up and grab Adora’s face between her hands. “Absolutely,” she said, kissing her lips.

And it was then that Adora realised that, for Catra, there was no other option: Adora was going to win this trial, and they were going to be free together. The other options weren’t real to her – they were distant possibilities, ones they would never experience or live through.

And that hope, that passion, made Adora feel warm for the first time in days.

“Okay,” she sighed. “I feel a little better.”

Casta was very warm and friendly – if not a bit fussy – when she met Adora outside of the courtroom. Angella and Micah were there too, and Adora’s heart sank when she saw Angella was back in her wheelchair. There was a tremor to her hands, and she looked very pale, but any time Adora asked, she insisted she was fine.

Micah and Angella left for the viewing gallery as Casta and Adora entered the courtroom. Adora’s eyes immediately found the TV cameras at the back – she scanned over them, feeling the world tilt, the edges blur, and she fought to stay present in the moment.

Her mind wanted to escape again, but this was not the time for it. Holding her breath to keep herself present, she took the seat beside Casta, resolutely keeping her eyes from wandering over to the Defence.

"All rise," said the court crier.

They all stood.

"I hereby declare the start of the proceedings for Corporal Adora Greyskull's charges of unethical behaviour and criminal acts against the Etherian army and Special Forces, to include unconscionable conduct, human experimentation, coercion and indecent relationships of fraternisation," announced Judge Norwyn. "The counter-argument of the Defence is an independent review of desertion and treason charges against Corporal Adora Greyskull. Any objections or modifications?"

"No, your honour," said the scribe.

The Judge nodded. "Then we will hear from the prosecution, Ms. Casta Amaris, with her opening statement."

Casta proceeded to deliver the speech Angella had written; Adora had heard it so many times that she could recite it herself. Citing the army's moral code of ethics, discussing the implications of biological warfare that the Horde used – and asking if these things, when painted in the same picture, should be placed on the shoulders of one individual.

It was a good speech, but lacking the *oomph* Angella gave it in her rehearsals. Casta was obviously nervous in the slight tremor of her voice when asking the difficult rhetorical questions like 'who holds the military accountable?' when aware of the camera crew at the back of the courtroom.

Across the room, Grizzlor was watching them with the air of a hunter calculating the next move of their prey. His beady eyes regularly pinned Adora, who felt… nothing. She had no interest in mind games – and, quite frankly, after what had happened with

Angella, she felt detached from the fight. Her mind was struggling to cope with the attention this was giving her – the need to keep up an appearance.

This case no longer just affected her – it affected the accountability and reputation of everyone involved.

But as bile settled in Adora's throat, she squeezed her eyes shut for a split second and tried to refocus on the present.

Casta had called the first witness to the stand: an ethics professor from the University of Brightmoon, who would describe, in detail, the moral code of ethics before Casta called the second witness to the stand: a military scholar, who would discuss the implications of Adora's contracts regarding the Heart of Etheria project as evidence of biological warfare.

This would continue for the next week; Angella had prepared a range of witnesses to prove how Adora being used as a weapon – consensual or non-consensual – was unlawful. Adora, herself, wouldn't take to the witness box until mid-way through the proceedings – when the Failsafe and She-Ra were discussed.

As for what the Defence had planned, they had no idea. Both parties had asked for non-disclosures because of the media presence. Tomorrow, the Defence would take centre stage and all they would be able to do is react and listen.

It was impossible to tell how well they'd done at the end of the day; the jury couldn't give anything away, and the Judge didn't react to any of the proceedings. Before they parted, Casta and Angella assured Adora they would listen to the news to get a picture of the media's verdict, so Adora didn't have to listen to it herself. Even if they had asked, she wouldn't have listened anyway.

At the end of the first day of the new trial, Adora crawled into bed without eating dinner, but didn't fall asleep until she felt Catra's warmth next to her.

9th March – Greyskull vs. Etherian Army, Brightmoon High Court

Another morning.

Another morning spent wallowing in her own helplessness and self-loathing.

As she stared at her phone, reading over the notes Angella had sent her about the first day of the court proceedings, Catra slid a bowl of cereal across the table, and asked, "Did you eat last night? You were in bed by the time I got home."

Adora didn't look up. "Uh, yeah," she lied. "Yeah, why'd you ask?"

"I didn't see any dishes in the sink."

"I washed them?"

"You don't sound too sure about that."

Shoulders slumping, Adora shook her head. "Sorry. I wasn't hungry."

"What's wrong?" Catra suddenly sat down next to her. "Are you nervous about the Defence today? Are you feeling well?" She chewed on her lip. "Mentally as well as physically, I mean. You've been… withdrawn lately. Since the Angella thing." Catra's voice was small. "It's making me worry."

Adora stared at her – properly looked through her girlfriend, the most important person in her world. She was clearly making her miserable, and the thought turned the taste in her mouth to acid. "I'm fine," she mumbled.

There was a moment of silence.

And then Catra snapped, standing up, "I wish you wouldn't lie to me."

"What do you want me to say, Catra?" Adora asked tiredly.

“Be honest!” Catra shouted, turning around, her hair whipping about. “You’re scaring me – it’s like you’re not here most of the time. I get it – I understand you feel guilty about Angella taking sick, and I know how stressful this is. Hell, I wake up every day feeling sick at the idea that our days together are numbered. But you need to talk to me. Don’t shut me out again. You promised you wouldn’t.”

Quite simply, Adora didn’t have the energy to deny Catra anything. She had been withdrawn lately, and she didn’t feel ‘here’ most of the time. Rubbing at her eyes, Adora talked to the table. Her only concern now was trying to appease Catra – to try and stop the conversation before it escalated further.

“Okay,” she said. “You’re right. I’m not doing… well. But I don’t know how to fix it.”

“You don’t have to,” Catra assured, walking back to the table and taking Adora’s hand. “You’re not alone.”

Adora allowed herself to be pulled to her feet, but she immediately looked away. “We should get going. We’re both going to be late.”

“Screw them.”

“*Catra*.”

The brunette lifted her hands in a surrender. “Yeah, yeah. Alright.” She pointed at her. “But this conversation isn’t over – you hear me? We’re talking about this when I get home.” Adora tried to turn away, but Catra pressed a swift kiss to her cheek. “And keep your chin up today, okay? I’m with you.”

Those words repeated in Adora’s mind all morning. They were all she could think about. Why? Adora was starting to think she was pushing Catra out again – withholding her true, dangerous feelings from her – in the hope that she would walk away.

I’m with you.

Adora wouldn't walk away from Catra. She couldn't, not now. She was selfish. But maybe if she pushed and pushed, and pulled away, receded into the furthest corner of her mind, Catra would see sense and leave.

Deep down Adora knew it was all nonsense. Catra was too far in to leave now. All she was doing was hurting them both.

They should've run away when they had the chance.

Inside the courtroom, Adora wasn't listening to Casta's briefing. She could hear the journalists behind them giving their views on the proceedings for today. They kept mentioning Grizzlor, and the term 'treason'*. What does treason mean? How can you commit treason in Etheria? What is the punishment?* It wasn't until Casta said three words – three words that caused her to suddenly panic – that she zoned in on the present.

"…if you're called."

Adora spluttered, "If I'm what?"

Casta blinked at her. "Weren't you listening to anything I just said?"

"No, sorry, I'm…" Adora shook her head in an attempt to clear it. "What did you say there?"

"If you're called to the witness stand, don't mention anything about the failsafe unless you're prompted," Casta repeated, more forcefully this time. "We're trying to keep this conversation about ethics before we move into the abuse of power and human experimentation narration."

But Adora was still stuck. "If I'm called? What do you mean? I thought I wasn't scheduled to stand witness until next week."

"For us, yes. But we don't know what Grizzlor is planning. He could call you at any time." Casta cocked her head. "Did Angella not go over this with you?"

“No – I mean, yeah." Adora squeezed her eyes closed, trying to remember. "She must have.”

“Are you feeling –”

Casta was interrupted by the court crier shouting 'all rise', and for that Adora was thankful. Everyone shuffled to stand, and the journalists retreated to the viewing gallery. Adora couldn’t take her eyes off the mic hanging above their heads.

I'm with you. I’ll be listening.

Adora could picture Catra sitting at her desk, marking papers, with her radio echoing around the empty classroom.

It made her feel cold and alone.

“Today, we will hear from the Defence,” said Judge Norwyn, crossing his hands. “They will be responding to the claims of abuse of ethics in the armed forces, and also introducing their own counter-argument with their charges of desertion against Adora Greyskull. Now, we will hear the Defence’s opening statements.”

Grizzlor remained standing as they all sat down. Adora didn’t watch as he readied himself to speak. Instead, she stared dead-ahead, unblinking. Bracing herself for what was to come.

This was always going to be the hardest part; listening to what she assumed would be lies and deceit.

Grizzlor stared speaking in a controlled, personable manner. “It was interesting that the prosecution chose to discuss the moral code of ethics in the proceedings yesterday. One of the main points of practise in the moral code of ethics for the armed forces is that of commitment, chivalry and loyalty. Above all else, participation in the army must be just and fair – committed to country and personhood.” His tone lowered. “This is why we take desertion very seriously. How can we fight a fair and just war – a moral war – if our soldiers are dishonourable? Dishonest?

Disingenuous?" Every word felt like a dagger piercing Adora's skin. "Today, my first witness will be Colonel Lonsfield of the Etherian Special Forces. If you will, sir."

Colonel Lonsfield.

Captain Lonsfield, as she had last known him.

They were going big and hard early.

Adora couldn't help how she flinched as she saw Lonsfield take to the witness stand. Beside her, she felt Casta shuffle and type frantic notes on her tablet. This wasn't good – she *knew* this wasn't good, and Adora didn't know anything about law. Whatever else the army had planned, Grizzlor was intending to control and narrative from the very beginning.

They were going to paint Adora in a negative light before Adora's team had the chance to discuss specifics of the Failsafe and experimental projects. Once the character assassination was over, people wouldn't be interested in how or why Adora acted in the way she did. Their minds would already be made up.

Adora would be the villain.

It was exactly how Angella had said: they wanted to bring Adora down hard and fast, so if they went down too, they'd go down together.

As for Lonsfield, he'd aged terribly in the last five years. His hair was white now, and he had large, wrinkled crevices around his mouth and on his forehead. He was wearing his uniform too – his badges were polished and on full display on his chest. Adora had forgotten how he had the most punchable face in all of history. He still wore a constant smirk, as if he was always ten steps ahead of everyone else.

"Colonel Lonsfield, you have studied the moral code of ethics, yes?" Grizzlor began.

“Yes, sir.”

“According to your knowledge, when was the last time there was a known breach in the moral code of ethics?”

Lonsfield frowned. “Not in my serving time, I haven’t seen it. Except from the case we’re currently discussing.”

Grizzlor nodded and took the time to pause. “Can you explain the procedures and practises you have in place to ensure your division in the army is acting honourably and with the best moral intentions?”

Lonsfield answered the question in detail. Standards and standardisation; practices and procedures; internal reviews and external balances. It all sounded convincing.

“And what about the case – to use the phrase of the prosecution – ‘human experimentation’?” Grizzlor asked, turning slightly towards Casta and Adora.

“Biological warfare, in all of its forms, is frowned upon,” Lonsfield answered immediately. “It should be noted, however, that during times of war, such rules can be relaxed. The pros and cons are always weighed up, of course. Mass death and destruction is a no-go, no matter what is happening in the war we’re fighting.” As an after-thought, he added, “And then there’s the topic of biological warfare, as such. The definition, I mean.”

“Have your participated in, or known of, missions involving biological warfare, to include human experimentation?”

“No.” Lonsfield was calm, but terse. “Not using the definition as I know of it.”

“And what definition is that?”

“Using person or persons – or any living thing on a micro or macro scale – to win against your opposite side.”

Grizzlor smiled. “Okay. Thank you." He paused to change his stance. "Colonel Lonsfield, I understand that you served alongside Adora Greyskull. In fact, she was your subordinate. Is that right?”

For a moment, Lonsfield met Adora’s eyes across the room. She didn’t dare to blink. “Yes, sir,” he said. “Corporal Greyskull served under me in the Heart of Etheria project.”

“Describe her character,” Grizzlor ordered with a twirl of his hand.

“She was bright and willing in the beginning. Over the course of the project, she grew to be difficult.” Lonsfield licked his lips. “Stubborn and hot-headed.”

Adora could *feel* her cheeks burn. Under the table, Casta placed her hand on Adora’s forearm.

Grizzlor went on, “Was she ever reprimanded for disobeying instructions?”

Lonsfield looked as if he was weighing up the answer. Carefully, he said, “Officially, no. I had to have a word with her on a few occasions. Sometimes she seemed unwilling to fight for our cause.”

“Can you give me an example?”

Lonsfield leaned forward, keen to get started on the topic. “Certainly. First, you have to understand what a privileged position Corporal Greyskull was in – she had hand chosen out of many soldiers to be the star player in our project. We all wanted her to succeed – *the project* to succeed. On one occasion, when I was giving her instructions for the next steps of the project, she questioned our methods and our goal. I had to remind her of her privileged position, and how many soldiers would kill to be in her shoes.”

Grizzlor gave nothing away. He watched as the scribes took notes, and then, tapping his pen against his hand, he said, “Tell me

about the Heart of Etheria project, Colonel Lonsfield. What was its aim?"

"The aim was to bring down the Horde's Arms Factory which houses the communicator. We strategically knew that if we brought down the transmitter, we could destroy the Horde's systems. We knew that the advanced technology the Horde used had a weak spot, and this was it. Using our own researched technology, and with a specialised team, we successfully brought down the Arms Factory and the transmitter at the same time."

Lies of omission, Adora thought. Yes, one strand of the Heart of Etheria project was taking down the communicator. To be precise, it was the final act. He had purposefully left out all attempts to discuss the She-Ra experiments and the failsafe. He was jumping straight to the end to save face.

"And what was Corporal Greyskull's role in this?" Grizzlor asked.

"She was tasked with bringing down the transmitter."

Adora's blood boiled. It rushed through her ears, making it hard to hear the next few questions.

"Yes, we all know she did." Grizzlor almost sounded amused. "But did it all go according to plan?"

"No. Greyskull acted out of command."

"Please expand."

Lonsfield pretended to pause, as if it was an effort to recall the specifics. "She chose to prioritise a fellow soldier instead of reaching the transmitter in good time. This would be considered admirable if the fate of Etheria wasn't at stake. She used a flare to alert us to the soldier's location, when she was supposed to use the flare to tell us the Arms Factory was clear. She then went alone, against instruction, to the transmitter." He added, "This is, of course, a brief version of events."

“Yes, thank you, Colonel. My goal today is to get a grasp on the larger picture, rather than an exact account of events. But, tell me, what consequence did Corporal Greyskull’s actions have on the overall plan?”

“We were called into the building too soon – we almost lost many of our team. If we had been five minutes early, the building would’ve collapsed on the back-up team, killing them all." Lonsfield gave a solemn shake of his head. "I had to react to stop that from happening.”

An echo of silence rang through the court room. Adora could imagine people watching and listening - people who knew nothing about her. They would be listening this and assuming the worst - calling her names - judging her and hating her. As distracted and overwhelmed as she was, she nearly missed what Grizzlor said next.

“Thank you, Colonel. That will be all for now.” Folding his arms, Grizzlor turned to Norwyn. “Judge, I would like to call Adora Greyskull to the witness stand.”

Brightmoon school

"Judge, I would like to call Adora Greyskull to the witness stand."

"Fucker," Catra spat at her radio, crushing the pen in her hand.

Ink splattered on her palm, leaking through the crevices to splatter on the essay she was marking.

A few students looked up at her, wearing a range of emotions. Catra didn't know what to do. She couldn't concentrate with all of them staring at her, watching for her emotions.

Wordlessly, she grabbed the radio and left the room. Glimmer would need to know about this.

From the witness stand, Adora could see it all. The gallery, the cameras, the scribes and the officials. The jury. She could see everything.

It was like taking centre stage in the middle of a theatre. Most people were just here for the entertainment, after all.

Adora had never wanted Catra beside her so badly in her entire life.

She felt like she was about to lose it – like she was barely able to hold on. As Grizzlor turned to her, with his beady eyes and broad chest, she used all of her remaining energy to *focus* and to *get this right*. She couldn't break. Not yet.

If not for her own sake, then for everyone else who was relying on her.

"Miss Greyskull, I have a few questions about your time in the military. There will be time for details later, but for now, could you tell me why you joined the army?"

Adora's mouth suddenly lacked any moisture. Forcing the words out, she answered, "I wanted to make a difference."

Grizzlor gave no reaction. "What age were you when you enrolled?"

"Sixteen."

"And what age were you when you were enlisted to the Special Forces?"

She paused, and she didn't quite know why. "Eighteen."

Grizzlor made a thoughtful sound at the back of his throat, but Adora couldn't help but feel it was patronising. He knew this information already; whatever his little show was for, it wouldn't be for her own benefit. "That's very young. I'm sure you were proud."

“Of course I was,” Adora replied defensively, unsure where this was going. “It was a dream come true.”

“And when you were assigned to the Heart of Etheria project, how did you feel?”

A hot streak of anger pierced Adora’s chest. “Honestly?" even to her own ears, she sounded strained. "Confused. I was told little to nothing about it.” Knowing it was stupid, but still reeling from the previous session, she went on, “Colonel Lonsfield lied when he said the Heart of Etheria project was just bringing down the transmitter. He didn’t mention the She-Ra experiments or the –”

“Objection, your honour,” Grizzlor said, interrupting her with a sharp shout. “The witness is straying from the topic. Colonel Lonsfield is not on trial.”

Judge Norwyn inclined his head and motioned for him to continue.

Adora physically bit her tongue to stop herself from saying something. How was this fair? Is this what Etheria considered to be a fair trial? Grizzlor continued, this time holding up a few sheets of paper. He walked towards the witness box and placed them in front of her.

“I have here copies of contracts that you signed during your participation in the Heart of Etheria project. Can you confirm these are your signatures?”

Adora was staring at the small print, and her own signature, and that of Hope and Lonsfield. A shot of panic went through her. “They are. But I –”

Grizzlor spoke over her. “You signed your consent to take part in the project known as the Heart of Etheria. Is that correct?”

Adora’s heartbeat had made its way to her throat. “Yes.”

“And you signed your consent to take part in the She-Ra experiments. Is that correct?”

Adora could feel a bead of sweat trickle down the collar of her blouse.

All eyes were on her.

She couldn't focus on any of them – not even the ones at the back, where she knew Angella and Micah were watching. Her vision pulsed in time with her heartbeat, and for a moment Adora thought she was going to black out. She gripped the chair she was sitting on, as if it was the only thing keeping her rooted in reality.

"I'll repeat the question, Miss Greyskull," said the Defence Barrister, somewhere in the background. "Did you or did you not sign a contract agreeing to take part in the She-Ra experiments?"

Adora licked her lips. "I did," she replied.

"And, did you or did you not sign a form of consent and a non-disclosure agreement for the failsafe technology to be placed inside your person?"

Adora's hands started to shake. "I did, but I didn't know what I was signing. I didn't know the extent of the –"

"Your honour," Grizzlor said, turning to face the judge. "Through her own admission, Miss Greyskull has agreed that she chose to partake in the Heart of Etheria project. She consented to be a host of experimental technology. As we have previously heard from her superior officers, not only has she broken all forms of conduct while she was a serving officer, but she has met the terms of the court martial that was issued against her." Grizzlor turned on his heel to face Adora. "Miss Greyskull deserted her post. She obstructed military commands, and now that she was faced with the consequences of her own actions, she decided to criminalise the decisions of the people who saved this country from the clutches of the Horde."

Adora shook her head. "I didn't – I'm not –"

Grizzlor silenced her with a raised hand. He narrowed his eyes as he homed in on her. “Do you regret your role in saving this country, Miss Greyskull?”

The question felt like a slap in the face.

Of course she didn’t *regret* it. She had regrets. With Catra listening, she felt the blood rush to her face. Shakily, she said, “No.”

“Then why are you intent on destroying the names of your superior officers who wanted nothing more than to end a war that had been raging since before you were born?”

“Objection, hearsay!” shouted Casta, rising from her seat. “Misleading question, your honour.”

As Grizzlor sat down, Adora felt a chill fall down her spine. The room was both too hot and too cold at the same time, and she felt the urge to run – to get far away and find somewhere to hide.

“You know better than to ask a leading question, sir,” Judge Norwyn reprimanded. “You may continue, but think better of it next time.”

“Apologies, your honour,” he said, waving it off. With his head bowed, Grizzlor circled back to the witness stand. “Miss Greyskull, I want to talk a bit more about the charges of desertion and treason against you. Tell me how and why you deserted your post.”

Screams and blood on the walls. The ceiling collapsing. Hauling Catra’s unconscious body through the window to safety. Pain and bright lights and glass falling. Waking up in hospital – looking Hope dead in the eye when she was asked to return to active duty –

Grizzlor tried to push her for an answer. “When was the exact moment you thought it was appropriate to go against military

commands, leave the army, and try to run away from your responsibilities?”

Adora sucked in a breath – it was loud and dry and it made her whole body shake. Stalling from the first breath, she felt the second catch in her throat. They kept coming, short and quick and painful, and she couldn’t sit here anymore – she was going to spiral head-first into a panic attack in front of thousands of people -

“Objection, your honour,” Casta said, jumping to her feet. “My client has PTSD. She has difficulty recounting events from this period of time. It’s clear that she’s struggling with these heavy-handed questions.”

“I can see that, thank you," Norwyn said sternly. He sat forward and looked between his scribe and Grizzlor. "Although the Defence has a right to question the motives and account of events given by Corporal Greyskull, I think we need to adjourn for today so that Corporal Greyskull can get the help she needs.”

Casta nodded. “Thank you, your honour.”

“To make up for the lost time, the Defence can call another witness or agree to the adjournment," Norwyn went on, eying Adora from the side.

Grizzlor took a moment to consider. He watched as Casta helped Adora out of the witness box, and there was a look of victory in his persistent gaze. “We’ll adjourn for now, your honour," he finally said.

Norwyn gestured to the scribe and court crier. “Proceedings adjourned due to health and wellbeing concerns. The next session will take place tomorrow morning.”

Embarrassed, ashamed, hating herself and completely spiralling (she hadn’t felt this bad since the time Catra left her standing

alone after the Honours Ceremony), Adora ran from the courtroom as soon as it was safe to do so.

These emotions were pressing against her gut and twisting their way up her throat. She wanted to cry. She thought she was going to be sick or faint. She wanted to throw something, to punch something – she needed out, away, far from here –

"Adora –" someone called after her.

She spun around, not sure who she was shouting at. "I fucked up, I know."

It was Angella. Patiently, and softly, she said, "It definitely didn't go to plan, but I'm more concerned you're alright."

"I'm done, Angella," Adora replied, her voice cracking. She walked back and forward, her arms waving in the air. "I'm *done* with this case. I failed. Let them do what they want to me, it doesn't matter anymore. I can't take this *humiliation* in front of a full TV crew – disappointing everyone, putting everyone in the line of fire –"

"Adora, stop," Micah interrupted, trying to reach out for her. "Take a few breaths. We all need to calm down."

"We knew this case was going to be dirty, Adora," Casta said. "You didn't say anything that we can't recover from."

Angella was nodding. "Not to mention, Grizzlor's argument was too loaded too soon. He was all over the place. Cheap tricks."

They weren't listening, or they didn't understand just how *done* she was. Trying to push back on the panic clenching in her chest, she did her best to sound normal before talking again. She wanted them to hear her – properly hear her. This was the last resort, and she was calling in on it now, because it looked like her only way out.

"Can I suggest something?"

“What is it?”

“I was talking to Entrapta before the case started and she has done a variety of tests on me,” Adora realised she was talking a mile a minute but she didn’t dare stop. “On the tech *in* me. We can use that as evidence, but there’s something more. During those tests, she came up with a hypothesis. She knows how to take it out of me if we need –”

“Absolutely not!” Angella spluttered, looking to Micah for support. “Entrapta isn’t a qualified medical practitioner –”

“She knows what she’s doing!” Adora argued.

“She could severely injure you. No.” Angella rounded on her again. “Not to mention, if she damaged the failsafe in anyway, the military would be able to sue her – to put her on trial for the same charges against you. You don't think we've already thought of this, Adora? No. It’s far too reckless and dangerous.”

Adora felt her heart break all over again. Anywhere she turned, the door closed in her face. It was too much. Something was going to explode, and when it happened, it wasn't going to be pretty. Suddenly, all of her intense feelings vanished. Like the calm before a storm, a shallow bay before a tsunami, Adora's insides stopped squirming and her mind cooled from the hot thoughts piercing her skull. Numbly, she muttered, “We’re going to lose the trial, Angella.”

“It was one bad day,” Angella replied, softly. “Tomorrow, Casta will discuss the failsafe and its health repercussions. You can talk again, if you like. Fix what you felt like you did wrong.”

Adora didn’t hear her. In her mind, everything was crashing down – she was looking at her freedom slipping away and all she could do was sit back and watch. All she wanted to do was go. She wanted to be alone. To think about this for herself.

“Okay?” Micah prompted, resting a hand on her back.

“Alright,” Adora said, because she knew it was what they wanted to hear.

“Good.” Angella motioned for them to make a move. “Now, get home and get some rest. We’ve had a stressful day and I’m sure Catra will be worried about you when she gets home.”

Adora couldn’t remember driving home. Before she knew it, she was standing in front of her front door with her key in her hand. The set of keys clattered together as her hand shook. She looked down at it as if it belonged to someone else, as if someone else was controlling her limbs and controlling her thoughts.

After a few attempts at inserting the key, she locked herself inside and dropped her bags and coat at the door. Home, alone, in her own space, she allowed herself to unwind. Like a spring being pulled apart, she slumped on the bottom of the stairs and shoved her head between her legs, drawing in long breaths.

A panic attack was coming – crashing into her – and it was going to be a bad one.

While she still had the ability to think, she stumbled up the stairs and felt her way to the bathroom. Her body was shaking so badly that it was hard to stand – her heart was racing, thudding, trying to break its way through her ribs. Sweating, gasping, and wired with hot, suppressive panic, she turned on the tap with a rough thrust of her hand.

But her vision was tunnelling - darkness was filling in the corners of her sight -

She missed the tap entirely and fell against the full-length mirror as her vision turned black.

Several moments passed - or perhaps it was a matter of seconds. When Adora came around, she couldn't tell up from down.

When light and sound came back to her, she realised she was sitting on the floor, surrounded by shards of broken mirrored glass, gasping for breath.

Her mind zoned in on the shards. For the second time that day, she was reminded of the last time she was sitting in broken glass - at the Horde's transmitter in the communication tower. She could almost feel the scar on her cheek – where the broken glass had hit her – flaring back to life with red, hot pain.

How many years had she *endured* bad memories and painful regrets?

And the powers that be still wanted more. They would always want more.

Adora didn't matter. Adora, in the bleeding flesh on the bathroom floor, did not matter.

It was all about the failsafe. She-Ra.

They only wanted her for She-Ra.

And she wanted out – she wanted to be free – the technology within her felt tainted, infected. A gaping wound that would never heal. It continued to destroy and corrupt everything it touched. First, her relationship with Catra. It almost brought down Angella. It would bring down Entrapta and Hordak and everyone else who wanted to help her.

She wanted it *out*.

Gone.

As the intense, fiery anger burst through her veins – Adora had a single moment of clarity.

She was feeling too much; hatred, anger, disgust, self-hatred, and it all came crashing down.

Adora’s body reacted as her mind went deadly silent.

Her fingers wrapped around a shard of glass.

A roar ripped from her throat.

And then there was blood.

It splattered on her trousers and on the floor. Her vision – which was blurry and disorganised – focussed on her left hand.

Other thoughts and feelings started to swim back to her in short bursts.

There was a small chip in her palm. The wires were cut, their ends frayed.

She was staring down at the failsafe.

The glass shard clattered against the floor.

Her right hand brushed against the exposed skin on her chest.

Blood.

What had she done?

Chapter End Notes

Content warnings for: blood, fainting, panic attacks, depression, derealisation, self-harm.

Whew! A lot has happened since I last posted. I had four teeth extractions, got braces, got a job offer and quit my job, to name the headlines.

I am *not* happy with this chapter. It was a beast of a topic, and something I started dreading from about halfway through. I knew Adora needed to reclaim her power and agency in some way, and I wanted it to be akin to the end of series 4 when she destroys the sword. She's low, and she feels helpless, and the only way out is the path that she chose, which in this case is getting the failsafe and the army tech - the elements of control - out of her.

That, obviously, brings us into some sensitive topics around self-harm, which is never pleasant to write about. I might make more in-depth notes about this on tumblr, but I'll leave it there for now.

We've only two chapters left, and I intend to get them posted before New Year.

Stay safe and if I don't post before the end of the week, Nollaig Shona!

Cx.

Redemption

Chapter Summary

> I'm back bitches. I know it's been a long time, but shit happened and I'm not over it but the story must go on. In case you need a recap (I know I did), Adora ripped the failsafe out of herself after a pretty bad court session, which caused some of you little rascals to lose the faith - but we're not done yet!
>
> Without further ado, here's part 29. (Same warnings from 28 apply)

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Brightmoon School - 3:24pm

Catra was staring at the clock.

As soon as it hit 3:30pm, she was planning on running to the car and speeding home. She had her bag and laptop packed up. Her coat was on the back of her chair and her foot was tapping out the seconds.

Five minutes to go.

The court session had ended nearly half an hour ago. She couldn't even *think* because she was so angry for what they'd put Adora through. Her brain was a swirling mess of Adora's nervous responses and the venomous tone of the Defence barrister. It would be better for everyone if they banned Catra from ever attending a court session, because the next time she saw Grizzlor in person, she was going to *claw his eyes out.*

Catra – even though she knew she was going to regret it – had spent the afternoon reading media coverage of the case. So far,

the reviews had been mixed. The tabloids mostly contained opinion pieces on Adora's character (*reluctant hero or sabotaged soldier?*) while the broadcasters offered different views on the evidence. Adora's emotional break at the end of the proceedings was either met with sympathy or cold indifference.

Catra had tried messaging Adora on every platform going but hadn't had a response. She hoped that she was okay and somewhere safe with people looking after her. She wouldn't do well on her own right now.

But Catra also knew Adora *extremely* well. And she knew, deep in her gut, that Adora would hide away at home as soon as she could and shut herself off from the world.

Fuck it.

She was going to go now.

"Great work today, class," Catra said, speed-walking to the door. "I'll see you next week."

"Wait, Miss, what about our homework?" shouted Josh.

There was a collective groan around the room.

Catra was already through the threshold. "I'm pretending I didn't hear that for your own dignity, Josh."

On the way to the car park, Catra stopped outside Glimmer's office. There were voices coming from inside, which told her the principal had company. She thought, very briefly, about checking on Bow, but she didn't want to waste any more time.

It was during the drive home that Catra's gut felt like it had rolled out of her body as the feeling of *something wrong* took over all her senses. Surely, Adora would've texted her back? Even just to say she was home? As soon as Catra parked the car outside of their house, she checked her phone again for messages. She had a few from Glimmer, but none from Adora.

Taking a shallow breath, Catra braced herself for going inside.

The door was locked, which was unusual. For the past few days, Adora had left it open for her, knowing she would be home soon after the court session ended. As soon as the front door was open, Catra knew Adora was home – and that was something. Her bag and coat were thrown on the bottom stair. Catra picked them up to put them on the cloak stand, and called up the stairs, "Adora?"

No response.

She tiptoed into the kitchen, calling again, "Adora?"

Still, no response.

Walking past the kitchen window, she checked outside for movement, but it was still – not even a breeze ruffling the limbs of the patio oak tree.

She's probably gone straight to bed again, and who can blame her? Catra thought. But she had no intention of letting Adora go to bed hungry – not again. Catra took the stairs two at a time. She walked past the bathroom, where the door was open –

And had to double back.

Why was there broken glass on the bathroom floor?

Thump-thump. Thump-de-thump. Her heart missed a few beats. A chill settled over her skin.

Catra pushed the door all the way back –

And her eyes landed on Adora slumped in a heap on the stone tiles, surrounded by broken shards of mirror.

"Adora!"

Catra's feet crunched over glass as she ran towards her girlfriend. Her hands found Adora's shoulders and heaved her into her arms. Adora's face was pale, her eyelids purple, and blood saturated the front of her blouse.

"Adora," Catra murmured, more to herself – she doubted the blonde could hear her. She could see Adora's chest rising and falling – the only saving grace – but as she stared at the dark red stain against her skin, Catra started to understand what she was staring at.

A large gash in the valley of her chest – hovering over her heart.

Adora had torn the failsafe out of her flesh.

An angry roar ripped from her throat, unbidden – Catra grabbed a piece of broken glass and flung it across the room. They – the army – had taken so much from them. Their youth – their health – their mental wellbeing – *and it was gone too far.*

It was hard to see because of the force of the blood pumping through her ears, making her head light and floaty. Catra tried to focus on Adora and did her best to look past the blood.

Holding onto her so tight it would no doubt hurt if she was conscious, Catra fished into her trouser pocket for her phone. Her mind was reeling, and she was finding it hard to figure out what she needed to do first. When the first responder answered her call with the question 'what is your emergency?' Catra felt herself flounder.

She was not going to lose Adora.

This had gone too far.

"Uh, police – no, sorry, ambulance. Please." Catra's hand shook. She cleared her throat and urged herself to calm down. "My girlfriend – she's bleeding out. Chest wound. Hurry. Please."

It was as if someone else was talking. Catra recited the address as if she were reading from a script. Her eyes couldn't leave the blood splats on the floor.

"And how long has the patient been losing blood?"

Catra shook her head. "I – I don't know. I just got home." She heard her own breath catch in her throat. "She has a pulse but it's weak."

"Okay, I want you to take a few deep breaths for me, ma'am. Did you say the patient is your girlfriend?"

Catra was crying. She wasn't sure when that started. Fighting the urge to throw something again, she gave a loud sniff. "Yeah. I want to marry her." She shook her head again – why did she say that? "I've always wanted to marry her," she tried to amend to sound sane. "I need to tell her that."

"Don't move her until the ambulance arrives but let me know if there's any changes in her pulse or breathing. Can you do that for me? ETA is four minutes."

"I won't move her," Catra promised. "I'm not going anywhere."

"Did you also say you needed the police, ma'am? Is there any indication that this wasn't an accident?"

Catra blinked a few times. She looked around; the broken mirror, the blood on Adora's hand, the locked door – it all pointed to this being intentional. "I – uh… I think it's self-inflicted." Catra hesitated, "But it's complicated. Shit – fuck." The realisation hit her like a tidal wave. "This is going to be on the news. Ah, fuck."

Just after the court case – the focus on the toll of Adora's health by the media – Catra realised this was going to look like attempted suicide. What would this mean for them? Would Adora be taken away?

Catra held onto her a little tighter.

“ETA is one minute, ma’am. Can the paramedics gain access to your building?”

She could hear the sirens already. Shuffling to the side to make more room, Catra said, “Yeah, the front door should be open.” Then she swept a stray strand of hair away from Adora’s clammy forehead. “Hang in there, ‘Dor. You’ve survived worse than this.”

They both had.

The ambulance had pulled up in the street – Catra could see the blue flashes reflecting through the bathroom window. She put her phone down and something caught her eye on the floor – she did a double take, because something didn’t feel right about it. Beside a particularly sharp and bloody piece of broken glass, there was a heart-shaped disk. Catra picked it up very carefully and held it up to the light –

It was when she saw the frayed wire on the back that she realised what this was – it was the failsafe.

Largely intact.

Footsteps running up the stairs indicated the paramedics had arrived. Without thinking, Catra shoved the failsafe chip in the pocket of her jacket.

The paramedics – one female and one male – invaded the scene. One readied the stretcher as the other attended to Adora, checking her vital signs. Catra tried to hold onto whatever of Adora she could. They cut away her blouse, and with it, the band of her bra. Catra felt a protective urge to shield her as the man gently inspected the jagged wound. Into his radio, he listed off, “We have a female in her twenties, non-responsive, but with a pulse. Injury appears to be shallow. We’ll need to bring her in.”

Catra knew she had to let go so they could transfer her to the stretcher. Stepping away, she gave them space to work while trying to keep as close as possible. As the male paramedic

shouldered most of the weight, the female paramedic placed her hand on Catra's shoulder.

"What's your name?"

Feeling herself shivering and she didn't know why, she answered, "Catra."

"Catra, do you know the patient's next of kin?"

"Uh – yeah." Catra felt her cheeks redden. "It's me."

The medic nodded. "Sibling, partner…?"

"Partner," Catra said, a little forcefully.

The paramedic smiled. "Do you want to ride with us in the ambulance?"

Catra was going to cling onto the back doors if they hadn't asked her – there was no way she was leaving Adora alone, no matter the circumstances.

The President's Cabinet Office – Etherian Central Government - 4:17pm

"And if he has a problem with that, tell him my husband will sue him for damages." With a rough sigh, the President threw his phone on his desk. Rubbing his eyes, he looked up at his secretary. "Martin, tell me there's one bit of good business from today."

Martin clucked his tongue. He leaned back on the chair and pinned the President with a stern look. "Speaking of said husband, he called around an hour ago. Lolly was sent home from school." He winced. "She stuck a crayon up her nose."

The President and Martin both paused to reflect on this tragic incident. Martin even had the dignity to look down at his clipboard

so the President could tiredly rub clean his glasses. After clearing his throat, the President continued, "And the five o'clock meeting is still –"

Someone knocked on the office door before pushing their way in. The President and Martin both looked around, slightly insulted at such an interruption.

"Sorry to barge in, Ezra," said Gloria Winkle, the Defence Minister. She was out of breath, her chest heaving, as if she had ran the full flight of stairs to the cabinet room. "There's been a development with the Greyskull case."

President Ezra frowned and checked his watch. "Didn't that wrap up a while ago? I read Martin's report already."

She nodded. "No, it did. This is new. The police have told us Greyskull was admitted to hospital in the last half an hour."

"Why?" he punctuated, sharply. "What happened?"

Gloria hesitated. She eyed his secretary who was watching with keen interest. "Might be best if we discuss this privately," she said.

The President sighed. He organised his files and handed them across the desk to Martin's outstretched hand. "Martin, file another report on this, will you? Thanks."

Wordlessly, Martin put the files under his arm and walked towards the door. As he passed Gloria at the threshold, he muttered a quick 'good luck'.

President Ezra gestured to the empty seat in front of his desk. His demeanour had changed; his posture was stiff, his movements deliberate, like a coil ready to spring. Gloria, sensing his unease, sat on the edge of the chair with her hands crossed on her lap.

"A chest wound," she said, breaking the silence. "They're assuming attempted suicide, but –"

“This is bad news for us, Gloria,” Ezra interrupted. “Very bad. What have you done about the She-Ra embargo?”

Gloria blinked a few times, startled. “It’s only a matter of time before the She-Ra papers are discussed in court,” she said defensively. “Greyskull hinted at them today. I thought we’d have another week or two to prompt a resignation, but if Greyskull has destroyed the failsafe…”

Ezra hummed. “We have to move forward. We have to take this situation into our own hands before the blame falls on our department.”

“What do you want me to do?” Gloria asked.

“Take back control. I want you to call the Commander-in-Chief. Ask him to resign. If he doesn’t, tell him *I’m* asking him to resign.” The President said this while writing her a note. “Then, have your staff contact all Etherian Broadcasters to announce the resignation.”

“You think that’ll be enough?”

“For now. For our own sake, this court case can’t go on. Not in the public eye. We’re the political party that won the war, but if the public find out how we did it – how the military did it – it’s over for us. Some of us, at least.” He stared at her, through her, his green eyes searching her face for a sign of weakness. “This is going to land on you, Gloria. Remember that. I want you to make a decision – tonight. Depending on the reaction… the next resignation will be you.”

Gloria pursed her lips. She smoothed down her trousers before she stood up. “I understand. My Department will have a response ready asap.”

But the President had already dismissed her. Without looking her way again, he flicked his wrist at the door. “Send Martin back in,” he ordered. “I need to talk to the Chief Justice.”

Brightmoon Hospital – the waiting room - 4:45pm

It only took another half an hour for Catra's phone to start blowing up. The only person she messaged was Glimmer with a brief '*In hospital with Adora. Tell your mum. Come asap*.' It was clear the media was already reporting it as a breaking headline – she had texts from practically everyone at the school (and Scorpia) wishing them well.

Catra, sitting in the waiting room by herself, had never felt so lonely in her life – and Catra's life was imprinted with loneliness like chapters in a book. The minutes – the seconds – dragged by with every drawn-out beat of her heart.

She never thought she'd say it, but she couldn't wait to see Glimmer and Bow.

In the meantime, a doctor had informed Catra that Adora was being "prepped" for surgery. She queried why she would need it in the first place, but apparently there were "unidentifiable obstructions" they had to remove before closing the wound. Adora was stable, and the doctor assured her that she wasn't in the danger zone. It would just require time to fix. Catra fingered the remnants of the failsafe in her pocket. Unsure whether to bring it up or not, she simply nodded and allowed the doctor to get back to work.

The police arrived minutes before Glimmer and Bow. They wanted to speak to Catra, who refused – at least until Adora was out of surgery. She also heard from a passing nurse that the police were keeping the media away from the hospital, but couldn't stop them from gathering outside the grounds, which was slowing down ambulances from dropping off other patients.

Glimmer and Bow were escorted into the waiting room by two nurses. Wordlessly, Glimmer threw her arms around Catra's shoulders as soon as they laid eyes on one another. Catra paused, feeling a tad awkward, but for once – and just this once – allowed

herself to sink into someone else's comfort. She rested her hand on Glimmer's upper back squeezed her eyes shut.

"How are you doing?" Glimmer asked, her voice muffled by Catra's shoulder.

"I'm tired, Glimmer," Catra rasped, on the verge of tears again. She pulled away and shook her head. "Really tired."

"Any news on Adora?" asked Bow, setting down a backpack of what looked like overnight clothes.

Catra gestured to the hospital doors behind them. "Getting prepped for surgery."

"Surgery?"

"She… pulled the failsafe out," Catra said carefully, avoiding their stares. "And she didn't get all of it." Hearing Glimmer's sharp intake of breath, Catra raised her hands to stop the flood of questions she knew were coming. "I don't know – I wasn't told much. Just something about obstructions preventing them closing the wound."

"But she's going to be okay?" Glimmer asked as she pulled Catra into the chair beside her.

Pausing, Catra shrugged. "Physically, yeah."

Mentally? Emotionally? She had no idea. Adora hadn't been herself in a while, and she doubted it was going to get any better any time soon. Catra closed her eyes for a few seconds, conjuring an image of Adora laughing on their bed after asking Catra to move in with her. Catra loved her so much it physically hurt.

But she was also angry. Confused. Upset.

"She had a terrible time of it in court today," said Glimmer, breaking the moment of silence. "They shouldn't have pushed her

so far – they know she has PTSD. My mum wants to file another complaint against them."

Catra's ears perked up at the mention of Angella. "Did you ask her what happens now?"

Nodding, Glimmer murmured, "She's looking into it."

In an effort to distract her, Bow patted Catra's knee, and did his best to sound the side of optimism. "It sounds like you found her in good time."

"I had a feeling. She hasn't been herself for the past few days – since Angella's collapse. The lights were on, but no one was home." Catra shivered as the lifeless stare Adora had given her this morning came to the forefront of her mind. "I didn't think she'd do something like this, though."

"I don't think this is a bad thing," he said carefully.

Glimmer quirked her head. "You don't?"

"No." Bow leaned on his elbows to get a good look at them both. "The army were trying to say Adora consented to being part of the experiment. Their whole argument against her is that she stole military equipment when she deserted, and posed a threat to national security. Adora removing the failsafe herself – even though she injured herself in the process – shows that she removes that consent." As an after-thought, he added, "Plus, she's not a threat to national security anymore, is she?"

Glimmer nudged Catra's elbow. "Where is the failsafe? Do you know?"

Feeling suddenly very self-aware, Catra stayed completely still to not freak them out. After a moment, she whispered, "I have it. I didn't know what to do with it."

"What did you do with it?" Glimmer hissed.

“It’s in my pocket.”

“It’s in your – are you crazy?” Glimmer yelled, jumping to her feet.

Catra put her hands up in a surrender. “I didn’t know what to do! What should I do?!”

Glimmer bit her lip and looked at Bow for help. When he also shrugged, she sighed and collapsed back in the chair, rubbing her forehead. “I actually don’t know either. Shit. Alright. I’m texting my mum.”

Brightmoon High Court – the offices - 5:07pm

Judge Norwyn was in his study when he heard the news.

He was a new article military-grade experiments, just published last week. As he folded the page to take a note, his desk phone buzzed.

“Norwyn, there’s a call here for you,” said Janie, the legal secretary on duty. She sounded bored; impatient. “Urgent, apparently.”

Norwyn put down his pen. “Who from and what for?”

“The Chief Justice. About the Greyskull case.”

Inhaling through his nose, he held in a sigh. “Put her through.”

No doubt she was calling about the interruption in court today – he had been expecting it. In fact, he was surprised she hadn’t checked in on him before now. The Chief Justice was off-hours at this time, and she had ample opportunity to call him all afternoon. He raised the receptor to his ear and clicked the ‘answer’ button.

“Norwyn, how are you?”

“Confused as to why you’re calling me at this hour, Emeline,” he said drily.

“I don’t blame you.” She snorted, low and rough. “I said the same thing to the President when he called. Have you seen the news?”

Norwyn’s eyebrows raised at the mention of the President. “I’ve been busy, as I’m sure you’ve seen on the news.”

“Very well.” She cleared her throat. “You see, the media are reporting that Greyskull is in hospital.”

“Oh.” Norwyn took off his spectacles and placed them carefully on the table. “I see. You know I mustn’t take an interest in these things.”

As the senior judge on the Greyskull case, it was illegal for Norwyn to discuss developments outside of court to the Chief Justice – or any other judiciary. Even when it came to court proceedings, he was limited to what he could talk about outside of court.

The Chief Justice knew this, of course. She would only tell him this information if there was something else going on.

“But if you were curious to know, then we’re being bombarded with claims of attempted suicide.” Emmeline paused. “After how the hearing ended today, it’s not surprising.”

“Hmm,” Norwyn offered, non-committedly.

Emmeline’s tone suddenly changed; she was razor-sharp, impatient. “Norwyn, we both know it wasn’t attempted suicide. You’re an intelligent man. I think it’s safe for us to assume that Greyskull has… taken matters into her own hands.”

He knew exactly what she meant; Greyskull had attempted to remove the ‘failsafe’, in other words, the tech the military had installed inside of her.

"Troubling news," he said, albeit reluctantly. "It could've been avoided."

"The President has been watching closely. With the election looming this year, it doesn't look well for his Ministry of Defence." On the other side of the line, Norwyn could hear Emmeline tapping something as she spoke. "Adora Greyskull is on her way of reclaiming her title as Etheria's sweetheart. This news, plus the embargoed papers, will call management into question." She almost sounded excited at the drama. "We're looking at a sacking, an inquiry and a vote of no confidence in the powers that be."

At this point, it was taking all of Norwyn's self-restraint to say nothing. "You *know* I can't comment on an active case, Emeline. Say what it is you have to say."

She didn't hesitate. "Expect a call tonight from the Defence Minister. A decision is being made."

Brightmoon Hospital – the waiting room - 6:33pm

Catra heard Bow's sigh of relief when Glimmer returned to the waiting room. Around half an hour ago, Glimmer received a phone call from Angella and had disappeared out the back exit to take it. Her eyes were wide, and she was bursting with nervous energy.

"What's going on?" Catra asked, sitting up straight.

"So much, apparently. My mum's just heard that the head of the army is stepping down tonight," Glimmer gushed.

"What?" Bow glanced between them. "Is it – is it because of Adora?"

"She thinks so. Apparently the Ministry of Defence is getting nervy."

Catra's head was too cloudy with grief and worry to properly dissect what was going on. "Wait, so, does that go in Adora's

favour or against her?”

“Well, the Commander-in-Chief is stepping down. Figures like that only resign when there’s signs of wrongdoing. Normally to avoid an inquiry.”

Bow gasped and clicked his fingers. “There’s an election next year! If the government thinks the media coverage of Adora’s case will sway opinion, then… Glimmer? What’s that look for?”

Glimmer’s phone had buzzed again, and she was smiling – a proper, big happy smile. She sounded like they’d just won a trophy. “There’s a protest outside Brightmoon High Court! It’s small so far – but it’s organised by a group calling for reform on the charges of treason and military desertion.”

An army resignation, a game of politics, a public protest… This was all turning into a wider conversation of human rights and a play of power. Once again, those in power were trying to stay in power – they only cared about Adora because it suited them, because there was something to lose or gain from the situation.

Adora’s life had been forfeited for a cause, and might, perhaps, be saved by another. A corrupted system that continued corrupting.

And what could they do about it? Once again, they were powerless. Pawns being played by a bigger power.

But if it meant Adora was safe – if Adora could be free – if they won this case – Catra wouldn’t complain about it. She’d never complain about anything again.

They could be free, and they could be together.

“Catra?” came Glimmer’s voice from very far away.

The sudden burst of hope and longing was too much to swallow – Catra had to put her head between her legs in case she would faint. She squeezed her eyes shut and waved Bow’s hands away. “I feel sick.”

All three of them jumped as the doors to the hospital room opened. Feeling a little dizzy, Catra squinted at the doctor standing in front of them, and immediately jumped up as if she was ordered to attention. Beside her, Glimmer held onto Bow with shaking hands and Bow wrapped his arm around her shoulder.

"Catra Areli?" the doctor asked, eyes landing on her. "Can I talk to you a moment?"

Catra nodded, mouth dry and voice dead in her throat. She glanced to Glimmer and Bow before following the doctor into the next corridor. He wasn't old – for some reason, Catra expected doctors to always be old. The ones in the military had been mostly retired army nurses with the battle scars to prove it.

The doctor had a pen in his hand and a clipboard under his arm. He leaned against the wall and fixed her with a curious stare.

"You're Adora Greyskull's next of kin, is that correct?"

"Yes."

"And how long have you been together?"

Catra immediately crossed her arms over her chest. "Why is that relevant?"

"Please answer the question," the doctor said, not unkindly. "I need to do a couple of checks to ensure Adora gets the help she deserves."

Catra bit her lip and looked away. Where did she even begin to answer that question?

"We grew up together," she began after a moment. "We were in the army together. We've been in a relationship for a few months now." It felt strange to say that out loud, and she was aware her voice was beginning to crack. "She doesn't have any biological family, if that's what you're asking. Her real family is right here."

"Apologies, I'm not trying to gauge anything other than a timeframe," he said, and raised his hands to ease her. "You've known Adora a long time, then. Has she been behaving out of character lately? Has she talked to you about mental health problems?"

Catra scoffed. "Unless you've been living under a rock, doc, I think you know what Adora's been facing lately. It's all over the news. Yes, she's been stressed and upset and – and yes, I've been worried about her. The case has taken its toll on her. Not to mention what they did to her today, which I –" Catra sighed, and tried to get a hold of herself. She was getting emotional again, and she didn't want to spill her guts to this guy like she had to the woman on the emergency call line. "Look, Adora hasn't been suicidal. I know that's what you're really asking. She's fighting this case because she wants to *live*." Catra met his stare. "But she has been struggling. We both have."

The doctor nodded as he wrote something down. "Thank you for your honesty. For what it's worth, it's clear to me that Miss Greyskull wasn't making an attempt on her life." He paused, as if unsure how to go on. "I removed… let's call it *debris* from the wound that indicates Miss Greyskull was attempting to dislodge a contraption from her chest wall. But given the nature of the injury, and my duty of care, I need to file a report for self-mutilation. Which, as you can imagine, starts to trigger alarms."

Catra's eyes bulged. "Are you going to admit her?"

"To a mental institution?" he shook his head. "No, but I will be requesting that staff keep an eye on her and that she receives counselling and a psych report as soon as she is capable of doing so." He looked closely at Catra as he clicked his pen and put it in his top pocket. "I will also have to write-up the evidence of an unidentifiable object in Miss Greyskull's chest wall."

Catra tried to figure out what he was implying, but her brain wasn't making it past normal levels of comprehension. She leaned in closer, and muttered, "What does that mean?"

The doctor glanced over his shoulder to ensure that they were alone. Slowly, and carefully, he said, "Public court case aside, if a patient of mine is admitted with an unidentifiable object in their body, it is my duty to ask why and how it got there. I need to report it to the hospital's medical institution, and if there is evidence of a crime, then it will be reported to the police."

Catra had no faith in the police. She had no faith in any institution. However, if they had this on record – that the failsafe existed, and there was medical evidence of it – then that can only go in their favour in court.

And it was at that moment Catra realised that the doctor was trying to *help* them.

"You can see Adora now, but only one visitor at a time," he said, interrupting Catra's thoughts. "I know the police are keen to speak to her, but I'm barring them until she speaks to a therapist."

Catra nodded. Before he walked away, she instinctively reached out for his arm to stop him. "Thank you, doc," she said, meaning every word of it.

He patted her hand and continued on his way, leaving Catra staring at Adora's hospital room door with a sense of hope and dread.

When Adora came around, the first thing she noticed was how warm and floaty she felt. She didn't want to open her eyes – in fact, she wanted to stay like this forever, feeling secure and comfortable without any anxiety or pain.

But there *had* been anxiety and pain.

She could remember it, and the memories of it were calling to her.

A weight on her chest tried to pull her under again and she fought against it. There was something she was forgetting – something she needed to wake up for. Her heavy eyelids resisted the initial

light that peaked through the darkness. Blinking a few times, she became aware of a brown blurry figure in her line of sight.

"Cash'ra?" she slurred, trying to lift her head.

"Don't try to move, dummy."

The room was white and blinding, and the bed was soft and scratchy. It hit her like a punch in a face where she was – the hospital.

The last time she'd woken up in a hospital bed she was alone and scared. Adora tried to push that thought away, she didn't want it. She didn't need it. It occurred to her that she felt too tired to feel panicked at being in a hospital again. There was pain, dull and hazy. Her mouth was dry and her head was heavy.

"What happened?" she said, and her voice was still slow and slurred. She tried to get up, but her chest ached. Groaning, she lay back down again and closed her eyes. "Oh yeah."

The failsafe. She'd torn the failsafe out of her chest.

She was free.

Adora felt… clean.

It was strange. The failsafe had felt like a diseased limb; she had done everything in her power to live with it but knowing that it was there was a weight she couldn't ever get rid of. No matter how hard she scrubbed at her skin, or tried to make it better, the failsafe was there, and it was a part of her – it was something that she couldn't get rid of.

And now it was gone. Knowing that, knowing that the tech that had been forced upon her was no longer *physically* inside her, made her feel lighter. Adora had amputated the diseased limb, and now it was time to heal.

Retrospectively, Adora could see she wasn't in the right state of mind when she did it. She had acted impulsively in an adrenaline and anxiety fuelled state. There were so many things she wanted to know: did she get it all out? What happened to it?

What was the consequence of doing it?

But something – she guessed it was the medication they put her on – was making her thoughts and movements slow. It hit her that Catra hadn't said anything at all during this time. Opening her eyes again, Adora peered to where her girlfriend sat, curled on her chair, watching closely.

"Are you okay?" Adora asked, concerned at Catra's quiet demeanour.

Catra scoffed. "You're asking me if I'm okay?

Adora frowned. That was exactly what she was asking. "Uh, yeah?"

Catra bit her lip and glanced to the side. "No, I'm not okay."

Right, yes, of course. Adora could tell that much. Her heartbeat elevated (at least she still had a heart), and Adora fumbled with the blankets around her chest. Her tone turned high-pitched as she asked, "Are you annoyed at me?"

"Yes," Catra said like it was forced from her. She shook her head and frowned. "No. I don't know."

Well, that made things so much clearer. They were so good at this communicating thing. Adora tried to gather her thoughts. Her mind wandered; her medicated brain was finding it hard to keep up and cooperate, but she did her best to stay focused on Catra. There was a slope to her shoulders and a crease on her brow that only appeared when she was intensely disturbed by something.

The last time Adora had seen it on her they were kids, and it was about Weaver.

Unsure of what to do or how to act, Adora blurted, "Want to talk about it?"

Catra was quiet for a few seconds. Adora counted them by listening to her own shallow breaths. The brunette transferred herself from the chair to Adora's bed. She still wasn't meeting the blonde's eyes. "What happened? Before I found you?" she asked quietly.

Adora winced as she realised that *Catra* had found her. That was an image she didn't want.

"I screwed up," Adora murmured, picking at a loose thread on the hospital blanket. "In court. When they asked me about –"

Catra inhaled sharply. "I heard it all–"

"It was bad, Catra," Adora said, and she felt so small saying it. "I took some sort of anxiety attack when I got home. I wasn't thinking – I couldn't think – and then it all became so clear." She gestured to her chest. "I had to get it out. I needed it out, I needed to –" the words *be clean, be free, take control* died on her lips. Instead, she said, "I'm sorry."

Catra met her eyes for a fraction of a second before they wandered to the bandages on Adora's chest. "Well, you got it out. I called an ambulance; they brought you here. They took the rest of it out in surgery." Catra's voice turned hard. "You need a psych evaluation, and the police are nearly breaking down the door to speak with you."

Adora nodded, taking it all in. "And the media?"

"They're outside the hospital too."

What would the media be saying about her now? And the police – did they want a report on what happened or did they want to arrest her on behalf of the army? It wouldn't exactly be the first time.

The seconds were ticking until the bomb exploded – she knew that. This had to come to an end one way or another. Feeling a little desperate, Adora gushed, "I'm done for. But I think I did the right thing. If they take me down, I want it to be for *my* actions. Removing the failsafe myself is the second thing I've done for myself, using my own agency, since I joined the army." Was she trying to convince herself or Catra? She wasn't sure, but when Catra pierced her with a soft, wounded expression, Adora was consumed with guilt. She conceded, "Yes – I was driven to it, and yes, I wasn't thinking clearly – I was confused and angry – but I don't regret it. And I'll tell them that. This is me now. Just me."

She needed Catra to see that. She needed her to understand.

"What was the other thing?" the brunette asked.

Adora frowned. "Hm? What?"

"You said taking out the failsafe was the second thing you ever chose for yourself," Catra repeated. "What was the first?"

Adora felt her cheeks redden. *Surely she should know*. Reaching for her girlfriend's hand, Adora's fingertips traced Catra's upturned palm. "Loving you," she said with a small smile.

A shadow of something passed over Catra's face. Adora immediately pulled her hand back, as if burned.

"Adora, listen…" Catra said tiredly, turning to fully face her. "I'm doing my best here, because I'm angry and upset, but I'm really trying to say this properly." Adora nodded to show she was listening. Catra's brows pulled together and her voice shook. "You need to stop acting like you're on your own. You need to stop pushing me away. You should've called me after the court hearing today – and yes, I know you weren't thinking straight – but please. I can't keep doing this – watching you hurt yourself over and over. I love you so much, but you need to accept that you need help, and that accepting help isn't a weakness." An angry

tear leaked from her eye and she practically slapped it off her face, adding in spite, “You fucking idiot.”

Adora felt every word deep inside her bones. She patted the empty space beside her on the bed. Rolling her eyes, the brunette shimmied closer.

Adora took a deep breath. This was going to be hard to say. A lump was steadily rising in her throat and she was urging herself not to cry.

It had been a fought few weeks. Hell, it had been a tough few years.

For both of them.

“I think I need help, Catra. I can’t think about the future right now, but if I – if we somehow make it through this, that’s what I’ll do. I’ll see my therapist again, not just Perfuma. I’ll really try to stop shutting everyone out.”

Catra’s eyes were watering. “You promise?” she whispered.

“I promise,” Adora said, holding Catra’s hand to her chest. “I love you. I'd do anything for you."

"I just want you to live," Catra said, brushing a thumb over Adora's flushed cheek.

Adora smiled and nodded. *If only it were that easy.* As she opened her mouth to say something stupid and cheesy, they were interrupted by the doctor knocking on the door and letting himself in. There was an apology on his face, but beyond that, he looked a bit flustered. Catra and Adora stared at him, waiting for him to say something. After a moment he shook his head and said, "Sorry, but I've just been talking to -" he straightened up "-the President is just off the phone with us. He wants to visit you."

Were the drugs doing something to her brain? Adora glanced between Catra and the doctor, waiting for one of them to break.

When neither of them did, Adora jabbered, "What - what President? There's a few in the - in the world."

In her line of sight, she could see Catra groan and roll her eyes. The doctor said, kindly and patiently, "President Ezra. Of Etheria."

"Tell him she'll do it," Catra said, folding her arms.

Adora rounded on her. "Catra!"

"What?" she hissed. "You'd be crazy not to - think of the leverage!"

She had a point - she usually did. The President wanted to visit for his own political agenda, but two could play at that game. If he wanted something from her, she would ask for something in return. All hope was not lost. Not yet.

Adora had her friends. Angella and Casta as her lawyers. Support from her peers. She had Catra and all of her love.

She had even regained a part of herself back.

"Okay," Adora agreed. "I'll do it."

Chapter End Notes

> Some other world-saving blonde superhero (do Adora and Buffy share the same birthday?) once said: the hardest thing in this world is to live in it. Be brave. Live.
>
> That's what Adora is trying to do - just live.
>
> I tell myself every single time I write something that I'm not going to bring politics into it, and yet, here we are. But how can we not talk about politics when we're discussing institutions and power? (Don't tempt me into writing a She-Ra political drama, please don't, it wouldn't take much).

It's a long chapter, and it kicked my butt, but I hope it wasn't too terrible. I'll try to get the next one out for next week, but no promises.

Until the next time, stay safe.

Cx.

(P.S. I know I said I'd write an analysis of ch28 on my tumblr, and it is coming!)

End Notes

Context for context sake: in my mind, this is set in modern day earth, but Eternia and Etheria are two countries at war with one another, and the Horde has occupied land in Etheria. For those who don't know about the special forces, they're an elite section of the military that deal with special, sometimes undercover, operations.

It's my first time writing for She-Ra, but just so you know, my writing style tends to be 'pain with plot', so I hope you're ready for the wild ride. I hope to update quite regularly; if not twice a week, definitely once per week.

I have a playlist for this fic here: https://open.spotify.com/playlist/1Huy51wvbvK1xUsLGhHnpv?si=a3viXy__RrSZ_mMgroYEEQ

If you enjoyed the first chapter and want more, drop a comment and kudos are always welcome.

Stay safe.

Cx.

Please drop by the archive and comment to let the author know if you enjoyed their work!